



MythLORE

A JOURNAL OF J.R.R. TOLKIEN,
C.S. LEWIS, CHARLES WILLIAMS,
AND MYTHOPOEIC LITERATURE



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edited by Rebecca Josephy, *G. Connor Salter*



WELCOME TO THE SPRING 2025 issue of *Mythlore*—with a page count within reasonable bounds this time! A few bits of *Mythlore* business before I introduce the contents. Dr. Kris Swank, a regular contributor to *Mythlore*, has joined the journal's board with this issue. We welcome her wide-ranging expertise on many of the authors you encounter in these pages, as well as their sources and inspirations in Celtic, folk, medieval, and Arthurian materials. And over the summer, John Rosegrant, also a frequent contributor to the journal, will begin assisting with the Reviews column.

As I move towards retirement from librarianship (but not from editing this journal), I would like to spend more time working with students and scholars who want to develop their expertise in editing. Please contact me if you are interested in a short-term internship of one or two semesters, or a longer-term commitment as editorial assistant.

While the majority of readers will first encounter *Mythlore* as individual articles on our website or in a library database, I still enjoy arranging the contents of each issue in some sort of logical or thematic progression which rewards the reader willing to start from the beginning and go on to the end. This issue is no exception. The first eight articles concern issues of fantasy and theology, some with a global perspective; taken together, one can see ways in which they might be in dialogue with each other. The groundwork is first laid with Matthew Thompson-Handell's bibliographic essay on the history of pagan, Christian, and blended interpretations of the religious system and values of Middle-earth. Tom Emanuel then addresses the sometimes-uncomfortable meta-issue of fandom as a religion, proposing a framework that makes theological sense of the custom of visiting Tolkien's grave.

Then we move into the application of specific concepts and theories. Eric Reinders examines Chinese and Thai translations of the *Aimulindalë*, drawing interesting parallels with translations of the Christian bible into those languages. René Girard's theory of imitative desire is used by Clinton Manley to dissect the Un-man's strategy in Lewis's *Perelandra*. Matthew McKenna applies G.K. Chesterton's ideas about free will and oath-taking to the Oath of Féanor, and Brett Roscoe shows how Lewis depicts the fear of God through his descriptions of Aslan. Taylor Driggers uses the tenets of queer theology to illuminate Diane Duane's *The Tale of the Five* series. And Ishani Anwesha Joshi

and Sathyaraj Venketasen discuss an example of the adaptation of mythic/religious symbolism in art that responded to the global crisis of COVID-19.

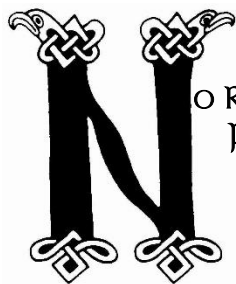
The remaining four papers address issues of medievalisms in fantasy. Mark-Eliot Finley finds echoes of *Beowulf* in the Harry Potter series. Maria Damkjær's exploration of book culture in Martin's *A Song of Fire and Ice* provokes us to think about the fragility of archives more generally (and joins the conversation started in *Loremasters and Libraries in Fantasy and Science Fiction* (Mythopoeic Press, 2022). Gavin S. Davis looks at how the importance of swords in different Middle-earth cultures represents different mediavalisms, and Laura N. Van Dyke explores the medieval immersion fantasy in Garner's *Elidor* as it contrasts, deliberately, with Narnia.

Our Notes in this issue are a mixed bag, but all concerned with the Inklings and the Inklings-adjacent. Łucasz Neubaur makes an addition to the resources on Tolkien's scholarly biography; Matthew Thompson-Handell finds a Miltonian parallel for a passage in a version of Túrin's story. G. Connor Salter examines elements of the *contes cruel* in Lewis. Ian F. Alexander takes us behind the scenes of online reference sources on Tolkien, and Salter and Clark Sheldon reveal more material from the Wade's manuscript files on Douglas Gresham and Joy Davidman. Finally, Robin Reid provides another thoughtful response to Dylan Henderson's "'A Bleak, Barren Land'" (*Mythlore* #143); good material to read before our next Online Midsummer Seminar celebrating the 10th anniversary of the MythPress essay collection *Perilous and Fair*.

We close, as usual, with an extensive selection of reviews of books about the Inklings, other fantasists, fantasy in general, and a few less-easily-classified items which may be of interest to *Mythlore* readers.

If you would like to keep up with news relating to *Mythlore*, please follow us on Facebook, where we post advance notice of papers accepted for upcoming issues, lists of items available for review, and so forth. In addition to the members of the *Mythlore* Editorial Advisory Board, the Mythopoeic Society Council of Stewards, and our ever-dependable referees, I'd also like to express my continuing gratitude to Phillip Fitzsimmons, University Archivist and Special Collections Librarian at Southwestern Oklahoma State University Libraries and our Administrator for *Mythlore* and Mythopoeic Society Archives, who directs the team adding content to dc.swosu.edu/mythlore/, and to his assistant Ben Dressler. My thanks also to David L. Emerson for moral support, eagle-eyed proofreading, and keeping the editor optimally caffeinated. As well I would like to gratefully acknowledge the assistance of Paul Irwin and Leslie Donovan with editing both the contributions themselves and the works cited lists to match MLA 9 style.

—Janet Brennan Croft



NO RAGNARÖK, NO ARMAGEDDON: PAGAN AND CHRISTIAN INTERPRETATIONS OF *THE LORD OF THE RINGS*

MATTHEW THOMPSON-HANDELL

IN HER 2014 ARTICLE “BUT WHAT DID HE REALLY MEAN?,” Verlyn Flieger refers to conflicting interpretations of *The Lord of the Rings*, citing by way of example the appeal of the work to neo-pagans (“an alternative to the dreary realism of mainstream culture”) and to Christians (“an evangelical message in its imagery of stars and light and bread and sacrifice”) (149). Flieger argues that such conflicting interpretations are a result, at least in part, of ambiguous and contradictory statements by Tolkien, statements which are indicative of unresolved conflicts within the man himself. One of the three topics examined by Flieger, as she develops her argument, is the question of intentional Christianity in Tolkien’s fiction. The focus here is on *The Lord of the Rings*, and Flieger looks at a range of statements by Tolkien which are anywhere from inconsistent to incompatible with each other. Examined particularly closely are Tolkien’s words to Robert Murray, to whom he wrote that *The Lord of the Rings* was “a fundamentally religious and Catholic work; unconsciously so at first, but consciously in the revision.” However, Tolkien goes on to speak of his deliberate omission of overtly religious elements. Flieger suggests that such ambiguity has led to the same statement being used to support contradictory positions: Joseph Pearce saying that *The Lord of the Rings* is “theologically orthodox” and Patrick Curry that the work has a blend of “Christian, pagan, and humanist ingredients.” Flieger then highlights the incongruity between Tolkien telling Murray about conscious revision of his work and then (a year later) telling W.H. Auden that there was “very little [...] conscious [...] intention in mind at any point” (150–2). Looking closely at these, and other statements, Flieger describes Tolkien’s “yes-but-not-yes tactics” as a means of responding to a wide range of readers without upsetting any of them (153–4). This is however more than just people-pleasing—the fact that Tolkien “trimmed his sails to meet winds from different directions” reveals “a deep ambivalence in the man that produced a creative tension in his fiction” (162).

Flieger revisited this theme in “The Arch and the Keystone” (her Guest of Honor address at Mythcon 50 in 2019), though with a subtle, but significant shift in the argument. In the earlier “But What Did He Really Mean?,” ambiguity and contradiction in Tolkien’s own statements are linked to two distinct

consequences: a creative tension in his fiction, and conflicting interpretations of his work. In “The Arch and the Keystone,” these two consequences are more explicitly connected to each other, and tension appears somewhat eclipsed by opposition: the contradictions in Tolkien the man result in contradictions in his work, which in turn contribute to contradictory interpretations of such work. Or as Flieger notes in her concluding remarks: “what they [scholars and critics] see is there, even when they’re seeing contradictory things” (16). Amongst the numerous and varied labels that have been put on the man and his work, Flieger notes the pairing of “a Christian apologist and a pagan” (6), revisiting the opposition between Christian and neo-pagan interpretations with which she opened her earlier 2014 article. She later observes that the fragmentation and polarization in Tolkien studies is in part a consequence of the fact that “so much of the primary evidence—that is to say, [Tolkien’s] writing—seems to toggle between diametrically opposite positions” (6–7). In *The Lord of the Rings*, Flieger identifies this opposition in the tragedy that befalls Frodo—that the hero fails in his appointed task only for Gollum to save the day; and that Frodo can save the Shire, but not for himself: “Frodo and Sam, at the Cracks of Doom and in the aftermath, embody between them the final tension and opposition that characterizes Tolkien’s masterwork” (13–4). Here there is another subtle shift from the earlier 2014 article, where ambiguity (rather than contradiction) had a more significant role to play: Flieger observes a conflict between faith and imagination which gives *The Lord of the Rings* “a power and tension [...] whose virtue is its indeterminacy.” Several examples are given, rounded off with Gandalf—or was it Saruman?—appearing to Aragorn, Legolas and Gimli: “for the Three Hunters the mystery is unsolved, and it seems clear that ambiguity is what Tolkien intended” (“But What” 164).

Scholars and critics¹ have indeed been identifying both Christian and pagan (or non-Christian) elements in *The Lord of the Rings* since its publication. What follows will look at the critical output up to 1981 (more on this date in a moment), in order to show that the presence and interaction of Christian and pagan elements is indicative of ambiguity rather than contradiction, and consequently that any opposition between Christian and pagan views is grounded to a greater extent in the perspectives of individual critics than in any contradiction within the work itself. In order to identify the critical responses that gave particular consideration to questions of Christianity and paganism, I went through the revised edition of Richard West’s annotated bibliography of Tolkien criticism (which covers the period to 1981) and noted those items where, in the title or in West’s annotation, the word “Christian” or “pagan” appears (or related terms such as “Christianity” or “paganism”). Further items were noted

¹ For the remainder of this article, I will use the term “critics”.

where a particular word indicated some treatment of these themes.² Additionally, three book-length studies were considered in view of their treatment (albeit relatively brief) of Christianity and paganism in *The Lord of the Rings*. The total number of critical responses examined was 32.³ In terms of the period covered, 1981 is the end date not only because that is as far as West's bibliography goes. It is also the year in which *The Letters of J.R.R. Tolkien* was first published, being thus a watershed after which many of Tolkien's own statements would have become widely available to critics for the first time. Before this, there will have been less opportunity for critical responses to *The Lord of the Rings* to have been influenced by such statements.⁴

I have divided the critical responses considered here into three groups: those which are more concerned with pagan (or non-Christian) elements in *The Lord of the Rings*; those which are more concerned with Christian elements; and those which consider a marriage of the two within the work.⁵ Pagan views highlighted elegiac qualities, the sense of loss and of defeat. Other non-Christian views described a world in which the will and the actions of individuals play their part against the backdrop of a higher power, and also considered how the work reflects archetypal human myths. What connects many of these views is their recognition that overt Christianity is absent from *The Lord of the Rings*, and in this absence is an ambiguity concerning the theology of Middle-earth. Seen alongside the Christian views, this ambiguity comes into even sharper focus. The higher power may be seen as Providence, the struggle between good and evil may be characteristically Christian, and the heroes can be Christ-like

² While this approach does not guarantee that every critical response with something to say about Christianity or paganism will have been considered, I suggest that it does provide sufficient coverage for reliable conclusions to be drawn. Aside from "Christian" or "pagan," the other keywords were: Beowulf, God, Providence, religious, and theological.

³ There were in fact four critical responses that were identified but which, on review, did not provide material that was sufficiently relevant to my topic, treating Christian or pagan elements in *The Lord of the Rings* only very briefly. Using the references in West's *Bibliography*, these were: II-80, II-437, II-547, and II-652.

⁴ This does not mean that Tolkien's own statements would have been *entirely* unknown to critics. The interview with Henry Resnik in 1966 which Flieger considers in "But What Did He Really Mean" and in "The Arch and the Keystone" appeared in the *Saturday Evening Post*, with a lengthier transcript appearing in *Niekas* 18 in 1967. Also, Tolkien's letter to Father Robert Murray in 1953, which is also considered in both of Flieger's articles, was extensively quoted in a piece by Murray himself which was published on 15 September 1973 (shortly after Tolkien's death) in the periodical *The Tablet*. At least one of the critics considered in my article was aware of that source—William Dowie, who quoted from it at length.

⁵ This is by no means a clear-cut division. There are borderline cases which might have been placed in a different group, though in my view the division is a sound one, and supports a structured approach.

figures. It is not a series of contradictions in the work that give rise to these competing views—it is the ambiguity that leaves the (critical) field wide open for interpretation. Turning to critics who acknowledged and examined the combination of pagan and Christian elements, they observed the elegiac tone of the former interacting with the moral and ethical themes of the latter, and with an optimistic view of good triumphing over evil. Some saw a tension and even an opposition between these two sides, where the conflict was primarily identified as one of tone. Questions of tone are less clear-cut—perhaps more ambiguous—than those of (say) theology or doctrine, and a blending of elegiac and joyful tone does not of itself represent a contradiction between a pagan and a Christian view of the world. What all of this suggests is that it is ambiguity rather than contradiction that leads critics to take such opposing views on this point.

PAGAN (AND NON-CHRISTIAN) VIEWS

In the period up to 1981, there were relatively few critical responses to *The Lord of the Rings* that focused solely on a pagan interpretation. The first such response came early, with Douglass Parker's article that appeared in the Winter 1956/57 issue of *The Hudson Review*. Parker is definitive—in his view, *The Lord of the Rings* is a pagan work, a recreation of *Beowulf* as Tolkien understood it, where "the unknown West Saxon" wrote of a world where Fate "has not yet wholly become a Christian god" and governs the universe in an impersonal way. Parker felt that Tolkien had "toiled well and successfully after his paradigm" and had created a story where humans and their endeavours are confronted by evil and are doomed to be lost, to fade, perish, or die. In the face of all this, the only valid response—and one which demonstrates the heroism in the work—is to face up to this tragedy of the human condition. This gives *The Lord of the Rings* a meaning which Parker calls "heroic-elegiac." Parker acknowledges the possibility of a Christian view of the work only in order to deny it—he feels that the promise of immortality (for elves and a few hobbits) is not sufficient to treat the work as anything other than pagan (608–9).

Over a decade later, two articles appeared in 1969 which both took a pagan view, though from rather different perspectives. Nan Braude compares the differing mythopoeic approaches of Tolkien, C.S. Lewis, and Charles Williams. On Tolkien, she says that his materials are "traditional archetypes" and that the foremost literary sources are Teutonic and Celtic myth (6). Of most interest however, is the contrast drawn with the overt Christian elements in Lewis and Williams, where Braude observes that "*The Lord of the Rings* is 'pagan' in the sense that it is to be read only in terms of itself: it does not point outwards to a greater reality, thus admitting its own insufficient reality" (7). Compared to the heroic-elegiac qualities described by Parker, this is a rather different understanding of what it means for a work of literature to be pagan. This serves

as a useful reminder that the term “pagan” (and the term “Christian”) can mean different things to different people—here it might be more appropriate to consider Braude’s view as “non-Christian,” especially in view of the reason for her distinction between Tolkien on the one hand, and Lewis and Williams on the other.

The other article that appeared in 1969 was by Charles Moorman (“Now Entertain Conjecture of a Time”). He takes a similar view to Parker, though expands the analysis. Middle-earth is “essentially pagan in conception”—a world where “heroic patterns may evolve.” Moorman adds that “Middle-earth, or at least certain portions of it, is the stark, basically pessimistic world of the sagas in which God does not intervene in human conflicts and in which the hero’s or the society’s struggle against evil culminates at best in a temporary victory achieved at tremendous cost” (62). He also observes pagan qualities both at the level of the individual (heroes such as Frodo paying “a high cost for victory”) and at the level of civilizations—with no hearkening back to a golden age (unlike in Narnia), and with outposts of light surrounded by darkness, which Moorman recognises as a theme from pagan heroic literature in the Western tradition (64–66). It is worth noting however a subtle difference between Moorman’s pagan interpretation and that of Parker—while the latter identified some meaning and value in the human struggle against inevitable loss and failure, the former suggests a more pessimistic and fatalistic tone: “evil must be combatted simply because it is a part of the heroic code to do so” (63). In terms of the possibility of a Christian interpretation, Moorman shuts the door on this, saying that the work “is in no way theological either in its structure or in its thematic pattern” (and note the implication that paganism cannot have a theology) (62). Just as Braude did, he contrasts Middle-earth with Narnia, primarily in terms of tone, so that the former is “bittersweet” with “no undiluted joy, no pure eucatastrophe” (68). He observes an opposition between Christian and heroic values, where forgiveness is incompatible with vendetta, and where the Christian view is “unflaggingly optimistic” (62).

Several critics identified in *The Lord of the Rings* a religious scheme, but one which is not explicitly pagan nor Christian. Their views indicate a way of looking at the ethical or spiritual value of the work without any doctrinal associations. The first of these critics was Patricia Meyer Spacks, whose 1959 article examined the work’s moral and theological scheme, noting that “for this scheme, there are no explicit supernatural sanctions: *The Lord of the Rings* is by no means a Christian work” (30). Spacks appears to take the same approach as both Parker and Braude—if a work displays no overt Christianity, it is not a Christian work. Spacks adds that religious practices are not apparent—nor is there an evident deity: “a clear ethos rules the virtuous, but its derivation is unclear.” That ethos is exemplified by the hobbits, by their virtues—loyalty,

cheerfulness in adversity, persistence, honesty, humility, and most of all, “naked will and courage” (quoting here from *Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics*) (31). Spacks sees in the destruction of the Ring, in spite of Frodo’s failure at the Cracks of Doom, a triumph of Fate—though not the impersonal *wyrd* of the pagan tradition—over the human failure of the will (34). As will be seen below, critics who took a Christian view could make the very same point about the human will, with Christian Providence taking the place of Fate. Although Spacks takes no firm position on the doctrine of the work, she does still identify elements which she characterises as pagan or Christian: the ethos which she has described above is closest to a pagan ethos, where Frodo remains steadfast in the face of overwhelming opposition (33); and the theological scheme of Middle-earth has Christian parallels, with “the possibility of a sort of Grace” (34) and where “the result of repeated choices of good is the spiritual growth of the chooser” (37).

Ten years after Spacks, Gracia Fay Ellwood would cover similar ground in a 1969 article whose main thrust was the treatment of good and evil in *The Lord of the Rings*. She considered archetypes and the universality of hero myths in human societies, as well as religious aspects and functions of such myths, without focusing on any particular doctrine or religion. Ellwood observes that in Tolkien’s work “there is no god visible beyond a hazy reference in an appendix to ‘the One,’ but the drawing power of the Uttermost West, the suggestion that Frodo was ‘meant’ to find the Ring, the preservation of Gollum, all show providential planning at work” (“Good Guys” 11). Ellwood makes no claim that such planning is the work of a Christian God—and indeed she includes a footnote (when making the observation quoted above) that refers to Spacks’s 1959 article.

Two further critics also saw in *The Lord of the Rings* elements that were religious in character without necessarily being Christian. In 1970, Bruce A. Beatie sought to explain the underlying reasons for what he dubs the “Tolkien phenomenon,” observing that the work has a mythical structure which speaks to something religious but which is rooted more deeply in the human condition than any one particular religion or dogma. He refers to the work of “archaeologist-historian” Gertrude Rachel Levy as having identified “the continuity of both symbolism and *structures* of religious thought, though the function and context of those symbols and structures change, from the Stone Age to the golden age of Athens.” Beatie adds that Levy would recognise the same structures in *The Lord of the Rings* (698). The Quest-myth in the work implies an ordered universe where the choices of an individual can have lasting significance. Such choices have as a backdrop “Fate, or God, or Augustinian predestination.” Although he allows for these contrasting backdrops, and is more concerned with concepts that are free of any particular doctrine, Beatie does say—though merely in parentheses—that the work “is basically Christian,

in spite of the lack of overt symbols" (699). Providing no further analysis on this point, one is left with the impression that any such identification is, for him, secondary to the mythical significance he describes.

In 1974, William Dowie's article (which was reprinted with revisions in 1979) also looked at religious, non-Christian characteristics of *The Lord of the Rings*. He noted that "the religiosity of Tolkien's trilogy is neither conceptualized nor dogmatized within the story. Yet the sense of the sacred is present in blood and symbol and theme. It is the unvocalized religion of man in touch with nature and the cosmos" (266–67). Dowie's analysis, which forms the first half of his article, draws a number of parallels between the text, and concepts or themes in Mircea Eliade's *The Sacred and the Profane*. In introducing this analysis, Dowie says that "the disagreement over whether Tolkien's eschatology is guided more by Christian or by Norse ideology misses the point that Tolkien plunges into the sacrality of the natural" (267). This argument is however rather weakened by the second half of the article, where Dowie identifies in the work certain Christian (but not pagan) moral and intellectual themes, which he also observes are present "in a context that has no explicit trappings of religion." Dowie suggests that this obfuscation of overt Christianity has a purpose—a way of "unobtrusively exploring the sacred" that "allows a fresh emotional contact with ideas that might otherwise be categorically prejudged." As will be seen below, this is a similar observation to those made by some other critics who have seen in *The Lord of the Rings* a pagan vehicle for delivering a Christian message—Dowie in fact cites one of these critics, Gunnar Urang, who had referred to the technique as "repaganizing" (274–75).

Some key themes emerge from these pagan and non-Christian views. The identification of *The Lord of the Rings* as pagan was (for Parker and Moorman, if not for Braude) a consequence of a tone which is heroic-elegiac, pessimistic, where human actions and achievements will ultimately be defeated by opposing forces. Other critics saw religious aspects which were not necessarily Christian—in particular, that the will and the actions of individuals are part of a universe which is influenced, ordered or directed by a higher power; and that there are structures and themes that speak to myths and archetypes that run "deeper" than organised religion. One important point relates not to something that was present, but something that was absent—many of these critics noted the absence of overt signs of Christianity. What is particularly interesting is that this same observation could lead to directly opposing conclusions. For Parker, Braude, Moorman and Spacks, *The Lord of the Rings* is pagan or non-Christian, in part *because of* this absence. For Beatie and Dowie, the work is Christian (at least in part), *in spite of* this absence. These competing views are possible because the lack of overt Christianity results in a Middle-earth that is ambiguous, at least in theological terms.

CHRISTIAN VIEWS

During the period to 1981, critical responses to *The Lord of the Rings* that focused on Christian elements in the work were more common than those that took a pagan or non-Christian view. While seven articles were considered in the previous section, sixteen will be considered here. These present a wide range of themes, characteristics and parallels which the critics identified as Christian.

Edmund Fuller wrote about Tolkien and *The Lord of the Rings* in *Books With Men Behind Them*, first published in 1962 (his chapter on Tolkien was revised and reprinted in Isaacs and Zimbardo's *Tolkien and the Critics* in 1968). Fuller observes that "In this story there is no overt theology or religion. There is no mention of God. No one is worshipped." He qualifies this by acknowledging that a "limited eschatology" is implied, though he does not say that it is a Christian one (29). All of that said, Fuller proceeds to focus on the Christian context of the work, by citing an aspect of the Christian tradition, before describing its equivalent in Middle-earth. Here he considers both the presence of a divine power that intervenes in the affairs of the world; and the interaction between Providence and free will (together with the importance of taking action) (29–30). Fuller also suggests that Gandalf and Frodo may be seen "not as Christ equivalents, but as partial anticipations of the Christ," noting Frodo's heavy burden and Gandalf's resurrection, as well as the latter's temptation to wield the Ring (35).

Two papers presented at the Tolkien conference that took place at Mankato State College in October 1966 gave particular consideration to Christian themes. Dorothy K. Barber examines the meaning of *The Lord of the Rings* through, amongst other things, the use of primary world figurative language as literal in the secondary world—looking for example at the association of light with God. Barber's conclusion identifies the destruction of the Ring as divinely ordained: "This climactic scene affirms the *evangelium*: Providence, or Good, or God, does exist and act in the affairs of Middle-earth in the continuing struggle against Evil" (49). In his conference paper (whose focus is heroism), Alexis Levitin observes that there is a Christian theme in Frodo's failure: "Human weakness is an everpresent theme in Christian literature, and even the heroes do not completely escape its effect." He adds that "Frodo, having carried the Ring, beyond all expectations, to the brink of destruction, cannot put the seal to all his previous acts. The implication seems to be that no fallen man could have done so" (32). This triumph of Providence over the failure of the will is the same point made by Spacks (noted above) though with Fate taking the place of Providence. One further point made by Levitin concerns the difference between a pagan and a Christian concept of endurance against the odds: "The Norse hero fights on in the face of defeat for the sake of fame, which he hopes will survive him. Frodo and Sam persevere out of duty alone" (33).

However, this particular distinction seems open to debate—Charles Moorman, in a 1972 article which will be considered further below, quoted E.V. Gordon on the pagan heroic view of the universe, with an emphasis more on courage than on fame: “the hero resisted to the end, and won satisfaction from fate, in being master of his life while he had it. [...] He might win the struggle, or he might know that it was hopeless; but it was better to die resisting than to live basely” (qtd. in Moorman, “Heroism” 30).

In a 1966 article, Donald Reinken looked with a Christian perspective at the philosophical and political relevance of Tolkien’s work for the modern world. He argues that the plot turns on the workings of Providence, where Frodo’s virtues are insufficient to complete the task on their own account. In accepting the “insufficient, finite good” and the “vainly rebellious evil” of earthly creatures, Providence “achieves good beyond human power or foretelling.” Reinken notes the absence in *The Lord of the Rings* of religious practices or references to God—but says that in spite of this, the apparent divine ordering of the world demonstrates that the work is “a powerful testimony” to God. He also goes on to suggest that the absence of overt Christianity is a deliberate means of conveying a Christian message without seeming to do so, the work being addressed to a secular age, which can be led “from a vulgar irreligion to God” (9). As noted above, Dowie would make the same observation in his 1974 article.

In a review essay for *The New York Review of Books* in 1967, Matthew Hodgart considered a range of topics, including some brief commentary on Christian elements. Tolkien is, with *The Lord of the Rings*, conveying a Christian message: “isn’t the book really a parable, consciously aimed at putting across the general Christian view that the universe is a battlefield between the forces of good and evil?” He then describes Frodo as a Christ-like figure, because of his suffering, and his sacrifice which saves the Shire, not to mention being “stripped of his garments, flogged by the soldiery, scratched by thorns.” It is worth noting that Hodgart is roundly critical of such a (perceived) aim of the work—conveying a message which he sees as “infantile” (11).

In a 1968 article on religious aspects of *The Lord of the Rings*, Sandra Miesel observes that “the remoteness and silence of Tolkien’s unworshipped One is typical of primitive theology,” but at the same time she maintains that “while the cultural framework is religionless, the attitudes expressed within it are traditional Christian ones” (210). Miesel says that the work presents an Augustinian view of good and evil (with the latter being a perversion of the former); that humility is a hallmark of the good and is opposed by arrogance; and that Frodo is a Christ figure who “willingly dies to the joy of living” (210–11).

Paul Pfothenhauer in his 1969 article lays out several Christian themes, the principal one concerning Providence. He quotes the familiar words of

Gandalf (“Bilbo was *meant* to find the Ring”) and Elrond (“the purpose for which you are called hither”) and says that “in all these events Tolkien is saying that events are finally shaped by a Power that remains unseen, goes almost unnoticed, and sometimes uses the most unlikely persons as His agents” (13–14). Pfothenhauer makes the point however that this does not deny free will—indeed claiming that *The Lord of the Rings* is amongst the best commentaries he has read on Augustine’s view that predestination and free will are two sides of the same coin (14). Two further Christian elements treated rather more briefly are temptation (to use the Ring) (14); and self-sacrifice (“Gandalf, Aragorn, Frodo, and Sam, are each in their own way Christ figures”) (14).

Catherine Stimpson’s booklet on Tolkien, in the series *Columbia Essays on Modern Writers*, appeared in 1969 and levelled criticism (at times harsh) at many aspects of Tolkien’s output. In this, there are some brief references to Christian elements in *The Lord of the Rings*. Gandalf and Frodo are seen as Christ-like figures—the former experiences “Christlike suffering” which “shows most clearly Tolkien’s growing religious concern and use of obvious Christian parallels” (34), and Sam is described as “a faithful Peter to Frodo’s Christ” (38). Stimpson also equates the Uttermost West with a Christian afterlife: “though the lands the boats of Círdan seek are heathen in name, they signify the Christian concept of redemption” (40–41).

One further article from 1969 appeared in the collection *Shadows of Imagination* (on Tolkien, C.S. Lewis, and Charles Williams). Although his article has a wider scope, Gunnar Urang identified two particular qualities which demonstrate a Christian theme in *The Lord of the Rings*. One is a providential design, apparent in the “sense of the interrelatedness of all the elements in this ‘history’ and of an ordering of all these elements to one end” (103–104). The other is an eschatology which is essentially biblical: “What the hobbits have become enmeshed in is a decisive struggle of cosmic scope. This is, of course, the imagery of biblical eschatology; the end is not an apex, but a crisis” (105). Urang shows conviction in his Christian view, though he also introduces a pagan perspective, referring to Tolkien’s 1936 lecture on *Beowulf*. He quotes him on how the poet knew “both the newer Christian poetry and the older heroic verse and could contemplate the new faith and learning and the native tradition together.” Urang then cites Tolkien’s observation on the language of the poet: “partly ‘re-paganized’ by the author with a special purpose.” This brings Urang to his point—*The Lord of the Rings* is also re-paganized, and with a special purpose: “Tolkien is at once committed to certain insights of traditional Christian belief and aware of the modern man’s scepticism about many of those insights. Therefore, ‘re-paganization’” (106). Here then is a view of Tolkien’s work as a Trojan horse for the Christian faith, a view expressed by Reinken in

1966 and which Dowie would repeat in 1974 (quoting Urang's use of the term "re-paganization").⁶

Gracia Fay Ellwood in her 1970 monograph *Good News from Tolkien's Middle-earth* examines the concept of the hero, but more particularly the figures who can be seen as Christ-like. Her analysis is more detailed than the references to Christ-like figures made up to this point by other critics. Ellwood observes that "Gandalf is essentially a type-hero; he resembles Christ largely insofar as Christ is also a type-hero who fights the evil one, dies, and returns to life. The other two [Frodo and Aragorn] are type-heroes as well, but have much more definite resemblances to the specific figure of Jesus" (104). Gandalf is said to be Christ-like chiefly because of his fight with the Balrog, the associated descent into an abyss, and his eventual resurrection (much close biblical analysis is provided) (113–18). Other resemblances, such as the healing of Théoden, the flood of the Bruinen, and resisting the temptation to use the Ring, are "too vague to be convincing" (113). Frodo's position as a Christ-like figure is closer to the human figure of Jesus because of his down-to-earth nature, and his love of physical pleasures, providing the backdrop and contrast to the privations he suffers on his journey (121–22). There are also resemblances to the Passion—the betrayal by Gollum at Cirith Ungol, Frodo stripped and beaten by the orcs, falling into thorns, suffering from a terrible thirst, "but above all, the crushing weight of the symbol of Evil, increasing as it nears the centre of the hell where it originated" (125–26). Aragorn is then considered ("an image of Christ the King") where the parallels include a royal lineage touched by prophecy, great feats of prowess (such as the descent into and emergence from the Paths of the Dead), and the glory of the events of the Field of Cormallen (134–41).

In a 1971 article, Willis B. Glover considers the Christian character of Middle-earth. He acknowledges that "Middle Earth in the Third Age is depicted without religion" and that the only mention of God is to be found in the reference to "the One" in Appendix A to *The Lord of the Rings*. Glover argues however that Middle-earth is—in a sense—a Christian world, since Tolkien was a Christian. He also notes that "it is monotheistic in the peculiar sense of the Biblical tradition" (3). Glover then identifies a range of elements to support his argument. First, Middle-earth is a non-dualistic world where evil is a corruption of good ("the Biblical world of the good creation") (3). Second, Providence is directed by a transcendent power, while still allowing for free will (5). Third,

⁶ These views on a covert message in *The Lord of the Rings* are also reminiscent of what C.S. Lewis said in a 1956 article in *The New York Times*, on the subject of fairy-stories as a vehicle for a Christian message: "But supposing that by casting all these things into an imaginary world, stripping them of their stained-glass and Sunday school associations, one could make them for the first time appear in their real potency? Could one not thus steal past those watchful dragons? I thought one could."

there is a Biblical structure to history in the sense of being non-cyclical (unlike the pagan view where “the pattern eternally recurs”)—and which can transcend and even control nature itself (5–6). Finally there are some brief concluding remarks on elements of Christian ethics such as forgiveness and redemption (citing Boromir), and pity (citing Gollum) (8). Perhaps the most striking point made by Glover is his suggestion that a monotheistic world with no mention of God, but where there is an awareness of an outside agency, is a concept “peculiar to the Biblical tradition and traditions deriving in considerable measure out of it including modern non-Christian humanism.” This association between a Biblical tradition and humanism lies in the latter’s search for meaning in a world where faith in God has waned and where atheism finds no meaning. Here Glover finds a reason for the appeal of Tolkien’s work: “it satisfies vicariously a nostalgia for a more meaningful world without making any demands of faith or change in belief” (5).

Clyde S. Kilby contributed a chapter to the 1974 collection *Myth, Allegory and Gospel* which examined Tolkien’s work as well as that of C.S. Lewis, Charles Williams, and G.K. Chesterton. Kilby’s chapter, on mythic and Christian elements in Tolkien, surveys a wide range of Christian elements and themes. He identifies the struggle between good and evil, reflected in the dichotomies of light and dark, and white and black (“one of the most obvious Christian intimations”) (129). He observes the directing power of Providence—and addressing the oft-heard argument that Lewis’s work is more overtly Christian, Kilby argues that Tolkien’s position here is not so different from Lewis’s—“one finds frequent parallels in which the veil is hardly less transparent in Tolkien’s story,” before adding that “in both a sovereign Good is constantly and consistently operative” (132). Kilby also notes the presence of Christ-like figures—Gandalf’s fall and resurrection, and Frodo’s suffering and struggle through Mordor (133–34). He identifies the qualities of pity, mercy and redemption demonstrated by certain characters, exemplified by the case of Frodo and Gollum, though also citing the fact of Frodo contemplating the possibility of redemption for Saruman (137). One final theme is the exercise of the will, as demonstrated by Frodo’s continued efforts, especially through Mordor: “the element of will in the Tolkien story rises above that of simple Stoicism and takes on something at least of a Christian color,” adding that “Saint Augustine’s doctrine of the effective will is well illustrated by Frodo” (138–39).

In a 1975 article, Cheryl Forbes argues that the tension between free will and Providence is one of the most compelling themes in *The Lord of the Rings*. There is significance in the need for characters to make choices—between the right way and the wrong way—and where the right choice is often unclear. Temptation and its interaction with the will is also considered, exemplified by Frodo’s relationship with the Ring: “The hobbit wants to resist the ring while he

longs to yield to it. In yielding to temptation he acts what he does not will; in this Tolkien captures the struggle of every Christian" (11). Forbes adds that Frodo's inability to cast the Ring into the fire demonstrates "the futility of trusting in free will" and that Providence achieves its aims as "the quest is accomplished regardless of Frodo's choice" (12). This view of the inadequacy of the will is similar to that expressed earlier by both Spacks and Levitin.

Of the three remaining articles, two make relatively narrow points in relation to Christian themes, whereas the other takes a very broad sweep. George Boswell's 1972 article (only considered now as the Christian point is a brief one) examines the "intentions, materials, methods, themes, and achievement" of *The Lord of the Rings* (188). The one observation on Christian themes argues that the concept of vicarious sacrifice is "the central communication of the entire work," exemplified by Frodo saving the Shire for others but not for himself (197). James Lynch trod a less well-beaten path with his 1978 article, which concerns how parties, feasts and banquets represent "a highly concrete pattern which indicates how Tolkien's Christianity informs his thought" (13). Two particular events are associated with Christian parallels: the feast given by Elrond at Rivendell has a particularly spiritual quality in so far as it is nourishing, in spite of the fact that "the food there is never described"; and the lembas gifted by Galadriel "is Tolkien's clearest description of magical, holy food. Here he comes closest to making an analogy between the meal and the Eucharistic feast" (14). Finally, Bruce Palmer's 1976 monograph presents a wide sweep of Christian parallels. These include the Uttermost West (inhabited by the Valar) representing an afterlife (8–9); the invocation of Elbereth, in a way reminiscent of invocations of the Virgin Mary, when the hobbits meet Gildor early in their journey; at the same meeting, the food and drink that is shared having a sacred and spiritual power (15–16); the phial of Galadriel containing a holy power of light, and the earth given to Sam representing something of an Edenic garden (21–22); the blessing given when Faramir and his companions eat, being reminiscent of saying grace before a meal (23); the sacrifice of Frodo to save the Shire (26–27); and the glory present in the events of the Field of Cormallen (25–26).

Several recurring themes emerge from this review of Christian interpretations of *The Lord of the Rings*. Foremost is that of Providence, the guiding hand of a higher power, interested in the affairs of Middle-earth and working behind the scenes to ensure the success of good against evil. Critics did not however see in this a deterministic universe—they identified the importance of the free will exercised by the characters and sought to understand this in the context of Providence. Some were more interested in the fine balance between Providence and will (Fuller, Pfotenhauer, Glover) whereas others took a view with more emphasis on the frailty of the will (Levitin, Reinken, Forbes).

Although sometimes connected to the workings of Providence, some critics saw the opposition of good and evil as a theme in its own right, arguing that the cosmic struggle found in the events of Middle-earth is essentially Christian (Barber, Hodgart, Kilby) and that it presents a non-dualistic, Augustinian perspective (Miesel, Glover). Another recurring theme is that of Christ-like figures in the narrative. Frodo, with his suffering and his sacrifice, is the foremost of these, followed by Gandalf, with his resurrection. Aragorn can be seen as Christ the King, and even Sam is identified by one critic as Christ-like (though another equates him with Peter). One further theme concerned the Christian significance of the pity and mercy shown by Frodo to Gollum, and the possibility of redemption for characters such as Boromir and Saruman.

What then of the relationship between these Christian views of *The Lord of the Rings* and the pagan views seen earlier? To the extent that they contradict each other, it seems to me that the contradiction lies more in the labels being applied, than in the substance of what is being labelled. Providence looms large in the Christian themes considered above, though as we have seen, it was also acknowledged by some that there is little overt Christianity in the work (Fuller, Reinken, Urang). One may recall that critics who viewed *The Lord of the Rings* as pagan or non-Christian could just as readily see this lack of overt Christianity as evidence for their own (opposing) view. Such opposition is therefore anchored more in the perspective of the critic than in any contradiction in the work itself—after all, they agree on what they see (or don't see!)—they just don't agree on what that *means*. A pagan or non-Christian view could look at the hints of a higher power intervening in the events of Middle-earth, and label this not as Providence, but as Fate, be it impersonal (Parker) or otherwise (Spacks); as some unnamed higher power (Ellwood); or as a manifestation of natural religion (Dowie). Whatever Tolkien really meant, he did not nail his colours to the mast, and this ambiguity opens the door to competing interpretations—but ambiguity is not contradiction. Similarly, a cosmic struggle between good and evil may appear, to a Christian, to be a very Christian affair—though adherents of many other religions (and those who subscribe to none) may beg to differ. Both Parker and Moorman identified a struggle against evil as a characteristic of their pagan interpretations, and good and evil were the focus of Ellwood's 1969 article which was free of a Christian interpretation. Whatever the label, the substance remains the same—a struggle between good and evil. Another theme which reveals some of this ambiguity is that of Christ-like figures in the work. What do critics see when they identify such figures? Foremost are the suffering and sacrifice of Frodo, and the resurrection of Gandalf. Such qualities might point towards something messianic, but at the same time they are not *necessarily* so. Sacrifice and suffering can be seen as heroic qualities—indeed Ellwood's analysis of Christ-figures in her 1970 monograph argues that "Christ is also a type-hero

who fights the evil one, dies, and returns to life" ("Good News" 104). If some critics label Frodo as Christ-like, while others label him as a hero without such associations, his suffering and his sacrifice remain the same.

A MARRIAGE OF THE PAGAN AND THE CHRISTIAN

As we have seen, one view of *The Lord of the Rings* is that it is a covertly Christian work, delivering its message without appearing to do so, simply by avoiding doctrine and dogma or by presenting the whole in an attractively pagan setting (Reinken, Urang). Whether one subscribes to this view or not (and even if one does, the question remains whether this was done deliberately), it suggests a means by which the Christian and the pagan co-exist within the work. Even without a crypto-Christian purpose, a marriage of pagan and Christian elements was recognised and considered by many critics in the period to 1981, and to them I will now turn.

From a scholarly perspective at least, Charles Moorman was not a man to take a narrow view, nor to remain stuck in his ways. Already we have seen how (in his 1969 article) he argued for an essentially pagan view of *The Lord of the Rings*. As we will see below, just 3 years later he would repudiate (at least in part) that view, making a case for a Christian interpretation. Before either of these articles, Moorman considered both sides, in a chapter on Tolkien in his 1966 monograph *Precincts of Felicity: The Augustinian City of the Oxford Christians* (reprinted in Isaacs and Zimbardo's *Tolkien and the Critics* in 1968). Here, he describes *The Lord of the Rings* as "essentially a Nordic myth" (201), adding later that "the greatest single influence on Tolkien is the eddas and sagas of the North." He speaks of how "the great Nordic theme of courage—courage to grapple not only with human foes, but with the monsters of the outer darkness—runs through *The Lord of the Rings* as it does through *Beowulf*" (212). Alongside all of this is a clear statement of a structure to the work that reflects a strongly Christian theme—the journey of Frodo, the quest of the myth hero, in a way that reflects in Augustinian terms "the establishment of the City of God on Earth" (Minas Tirith) and where the Shire and Mordor represent the Earthly City (210). Moorman does not however place these pagan and Christian elements in relation to each other.

One of the earliest clear statements of the interaction of pagan and Christian elements appeared in a review essay by Michael Wood in *New Society* in 1969. Wood describes the theology of *The Lord of the Rings* as "an extraordinary synthesis of heroic northern myth and Christian promise." He states that Tolkien believes in Christian Providence but also that "within Time the monsters win." The capitalisation of "Time" is significant—this reveals how Wood sees the two concepts co-existing, for Time is terrestrial: "the treats come later, in the islands of the blessed." However, such co-existence does not, for

Wood, deny a tension where the heroic theme of the work “seems strangely at odds” with its elegiac tone (493). Another critic who saw a synthesis of the pagan and the Christian was C. Stuart Hannabuss, who at the start of a 1971 article set out his view with great clarity: “I believe that Tolkien was working out a quasi-Christian morality in pagan terms, using a former culture and literary tradition to furnish the scenario to a quest which incorporated the major issues of Life” (87). Hannabuss observed a dualistic struggle between the “broadly good and bad” which he characterises as Christian in so far as the good are victorious—and yet the victory is “almost Pyrrhic: so clearly do the heroes anticipate and acknowledge defeat that we are in the world of Beowulf and the Norse sagas” (87–88). There is more too from a Christian perspective, with subconscious allusions to Christian iconography (the Nazgûl as the Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse, Gandalf on a white horse evoking the text of Revelation)—though there is something running deeper: “subsuming the overtly Biblical is the story which can in poetry mirror man’s dilemmas and look Life in the eye” (93–94).

In a 1972 monograph on Tolkien, Robley Evans acknowledges both pagan and Christian elements in *The Lord of the Rings*. In similar terms to Wood, he recognises a fusion between the two, while acknowledging their opposition: “the elegiac tone of Tolkien’s fantasies” being “contrary to the Christian joy of affirmation associated with the romance [genre]” (83). Thus the romance Quest reveals meaning and order in the universe while the Northern European tradition encapsulates “man’s struggle to preserve something of civilization for a little while against the dark, perhaps nameless, forces that will triumph over him in the end” (84). Evans sees the tension and opposition as one reason for the work’s power: “[Tolkien] is an author who can make his sense of joy and of fate profitable because they can be played off against each other” (84).

Also in 1972, Moorman issues the corrective referred to above, disavowing his “earlier identification of Tolkien as an underground pagan” (“Heroism” 31). The use of the word “underground” is curious here—I am not able to discern, in his 1969 article, any indication of Moorman equating Tolkien’s personal world view with the pagan qualities of his work. In any event, Moorman explains that his *volte-face* is grounded in a close and uninterrupted reading of the Frodo-Samwise narrative, “skipping the adventures of the other members of the Fellowship, a narrative which, though necessary, is none-the-less peripheral” (29). His conclusion from this reading is that the heroism encapsulated in the Frodo-Samwise narrative is characterised by “specifically Christian ethical qualities—endurance, humility, mercy, and purity—as opposed to the more usual heroic values—courage, prowess, loyalty” (35). Furthermore, in the same vein as Levitin, Reinken and Forbes, Moorman identifies a Christian theme in the ultimate failure of the will to achieve the destruction of the Ring, so that this climactic scene suggests that “God, using

Satan's own weakness, his greed for power, must snatch victory from defeat on behalf of man" (38). While those other critics took a firmly Christian view, Moorman continues to recognise the significance of pagan elements in the work. We have already seen how he draws the distinction between Christian ethical qualities and the "usual" heroic virtues, and he argues that *The Lord of the Rings* is "a mixture of pagan spirit and Christian ethos [...] in which the proportions defy measurement" (38). Hard as it might be to measure these proportions, Moorman does offer a view on a key touchpoint between the two—the exercise of free will. In the absence of a clear or overt divine influence, what matters are the actions of the hero: "it is this emphasis on the free will of the individual and his responsibility to common humanity which provides a link between Tolkien's Christianity and his paganism" (32). Moorman, in similar terms to Evans, also argues that the tension and opposition between these two (an "ambivalence of value") is a prime reason for the greatness of the work (38).

Three further critics writing in the first half of the 1970s would also observe a combination of Christian and pagan (or "pre-Christian") elements in *The Lord of the Rings*, though without identifying a tension or opposition between the two. In a 1972 article, Douglas Barbour sees some truth in how Parker highlights the heroic-elegiac tone of the work, but feels that Parker does not allow room for the optimism that reflects Tolkien's Christian perspective, adding that Tolkien does not follow the *Beowulf* poet in accepting defeat for both gods and heroes as an inevitable outcome: "for his imagination is powerfully Christian, and he sees the victory of good as always possible" (36). Thus Parker's view is too narrow: "it is not just the elegiac feeling which is produced" (38). Paul Kocher in a 1972 monograph looks at Tolkien's treatment of good and evil, and sees in this "how far Tolkien wishes his treatment of evil to be considered not only moral but metaphysical," (76) though adding a note of caution against "forc[ing] a literary masterpiece into any tight philosophical mold, Thomistic or otherwise. Middle-earth is avowedly pre-Christian" (77). At the same time, Kocher observes in the work "a general foundation of natural theology in the areas of moral norms and the working out of a providential cosmic order," with the consequence that the free peoples of Middle-earth have a status "which if not precisely Christian is still very much like it in overall tone" (84–85). In a 1974 monograph, Randel Helms looks at the fusion of pagan and Christian elements in the context of Tolkien's *Beowulf* lecture. Helms notes how Tolkien defended the poem from charges that it is a "deeply flawed mixture of pagan and Christian" before adding that "Tolkien urges that this very fusion is the source of much of the poem's power." Helms argues that the defense of the *Beowulf* poet (in Helms's words, "already himself on the Christian side but still imaginatively alive to the ancient traditions") is just as powerful a defense of Middle-earth, noting for example that the monsters in both tales are enemies of

mankind as well as enemies of God. That being said, Helms sees in *The Lord of the Rings* (as did Urang) the same suppression of Christianity that Tolkien observed in *Beowulf*—though unlike Urang, he does not infer an apologetic purpose on Tolkien's part (5–6).

The last critic to be considered here made a similar observation to Wood, Evans and Moorman, concerning the tension and opposition between pagan and Christian elements in *The Lord of the Rings*. In a 1980 article whose principal thesis concerns Tolkien's use of humour, C.D. Stevens sees tension in "Tolkien's attempt to reconcile two disparate and sometimes conflicting sources of inspiration for his view of human existence: the 'Commedia' of the Christian mythos with the considerably bleaker view of the universe typified by much Anglo-Saxon poetry, including *Beowulf*." For Stevens, a result of this attempted reconciliation is "a tale in which comic reintegration and elegiac resignation struggle to dominate tone" (122). It is worth looking closely though at what Stevens says—the conflict he identifies is not in *The Lord of the Rings*, but in two sources of inspiration—the Christian and the pagan. Is this splitting hairs? I suggest not, for the distinction is important in considering whether (and how far) conflicting views on Tolkien's work may be a consequence of conflicts in the work. Stevens says that the Christian mythos is opposed to the pagan view of the universe. However, neither of these is lifted lock, stock and barrel into *The Lord of the Rings*. Indeed, Stevens observes that in Christian belief, "tragedy is frequently considered to have been rendered impossible by the twin facts of grace and redemption" but that "this attitude is modified in literature" (for example, by chance or by the freedom to accept or reject grace). He observes Christian elements in Tolkien's work, especially moral and ethical qualities, but notes at the same time an absence of "an assured destiny akin to the concept of salvation" (128). So where then is the conflict with the pagan world? As noted above, it is the *tone* of the work where Stevens sees a conflict, not for example in theology or doctrine.

Looking at these views of the marriage of pagan and Christian elements, a picture begins to emerge, where there is broad agreement that the dominant pagan element is the elegiac tone of the work, and that Christianity is represented by moral and ethical qualities, as well as by an optimistic (indeed, joyous) view of the victory of good over evil. Not all of the critics considered in this section make a point about tension or opposition between pagan and Christian elements—but those who do are in agreement that it is the tone of the work where the conflict lies (with the possible exception of Moorman who sees ambivalence in the value systems of the two). As noted above, we have an elegiac tone at odds with the theme of heroism (Wood), or opposed to Christian joy (Evans), or grappling with the Christian "Commedia" (Stevens). Even critics who made no particular point about tension or opposition saw tone as an

important part of the pagan-Christian dynamic—an elegiac feeling rubbing shoulders with the possibility of victory (Barber), or a Christian tone in a pre-Christian setting (Kocher). All of this is important, because tone is more elusive—and arguably more subjective—than theology or doctrine. It lends itself less to binary positions, and more to a spectrum of feeling. There is no Ragnarök in *The Lord of the Rings*, nor is there an Armageddon. There is sadness, and loss, mingled with hope, and joy. The mingling of such things does not mean that the work embodies an opposition between pagan and Christian views of the world. It means that it is bittersweet. So if critics and readers argue over whether the work is pagan or Christian, that argument is grounded to a far greater degree in their own perspectives, than to any contradiction in the work itself.

CONCLUSION

Many critics have identified *The Lord of the Rings* as essentially Christian. Many have identified in it a homage to a pagan world. In doing so, inferences have to be drawn and interpretations have to be made. Those inferences and interpretations all have the same point of departure—the work itself. Looking at critical responses up to 1981, the debate and disagreement between Christian and pagan views seems to have been a product not of contradictions in the work, but of its ambiguity, at least in theological matters. This ambiguity left the critical field open for scholars and critics, who would bring their wide range of perspectives to bear, to reach competing and even contradictory conclusions. For that reason, the period suggests that a more appropriate lens for viewing the pagan and Christian dynamic in *The Lord of the Rings* is that presented by Flieger in 2014 in “But What Did He Really Mean?,” where she highlights the ambiguity and indeterminacy of the work. The central part played by contradiction in her keystone analogy from 2019 makes that particular lens less fitting. It would be of interest to examine the pagan and Christian interpretations of the work after the publication of *The Letters of J.R.R. Tolkien* in 1981 (and the increased awareness of Tolkien’s own statements that would have followed), to see what role ambiguity and contradiction play in later interpretations. Furthermore, the pairs of contradictory labels presented in “The Arch and the Keystone” provide ample opportunity to examine specific threads in the history of Tolkien criticism, to look behind the labels, and to see just how far each of these reflects a tension and an opposition in Tolkien and his works.

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MATTHEW THOMPSON-HANDELL is an independent scholar with a particular interest in responses to Tolkien's work, both critical and popular. He has written articles for the *Journal of Tolkien Research*, *Beyond Bree* and *Angerthas* (the journal of Arthedain, the Tolkien Society of Norway).





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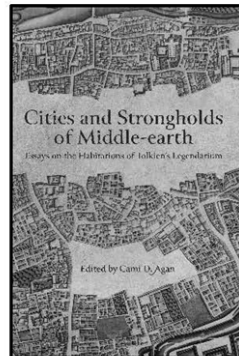
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AN ASPIRATIONAL CULTUS? TOLKIEN FANDOM AT THE BORDERS OF BELIEF

TOM EDMANUEL

PRELUDE: A DEPLORABLE CULTUS?

I HAVE ALWAYS FELT THAT CEMETERIES ARE TOLKIENIAN PLACES: the thoughtful stillness, the intertwining of natural rhythms and the work of human hands, the awareness of mortality and deep time. I grew up down the street from a historic graveyard, and it was not uncommon for visitors to find me sitting, cross-legged, in the shade of a honey locust tree with a dog-eared paperback in hand—perhaps my father’s Ballantine paperback copy of *The Return of the King*, the one with Barbara Remington’s unforgettable cover art. My younger self would have been overjoyed to know that twenty-odd years later he would find himself at J.R.R. Tolkien’s grave in Oxford with hundreds of likeminded others, summoned by our shared passion for Middle-earth and the man who wrote it into being. The occasion of our meeting is Oxonmoot, the annual gathering of the U.K. Tolkien Society, and our convergence upon Oxford’s Wolvercote Cemetery on this early September afternoon commemorates the fiftieth anniversary of our favorite author’s death.

Clad in everything from formalwear to faded T-shirts and handwoven cloaks, we wend our way through the headstones to the grave which Tolkien shares with his wife Edith. The chair of the Tolkien Society greets us and invites us into a space of quiet reflection—not difficult to achieve in a sunny graveyard in late summer. Having gathered our thoughts to Tolkien and the ways in which his works have touched our lives, we listen to a reading from the climax of *The Lord of the Rings* (*LotR*): the destruction of the One Ring and the fall of Barad-dûr, followed by Gandalf’s rescue of Sam and Frodo from the wrack of Mount Doom and the hobbits’ awakening amidst the green trees of Ithilien. When the reality of Sam’s deliverance dawns upon him and he cries aloud, “I feel like spring after winter, and sun on the leaves; and like trumpets and harps and all the songs I have ever heard” (*LotR* VI.4.952), tears pool at the corners of my eyes. Then the reading ends and the crowd lapses into contemplative silence. I glance around me: fellow attendees are withdrawing tissues from the pockets of their cosplay outfits, squeezing the hands of loved ones, weeping in earnest. At an unspoken signal, representatives of the Tolkien Society and other fan organizations lay memorial wreaths upon the Tolkiens’ grave. When this is done, a single unaccompanied voice rises in song:

“Namarië,” Galadriel’s hymn of parting to the Fellowship of the Ring in Lothlórien. When the music has died away, and there is nothing left but “sun on the leaves” (LotR VI.4.952) and wind in the grass, we breathe a sigh of relief that settles somewhere between nervous laughter and tears. The memorial, and by extension Oxonmoot, has reached its end. The time has come to bid each other goodbye.

Past attendees of Oxonmoot will recognize what I have just described as *Enyalië*, a word which means *remembrance* in Tolkien’s invented language Quenya. Ever since Tolkien’s death in 1973, fans have gathered at his graveside each September for this ritual of memory and appreciation. Yet as moved as I was by Enyalië 2023, I am not sure that Tolkien would have quite approved of it. In a 1965 letter, his friend W.H. Auden wrote to him “fear[ing] that most of the members” of the newly organized New York Tolkien Society “would be lunatics” (*The Letters of J.R.R. Tolkien* [Letters] 500, #275). Tolkien responded wearily: “Yes, I have heard about the Tolkien Society. Real lunatics don’t join them, I think. But still such things fill me too with alarm and despondency” (500). He would give the U.K. Tolkien Society his blessing four years later and serves, to this day, as its president *in perpetuo*. But there is little question that his relationship to his literary devotees was always one of ambivalence, leading him to infamously dub his burgeoning fandom “my deplorable cultus” (Carpenter 233). Given Tolkien’s philological background, it seems reasonable to assume that his use of the word “cultus,” with its strong religious connotations, was deliberate. The word “fan” itself has its origins in the Latin *fanaticus*, referring to temple devotees (Jenkins, *Textual Poachers* [Poachers] 12), and its emergence during the late nineteenth century as a descriptor for ardent lovers of sports and music was likely intended to evoke associations of religious enthusiasm (Cavicchi, “Foundational Discourses of Fandom” 29–30). Tolkien the philologist seems to have intuited what the history of the word implies: there is a connection between the passion of the fan and the devotion of the believer.

Given his apprehensions regarding his “cultus,” his Roman Catholic faith, and his insistence that his legendarium did not constitute “any kind of new religion or vision” (Letters 403, #211), Tolkien might well have eyed Enyalië with suspicion. Perhaps he would worry that we were engaged in idolatry, venerating him as a secular saint or literary deity. Superficially at least, there might be something to this: with its graveyard setting, communal readings, and meditative silences, the Enyalië I attended reminded me of nothing so much as Christian liturgy. But speaking as a practicing Christian, it did not threaten my religious commitments in any way; at no point was I concerned that we were worshiping Tolkien the man. If anything, the memorial’s worship-like structure made it *more* impactful for me, not less. What are we to make of this collision between Tolkien fandom and the trappings of faith?

In what follows I will attempt to answer this question, which is thornier than it might at first appear. I will first survey the state of scholarly debate around fandom and religion before outlining my own working definition of religion as *sacred worldbuilding*. I will link this to Tolkien's theory of fantasy worldbuilding in his essay "On Fairy-stories" (OFS) to propose a framework for understanding and researching the religious qualities and affordances of fandom as the activities of a *secondary faith community*. I will then use this framework to exegete Enyalië as a prime example of what might be called a *fan liturgy*, a powerful collective experience that takes religious form without carrying overt religious content. Having undertaken this interdisciplinary pilgrimage, I will arrive at my conclusion: that Tolkien's secondary world, his community of devoted fans, and the lineaments of Christian ritual have combined to produce, in Enyalië, a fan practice which troubles the boundaries between the sacred and the secular, the world(s) of fantasy literature and the world(s) of everyday experience. This would almost certainly have made J.R.R. Tolkien uncomfortable. But as I hope to show, it tells us something important about why his fiction remains compelling to so many people of so many faiths—and offers, perhaps, some lessons to existing communities of meaning in a pluralistic, post-Christian world.

GATHERING: SECONDARY BELIEVERS, SECONDARY WORLDS

As Tolkien inferred, there are many striking parallels between media fandom¹ and religion. Pioneering fan theorist Henry Jenkins (*Poachers* 17–18) writes of fans' intense identification with beloved characters and stories, while Matt Hills points out that fandom involves immersion in fantastic, "hyperdiegetic" worlds (104). John Lyden draws attention to fandom's careful exegesis of "canonical" texts (783–84), a commitment which can result in fiery debates with rival interpretive communities (cf. Walls-Thumma 93–95). These debates then result in exclusion along lines of race, gender, sexuality, and other axes of marginalization (Hannell 25, Pande 209, Stanfill 195, Thomas and Stornaiulo para. 3.1). What to make of these parallels is another matter. To paint an ongoing scholarly debate in broad strokes, there are three general "schools"

¹ I use the terms "fandom" and "media fandom" interchangeably in this essay to indicate fandoms which coalesce around narrative media: books, films, video games, television shows, and the like. Other forms of fandom obviously exist, such as music and sports fandom; but following Mark Duffett's lead (3), I exclude them from consideration for the sake of analytical clarity. I believe that the underlying dynamics of, say, sports fandom and media fandom are much closer than Duffett seems to think; Tolkien himself suggests as much when he compares the spell cast by fantasy to the spell cast by a game of cricket (OFS 51). However, folding other categories of fandom into my analysis would require more space than the present essay allows.

of interpretation within the field of fan studies. Scholars in the first school, including Michael Jindra (229), Candy Leonard (20–22), Jennifer Porter (279), and Jennifer Otter Bickerdike (8), claim that fandom either is a new religious movement or that it effectively replaces religion in an increasingly secularized culture. Those in the second school, such as Andrew Crome (413), Mark Duffett (146–47), and Henry Jenkins (*Fans, Gamers, and Bloggers* 17–18), reject the comparison, arguing that fandom lacks religion's exclusive ethical demands and transcendent frame of reference. Scholars in the third and final school take the real similarities between the two phenomena seriously without accepting a one-to-one correspondence between them, viewing fandom as an existential (Cavicchi, *Tramps Like Us* [*Tramps*] 188) or "neoreligious" (Hills 85) project of identity and community formation (Zubernis and Larsen 154–55).

In large part these debates come down to definitions of religion. Those who reject parallels between fandom and religion tend to use narrow *substantive definitions*, which are concerned with formal characteristics of religion such as institutional arrangements, doctrines, claims for the existence of supernatural agents, etc. Those who embrace the parallels prefer broad *functionalist definitions*, which are less about what religion "is" and more about what religion "does": the various functions it performs in the lives of individuals, communities, and societies. Those in the middle tend to blend functionalist and phenomenological approaches; the latter center on "the lived experience and perceptions of people in relation to religion and the sacred" (Lynch 128)—what religions "feels like" if you will. The definitions we use inescapably shape what we consider to be religious and, therefore, worthy of study. As Michael Elliott cautions, "if we insist on comparing fandoms to religion, then we need to be clear about which scholarly approaches we are using" (109). I intend to do just that.

For the purposes of this study, I draw upon both functionalist and phenomenological approaches to define religion as *sacred worldbuilding*. This is a creative adaptation of sociologist Peter Berger's definition of religion as "cosmization in a sacred mode" (26). For Berger, all human society and culture is worldbuilding activity. First and foremost this means the construction of a *meaningful* world, a symbolic cosmos within which humans can scaffold their actions and experiences as part of a purposive whole (20). What distinguishes religious worldbuilding in particular from social worldbuilding in general is its explicitly sacred character. All socially constructed worlds seek to answer questions of meaning: Where do we come from? Where do we belong? What is our purpose? Why do we suffer? What happens when we die? Religion seeks to create and maintain a symbolic universe in which its answers to such questions retain ultimacy, and credibility, even in the face of human finitude and suffering (51), what Tolkien's friend C.S. Lewis called *the problem of pain*.

However, I want to nuance my definition around the nature of *meaning*, the nature of the *sacred*, and the supposed universality of the category *religion* itself. Religion may be a world of meaning, but it is also a genuine world, experienced bodily and emotionally as well as symbolically and imaginatively. Following feminist critics (Ammerman 103–04, McDannell 145, McGuire 13–15), I make space in my understanding of religion for the embodied meanings of affect, ethical praxis, material culture, and—importantly for the present essay—ritual. Likewise, the sacred has historically been understood as absolute transcendence, the Holy Other; this is how Berger himself defines it (26). However, this places us in danger of turning the transcendent God of Christianity into the implicit yardstick by which we measure all religion everywhere (Asad 42, Mandair and Dressler 12). I prefer sociologist Gordon Lynch’s definition of the sacred as *that which is held to be and experienced as sacred* by a given individual or community under a given set of cultural and historical circumstances. On Lynch’s reading, the sacred

exerts a gravitational pull on the feelings, motivations and behaviour of individuals and groups [...]. It binds people into particular kinds of identities, communities and ways of living which are experienced not simply of their own free choice, but as compelled or inspired by the sacred object. (138)

Following on from this, I do not make any universal claims for my definition of religion. Instead, I posit it as a limited, stipulative understanding of religion in the modern West (cf. Taylor 15–16), one with special utility for considering the religious affordances of fandom and popular culture.

One major point in favor of adopting and adapting a flexible definition of religion-as-sacred-worldbuilding for the study of media fandom is that it mirrors the importance of worldbuilding to popular narratives, especially in an era of transmedia “extended universes” (Jenkins, “Transmedia Storytelling 101,” Wagner 212, Wolf 10–13). The notion of religion-as-sacred-worldbuilding also accords with Tolkien’s understanding of his literary project in “On Fairy-stories.” There, Tolkien distinguishes between the *primary world* of everyday reality and the *secondary world* of the text, with the related terms *primary belief* and *secondary belief* (OFS 52). For Tolkien, sub-creation is both the human faculty of creativity as well as its imaginative product. His use of the prefix *sub-* denotes a distinction between the creativity of God, understood as *ex nihilo* or “out of nothing,” and human creativity, which uses the given elements of creation as it exists—the so-called primary world—and rearranges them to produce new things. In Tolkien’s Roman Catholic faith, human beings are created in the *imago Dei*, the image and likeness of God (*New Revised Standard Version Updated Edition*, Gen. 1:26–27)—that is to say, created in the image of a Creator. For him,

humanity's sub-creative power, while derivative of and subordinate to God's, is "ultimately of the same stuff" (OFS 47). One might even say that human creativity is a kind of participation in the Divine life, a co-creative improvisation upon the Music of Creation: as Tolkien puts it, "We make still by the law in which we're made" (56). Any product of human art is an example of sub-creation, but Tolkien is chiefly concerned with language and its unique capacity to generate a *secondary world* in the reader's imagination:

[T]he story-maker proves a successful 'sub-creator'. He makes a Secondary World which your mind can enter. Inside it, what he relates is 'true': it accords with the laws of that world. You therefore believe it, while you are, as it were, inside. The moment disbelief arises, the spell is broken; the magic, or rather art, has failed. You are then out in the Primary World again, looking at the little abortive Secondary World from outside. (52)

Secondary or literary belief in a secondary world is contingent upon the storyteller's successful cultivation of the "inner consistency of reality" (59), that is, the construction of a world whose internal laws of operation, while different from the primary world, are nevertheless internally coherent and provide a plausibility structure for the story and its fantastic events. The construction, in short, of a meaningful world, one with the "inner consistency of reality" for those who believe.

Even in this brief sketch, suggestive parallels emerge between the respective projects of religious as well as fantasy worldbuilding. Tolkien uses that worldbuilding medium *par excellence*, language, and more specifically narrative, to invoke a world and engender secondary belief therein. This is precisely what religious worldbuilding does, albeit on a more ambitious scale and with higher metaphysical stakes. Tolkien already viewed secondary worldbuilding as an implicitly religious activity; I might go so far as to define it as *secondary cosmization in an implicitly sacred mode*. Following on from this, I posit fandom itself as a kind of *secondary faith community*. If religious worlds and fictional worlds share structures of believing, then the individuals and communities who use them as resources for crafting identity, community, and meaning may share structures of practice too. Battles over canonicity and the development of "fanon" (Duffett 217), fan tourism (Zubernis and Larsen 146), integration of fan objects into primary-world religious activities such as weddings (Robertson 169–70), fan "conversion" experiences (Cavicchi, *Tramps* 42), and the production of transformative works (Barenblat 175) can all find a place within this framework—and so can Enyalië.

PROCLAIMING: A PILGRIMAGE TO MIDDLE-EARTH

I am far from the first person to delve into Tolkien fandom as a subject of scholarly inquiry. My forerunners include Megan Abrahamson, Maria Alberto, Jane Glaubman, Robin Reid, Amy Sturgis, Karen Viars and Cait Coker, and Dawn Walls-Thumma as well as two massive global reception studies: *The Lord of the Rings Project* (Barker), a survey of fans of Peter Jackson's film trilogy which received nearly 25,000 responses; and *The World Hobbit Project* (Barker), a similar survey of fans of Jackson's *Hobbit* which collected in excess of 36,000 responses. Nor am I the first person to engage with the question of religion in Tolkien fandom. Previous studies include Markus Altena Davidsen's ethnography of "Tolkien spirituality," those who use Tolkien's fictional legendarium as the basis for so-called "real-world" religion (188);² Robin Reid's examination of atheist, agnostic, and animist Tolkien fans (78); and Jeroen de Kloet and Giseline Kuipers' study of how viewers of Peter Jackson's film trilogy "appropriate *The Lord of the Rings* [...] to articulate the idea of a spiritual self" (317). As valuable as these studies are, for present purposes I am less concerned with how fans' (non)religious commitments interact with Tolkien's fiction. Instead, I wish to examine how Tolkien fan practices, in and of themselves, might be considered (secondarily) "religious" under the definition of religion which I advance above.

If ever a practice were ripe for such consideration, it would be Enyalie. The graveside memorial which closes the Tolkien Society's annual gathering is nearly as old as the Society itself. Founded in 1969 as a more "respectable" alternative to the explosion of Tolkien fandom on U.S. college campuses in the late 1960s (Saler 191–92), the Tolkien Society is not the oldest Middle-earth fan organization, but it is one of the longest-lived and most active (Coker 526–27). Today it counts hundreds of members from around the world and numerous local chapters or "smials," but it has much humbler origins as a small, tight-knit group of fellow-enthusiasts who communicated via mimeographed newsletter. Little more than a year after its namesake's death on 2 September 1973, a small group of Tolkien Society members gathered in Oxford from 13–15 September 1974 to tour sites associated with the Inklings, meet with Tolkien's children Michael and Priscilla, and pay their respects at their favorite author's grave. As Rosie and Stuart Clark, the editors of the Society's bulletin *Amon Hen*, reported at the time, a "floral tribute was laid, and more photographs were taken. 'A Elbereth Gilthoniel' was recited over the grave, and we left his resting place with many a 'Namarie [sic]!' (11). This simple ritual was the inaugural Enyalie,

² For a discussion of a similar phenomenon using very different source material, consult John Engle's account of esoteric communities who incorporate H.P. Lovecraft's Cthulhu Mythos into their belief and practice (87–92).

though it was not yet called by that name; and the attendees swiftly agreed to make it, and Oxonmoot, an annual tradition.

In the half-century since then, Oxonmoot has shifted to the beginning of September and expanded to involve hundreds of participants both onsite in Oxford as well as online. It is, if not unique, then certainly noteworthy among fan conventions (“fancons”) for the ways in which it bridges conventional fandom and the academy.³ Oxonmoot attendees can take part in the trivia competitions, amateur performances, fanart exhibitions, and costume contests which have long characterized fancons, as well as a slate of panels featuring papers from Tolkien scholars both established and emerging. This makes sense: many (though not all) Tolkien scholars first came to him as a subject for research because we love his works, making us prime examples of the somewhat clunky neologism “acafans.” Likewise, Tolkien’s own career as an Oxford professor, and the clear influence of his professional interests on his fiction, have shaped how many readers engage with his work as a quasi-academic pursuit (Glaubman 265–67). As important as these elements of Oxonmoot may be, the Tolkien Society’s own website states that Enyalië “was the origin of Oxonmoot, and is in many ways [its] soul” (“Enyalië”). It is, in a sense, both where the gathering begins and where it ends, its alpha and its omega. Those of us in attendance at Enyalië 2023 were thus followers in a long line of pilgrims to Tolkien’s resting-place.

I use the word “pilgrim” deliberately, for such visits to Tolkien’s grave are clear examples of fan pilgrimage or literary pilgrimage. There is a rich vein of scholarship on this subject, including work by Evgenia Amey, Anne Klara Bom, Lorraine Brown, Jane Lovell and James Thurgill, Ryosuke Okamoto, Jennifer Otter Bickerdike, and Lynn Zubernis and Katherine Larsen. There have also been investigations of Tolkien-related tourism, including those by Anne Buchmann, Kevin Moore, and David Fisher and by Robbie Goh. But with one notable exception, I have not identified any studies which are not primarily concerned with fan travel to filming locations in New Zealand. Visits to Tolkien’s grave, by contrast, constitute a form of biographical tourism in which fans visit sites directly associated with the author. These may include places where the author lived and worked, burial locations, and/or real-world locales which supposedly inspired their fiction. Visits to such sites reflect and reinforce, in the primary world, the reader’s “symbolic pilgrimage” through the secondary world of the text (Aden 88). This is certainly the case for Oxonmoot: the first attendees even referred to the famous Eagle and Child pub in Oxford as “the Mecca of any Inklings pilgrimage” (Clark and Clark 7). Such language mirrors

³ Although I have not attended it in person as I have Oxonmoot, the Mythopoeic Society’s annual gathering, Mythcon, would be another example of this.

what happens on traditional religious pilgrimage, where a physical journey through an external geography corresponds to an internal, imaginative journey of faith (Barush 201–03). As liminal spaces situated upon the boundaries of life and death, gravesites are common destinations for both religious as well as fan pilgrimages. Visitors may leave offerings such as candles, coins, or flowers (Brown 171) or take a moment in contemplative silence (Middleton 313) as ways of paying their respects.

This is exactly how fan pilgrims interact with Tolkien's grave. When Mina Lukić and Dejan Vukelić surveyed 500 visitors to Tolkien-related locations in the U.K., they found that 63 percent of them had visited Tolkien's grave. Of those, 84.4 percent reported that it was either a very important or *the* most important Tolkien-related location they visited (68). Nine respondents outright used the words "quest" or "pilgrimage" to describe the experience (72), but far more drew upon the emotionally and spiritually charged language of profundity, beauty, and even sacredness (76–77). They reported engaging in a host of "rituals of homage enacted at Tolkien and Edith's grave" which

range[d] from silent contemplation to singing, reciting, reading excerpts from Tolkien's works silently or aloud, or living wreaths, flowers, notes, drawings, coins, figurines, jewellery, and other tributes, as well as taking some mementos, which are usually photos, but several participants also mentioned gravestone rubbings, stones, or plants. (75–76)

One respondent noted that their visit was "given further weight by the thousands of like-minded pilgrims who had sang, wept, and contemplated at that exact spot for so many years" (72). Many others said that the grave was where they felt closest to both Tolkien and to his work, prompted by the names Beren and Lúthien inscribed on the headstone alongside the Tolkiens' proper names. "I think it's the ultimate fantasy homage," one respondent wrote. "The connection of his works and his real life manifested in stone" (82). This all makes imminent sense within the framework of fandom-as-secondary-faith. Just as "primary believers" in Christianity or Islam go on pilgrimage to the Holy Land to visit sites associated with a beloved religious world, "secondary believers" in Middle-earth go on pilgrimage to Oxford to visit sites associated with a beloved secondary world. As Lukić and Vukelić point out, however, Enyalië is a communal practice, not merely a personal one (84–85). If pilgrimage is typically an act of individual devotion, what is the relevant parallel to a collective act like Enyalië?

My answer would be *liturgy*—and using Constance Cherry's fourfold framework of Christian worship, we can see just how closely Enyalië reproduces the lineaments of Western Christian liturgy. Just as the narthex of a church serves as a liminal threshold between the secular world "outside" and the sacred

world “inside” the worship space (Turner 74–75), the commute from the University of Oxford to Wolvercote Cemetery and the procession to Tolkien’s grave can be seen as “narthetical” actions. Once participants are in place, the welcome and invitation to reflection constitute the *gathering*, as scattered individuals are called into a collective liturgical body (Cherry 56). The second movement of worship, the *proclaiming*, is the space in a Christian service in which “people may be addressed by God through the Holy Scriptures and thereby changed for God’s glory and kingdom” (70). At Enyalië, however, there are neither readings from Scripture nor a homily. It is not the Word in a theological sense which is proclaimed but rather “mere” words, a selection from Tolkien’s writings. Next comes the *responding*, in which the gathered community takes ritual action in acknowledgement of what they have heard proclaimed: for “without some response, worship fails to fulfil its purpose—that of God and people in relationship” (99). In Western Christian services there have historically been a variety of responses to the proclamation of the Word: the prayers of the people, the offering, and most importantly to sacramental traditions such as the Roman Catholic Church, communion. At Enyalië, the response corresponds to the silence which follows the reading, the laying of wreaths, and the singing of “Namarië.” This last acts as a hinge between responding and *sending*, which is “the final movement of the corporate worship service, in which we plan to ‘disassemble’ as intentionally as we assembled” (112). This is the point at which a Tolkien Society representative announces the conclusion of the gathering and attendees bid each other farewell and leave the cemetery.

For as closely as Enyalië hews to the structure of a Christian worship service, right down to its physical setting in a churchyard, it remains emphatically nonreligious. At the gathering I attended, the sole reference which could be construed as “theological” occurred when the chairperson of the Tolkien Society alluded to Tolkien’s notion of *eucatastrophe*, and then only insofar as Tolkien called it an “echo of *evangelium*” —that is, the Good News (OFS 77). This follows: the Tolkien Society is a secondary faith community not a primary one. Explicit gestures toward a deity or deities make little sense in that context. Yet my response to Enyalië, and that of other participants whom I witnessed in similarly heartfelt displays of emotion, felt more worshipful than anything I have ever experienced at a fancon. To the point: I always carry with me a polished hand sample of rose quartz from my hometown, a kind of personal talisman. Before the memorial began, I felt compelled to place my rose quartz on the edge of Tolkien’s grave for several minutes, as if it would absorb the spiritual energy of the occasion. Even in using the term “spiritual” here I acknowledge something exceeding literary appreciation; for as Matt Hills writes, religious language “does not surrender all religious force when used by fans, even if this use may also be ironic or humorous” (88).

Yet here we are faced with a conundrum. According to Cherry, the primary purpose of Christian worship is to facilitate an encounter between the gathered community and God (54). Under my definition of religion-as-sacred-worldbuilding, I might say that worship, considered broadly beyond its Christian manifestations, is a technology of religious worldbuilding. It forms participants for participation in a meaningful cosmos and invites them into relationship with the sacred as their tradition understands it (cf. Woodhead 61–62). No gods were invoked at the Enyalië I attended; no intercessory prayers were offered. Yet I felt as though the ritual brought me into contact with *something* which moved me to tears. Perhaps it was simply collective effervescence, Émile Durkheim’s coinage for the “electricity” which is generated by gatherings oriented toward a common sacred object. Collective effervescence reinforces group cohesion and engenders a sense of participation in an “impersonal, extra-individual force [...] [which] makes [individuals] feel as if they are in contact with an extraordinary energy” (Carls). Collective effervescence is a common schema for analyzing fan activities such as rock concerts (Duffett 151–52, Elliott 113, Leonard 29). But like many strictly functionalist accounts of religion, it risks reducing the sacred to the merely social. If my analytical framework for religion and fandom holds, then even if it was not inviting us into an encounter with specific supernatural agents, the “secondarily sacred” space of Enyalië was still inviting us into an encounter. The question is: with what?⁴

RESPONDING: THE BORDERS OF BELIEF

I have argued that both religion and fandom share homologous structures of belief and meaning-making, but I have heretofore treated them as distinct, if related, phenomena. I now wish to consider whether religion and fandom ever transgress the border between one and the other; when and why that transgression occurs; and whether it is occurring at Enyalië. To do this, I need to return to Tolkien’s theory of sub-creation and my theory of religion-as-sacred-worldbuilding, to re-examine the relation between “primary” religious worlds and “secondary” fantasy worlds—and to see whether that apparently self-explanatory binary holds up under closer scrutiny.

When Tolkien describes the means by which a human artist makes a “successful” secondary world, he notably does not call them a worldbuilder; rather, he calls them a “*story-maker*” (OFS 52, emphasis mine). Tolkien understood intimately that narrative constitutes one of the generative logics of fantasy worldbuilding, serving as both an impetus to sub-creation and the

⁴ Many thanks to Dr. Anna Milon for first posing this question to me, and for many thoughtful conversations to work out some answers.

means by which the sub-created world is mediated to the reader (cf. Wolf 198). In the tradition of narrative theology, it also constitutes one of the generative logics of religious worldbuilding. Catholic theologian Johann Baptist Metz argues that, contrary to the way in which systematic theology has often been done throughout Christian history, with religious narratives taken as illustrations of propositional truth,

stories of conversion and of exodus do not serve as dramatic window-dressing for a preformulated 'pure' theology. Rather, they belong to the fundamental way theology itself operates. [...] On the contrary, talk about God has an essential and inalienable memorative and narrative structure. (62)

Likewise, in his explorations of Biblical parables, John Dominic Crossan posits that the Bible should itself be understood as parabolic, as a story first and foremost which is meant to upend the listener's past expectations and provoke spiritual and social transformation (56). Most germane to my present purposes is George Lindbeck, whose linguistic-cultural understanding of theology complements Tolkien's understanding of the religiosity of narrative worldbuilding to a truly remarkable extent.

For Lindbeck, religious symbols, stories, and rituals are themselves a kind of language, providing a grammar and a vocabulary in which religious communities communicate sacred meaning (cf. Woodhead 61–62). To be religious, then, is to be fluent in the language that is religion. Lindbeck writes, from his standpoint as a Christian theologian:

To become a Christian involves learning the story of Israel and Jesus well enough to interpret and experience oneself and one's world in its terms. [...] A comprehensive scheme or story used to structure all dimensions of existence is not primarily a set of propositions to be believed, but is rather the medium in which one moves, a set of skills that one employs in living one's life. (34–35)

The Biblical tradition sings a religious world into existence by means of story, symbol, and ritual—and Christians enter into its story-world in much the same way that readers enter into Middle-earth. However, the key difference between the mere reader and the true believer is that for the latter, the story-world is not simply literary:

For those who are steeped in them [religious narratives], no world is more real than the ones they create. A scriptural world is thus able to absorb the universe. It supplies the interpretive framework within which

believers seek to live their lives and understand reality. [...] It is the text, so to speak, which absorbs the world, rather than the world the text. (117–118)

I am reminded of Tolkien's remarks on eucatastrophe, the sudden joyous turn in a work of fantasy which he sees as "the true form of fairy-tale, and its highest function" (OFS 75). For Tolkien, this is the moment at which a fairy-story comes closest to offering readers an intimation of the sacred: "In such stories when the sudden 'turn' comes we get a piercing glimpse of joy, and heart's desire, that for a moment passes outside the frame, rends indeed the very web of story, and lets a gleam come through" (OFS 76). Note Tolkien's and Lindbeck's shared language of the story transcending its own narrative frame.⁵ That, I argue, is what is happening at Enyalië: Tolkien's secondary world is transcending its narrative frame, if only for as long as the ritual lasts.

No doubt Tolkien's grave in general, and Enyalië in particular, enable some participants to feel closer to J.R.R. Tolkien the historical person (Lukić and Vukelić 83–84). I now reflect that placing my hand sample of rose quartz on Tolkien's grave was motivated, in part, by an awareness that his mortal remains are laid to rest on this very spot. But it stretches credulity in more ways than one to describe Enyalië as veneration of Tolkien the man in place of a saint, let alone a god. Nor, I think, does it necessarily imply primary belief in the events and characters of his secondary world (cf. Davidsen 31–32). Rather, it is Enyalië itself which "passes outside the frame" of the text (OFS 76). For those of us who feel called to gather at Wolvercote Cemetery, Middle-earth is "real" enough to justify, not only the expenses associated with attending Oxonmoot, but also our physical and emotional presence at an embodied ritual in a literal, liminal churchyard—all this despite, or alongside, any primary-world spiritual commitments we may or may not hold.

But that is not all: for the building-blocks that make up Enyalië are quarried from Middle-earth itself. In a Christian liturgy, a historically common way of moving from the response into the sending is by singing the *Nunc dimitis*, the Song of Simeon: "Master, now you are dismissing your servant in peace, according to your word, for my eyes have seen your salvation, which you have prepared in the presence of all peoples, a light for revelation to the gentiles and for glory to your people Israel" (Luke 2:29–32). As discussed above, a performance of Galadriel's farewell-song "Namarië" fulfils this role at Enyalië. The musical setting used at Enyalië is Tolkien's own, who consciously modelled

⁵ At the risk of theological overboldness, I might even say that a religious world can be thought of as a secondary world which has come to "absorb" the primary one—but to tweak the classic scholarly deflection, that passes well outside the frame of the present paper.

it on Gregorian chant (Tolkien & Swann v–vi). But the Quenya text of the poem gestures not toward theological salvation but toward Valinor—a place of great spiritual significance in the legendarium, no doubt, but not exactly the Christian Heaven. “Namarië” has effectively transcended its narrative context to become, itself, liturgical song. This is even clearer during the proclaiming section of the ritual. At Enyalië 2023, the excerpt from *The Lord of the Rings* spanning the fall of Barad-dûr to Sam’s awakening in Ithilien lasted about thirteen uninterrupted minutes. This gave attendees more time to deepen meaningfully into the story-world than a shorter reading might have—or, for that matter, than many perfunctory readings of sacred texts in primary-world religious rituals. Moreover, this passage is part of the climax of *The Lord of the Rings*—“the most stunning *euclatostrophe* in modern literature,” as Verlyn Flieger would have it (“The Arch and the Keystone” 14). The only other moment in Tolkien’s legendarium that comes anywhere close is when the immortal Lúthien “plead[s] before the inexorable Mandos” (*Letters* 590, #340) for the life of her mortal beloved Beren. But by chance, “if chance you call it” (*LotR* I.7.126), Beren and Lúthien are present at Enyalië as well. Their names are emblazoned upon Tolkien’s headstone like the words “Do this in remembrance of me” (Luke 22:19) may be emblazoned upon a Christian altar.

The line I just cited about “the inexorable Mandos” comes from a letter Tolkien wrote to his son Christopher in July 1972, as he was making preparations for his wife Edith’s grave. He draws a direct comparison between Lúthien and Beren on the one hand and Edith and himself on the other, requesting that her grave be inscribed with the Elvish name “which says for me more than a multitude of words: for she was (and knew she was) my Lúthien” (*Letters* 590, #350). Five decades later, Lukić and Vukelić reflected on their survey of visitors to the grave which the Tolkiens share:

[I]t is a site where not only Tolkien and Edith are present, but also his fictional world, evoked by a simple, but powerful reference. This double presence can simultaneously tap into readers’ admiration and respect for the author himself and their love for his writings. This “fusion of Tolkien’s personal life and his ‘sub-creation’” for many visitors makes the grave the most important Tolkien-related place in the world[.] (71)

For Tolkien, the line between “primary” and “secondary” had already long since blurred, at least as far as Beren and Lúthien were concerned; the story had transcended its narrative frame (cf. Flieger, “Tolkien’s Lúthien” 235). None of Tolkien’s fans will ever have the same relationship to those characters that their author did. But it does not seem unreasonable to me to infer that at least some Enyalië attendees are experiencing the interpenetration of Middle-earth with our own lives—or at least that is what *I* experienced at Enyalië 2023. By this I do

not mean that I came to believe literally in the destruction of the One Ring and the fall of Sauron, any more than Tolkien believed in the Tale of Beren and Lúthien as a factual account of historical events.⁶ Rather, I became so immersed in the story-world—bodily, emotionally, imaginatively, symbolically—that sharp distinctions between “primary” and “secondary” no longer adequately described my engagement with it. Truth be told, I am not convinced that they ever did.

This brings me back to my as-yet unanswered question: what, if anything, do we encounter at Enyalië? Or to put it another way: what do we glimpse beyond the narrative frame? For the Roman Catholic Tolkien, it is an intimation of the Good News of Christianity (OFS 77, cf. *Letters* 579, #328). Christian Tolkien commentators such as Paul E. Kerry (244), Alison Milbank (111–12), and Ralph Wood (275) would go further, viewing Middle-earth itself as a prism which refracts Christian truth, even to non-Christians who do not recognize its source. Within that framework, the question of what we encounter at Enyalië is not really a question: it is the God of Christianity, mediated to us by Tolkien’s legendarium. I would respond that if Tolkien had wanted his readers to only find Christian truth(s) in his fiction, he ought to have sub-created a world that was less open to interpretation (cf. Emanuel 47–48). For as much as it resembles one, Enyalië is not a Christian worship service; it is a fan ritual. The criterion for participation is not primary belief in a religious world but secondary belief in a fantasy world. The sub-creator of that world held certain religious views, but the readers who enter therein are in no way obligated to share them. We should hardly expect a fan ritual based on Middle-earth to leave any less room for interpretation than Middle-earth itself.

Again: what do we encounter at Enyalië? Perhaps now I can give a proper answer—or better, several answers. We encounter Middle-earth and Tolkien its maker. We encounter one another, called together in this place by a shared love of these stories. And we encounter whatever intimation of “Joy, Joy beyond the walls of the world, poignant as grief” (OFS 75) it is that we experience when a story transcends its narrative frame and becomes *our* story—as fans, as fellow-pilgrims, as (non)believers. We encounter, in short, the sacred as Gordon Lynch defines it, not as theological transcendence but rather as that “gravitational pull on the feelings, motivations and behaviour of individuals and groups that [...] binds people into particular kinds of identities, communities and ways of living” (138). We need not pin a particular religious interpretation to Enyalië, any more than we need pin a particular religious interpretation to

⁶ Though it may be worth noting that Tolkien also appears not to have believed in the Garden of Eden, a central narrative of his own Christian tradition, as a factual account of historical events (*Letters* 158–159, #96).

The Lord of the Rings. It is not a worship service; it has little need of formal doctrines. But it is a liturgy, a memorial, a collective worldbuilding practice of the community of fans who return to Tolkien's grave year after year to celebrate his sub-creation and weave it more deeply into the fabric of our own lives.

SENDING: AN ASPIRATIONAL CULTUS?

Having wandered into the perilous realm where primary and secondary worlds touch, I would now like to take a step back and offer some important clarifications. Firstly, I want to re-emphasize that for the vast majority of readers, Tolkien fandom is *not* a religion in the same sense that, say, Islam or Sikhism or Eastern Orthodox Christianity would be. To be sure, there are individual cases where a fictional secondary world has, in fact, "absorbed" the primary world in Lindbeck's sense. Markus Altena Davidsen's aforementioned Tolkien religionists (31–32) are one example; *Star Wars*-inspired Jedis (Grant 39), Lovecraft spiritualists (Engle 85), and "Snapewives" in the *Harry Potter* fandom (Burton 64–65) are three others. This is a marginal phenomenon in any fan community, however. I would wager that for most, *The Silmarillion* is no more a substitute for Holy Writ than Enyalië is a substitute for the Hajj. Viewing fandom as a simplistic "replacement apparatus" (Bickerdike 8) for religion is problematic for any number of reasons, but perhaps most obviously because many Tolkien fans, myself included, already belong to a religious tradition. Our love of Middle-earth—of any fictional story-world—exists alongside and in conversation with our faith (cf. Crome 413). The same goes for nonreligious readers, who might understandably bristle at being told that their fandom, however deeply felt, was "actually" religion in disguise (400–01). Fandom is less *religious* than *religioid*, Georg Simmel's word to describe attitudes, affects, practices, and communities which reproduce religious forms without embracing religious content (Motak 112–14).

Second, I want to acknowledge again that my definition of religion-as-sacred-worldbuilding is *a* definition, not *the* definition. Drawing as it does on religious studies, fan studies, and fantasy studies alike, I submit that it enables us to better understand how worldbuilding contributes to the development of both religion *and* media fandom, which in turn enables us to unpick the religious affects, effects, and affordances of narrative worlds both sacred and secular. But other definitions will draw our attention to other important features and manifestations of the religious impulse in other cultures and eras. I have tried to be flexible and non-essentialist in constructing and applying my model, and I believe it has cross-cultural relevance. Yet I have relied primarily on Western thinkers and frameworks to theorize a British fan organization's Anglophone fan ritual, one which itself mirrors the form of Western Christian liturgy and is grounded in the works of a White, male, English, Roman Catholic author of the

mid-twentieth century. Whether my analytical framework would hold up similarly well in non-Western contexts remains an open question. For example: in 2023, the journal *Transformative Works and Cultures* published a special issue wholly dedicated to fandom(s) in China. My intuition is that things might shape up rather differently in a country of 1.4 billion people, grounded in non-Christian and non-Western cultural and religious traditions, officially communist yet deeply embedded in the global capitalist economy. More work remains to be done.

Third, I want to offer a caution to my fellow “secondary believers.” If Tolkien fandom is a secondary faith community as I have argued, then we must engage Tolkien’s story-world ethically and responsibly, just as Christians like myself must grapple with the real tensions in our own tradition. Regarding controversy over the inclusion of dark-skinned Elves and Dwarves in Tolkien fanfic and fan art, Walls-Thumma writes:

Again and again, what some fans thought Tolkien meant or believed he intended was elevated to the status of canon where it was not open to question and where canonicity became a convenient diversion from discussions of sexism, racism, and homophobia in the legendarium and fandom. (95)

In many ways the Christian Bible is no different: powerful narratives of resurrection, liberation, and radical grace coexist alongside “texts of terror” which ecclesiastical authorities have weaponized to subjugate women and queer people for centuries (Trible 3, Bauer-Levesque 390). In a time when stories of all stripes are being wielded as cudgels against marginalized communities, we must confront the fact it is precisely the multivalent meanings of our stories and rituals which open them up to noxious interpretations (Emanuel 47). It is incumbent upon us to actively build communities that are hospitable to as many different expressions of humanity as possible, in Tolkien fandom and beyond.

Bearing these caveats in mind, however, I want to conclude with that openness to interpretation which I just mentioned. Even if the Tolkien Society is not the Church of Rome—even if Enyalië is not Easter Sunday—there is no denying that Tolkien’s stories of Middle-earth are profoundly moving to many people. In my ongoing research into the reception of *The Lord of the Rings* amongst twenty-first century readers, I am consistently struck by the depth of feeling with which people express their love and appreciation for Tolkien’s masterpiece. Likewise, even if fandom is not a replacement for religion *per se*, formal religious affiliation has been declining in the so-called “developed” world for decades. Political scientist Ryan Burge reports that 30 percent of Americans now describe themselves as nonreligious, the highest percentage

ever (31). There are no signs that this downward trend of disaffiliation from traditional spiritual communities will stop anytime soon: among young Gen Z Americans, only 36 percent identify as Christian, in contrast to 48 percent who identify as atheist, agnostic, or “nothing in particular” (83). In a very real way, Westerners like myself are living in a post-Christian world. Religion has not disappeared, of course. But as philosopher of secularity Charles Taylor writes, “a society in which it was virtually impossible not to believe in God” has given way “to one in which faith, even for the staunchest believer, is one human possibility among others” (3). Under such conditions, a person’s love of Tolkien might well prove an important tool for crafting identity, finding community, and making meaning. It has certainly proven to be so for that bookish boy huddled in the graveyard up the road, obsessively rereading *The Return of the King* for the umpteenth time.

In a pluralistic world of many faiths and no faiths, perhaps Enyalië can serve as an exemplar of a “post-Christian liturgy.” It draws upon familiar ritual technologies and the story-worlds that are already meaningful to people, offering a glimpse of “something more” without needing to delimit or define the *something* in question. It cracks open “secondarily sacred” space in which individuals can meet and be moved but whose religious and ideological differences might otherwise prevent them from practicing alongside one another. Whatever a person’s ethical and metaphysical commitments regarding the primary world, there is nothing preventing them from finding common meaning in a secondary world. For there remains a key difference between religion and fandom, Tolkien’s misgivings notwithstanding. Religious practitioners (typically) consider the religious world and the primary world to be one and the same. Fans, on the other hand, (typically) proceed from the assumption that there is a boundary between the secondary worlds of their favorite texts and the primary world—or perhaps I should say *worlds*—of everyday life. If I have accomplished nothing else, I hope to have shown that this boundary may be more porous than we have been led to believe.

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THE REV. TOM EMANUEL is a theologian and doctoral researcher with the University of Glasgow's Centre for Fantasy and the Fantastic. His current project explores the reception of J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* among nonreligious readers and is funded by an Arts and Humanities Research Council (AHRC) doctoral partnership with the Scottish Graduate School of Arts and Humanities (SGSAH). His work has appeared in the *Journal of Tolkien Research*, *Mallorn*, *Mythlore*, *Tolkien Studies*, and *Zeitschrift für Fantastikforschung*. Tom is an ordained minister in the United Church of Christ and lives in Glasgow with his spouse and their two children, whom they are already inducting into the "deplorable cultus" of Tolkien fandom.



OMS 4—Online MidSummer Seminar 2025

August 2-3, 2025 Via Zoom and Discord

*MORE PERILOUS AND FAIR:
WOMEN AND GENDER IN MYTHOPOEIC FANTASY*

GUESTS OF HONOR:

Janet Brennan Croft and Leslie A. Donovan, co-editors of *Perilous and Fair*

Celebrating the 10th anniversary of the
publication of *Perilous and Fair: Women
in the Works and Life of J.R.R. Tolkien*

Co-chairs:

Cami Agan, Clare Moore,
and Robin Anne Reid



Join us for an online conference that focuses on intersectional feminist approaches to women and gender in fantasy, science fiction, speculative fiction, or other mythopoeic work and that will honor the first anthology on women and Tolkien, *Perilous and Fair: Women in the Works and Life of J.R.R. Tolkien* (2015), edited by Janet Brennan Croft and Leslie A. Donovan.

Intersectionality, or intersectional approaches, developed out of research and scholarship by Black women, highlighting how aspects of identity (such as race, gender, sexual orientation, or class) overlap and intersect. Since then, feminist scholars in a number of disciplines, including literary studies, have adapted intersectionality in their work.

DIVINITY AND THE VOID IN CHINESE AND THAI TRANSLATIONS OF THE *ANULINDALE*

ERIC REINDERS

TOLKIEN'S WORK HAS BECOME A GLOBAL PHENOMENON, and I argue for more attention to readings outside of English. What new readings of his texts emerge from placing them in the contexts of different languages, such as in this case Mandarin Chinese or Thai? I want to think of these stories circulating globally.

This is not a question of what the author may have intended, but of how the stories are perceived and re-told. The canonicity of the original is immutable, but millions of fans can't read the original, except through a translation. My approach is to treat the translations as stories in their own right, and then to try to articulate some of these alternatives into my native tongue. It is in multiple translations of the same source text that we begin to see Tolkien's works as a kind of narrative tradition of greater complexity than that of any single book in one's native language—especially if it's under copyright. Everyone's first reading of *The Lord of the Rings*—even if it is not in English—remains foundational in any subsequent reading; and disputes over interpretation quickly become disputes over translations. Translation is a *precise*, linguistically *intimate* exchange of meaning, and I hope that a focus on these rich negotiations of meaning might contribute to a larger project of a comparative study of the imagination. I am looking at Mandarin Chinese and Thai simply because these are within my own ability, and I genuinely encourage studies adding to the existing literature on Tolkien's works in all its many languages. Looking at two different languages, and at multiple translations in the same language, provides the opportunity to shift perspective and make more complex comparisons.

Previous studies of Tolkien in translation have dealt primarily with Western translations—such as *Tolkien Through Russian Eyes* (2003), *Tolkien in Translation* (2011) and a number of articles and chapters. Here I want to expand that comparative scope. The scholarship has (in my view) tended to focus on a qualitative evaluation of *fidelity*. If we imagine translation primarily in terms of a transfer of semantic content, our questions tend to be about fidelity, the degree to which the translation has replicated or “captured” the precise meaning of the original text, including all of its nuances. But taken literally, this is to put translation in an unwinnable battle with itself, since in fact no two words ever mean exactly the same thing. Instead, current work in translation theory, such

as that of Emmerich (2017), Venuti (2019), and Briggs (2017), has emphasized the creativity of new re-tellings.

Though Tolkien was cautious about translations of his own work, his discussion of story-telling in “On Fairy-stories” supports the view that two “versions” of the “same story” are to be considered each in their own right, not only as an “original” and subsequent “derivatives.” Though it would be quixotic to deny the actual *sequence* of publication, I set aside the *hierarchy* of original and translations, in order to consider translated texts as circulations of the imagination, as elaborations of a mythos, and as intercultural exchange. Although a translator might simply misread the original, for the most part we are dealing with varying interpretations, expressions of translators’ individual and idiosyncratic understandings. Fidelity is certainly a valid concern, but it is not the only concern.

To reveal to English-readers some of what is happening in the translated texts, I use a literalistic style of back-translation, combined with annotation and discussion. While no two words can ever mean exactly the same thing, we easily recognize degrees of proximity. One translation may represent the original’s words in a *relatively* literal way, while another is less “faithful” but communicates what we perceive as the intention of the story more accurately. In the one case the text is relatively *foreignized* (by its inclusion of phrases deemed strange in the target language); in another case the text is relatively *domesticated* (by its use of idioms which diverge from the source text but are meaningful in the target language). This contrast is also known as formal vs. dynamic translation, or source-language-oriented and target-language-oriented translations. In making this contrast, I emphasize “relatively,” because although *absolute* literalism in a translation is simply impossible, and *absolute* domestication would no longer be considered a translation at all; yet on a case-by-case basis we can still see the *relative* distinctions quite clearly. Back-translation leans heavily towards the formal, source-language-oriented, and foreignizing style. One caveat is that these back-translations should not be mistaken for good or finished translations. In order to evoke in English what is happening in the Chinese or Thai, my back-translations are often awkward and ungrammatical, which of course is not true of the Chinese and Thai texts.

In *Reading Tolkien in Chinese: Religion, Fantasy and Translation* (2024), using the original and three Chinese translations, I explored a variety of themes, including the afterlife and fate. One theme I did not address in that study was cosmogony, primarily described in the *Ainulindalë* and *Valaquenta*. Here I examine a 2001 translation by Li Yao for the Yilin Press, a 2002 translation by Deng Jiawan (Joy Teng), and her 2015 revised translation—that is, two translations by the same translator. And to this list I can add a 2010 Thai translation by Thida Thanyaprasertkul. For ease of reference, these works will

be cited by translator, name of text, and page number; and in the case of the two *Silmarillions* translated by Deng, with the year of publication added.

Firstly, the titles. In the Chinese translations, *The Silmarillion* is paraphrased as “the elves’ jewels.” *Jingling baozuan* 精靈寶鑽/ 精灵宝钻. In the Yilin edition, there is an added prefix, *Mojie qiyuan* 魔戒起源 (“The Beginning of *The Magic Ring*”); *mojie* is the general name for the whole franchise. So the Chinese title is a gloss rather than a transliteration of “*The Silmarillion*.” In the text, the word “*Silmaril*” is transliterated as *Xi-ermali-er* 熙尔玛利尔, or *Ximali-er* 茜玛丽尔 but more often *jingling baozuan*, “the elves’ jewels” is used. The Thai title is not precisely *The Silmarillion* either, but: ตำนานแห่งซิลมาริล *Tammaan haeng Sinmarin*, “legend of the *Silmarils*” which tells us something of the text’s genre, and transliterates *Silmaril* as *Sinmarin*. (In Thai, the ‘l’ sound in final position within a syllable such as ‘sil’ is converted to an ‘n’ sound.)

As for the *Ainulindalë*, Li retitles this text simply as *Airu* (i.e. *Eru*, the name of *Ilúvatar*), though the *Valaquenta* is given as “the legend of the *Valar* (*Fanla de chuanshuo*).” For the *Ainulindalë*, Deng uses *Ainu de da yuezhang* 埃努的大樂章 (the great musical movement of the *Ainur*). For *Valaquenta*, *Weila benji* (the annals of the *Valar*); *benji* is usually used for royal annals, pertaining to the deeds of an emperor. In her revised translation, the *Ainulindalë* is retitled *Chuangshilu* 创世录 (record of the creation of the world). The Thai translation simply renders *Ainulindalë* and *Valaquenta* phonetically.

In examining these multiple versions, I am looking specifically for instances where something stands out as different—not in error but assuming a conscientious effort to translate well. In the case of these cosmogonic narratives, the first line in the original and in translations gives us some different senses of the name *Eru*, and of *Eru*’s pronouns, and therefore the nature of *Eru*. Slightly further in the narrative we find what I consider to be some intriguingly different connotations of the *Void*.

THE FIRST LINE

The *Ainulindalë* begins with a disembodied unity creating a series of successively less powerful and more physical beings. The first generation of such beings manifests as musical notes, which form chords, and hence harmony, complexity, and inevitably discord. Vision is created to express that music, and then the materialization of that vision is the world. The world is then populated. We are presented with a descent from spirit to matter, from unity to multiplicity and specificity. The *Valar*, the elves, then humans (or as Tolkien called them, “*Men*”), then dwarves, orcs. There are a few quirks to this descent. Against the divine plan, dwarves were created before elves, but *Ilúvatar* put them to sleep. Also, we don’t hear about animals or bacteria, but the general sequence is clear. As with all mythologies, certain obvious questions are unanswered.

In drawing a continuous narrative line from the very beginning of everything to the Fourth Age under the “dominion of Men,” the entire oeuvre moves from a high mythological register to chronicles in historical time. There are several markers of this descent. We note the shift in tone from *The Silmarillion* to *The Hobbit*. The thinning of the elves is also a transition from myth to history. Or perhaps the Valar themselves might represent a kind of pivot: initially very active, then gradually disappearing from the story. Even early on, they could take form, or not. We read that their taking form is a kind of clothing or disguise. The Vala Ulmo “will seldom clothe himself in a body after the manner of his peers” (*Silmarillion* [Silm.] 17). Li gives us an overly literalistic “seldom wears clothes like his peers” (Li Silm. 17), which suggests that Ulmo is usually naked. Deng has, Ulmo “very rarely like [his] peers puts on a flesh-body form (肉身的形體 *roushen de xingtì*)” (Deng Silm. 2002 19). The Thai: “He (*phra-ong*) does not like to walk on the land, and does not like wearing a body (*rang*, figure) disguise (*jamlæng*) such as the other devas (*thep*, gods) prefer” (Thanyaprasertkul Silm. 56).

The opening phrase from the *Ainulindalë* is: “There was Eru, the One, who in Arda is called Ilúvatar” (Silm. 3). Li has “惟一者” 埃如, 在阿尔达王国被叫做伊路瓦塔” (Li Silm. 3). Back-translated, this is: “‘The only one’ *Airu*, in the *A-er-da* royal domain is called *Yi-lu-wa-ta*.” The phrase “the only one” is in quotation marks for some reason, perhaps to suggest whatever the capitalization of “One” suggests, such as that “the One” is a title or name, not merely “there was just the one of him.” Notice also the active verbs: this version reduces the sense of beginning the story at the start (“There was . . .”), instead starting with a naming (“... is called . . .”).

Deng’s two versions have almost the same basic text. “始有一如, ‘独一之神’, 其名在世界間稱為伊露維塔.” “In the beginning was *yiru*, ‘the only god,’ its name in the world (*shijian*) was *yi-lu-wei-ta*” (Deng Silm. 2002, 3). This 2002 edition has a series of footnotes on key terms (or rather, sidenotes, since as a vertical text they appear to the left of the page, not at the bottom. The sidenotes were imported into the body of the text, parenthetically, in the 2015 version). For example, after *yiru*, Deng gives the term in Roman letters, notes that it is a Quenya word, and gives a general description of that deity. For the 2015 publication, she changed the paraphrase of Arda as “the world” to a transliteration (*a-er-da* 阿尔达) (Deng 2015 Silm. 31). In both cases, for “the One,” Deng gives us *duyi zhi shen* (the only god). In this context it is clear that *shen* should be “god,” though the word 神 *shen* can also mean a spirit, or consciousness, or soul. Since Chinese does not have capital letters, there is no distinction between “god” and “God.” *Shen* might also be plural, though here the context makes it clear we are talking about a singular god, not gods.

THE NAME ERU

The first thing to note here is the differences of dealing with the proper name Eru. The Chinese script is in the form of characters. All characters have meanings, however obscure, but certain characters are customarily used for transliteration. Phrases transliterated into Mandarin Chinese have a distinctive look. Li gives Eru as 埃如 *airu*, and these characters are fairly commonly used in transliteration, so I think readers would immediately perceive it as a proper noun, despite the lack of capitalization in Chinese. In English, if the text said, “There was eru,” we might be slightly confused, but with the capital E, we accept that “Eru” is the name of “the One,” a proper noun, and we do not therefore try to find “eru” in a dictionary, or wonder if it is a typo. In itself, “Eru” does not mean anything outside of Tolkien’s usage (Halsall 31–32). But what is the meaning of Li’s *airu*? *Ai* means dust, but it is often used in transliterations—such as the first syllable of the Chinese for Eiffel Tower, Exxon Corporation, emir, and Ethiopia. *Ru* 如 has a range of meanings related to *if, as if, like, equal, for example, thus, and according to*. It is not commonly used for transliterating names beginning with Ru–. Nonetheless, again, *airu* closely resembles in sound the original Eru, easily perceived, in Chinese as in English, as a proper noun but not much else. I doubt anyone would read it as “dust-like.”

Here, though, we see a fascinating move by Deng: she chose characters closely resembling the sound of Eru—*yiru*—but these characters have potent meanings. *Yi* is “one,” and combined with *ru* we get: 一如 (*yiru*). In a Buddhist context, *yiru* is a literary term for absolute reality, the “one thusness,” a synonym of *zhenru* (“true thusness,” namely, reality as it “really is like”); the nondual whole of existence, in contrast with our fragmenting perceptions. In saying that ultimate reality is *like what it is like*, one is reminded of the phrase, “it is what it is,” or even Exodus 3.14, where God says to Moses, “I am who I am” or “I am that I am,” though the Buddhist “thusness” is certainly *not* meant in a theistic sense. At least for those readers with some knowledge of Buddhist philosophy, *yiru* then belongs to a register of place-markers for a non-dual ultimate reality beyond words. For readers without such knowledge, it would still have a certain metaphysical or spiritual sound. This *yi*—is not common in transliteration, where *yi* 伊, *yi* 以, or *yi* 意 are more common (as in Iran, Israel, and Italy).

Starting from a strong assertion of the limits of language, Buddhist philosophers developed a vocabulary for talking about reality while avoiding the pitfalls of saying too much about it—this is the idea of language as the “finger pointing to the moon.” *Yiru* is a descriptor or label for ultimate reality, which posits that reality is non-dual (*yi*, one), and furthermore “like that” or “is what it is” (*ru*). *Yiru* is thus a name for the fundamental nature of reality *here and now*, much like Buddhist emptiness. The idea of emptiness does not say that things simply don’t exist, but rather they don’t exist *in themselves*. In a Buddhist

sense the term does not refer to a *creator* god, because the true nature of reality does not have such things as intentions, desires, or individual consciousness, so perhaps this choice makes the cosmogony slightly less theistic. But if so, only momentarily—as the story goes on, Eru sees, speaks, and makes, like a god.

Since Thai is phonetic, the Thai translation gives us a rather different linguistic phenomenon: “A long time ago, there was eru the one who is one (พระผู้เป็นหนึ่ง *phra pu pen neung*) who was called in the arda world *iluwata*” (Thanyaprasertkul *Silm.* 39). *Pu pen neung* is literally “person who is one.” *Phra* is an honorific prefix for various sacred persons, most commonly monks but also gods. As with Chinese, lacking the definite article and capital letters, simply to say “the One” would sound like just “one” and not make much sense, hence this more formal phrasing. *Phra* is followed in the next line by the use of พระองค์ *phra-ong*, combining the sacred-honorific *phra* with *ong*, the Thai count noun for sacred objects; *phra-ong* becomes a pronoun, putting Ilúvatar in the class of gods, kings, Buddhas and Buddha-images. (For a sense of how count nouns work, think of “one *piece* of paper,” “two *pairs* of trousers,” etc.)

In the course of the Southward migration of the Tai peoples, they adapted a Khmer script for their writing, a script which is phonetic in nature. The language absorbed vocabulary of Indic origin, which is now particularly visible in the jargons of royalty and Buddhism. Monarchs of the current dynasty for example are known as พระราม *Phra-raam* the first, the second, etc.—in other words the Hindu deity Rama. This distinctive honorific or “royal” language (*raajasap*) is not merely a set of specialized terms but a series of different lexical registers. In English we can say “The King ate breakfast” and “the dog ate breakfast” using the same verb; in Thai there are entirely different terms for various social contexts. In the third paragraph of the *Ainulindalë*, Ilúvatar “said” such-and-such; in Thai the verb is *trat* คริส which is only used for royalty or deities. Of course English is capable of distinguishing such things: though Tolkien used a simple “said,” we might say a god like Ilúvatar “pronounced” or “declaimed,” but these do not approach the systematic, specific hierarchies of Thai royal language. Consistently the Thai uses verbs in *raajasap*, for Ilúvatar and the Valar: *trat* for speak, ถวาย *tawai* for give, and so on. The text also uses เทพ *thep* (a Thai pronunciation of the Sanskrit word *deva*, meaning “god”) as a prefix before the proper names of Valar: the deva Ulmo, the deva Mandos. This is entirely natural in Thai, but now, we might return to the English and find “he” and “said” rather flat. Almost disrespectful. In English as in Thai, we learn of Ilúvatar’s divine nature semantically (through what is said of Him), but the Thai adds a layer of lexical distinction, which sounds like something you would hear in a temple, or a palace.

HE AND HE

It came to pass, “he made first the Ainur, the Holy Ones, that were the offspring of his thought, and they were with him before aught else was made. And he spoke to them, propounding to them themes of music; and they sang before him, and he was glad” (*Silm.* 3). In the original, Ilúvatar has a male pronoun. Let us set aside the complex theological question and cultural history of gendering something like the Christian God or the cosmic and formless Ilúvatar, and instead observe that “he” is a *lower-case* pronoun. Surely Ilúvatar deserves a He?

Neither Chinese nor Thai have capital letters, so the distinction between “He” and “he” is either invisible, or must be dealt with in other ways. Li gives us: “he (*ta* 他) first made the “holy worthies” [or sages, *shengxian*] *a-yi-nuo*. These ‘holy worthies’ were all born from what his heart-mind thought. Before other people were created, there were only them and him together. Ilúvatar and they spoke of many things [*tantian shuodi*, talked of heaven and spoke of earth], and he gave them musical themes; and so they sang for him songs, he was very happy” (Li *Silm.* 3). The third-person pronoun *ta* 他 is either gender-neutral or male, or ambiguously both, because it is a default ungendered pronoun for people in general, much like the now-outdated use of “he” or “man” for people in general. And yet, *ta* 他 is in contrast with *ta* 她, “she,” a character never used for males. So with Li’s translation the male gender is implicit, easily assumed, strongly implied. But again the “he” here (*ta* 他) is the exact same pronoun as any other, non-divine “he” (*ta* 他).

Deng however uses another variation: “It (*ta* 祂) first made from [Its] own thought many *ai-nu*, ‘the sacred envoys’ (*shensheng de shizhe*), they were before the myriad things were made and were with It. It spoke to them, It proposed to them the topics of song (樂曲的主題 *yuequ de zhuti*). So before It, they loudly sang, which made It completely happy” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 3). In her later translation, she changed “the sacred envoys” to “holy ones (*shenshengzhe* 神圣者)” (Deng *Silm.* 2015, 31).

Deng uses a less common variant of the third person pronoun, *ta* 祂 rather than the more common *ta* 他 as Li uses. They are pronounced the same (just as “He” and “he” are pronounced the same), but *ta* 祂 has a radical component which indicates it is used for gods. Since Tolkien gendered Ilúvatar male, it makes sense to read *ta* 祂 in this line as male, but whereas “he” is always male, *ta* 祂 is not particularly gender-specific. This is why I have translated 祂 as “It,” despite the discourtesy of calling someone (let alone a god) “It.” Still, this pronoun choice presents a *lexical* analogue of the *typographic* distinction “He/he.” In a larger frame, it does raise the question of why Tolkien did not use

“He,” since *Ilúvatar* is obviously a fictional analogue of the Christian God—perhaps it was intended to create a little distance between *Ilúvatar* and the Christian God. In Deng’s translations there is no such issue—she used the pronoun for a God.

The Thai version similarly resists the absent capitalization of *Ilúvatar*’s pronoun though a lexical choice of *phra-ong*. Back-translating this particular *phra-ong*, I would either use a literalistic “the holy one,” or given the context, “He.”

Capitalization of deities is not a trivial matter, as shown by a remarkable example from a Russian translation. Nataliya Rakhmanova systematically turned phrases in which a deity is implied, such as “Bless me,” into explicit terms: “God bless me.” (Ferré et al note a similar pattern in French translations; 55). But as Mark Hooker writes, “At the time that she did her translation, *God* was a sensitive word to Soviet editors and censors. It was never spelled with a capital “G”, unless it began a sentence” (71). Some translators even contrived to put the word always at the start of the sentence so that it would be capitalized, and censors contrived to move the word later in the sentence so it would not be capitalized (71).

BUDDHIST CONNOTATIONS OF THE VOID

How do the translations speak of what is *not* *Ilúvatar*—not created by *Ilúvatar*, namely: the Void? The melodies filled up the space of *Ilúvatar*, “and the music and the echo of the music went out into the Void, and it was not void” (*Silm.* 4). Li has: “The music and its echo flowed out into the void [空虛 *kongxu*], and thereby the world was not again void [*kongxu*]” (Li *Silm.* 4). When the original says, “the Void, and it was not void” (*Silm.* 4), we have the term as nominal and adjectival, with and without the definite article, with and without capitalization. Since Chinese does not have capitalization, there is no parallel typographic way to distinguish between Void and void. For both, Li uses *kongxu*, which is also both nominal and adjectival. Deng uses *kongxu* and *kong*, but frames them more explicitly. She renders it as: “this movement [in the musical sense: 樂章 *yuezhang*, music-chapter] and its echo floated into ‘the domain of emptiness’ (*kongxu zhi jing*), and yet it was not empty (不是空的 *bushi kong de*)” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 4. 2015 32 is very similar). As a “domain,” the first use is clearly nominal and spatial, whereas the construction *bushi . . . de* clearly marks the second usage as an adjective. Deng creates a lexical solution to the puzzle of the unrepresentable typographic distinction.

The Thai translation for Void involves the word สลฺย *soon* (zero, empty). The music “went out to struggle with empty space (สลฺยภูมิ *soonpumi*), which at this time was not vacant and empty (ว่างสลฺย *wangsoon*) again.” (Thanyapratertkul *Silm.* 40). The Thai translation differentiates them by using the nominal *soonpumi* (empty-place or zero-place) and a more abstract

compound *wangsoon* (empty-zero or empty-empty). Similarly, in translating “it seemed to him that Ilúvatar took no thought for the Void, and he was impatient of its emptiness” (*Silm.* 4), the Thai gives “the Void” as *soonpumi*, though “emptiness” here is ความว่างเปล่า *khwaam wangplao*, very literally “empty-ness” or “nothing-ness” (Thanyaprasertkul *Silm.* 41). There is an etymological lineage here: Thai *soon* is derived from Pali *suñña*, itself derived from Sanskrit *śūnya*, the abstract noun of which is *suññatā* in Pali (more widely known by the Sanskrit *śūnyatā*), and usually translated as the Buddhist term “emptiness.” *Soonpumi* also uses the Sanskrit-derived *bhūmi* (place). In Thailand, Buddhist philosophical terms tend to be derived from texts in the scriptural language Pali.

In “the Void, and it was not void,” the endless emptiness is given a proper noun status, where small-v void means only empty. In Li’s translation, the Chinese term for both of these is *kongxu*. Deng uses *kongxu* for the noun, and *kong* for the adjective. *Kong* in particular has strong Buddhist associations, namely the Chinese translation of *śūnyatā*, “emptiness.” Some translators of Buddhist sutras or ideas into English have rendered *śūnyatā* as the Void, though this usage has fallen out of fashion. The use of Chinese *kong* or Thai *soon* does not mean the story is necessarily read as Buddhist, however. Though *kong* has a Buddhist resonance, it also just means, empty. As in: empty bowl, empty room. Besides, the Buddhist idea of emptiness implies, whatever might be in the bowl, it *and the bowl itself* are both empty—that is, have no independent essential existence—an entirely different point. Furthermore, the Buddhist rhetoric of “the emptiness of emptiness” asserts that in Buddhist terms emptiness is not a Being in itself. In Christianity there is an interesting parallel history of the theology of Nothingness (see Harrison).

For Tolkien, is the Void a Being in itself? Tolkien gives us some clues about the surrounding absence. Darkness is sometimes the mere absence of light, but when capitalized it is a thing in itself. We see the same pattern with Light/light: “The Light failed; but the Darkness that followed was more than loss of light. In that hour was made a Darkness that seemed not lack but a thing with being of its own: for it was indeed made by malice out of Light” (*Silm.* 81). The endless expanse of emptiness surrounding them is conceived as a kind of Being in itself or anti-Being. The translations lack the option of capital-D Darkness. The Li translation does nothing about the problem but relies on the context, which in this case makes the meanings of the words clear enough (Li *Silm.* 76). But Deng is more perceptive of the nuance. For the simple “but the Darkness”, Deng shifts the grammar a little: “There was at that time created a kind of darkness” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 107). For Darkness as “a thing with being of its own,” Deng has “it was a kind of concrete existence (實體存在 *shiti cunzai*)” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 103). And in the later version, the Darkness “possessed its own life (拥有自己的生命 *yongyou ziji de shengming*)” (Deng *Silm.* 2015 107).

EMPTINESS AND HUNDUN

In the original, Melkor “had gone often alone into the void places seeking the Imperishable Flame; for desire grew hot within him to bring into Being things of his own, and it seemed to him that Ilúvatar took no thought for the Void, and he was impatient of its emptiness” (*Silm.* 4). We see void, Void, and emptiness. Deng treats both “the void places” and “the Void” as “the domain of emptiness” (空虛之境 *kongxu zhi jing*)” and elaborates on emptiness as *kong* with the phrase 空無一物 *kong wu yi wu*, “empty without a single thing” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 4–5; 2015 32–33). But Li introduces a different Void: “He often went alone to the empty and spacious (空曠 *kongkuang*) places, looking for the ‘unextinguishing flame.’ In his breast there was a hot desire, he thought to make life (生命 *shengming*) himself. In his view, Ilúvatar basically had not thought of the *hundun* unmanifested world (混沌未開的世界 *hundun weikai de shijie*). Facing an expanse of emptiness (*kongxu*), he was very impatient” (Li *Silm.* 4). Here we get three voids: 1. “the void places” is 空曠之地 *kongkuang zhidi*, empty and vast place, big open space; 2. “the Void” is *kongxu*, meaning empty, emptiness; and 3. “its emptiness” is 混沌 *hundun*, which is further clarified by the phrase “unmanifested world” or “the world not yet begun.”

Hundun is a term of Daoist origin, usually glossed as a primordial chaotic potentiality, a seething foment which allows no divisions. It is *not* empty. Whereas in a void there is nothing, in *hundun* there is no (particular, individualizable) *thing*. Everything is there, but distinctions cannot be made, so we are unable to make selfish subject-object distinctions, let alone distinctions such as chair-table-room-person.

This notion of *hundun*, if not the term itself, appears for example in chapter 69 of the *Daodejing* (here using Lau’s translation of the Mawangdui version):

There is a thing confusedly formed (混成 *huncheng*),
 Born before heaven and earth.
 Silent and void (寥 *liao*, silent, deserted, open)
 It stands alone and does not change.
 Goes round and does not weary.
 It is capable of being the mother of heaven and earth.
 As yet I do not know its name.
 I style it ‘the way’ (*dao* 道). (Lau)

In this sense there is no *thing* in *hundun*. If an image of emptiness is a bowl with nothing in it, the image of *hundun* would be a bowl with a gloppy,

squishy soup in it—indeed, the term comes to us in its English pronunciation of its Cantonese pronunciation: wonton. Next time you have wonton soup, remember that you’re looking at a Daoist image of the original and ultimately true form of the universe. Except that the bowl isn’t part of the metaphor, of course. *Hundun* does resemble *śūnyatā*, in that neither posits a simple absence (like an empty room), but *hundun* emphasizes the chaos (in which no single thing exists separately) where *śūnyatā* emphasizes absence (of any *separate* thing).

Similarly, when Ilúvatar says, “And I will send forth into the Void the Flame Imperishable” (*Silm.* 9), Li gives us *hundun*: “I want to send the unextinguishing flame into an expanse of *hundun* (*yipian hundun zhizhong*)” (Li *Silm.* 9). Consistent with other cases, Deng uses “domain of emptiness” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 11; 2015 37 is almost the same). The Thai, of course, has no *hundun*: “we will send eternal fire into the *soonpumi*” or empty place (Thanyaprasertkul *Silm.* 46).

A synonym for *hundun* is *dakuai* 大塊/大快—the great clod, the big lump. An image of lumpy inertia. But also the imagery of eggs, the womb, and fetal gestation are frequently part of this concept. There is some overlap with the story of Pangu, first recorded in the 3rd century CE but undoubtedly older. Initially there is only formless chaos, which eventually forms a cosmic egg. Inside the egg, yin and yang harmonize and create a humanoid figure, Pangu. He then creates the world in a division and separation of earth and sky (again, a binary polarity). Then Pangu dies and falls apart, becoming parts or aspects of the world such as the sun and moon, the wind, mountains and rivers, and animals—here death is associated with multiplicity and physical substance—with our world.

The Daoist philosopher Zhuangzi 莊子/庄子 (ca. 369–286 BCE) tells a story about the egg-like *hundun*: as a primordial unity it was whole and filled with life; the Emperors of the North and South (representing binary distinction) wanted to be helpful, and thought: we have seven holes in our bodies, let’s give *hundun* seven holes. They drilled a hole a day, and on the seventh day *hundun* died (Mair 71). In Daoism this story illustrates a basic distinction between *qiantian* and *houtian*, literally anterior heaven and posterior heaven. We shouldn’t take “heaven” too literally here, but read it more as “world.” The world before the fall, and the world after. The world before is “the *hundun* unmanifested world (*hundun weikai de shijie*),” in which all things are potential, whole, and integral, if as yet unrealized. We are living in the world *after*, in which we make the millions of distinctions whereby we cut the world up into tiny pieces, and obscure the fundamental integrity of the world. This is imagined as a lamentable fall from potential to actual, from infinite to finite, from deathless to mortal.

There are other examples of *hundun* as Void. “But when they were come into the Void, Ilúvatar said to them: ‘Behold your Music!’ [...] and they saw a new World made visible before them, and it was globed amid the Void, and it was sustained therein, but was not of it” (*Silm.* 6). As George MacDonald said of God’s creation, “He utters them into the visible” (4). Li’s re-telling has, “Coming to the place of *hundun*, Ilúvatar said to them: ‘Look at your music!’ [...] Before the Ainur’s eyes appeared a new world, that was a giant globe which formed in the midst of *hundun*. It seemed to be continuously suspended there, constant and not decreasing” (Li *Silm.* 6). And Deng: “They came to ‘the domain of emptiness,’ Ilúvatar said to them: ‘Look! Your musical movement! (*yuezhang*)’ [...] Before their eyes appeared a new world (*yuzhou*, universe, space and time), in the emptiness (空無 *kongwu*) there was a globe (球體 *qiuti*, sphere-body) manifested, existing (存立 *cunli*, existing and established) and not falling in emptiness (*kongxu*), yet not belonging to (不屬於 *bu shuyu*) emptiness” (Deng, *Silm.* 2002 6; 2015 34 is similar). Whereas Li breezes past it, the more theologically aware translator, Deng, picks up on the notion of the world being “in” but not “of” the Void, very much analogous to John 17:13–14, with its contrast of Christ and Christians being “in” but not “of” (*shuyu*) the world.

VOID IN THE VALAQUENTA AND GENESIS

Just as Genesis outlines the process of creation (Gen. 1:1–2:4) and then backs up and goes over part of the narrative in more detail (2:4–2:14), when we move from the *Ainulindalë* to the *Valaquenta* we get another variation of the cosmogony. The opening lines from the *Valaquenta* more or less repeat the same initial starting point, the manifestation of the Ainur, their music, and the granting of vision. “Therefore Ilúvatar gave to their vision Being” (*Silm.* 15). The capital-B “Being” is a very abstract concept, even if it refers to things actually existing. It is paraphrased by Li as, “Ilúvatar let this view be born in the world” (Li *Silm.* 15), whereas Deng’s 2002 translation spells it out a bit more: “Soon after, Ilúvatar made the beautiful sight that they saw into concrete (具體 *juti*) material existence (物質存在 *wuzhi cunzai*)” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 17; 2015 43 is very similar). And we read, Ilúvatar “set it amid the Void” (*Silm.* 15). Li: “also put it in an expanse of *hundun* (*yipian hundun zhizhong*)” (Li *Silm.* 15). Again we see the Void as *hundun*, whereas Deng has, “placed this existence in the emptiness (*xukong*)” (Deng *Silm.* 2002 17; 2015 43 very similar).

Another reference to the Void suggests a rather different meaning: “But in after years he [Sauron] rose like a shadow of Morgoth and a ghost of his malice, and walked behind him on the same ruinous path down into the Void” (*Silm.* 24). Here, “into the Void” would seem to mean, into utter destruction and non-existence. But Li continues the usage: “Later, he simply became Morgoth’s shadow, became a ghost (幽灵 *youling*, dark spirit) of cruelty. Into the *hundun*

world with his master he followed like a shadow, following closely" (Li *Silm.* 24). Li's text implies he became an actual ghost, rather than a continued presence of Morgoth's cruelty. Similarly, the original clearly means he was *like* a shadow of Morgoth—he was a lesser form, mimicking his master, and Li loses the simile. Usually, I find the metaphors of the original are turned into similes in the Chinese; here the reverse is true. Li also reads "the Void" using the term *hundun*. Deng's translation is particularly vivid and colorful: "he rose suddenly like the monstrous shadow (魅影 *meiying*, *mei* = demon, evil spirit + *ying*, shadow) of Morgoth, like his evil-poisonous (惡毒 *e-du*) ghost (鬼魂 *guihun*) continuing to be tangled in the world, until in the end he stepped on Morgoth's dust (*houchen*, dust raised by someone walking ahead), fell into emptiness (*kongxu*)" (Deng *Silm.* 2002 30; see also 2015 52). She makes the shadow monstrous. And walking behind Morgoth now has a more vivid and dismal quality.

Given the widespread presence of Christianity in China today, the translations of Void may not only suggest Daoism and Buddhism. Genesis 1:1, from the RSV: "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth. The earth was without form and void." A modern Catholic Mandarin Chinese translation has: "At the start of the original beginning, when the Lord of Heaven made heaven and earth, the great land was one expanse of *hundun*, without form and without pattern." I have checked several Protestant translations and they also use *hundun*. Reading the *Ainulindalë*, a reader may just as likely hear an echo of the Bible as a Daoist text.

Of course, there is another cosmogony in the Bible, one that is sound-based: the start of John's Gospel: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was in the beginning with God; all things were made through him, and without him was not anything made that was made" (John 1:1–4). The same Chinese Catholic translation has: "At the start of the original beginning, there was 'dao', 'dao' and the Lord of Heaven existed together, 'dao' was the Lord of Heaven. In the beginning, 'dao' existed together with the Lord of Heaven. The myriad things (*wanwu*) were made according to 'dao,' without 'dao' there would be nothing at all." Here we have Logos glossed as Dao, the key concept after which "Daoism" (or "Taoism") is named. (This choice is further complicated by the use of *dao* as a verb, meaning "to speak," a pun we find in the first line of the *Daodejing*.) We also have "all things" translated as 萬物 *wanwu*, myriad things, 10,000 things. This is another intertextual moment: In the *Daodejing*, chapter 42, the transition from the world-before to the world-after is phrased as "The dao gave birth to one, one gave birth to two, two gave birth to three, and three gave birth to the ten thousand things (*wanwu*)" (author's translation).

CONCLUSION

The beginning of the world was an emergence from some undifferentiated and non-dual state into differentiated form, and this fragmenting process is associated with speaking or naming. This is a familiar pattern from Daoist philosophy, and from the Christian Bible, and from Buddhist philosophy (sort-of). It also resonates with chaos theory, the emergence of cognition, and childbirth. Time is a *descent*: from good to bad, from spirit to form, from long life to short life.

The Daoist, Buddhist, or Christian origins of certain terms, and the intertextual flow among these categories, do not of course require us to see those religions in every use of a word. *Hundun* is also used in the phrase *hundun lilun*, “chaos theory.” *Dao* can also simply mean a way (to get somewhere or do something). But even secularized terminology, when re-inserted into a scripture or a scripture-like fiction, is re-animated with religious meaning. An examination of the Buddhist or Daoist elements, whether in Chinese or Thai translations or in the original, is certainly not equivalent to claiming they were intended. Finding them in a translation assumes only that translators use what is available to them, and that no language is entirely free of its form of life. As Wittgenstein wrote, “to imagine a language means to imagine a form of life” (8).

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ERIC REINDERS is associate professor of religion at Emory University, where he teaches on Chinese religion, theories of religion, and religion and fantasy. His B.A. and M.Phil are from Hull University, UK, and his Ph.D. is from the University of California, Santa Barbara. He is the author of *Reading Tolkien in Chinese: Religion, Fantasy and Translation* (2024), *The Moral Narratives of Hayao Miyazaki* (2016), and *Buddhist and Christian Responses to the Kowtow Problem in China* (2015). His current research concerns Chinese translations of *Dracula*.



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THE MIDDLE-(UN)MAN OF DESIRE: A GIRARDIAN READING OF *PERELANDRA*

CLINTON DANLEY

In the birth of desire, the third person is always present.

—René Girard¹

Why do we desire what we do? Why do we strive for a certain education, aim at a certain career, read certain books, pursue certain lovers, or attend certain conferences? In short, why do we want what we want? French polymath René Girard answers that we desire what we do because we imitate the desires of others. According to Girard, we don't actually know what to want so we look at our heroes and neighbors to see what they want and follow suit. Girard identifies this *mimetic desire* as the engine that drives human culture.²

Girard famously argues that all great works of literature “reveal the imitative nature of desire” (*Deceit* 14).³ The greater the work, the more mimetically perspicacious the author. Given Girard's theory, we would expect the greatest fantasy authors to erect their sub-creative world with an intimate awareness of mimetic desire. And when we turn to C.S. Lewis, this is just what we find.

Lewis repeatedly explores imitation and rivalry with hyper-mimetic characters like Edmund Pevensie, Orual, and the unstable Studdocks. But perhaps Lewis's most insightful exploration of this middle place of desire comes in the middle book of his Ransom trilogy. *Perelandra* presents a supposal of an Eden-like temptation in an unfallen world, and Lewis envisions this event as inexorably mimetic. In this paper, I argue that the Un-man's temptation intentionally leverages the power of mimetic desire. Therefore, a Girardian reading of *Perelandra* offers fruitful insight into Lewis's take on Satanic deception.

¹ Girard, *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel: Self and Other in Literary Structure* [*Deceit*] 21.

² Burgis defines mimetic desire as “[d]esire generated and formed through the imitation of what someone else has already desired or is perceived to desire. Mimetic desire means that we choose objects due to the influence of a third party, a model or mediator of desire” (223).

³ “[T]he great writers apprehend intuitively and concretely, through the medium of their art, if not formally, the system in which they were first imprisoned together with their contemporaries” (Girard, *Deceit* 3).

Before exploring *Perelandra* directly, I will briefly summarize Girard's mimetic theory and present Lewis's exposition of that same desire in his essay "The Inner Ring."

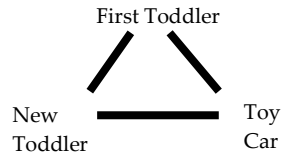
LOVE BY ANOTHER'S EYES

Love in one person is infectious in kindling it in another.

—Augustine, *Confessions* IV. xiv (21)

GIRARD'S MIMETIC THEORY

Girard's mimetic theory is vast and deep, but even a child can grasp the basic concept. If a toddler walks into a room with a hundred indistinguishable toy cars and another toddler is playing with one of those cars, which car will the new child desire? Of course, the car being played with. Why? Because *desire is contagious*. The original child indicates the value of the toy to the second. And if there are no checks in place, their shared desire will result in rivalry and toddler violence. Without outside interference, the only way to avoid the conflict would be to introduce a third notably different toddler into the mix that the first two could vent their aggression on. Behold mimetic theory in miniature.

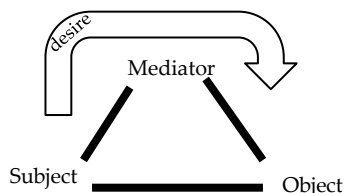


All desire (apart from basic survival needs) is the result of imitating the desires of others. Girard explains, "We assume that desire is objective or subjective, but in reality, it rests on a third party who gives value to the objects" (Girard, *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning* [*Satan*] 9). Our desires spring not from within ourselves or from the object's intrinsic value but from the presence of a third party—what Girard calls a *mediator*.⁴ Mediators are "go-betweens" or middlemen of desire, "acting as agents between the individual imitating them and the world" (Williams ix). For Girard, the shape of desire is triangular, existing in this middle place between a subject, a model, and an object. When the desired object can be shared, mimesis leads to friendship. Thus, Girard affirms, "Mimetic desire is intrinsically good" (*Satan* 15). However, when the object cannot be shared, rivalry and violence inevitably ensue. "The mimesis of desire is both the best of friendship and the worst of hatred" (Girard, *A Theater of Envy* [*Envy*] 10).⁵

⁴ Mimetic theory does not deny objective values or the intrinsic worth of things, but how we come to see and desire those values relies on a mediator.

⁵ "Friendship is this perpetual coincidence of two desires. But envy and jealousy are exactly the same thing" (*Envy* 10).

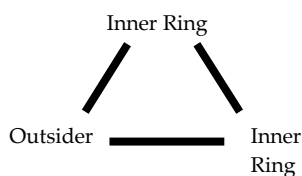
Consider one more example. When you see a commercial for an ice-cold Coke, what do you immediately long for? Coke, of course. All advertising is intrinsically mimetic, indicating what you ought to want. But more importantly, *how* is that value indicated? Typically, an obviously attractive person models the drink. Girard exposes the tactic: “[T]he most skillful advertising does not try to convince that a product is superior but that it is desired by Others” (*Deceit* 104). Objects are much like sports jerseys. They have little value to us in themselves, but when we don the jersey with the star’s name, we become like the star.



Mimetic theory posits that all desire is ultimately *metaphysical* or *ontological*. We long to be the mediator. The desired object is simply a means to that end.⁶ This longing-to-be is exactly what Lewis describes in his seminal essay on desire.

LEWIS’S INNER RING

What has been observed of Shakespeare is undoubtedly true of Lewis, he “explains everything he dramatizes and dramatizes everything he explains” (*Envy* 146). The desire he dramatizes elsewhere (especially in *That Hideous Strength*), he explains in “The Inner Ring.” He states, “I believe that in all men’s lives [...] one of the most dominant elements is the desire to be inside the local Ring and the terror of being left outside” (146). For Lewis, human beings have a ubiquitous desire to get in. The desire may be sparked by a shared object of interest—a hobby or work of art—but the real aim is *the sense of being* that is imagined to come with entry into the Ring. This “longing to be inside” is nothing other than Girard’s metaphysical desire. *To be in is to be like*. Those in the desirable circle mediate the desire for the status of being in the circle.



Just like mimetic desire, Lewis sees the Inner Ring as inevitable—in itself neither good nor bad. “This desire is one of the great permanent mainsprings of human action” (151). But it is dangerous and easily manipulated. The lust to get in energizes competition, rivalry, and advertisement, often leading to moral compromises. “Of all passions the passion

⁶ “However desirable the object may be, it pales in comparison with the model who gives it value” (*Envy* 43).

for the Inner Ring is most skilful in making a man who is not yet a very bad man do very bad things" (154). Or we might say the passion for the Inner Ring can make a Lady who is not yet bad at all do very tragic things.

Like Girard, Lewis sees this imitative desire ending in disappointment and eventually disaster unless recognized and renounced. "The quest of the Inner Ring will break your heart unless you break it" (156). In a sense, *Perelandra's* central drama embodies this one statement.

THE MIDDLE-(UN)MAN OF DESIRE

I will excite their minds with more desire.
—Satan, *Paradise Lost* (4.522–23)⁷

The temptation scene in *Perelandra* is a supposal of what might have happened in Eden. The Un-man, a Satan figure who stood before Eve in the garden (Lewis, *Perelandra* [P] 103) and remembers the cry from the cross (130), tempts the Green Lady, a new Eve, to disobey Maleldil's (God's) single command not to sleep on the Fixed Lands. However, Maleldil sends the man Ransom to thwart the Un-man's assault.

Lewis presents three conversations between the Un-man and the Lady. After the final one, he summarizes the Un-man's tactics, "He was making her mind a theater in which that phantom self should hold the stage. He had already written the play" (P 118). This strategy has three mimetic tactics that roughly correspond to the three cycles of conversation: 1) make her mind a theater, 2) write the play, and 3) put self on stage. We will examine each in turn.

1. MAKE HER MIND A THEATER

If every Pandarus is a kind of playwright, all playwrights are panders in disguise.
—René Girard⁸

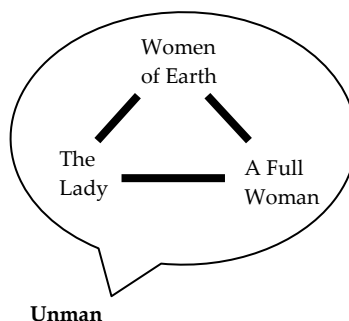
If we were to imagine an average tempter, say the demonic apprentice in *The Screwtape Letters*, attempting to cause the Lady to fall, the brunt of the assault would likely focus on the Fixed Lands themselves. The tempter would wax eloquent about the Lands' desirability and the injustice of God to deny them. However, the Un-man takes a far more subtle route.

⁷ It is beyond the scope of this essay, but the parallels between Milton's Satan and Lewis's Un-man are legion. The tactics both use to tempt the Eve-character are essentially the same. Both leverage the power of mimetic desire through the faculty of imagination. Of course, we would expect these parallels since Lewis was writing *A Preface to Paradise Lost* around the same time as *Perelandra*. But the mimetic nature of Milton's Satan confirms we are on the right track in seeing the same dynamic in Lewis.

⁸ *Envy* 158.

A PANDER OF DESIRE

The Un-man acts as a *pander of desire*. As Girard observes of Shakespeare's Pandarus, the Un-man acts as "the midwife and engineer of desire, its Alexander and Napoleon. [...] Like the God of Descartes, his initial push sets entire worlds in motion" (*Envy* 123). Or at least, so he hopes. He channels the zeitgeist of advertising and targets the Lady as his sole demographic. Like the advertiser, the pander role allows the Un-man to foster desire in the Lady without becoming her rival. He can orchestrate the fall of *Perelandra* from outside the mimetic triangle. So he acts as the great stage manager of desire.



THEATER OF THE MIND

From the beginning, the Un-man creates in the Lady a desire *to be* a certain kind of person. He erects a stage of *metaphysical desire* and lures the Lady on to it. The desire is to be "a full woman [...] like the women of my world" (*P* 90–91). When the Lady asks what those women are like, the Un-man paints a grand picture:

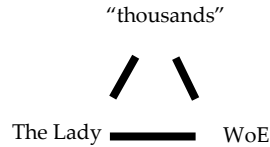
They are of a *great* spirit. They always reach out their hands for the new and unexpected good, and see that it is good long before the men understand it. Their minds run ahead of what Maleldil has told them. They do not need to wait for Him to tell them what is good, but know it for themselves as He does. They are, as it were, *little Maleldils*. And because of their *wisdom*, their beauty is as much greater than yours as the sweetness of these gourds surpasses the taste of water. And because of their *beauty* the love which the men have for them is as much greater than the King's love for you. (*P* 91, emphasis mine)

Welcome to the Un-man's theater. He fills the stage of her mind with what I will call the eminently desirable *Women of Earth* (WoE). These WoE have four noteworthy traits to spark the Lady's mimetic envy.

First, the WoE are great and great because they are progressive. They always reach out for the new good. Later, in a classic case of propaganda, the Un-man redefines the word Death to capture this progressiveness. Only through "Death in abundance" (i.e., constant progress) can "the real oldness and the

strong beauty and the uttermost branching out" come (P 98).⁹ These traits characterize the WoE, and the Un-man makes Death-as-progress the pathway to become them.

Second, the WoE are beautiful. However, for the Un-man, beauty is but a tool of envy. It only serves as an aphrodisiac of sorts.¹⁰ Beauty is desirable because it inflames desire. The Un-man returns to this at the end of this first temptation. As he expands his portrait of the tragic heroine, he explains that by attaining rivalrous knowledge, a few women became "more beautiful and excelled their fellows as you excel the beasts; and thousands were striving for their love" (P 103). Here the WoE are the victorious rivals of all lesser women and, thus, the objects of desire for all men. Beauty can make the Lady a new Helen, "the woman with the thousands of lovers" (P 103).



Third, WoE are "old." Lewis weaves the idea of "becoming older" throughout this section, making it roughly synonymous with gaining wisdom or maturity. However, the Un-man equivocates with the term, flitting between wisdom, age, and loss of childlike innocence.¹¹ Girard captures the Un-man's ambiguity well, "Hell begins when the heaven of childhood gives way to mimetic rivalry" (*Envy* 77). The Un-man meditates a way of getting old that smells like sulfur. However, he makes this ill-gotten wisdom the source of the beauty and greatness of the WoE (P 97). He tells the Lady, "When you are fully grown you will be even wiser and more beautiful than the women of my own world" (P 99). The Un-man makes growing old the ticket to becoming a victorious rival over the WoE.

Finally, WoE are "little Maleldils." The Un-man presents them as goddesses and defines divinity as independence. They are goddesses because they need no mediator to show them what is good. Neither men nor Maleldil model desire for them. Girard calls this the *Romantic self* that denies the imitative nature of desire and instead embraces the "lie of spontaneous desire" (*Deceit* 16). The Un-man reinforces this independence later by asserting "your own reason" acts as the final arbiter of what is good (P 100). Reason stands above the commands of Maleldil, allowing the Lady to be "really separate from Him" (P

⁹ He also condemns Ransom's love of the past: "He wanted you to remain young, not to learn Death" (P 98).

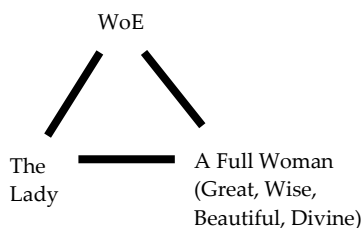
¹⁰ "Envy is the aphrodisiac par excellence" (*Envy* 23)

¹¹ Ransom refutes the Un-man's advances, stating, "In our world to be older is not always to be wiser" (P 102).

101). Again, this is just the Romantic lie¹² in new clothes, but behind the king of all temptations stands the ancient, naked claim, “You shall be like gods” (Gen. 3:4).

With his deft stage management, the Un-man parades the WoE as an Inner Ring the Lady must get into. He creates in her a desire to be “a full woman” like them—great, wise, beautiful, and divine. He fathers envy.¹³

Mimetic desire to be like the WoE forms the cornerstone of the Un-man’s strategy and illuminates the strange absence of the Fixed Lands in the Un-man’s initial assault. The Lady hints that he has spoken of the Fixed Lands often (*P* 89), but Lewis presents none of it. The Un-man hardly mentions the “object” he is trying to



sell. Why? Because he knows if he can make the Lady desire the WoE, living on the Fixed Lands will serve as a means to that end. Again, Girard exposes the illusion of the desired object, “The object is only a means of reaching the mediator. The desire is aimed at the mediator’s *being*” (*Deceit* 53). The Un-man must make her mind a theater of desire before he incites her to action.

2. WRITE THE PLAY

Assaying, by his devilish art, to reach the organs of her fancy, and with them forge illusions, discontented thoughts, vain hopes, vain aims, inordinate desires.
— *Paradise Lost* (4.800–09)

In the second stage of the Un-man’s temptation, he writes the play the Lady must perform to become one of the WoE. To that end, the Un-man wields perhaps the most powerful means of awakening desire—*storytelling*. Stories appeal primarily to the imagination, not reason, and grant access to new worlds with new models. But the imaginary nature of literary models does not limit their influence over us. The mediator may be imaginary, but the mediation is not (Girard, *Deceit* 4, 23).

The Un-man himself recognizes this power of story. When the Lady asks what purpose his flights of fancy serve, he responds, “The world is made up not only of what is but of what might be” (*P* 89). The Un-man knows denizens

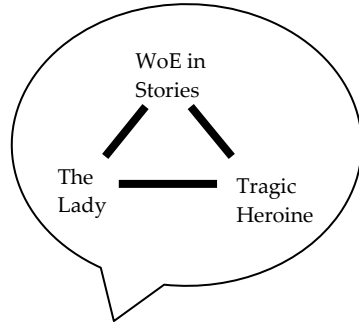
¹² Burgis defines the Romantic lie as “the idea that our choices are completely autonomous, independent, and self-directed. Someone under the power of the Romantic Lie never thinks of their behavior as mimetic” (Burgis 224).

¹³ “Envy subordinates a desired *something* to the *someone* who enjoys a privileged relationship with it,” says Girard. “Envy involuntarily testifies to a lack of *being*” (*Envy* 4).

of imagination shape the real world, especially by influencing what we want. In true mythopoeic fashion, the Un-man weaves new worlds to capture the Lady's fancy.¹⁴

THE MIMETICS OF MYTHOPOEIA

Lewis leaves us in no doubt as to what world the Un-man constructs. He tells the Lady "with extreme beauty and pathos, a number of stories" (P 107). The theme running through these stories is the *tragic heroine*: "Each one of these women had stood forth alone and braved a terrible risk for her child, her lover, or her people. Each had been misunderstood, reviled and persecuted: but each also magnificently vindicated by the event" (P 108). The Un-man cares not if the Lady understands all of these tales. He aims to shape her imagination, not enlighten reason:



**The Un-man's
Storytelling**

What emerged from the stories was rather an image than an idea—the picture of the tall, slender form, unbowed though the world's weight rested upon its shoulders, stepping forth fearless and friendless into the dark to do for others what those others forbade it to do yet needed to have done. (P 108)

Jadis the White Witch, Lady Macbeth, Clytemnestra, Anna Karenina—the Un-man conquers the Platonic form of the tragic heroine, and it is a potent enchantment. Even Ransom admits the spell "was very well done" (P 108). By imitating these "goddess shapes," the Lady herself can become a goddess. With their storyline, the Un-man sets the Lady up to be a tragic Don Quixote.¹⁵

¹⁴ Girard argues extensively that myths often conceal the source of our desires, the inevitable violence that emerges from those rivalries, and the innocence of the scapegoat. Curtis Gruenler has shown that Lewis recognized this same function of myth in *Till We Have Faces* ("C.S. Lewis and René Girard on Desire, Conversion, and Myth: The Case of *Till We Have Faces*"). However, Lewis also had a high view of myth and myth-making as a pathway to find truth and know God. There is work to be done here reconciling these three so I plan to make this interaction between the Un-man's storytelling, Girardian myth, and Lewisian mythopoeia the topic of a future paper.

¹⁵ Girard reads *Don Quixote* as a paradigmatic example of mimetic desire meditated through story (*Deceit* 1–4). The chivalric tales, especially about Amadís, awakened Quixote's desire for the being of a chivalric knight. "Amadís was the polestar, the morning star, the sun to valiant, enamored knights, the one who should be imitated by all of us who serve under the banner of love and chivalry" (Cervantes 229). That desire—the apple of

MIMETIC DOUBLES

The Un-man's success follows quick on the heels of his storytelling. In Girard's system, as mimetic rivalry increases, the subject and the mediator become more and more alike. He calls this *mimetic doubling*.¹⁶ As the subject's desire for the mediator increases, she will increasingly imitate them and differences will disappear. Lewis shows us this exact phenomenon.

Immediately after the Un-man pens his play in the Lady's imagination, she begins to look like "a tragedy queen" (P 108). The transformation appalls Ransom. Until now, the Lady has been heavenly, but now she looks "so like a woman of our own race." She has begun to take on the "rôle" of the WoE, wearing the borrowed robes of "invited grandeur" and "enjoyed pathos" (P 109). Through the power of suggested desire, the Un-man writes the script of the Lady's fall, and she starts practicing the part.

DESIRE FUELED BY DENIAL

However, in the second phase of the temptation, the Un-man does not limit his tactics to the imagination. He repeatedly returns to the command—Maleldil's prohibition against living on the Fixed Lands. At one level, an explanation of this fixation springs ready to hand. The Un-man aims at disobedience; therefore, he must undermine the legitimacy of the call to obey. This tactic is as old as Eden. But mimetically, the Un-man does something far more powerful. He knows *the desirability of a good withheld*. As any parent can tell you, "Don't do that!" makes "that" all the more attractive.

Girard explains, "The disadvantage of the prohibitions [...] is that they don't finally play their role in a satisfying manner. Their primarily negative character [...] inevitably provokes in us the mimetic urge to transgress them" (*Satan* 14). A lawgiver sets himself up as an obstacle to the prohibited good—in Girardian terms, a *rival*—and "[o]pposition exasperates desire" (10). The Apostle Paul makes the same observation: "Sin [...] through the commandment, produced in me all kinds of desire" (Rom. 7:8).¹⁷

his eye—grew rotten and spoiled his imagination. He ended up tilting with windmills. The Un-man aims to make the Lady equally quixotic as she imitates the tragic trajectory of the heroines he portrays.

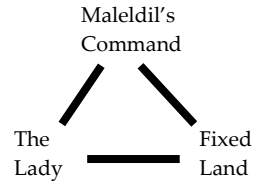
¹⁶ "'Mimetic doubles' refers to the situation in which rivals become so obsessed with each other that they mirror each other's emotions and actions. The doubles act alike but they mistakenly see a great difference between them. Mimetic doubles can be quite dangerous to one another and to others and quite self-destructive" (*Satan* 22n2).

¹⁷ Paul goes on to point out that the commandment itself is not at fault. "The law is holy, and the commandment is holy righteous and good" (Rom. 7:12). Lewis seems to maintain this same view of Maleldil's prohibition. The prohibition in Eden against the tree of the knowledge of good and evil and that against sleeping on the Fixed lands, both were indeed prohibitions against *goods*, desirable in their time and place. And so, it seems like the

The Un-man has already stoked desire in the Lady to become like the WoE, that is, “little Maleldils” (P 91). Now he can return to the object as a means to that end.

THE FINAL TOUCH

At the end of this cultivation of the imagination, the Lady is almost ready for her debut. However, the Lady’s reaction to the Un-man’s suggested desire is still motivated by love for others—“love for the King and for her unborn children, and even, in a sense, of Maleldil Himself” (P 113). But the seed of selfishness is there, ready to produce toxic fruit:



[F]rom the moment when the Un-man began its tragic stories, there was the faintest touch of theatricality, the first hint of a self-admiring inclination to seize a grand rôle in the drama of her world. It was clear that the Un-man’s whole effort was to increase this element. (P 113)

The final step remaining for the Un-man is introducing the “unselfconscious” Lady to herself (P 109). The stage is set; the play is written. Now for the star of the show.

3. PUT SELF ON STAGE

Art thou afeard to be the same in thine own act and valour
as thou art in desire [...] letting ‘I dare not’ wait upon ‘I would’?
—Lady Macbeth, *Macbeth* 1.7.39–44

When Augustine pondered man’s original fall, he coined the term *incurvatus in se* to capture the picture of man turned in on himself. Instead of being rightly ordered toward God and creatures, fallen man looks only to self. The Un-man tries to produce that scoliosis of the soul in the Lady in this final section of the temptation. As of yet, she remains innocent. But though she had not fallen, “half her imagination was already filled with bright, poisonous shapes” (P 114). If the Un-man can inflate her self-esteem, her dreaming will become doing.

“disadvantage” Girard identifies may not be the whole story. The increased desire brings the test to a point. Will one trust God to give the desirable good in his time and his way and, thus, be friends with God? Or allow the prohibition to create rivalry, as God is seen withholding the good (as the Un-man and the Serpent try to frame the matter)?

PLAYING DRESS-UP

To produce that effect, the Un-man introduces the Lady to clothing. In a twisted parody of God clothing our first parents, the Un-man kills birds and weaves their feathers into a dazzling robe. The Lady wears the cloak “to be beautiful,” harkening back to the original rivalrous desire the Un-man fostered in her (P 115). At first, Ransom thinks the Un-man’s only aim is to create vanity, but he soon realizes the more insidious target.

The robe is part of the Lady’s assumption of the role of tragic heroine mediated by the WoE. Again, Ransom observes the doubling effect: “She appeared to him at that moment as a woman whom an earth-born man might conceivably love” (P 116). By dressing her up, the Un-man instigates a full-dress rehearsal. The Lady becomes an actor in costume. Aristotle observed that we love the theater because we love imitation—*mimesis*. He doesn’t explain why, but mimetic theory does. Theater allows one to try on the being of the other (*Envy* 59). I can put on Hamlet like a coat. I can wear Macbeth and don Brutus.

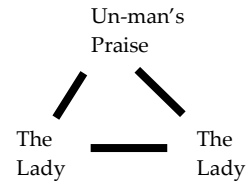
Thus, Ransom laments the Lady’s transformation into an actor because it constitutes one more step down the mimetic path. When the Lady takes on the appearance of others, she participates in the opposite of what Lewis calls *good pretending*. For Lewis, pretending is a way of becoming. Who we pretend to be today determines who we become tomorrow. *Desires* today reveal *being* tomorrow. Thus, in assuming a role, the Lady is becoming her model.

SELF, MEET SELF

However, the Un-man uses the clothing for an even greater effect. The clothing provides an excuse to give the Lady a mirror and introduce her to herself. After the Lady laments, “We cannot see ourselves” (P 116), the Un-man produces a mirror from his pack and hands it to her. The effect is electric.

“‘That thing’ (she pointed at the mirror) ‘is me and not me’” (P 117). Of course, that is the point. She speaks better than she knows. On one level, she sees herself dressed up like the WoE. The process of mimetic doubling is making her *not-her*. But at a deeper level, the physical reflection in the mirror is her but not all of her. “The image of her beautiful body had been offered to her only as a means to awaken the far more perilous image of her great soul” (P 118). The physical reflection merely begins to coil her inward, but the curve ends with “the dramatic conception of the self” (P 118)—beautiful, independent, tragic, imperious, and desirable.

This romantic view of the self is critical to the Un-man's plan. Mimetic desire most affects us when we least suspect it, and we least suspect it when we imagine ourselves most independent. The more romantic, the more mimetic. If I think my desires originate in me (subjective) or the object (objective), I will not suspect a mediator dictating them. Thus, one philosopher warns, "There are always models of desire. If you don't know yours, they are probably wreaking havoc in your life" because "models are most powerful when they are hidden" (Burgis 21). By turning her in on herself, the Un-man blinds the Lady to the mimetic engine that drives the temptation.



However, although the mirror elevates the Lady's self-esteem and self-consciousness, it could not succeed without the Un-man's praise. In this section, he calls her beautiful three times, a tactic he doesn't use in the first two stages. Why? The flattery—the expressed desire couched as praise—indicates her worth and makes the mirror effective.¹⁸ The Lady absorbs the repetitive praise of the Un-man and, as a result, loves herself all the more.

PRIDE BOUND TO ANOTHER

Ironically, her self-love is wholly dependent on another. As Girard repeatedly asserts, pride depends on the other to uphold it. "The more 'proud' and 'egotistic' we are, the more enslaved we become to our mimetic models" (*Satan* 15).

Here we see how utterly self-defeating the Un-man's tale of independence proves to be. In trying to create separation from Maleldil, the Lady must resort to other mediators. The choice is not independence or not; the choice is who to be dependent on. "Metaphysical autonomy" is a myth the Un-man weaves (Girard, *Deceit* 56). "[Self] renounces the divine mediator only to fall back on the human mediator," explains Girard. "True freedom lies in the basic choice between a human or divine model" (58).¹⁹

¹⁸ Shakespeare captures the effect in *As You Like It*. Rosalind explains how Silvius's praise of Phebe enflames her value of herself: "'Tis not her glass [mirror], but you that flatter her, / And out of your eyes, she sees herself more proper / Than any of her lineaments can show her" (3.5.54–56).

¹⁹ The full quote is worth noting: "[Self] renounces the divine mediator only to fall back on the human mediator. [...] Christianity directs existence toward a vanishing point, either toward God or toward the Other. Choice always involves choosing a model, and true freedom lies in the basic choice between a human or divine model. The impulse of the soul toward God is inseparable from a retreat into the Self. Inversely the turning in on itself of

If the Lady remained rightly oriented to Maleldil and his desire expressed in command, she would become more and more herself. But as the Un-man twists her toward self, she becomes more like others—namely, the WoE.²⁰ Lewis highlights this same reality repeatedly throughout his corpus. Through obedience, we become more fully the individual God intended us to be. For both Girard and Lewis, the attempt to dethrone God can only succeed in erecting men as gods.²¹

So the Un-man crafts the theater of desire, writes the drama of the WoE, and casts the Lady in her role. Nothing now remains but to watch the Lady's tragic fall—nothing, that is, except the eucatastrophic triumph of Ransom.

THE TRIUMPH OF RANSOM

God in his wisdom had foreseen since the beginning that the victim mechanism would be reversed like a glove, exposed, placed in the open, stripped naked, and dismantled in the Gospel.
—René Girard²²

For Girard, rivalrous desire always ends in one of two ways. Either the subject totally renounces the desire by finding a new model (i.e., the toddler leaves the room) or mimetic conflict escalates, eventually resulting in violence (i.e., a toddler war of all-against-all). That violence is often targeted at a scapegoat (i.e., the different third toddler),²³ who is arbitrarily assigned blame for the conflict and abused, exiled, or even murdered.²⁴ Violence against the

pride is inseparable from a movement of panic toward the Other. [...] The imitation of Christ becomes the imitation of one's neighbor" (*Deceit* 58–9). Elsewhere Girard expands the point: "What Jesus invites us to imitate is his own *desire*, the spirit that directs him toward the goal on which his intention is fixed: to resemble God the Father as much as possible. [...] In inviting us to imitate him, he invites us to imitate his imitation. [...] [O]nce we imitate Jesus, we discover that our aspiration to autonomy has always made us bow down before individuals" (*Satan* 13–14).

²⁰ "[The] atomization of the personality is the final stage of internal mediation" (*Deceit* 92).

²¹ "The romantic is always falling on his knees before the wrong altar; he thinks he is sacrificing the world on the altar of his Self whereas the real object of his worship is the Other" (*Deceit* 87).

²² *Satan* 151.

²³ In mimetic theory, a scapegoat is "[a] person, group, or thing that a community chooses to expel or eliminate in the midst of a mimetic crisis in order to bring about a resolution. The scapegoat absorbs all of the mimetic tension and violence, which had previously been undirected and chaotic, onto itself. The scapegoat is often chosen randomly, through a mimetically driven process of judgment" (Burgis 224).

²⁴ Girard points to Joseph as a prime example of this mimetic cycle, but instead of concealing the innocence of the scapegoat as myths do, the Bible exposes the collective violence of Joseph's brothers against an innocent victim (*Oedipus Unbound* 105–13).

scapegoat is cathartic but does nothing to remove the root of rivalry. For Girard, all human culture grows from this *scapegoat mechanism* and “the founding murder.”²⁵

However, Girard argues that Christ, as the innocent and voluntary scapegoat, exposes the mechanism. Christ really does bear the sins of the world and so secures real peace. He is the divine model of rightly ordered desires. Therefore, for both Girard and Lewis, the cross is the corner of cosmic history, the turning point after which there is no return (*P* 54). The triumph of the cross unveils the deceptive catharsis of the scapegoat. We can no longer take refuge in the faux happy ending it offers.²⁶

Therefore, it is fitting—and utterly Girardian—that the mimetic escalation in *Perelandra* ends in violence that imitates the cross—imitates but does not duplicate. Ransom realizes the Un-man’s mimetic tactics are bound to succeed eventually. At the end of each temptation cycle, he laments, “This can’t go on” (*P* 109, 114, 119). Finally, he concludes he must sacrifice himself to destroy the Un-man’s power over the Lady. Maleldil confirms Ransom’s fears, “It is not for nothing that you are named Ransom. [...] My name also is Ransom” (*P* 125–26). To use Girard’s categories, Ransom looks to Christ as a non-rivalrous model.

But Ransom would not endure a second cross for “Maleldil never repeated Himself” (*P* 123). Instead, Ransom gives himself to be a *preemptive scapegoat* of mimetic violence. No sin needs redemption on *Perelandra*, but there is mimetic tension to deescalate. Both symbolically and physically, Ransom bears the teeth and claws of mimetic violence unleashed by the Un-man. He, in a sense, preemptively rescues an unfallen world with a new kind of redemption. Ransom is a scapegoat that *prevents sin* instead of *atoning for sin*.

It is hard to imagine anything more Girardian or Lewisian or Christian than this ending. Ransom averts the mimetic crisis instigated by the Satanic Un-man by imitating the sacrifice of Christ. The mimetic reading of *Perelandra*

²⁵ “Sacrifice lies behind everything distinguishing humans from animals, behind everything enabling us to substitute properly human desire for animal instinct, namely, mimetic desire. If becoming human involves, among other things, acquiring mimetic desire, it is obvious that humans could not exist in the beginning without sacrificial institutions that repress and moderate the kind of conflict that is inevitable with the working of mimetic desire” (*Satan* 90).

²⁶ Many of Shakespeare’s plays employ the scapegoat mechanism to offer the semblance of a happy ending to unperceptive readers. Uncovering Shakespeare’s brilliant use of the scapegoat is one of Girard’s major themes in *A Theater of Envy*. Elsewhere, he explains how the Gospels exposed the scapegoat mechanism: “The Passion accounts reveal a phenomenon that unbeknownst to us generates all human cultures and still warps our human vision in favor of all sorts of exclusions and scapegoating. If this analysis is true, the explanatory power of Jesus’ death is much greater than we realize, and Paul’s exalted idea of the Cross as the source of all knowledge is anthropologically sound” (*Satan* 3).

indeed opens up “a new dimension of glory” (P 184) and new insights into both the power and impotence of Satan's deception. To quote Tor of *Perelandra*, “We have learned of evil, though not as the Evil One wished us to learn. We have learned better than that” (P 179).

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CLINTON MANLEY is a recent graduate of Bethlehem Seminary. He currently serves as an instructor of literature at Bethlehem College and editor for Desiring God Ministries. He lives in Minneapolis with his lovely bride, Mackenzie, and their three children.



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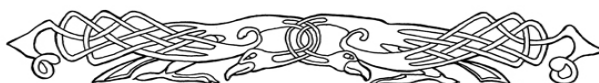
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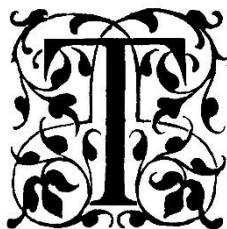
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THE LIBERTY TO BIND ONESELF: CHESTERTON AND THE OATH OF FĒANOR

MATTHEW MCKENNA

INTRODUCTION

IT IS WELL-KNOWN THAT G.K. CHESTERTON WAS INFLUENTIAL ON TOLKIEN.¹ This paper will read the oath of Fëanor in *The Silmarillion* through the lens of Chesterton's philosophy of oaths, and it will suggest that Tolkien was speculatively influenced by Chesterton on this topic. It will do this by an exposition of Chesterton's philosophy of vows followed by an in-depth exposition of the oath of Fëanor throughout *The Silmarillion*. The thesis is that the oath of Fëanor works according to the mode of Chesterton's philosophy of oaths, that is, the oath compels the oath-taker to act. Viewing the oath of Fëanor through the framework of Chesterton's philosophy of oaths helps make it explicit to the reader how the oath drives the sons of Fëanor to commit many evil acts.

Additionally, this paper will respond to a claim regarding the oath of Fëanor made by Alexander Bruce. This will show a practical benefit of reading the oath of Fëanor through the lens of Chesterton's philosophy of oaths by highlighting the diminished freedom of the sons of Fëanor.

CHESTERTON ON THE VOW

Chesterton admires vows and sees them as eminently good things.² He values the capacity to make a vow and considers it the very height of freedom.

¹ Milbank's thesis is that "the essayist, poet, Christian apologist and writer of fantastic tales G.K. Chesterton was an important influence both on Tolkien's fiction and his literary criticism of the fairy tale" (Milbank viii). See also Pearce 161–81; Pearce argues that Chesterton was an indirect influence on Tolkien (164).

² Some people think that Catholicism (the religion of both Chesterton and Tolkien) should forbid oaths (Meier 53). Their argument is simple, during the Sermon on the Mount Jesus teaches: "Again you have heard that it was said to the men of old, 'You shall not swear falsely, but shall perform to the Lord what you have sworn.' But I say to you, do not swear at all, either by heaven, for it is the throne of God, or by the earth, for it is his footstool, or by Jerusalem, for it is the city of the great King. And do not swear by your head, for you cannot make one hair white or black. Let what you say be simply 'Yes' or 'No'; anything more than this comes from evil" (Matt. 5:33–37, RSVCE). A simple reading of the text implies that taking oaths at all is wrong. Yet, Augustine and Aquinas hold that this cannot be taken literally since Paul takes oaths within his epistles several times (Augustine

He writes, “I could never conceive or tolerate any Utopia which did not leave to me the liberty for which I chiefly care, the liberty to bind myself. [...] If I vow to be faithful I must be cursed when I am unfaithful [...]. I should ask to be kept to my bargain, to have my oaths and engagements taken seriously; I should ask Utopia to avenge my honour on myself” (*Orthodoxy* 130). He immediately applies this idea to marriage as an example of such a vow, wherein people freely choose to bind themselves together for the rest of their lives.

The gravity of vows, even rash vows, appears in Chesterton’s novel *The Man Who Was Thursday*. In it, the main character Syme makes a vow to Gregory (a street-preacher of anarchy whom Syme does not believe is a real anarchist) not to reveal what Gregory will tell him (18–19). Gregory then reveals and proves that he is a real anarchist with deadly plans. Syme, in turn, makes Gregory swear that he will not reveal to anyone what he is about to tell him (28). Syme then reveals to the anarchist Gregory that he is a police detective. Both characters feel bound by their oath and keep their oaths throughout the story — Syme even lies to prevent breaking his vow (81–82).³ At one point when Syme is strongly tempted to break his vow he says, “Theoretically I ought to drown myself first. I promised a poor fellow, who was a real modern pessimist [i.e., Gregory], on my word of honour not to tell the police. I’m no hand at casuistry, but I can’t break my word to a modern pessimist. It’s like breaking one’s word to a child” (105). One of Syme’s companions who is in the same situation comments that, “I tried to tell the police and I couldn’t, because of some silly oath I took” (105). Even to save lives from the anarchists and their deadly plans, Chesterton indicates that it would be wrong to break one’s vow, even an admittedly rash now.

So, a vow or oath for Chesterton combines “the fixity that goes with finality with the self-respect that only goes with freedom” (*The Superstition of Divorce* 267). It is the use of one’s greatest freedom of the will to remove one’s freedom in the future. Elsewhere he writes, “The man who makes a vow makes an appointment with himself at some distant time or place. The danger of it is that [he] himself should not keep the appointment” (“A Defense of Rash Vows”).

Chapter 17, #51; Aquinas II–II, q. 89, a. 2, ad 1; for examples of Paul’s oaths see Phil. 1:8, 1 Cor. 1:9, 2 Cor. 1:23, Rom. 1:9). Thus, due to the principle of the unity and content of scripture from *Dei Verbum* (the interpretation of any passage must take into account and be compatible with the rest of scripture—scripture passages enlighten each other), Catholics can take oaths (*Dei Verbum*, #12).

³ Syme lies to Wilks (professor de Worms or Friday) about being a detective prior to Wilks’s revelation that he is also a detective. In a way, Syme makes an oath that he is not a policeman; he makes a false oath to avoid breaking his first one to Gregory.

THE OATH OF FĒANOR

I propose that in the oath of Fëanor we can see Chesterton's influence on Tolkien. Chesterton valued freedom and the capacity to take oaths which bind us and limit our actions in the future. This appeared in *Orthodoxy* and *The Man Who Was Thursday* (key and well-known Chestertonian texts), which were written around the same time. The same idea will be shown to be at work in the oath of Fëanor for the oath-takers are bound by their oath and forced to act upon it. They are even moved to act against their consciences—the oath truly binds them. At the very least we see the same idea in both their thought, a convergence in thought. Thus, Tolkien and Chesterton agree on the binding power of oaths or vows. If one does not want to say that Tolkien was influenced by Chesterton on this point, then one can approach this idea as simply taking Chesterton's philosophy of oaths as a framework for reading the oath of Fëanor.⁴ Taken thus, using Chesterton's view on oaths helps us to see how intensely and totally the oath of Fëanor compels the sons and forces them to take action, even when they would prefer not to act.

The oath of Fëanor and his sons plays a key role throughout *The Silmarillion*.⁵ After Morgoth steals the Silmarils and flees, Fëanor leads the Noldor to recover them. As they depart Valinor they take the following oath:

Then Fëanor swore a terrible oath. His seven sons leapt straightway to his side and took the selfsame vow together, and red as blood shone their drawn swords in the glare of the torches. They swore an oath which none shall break, and none should take, by the name even of Ilúvatar, calling the Everlasting Dark upon them if they kept it not; and Manwë they named in witness, and Varda, and the hallowed mountain of Taniquetil, vowing to pursue with vengeance and hatred to the ends of the World Vala, Demon, Elf or Man as yet unborn, or any creature, great or small, good or evil, that time should bring forth unto the end of days, whoso should hold or take or keep a Silmaril from their possession.

⁴ There are two chief reasons one might not want to admit an explicit influence of Chesterton on Tolkien regarding oaths. First, Chesterton's philosophy of oaths is small and appears infrequently in his writings—it is not something for which he is known nor is it well drawn out by him. Second, there is no biographical evidence that Tolkien is drawing from Chesterton about oaths—he never mentions Chesterton's philosophy of oaths or any source for the oath of Fëanor.

⁵ "Fëanor inspires his sons with his terrible oath, a prime mover in the story of the Silmarils. The efforts of the seven sons to keep that oath lie behind the machinations of much of the latter part of *Quenta Silmarillion*, while the flight of the Noldor, inspired by Fëanor's lust for vengeance against the killer of his father and the thief of the Silmarils, will result in the events of the middle parts of the work, the establishment and history of the kingdoms of the elves" (Helms 54).

Thus spoke Maedhros and Maglor and Celegorm, Curufin and Caranthir, Amrod and Amras, princes of the Noldor; and many quailed to hear the dread words. For so sworn, good or evil, an oath may not be broken, and it shall pursue oathkeeper and oathbreaker to the world's end. (*Silmarillion* [*Silm*] 9.73–74)⁶

Immediately, the narrator points to the binding nature of the oath—it cannot be broken. There is some vagueness in precisely what this means because the narrator says the oath would pursue an oathbreaker—such an oath “may not be broken” but also one can be an oathbreaker. Perhaps it means that the oath would psychologically affect an oathbreaker relentlessly and drive him to fulfill the oath. Further, it is clear that the oath is a rash oath—an evil oath. It is described as “terrible,” “dread words,” and the narrator plainly says that “none should take” such an oath. A particularly evil part of the oath is that it names even good people as enemies if they should keep a Silmaril from them.

Before examining how the oath works in the rest of *The Silmarillion*, we should note that Morgoth does not fear this oath, despite it being primarily an oath to attack him unceasingly. On the contrary, Morgoth likes the oath because he understands how it drives the sons of Fëanor to ruinous deeds. Chapter twenty-three of *The Silmarillion* says:

Morgoth thought that his triumph was fulfilled, recking little of the sons of Fëanor, and of their oath, which had harmed him never and turned always to his mightiest aid; and in his black thought he laughed, regretting not the one Silmaril that he had lost, for by it as he deemed the last shred of the people of the Eldar should vanish from Middle-earth and trouble it no more. If he knew of the dwelling by the waters of Sirion, he gave no sign, biding his time, and waiting upon the working of oath and lie. (*Silm* 23.233)⁷

Morgoth is, of course, right about this. At three previous points the narrator has said that the oath hurt the elves. First, in the curse of Mandos the elves hear that, “On the House of Fëanor the wrath of the Valar lieth from the West unto the uttermost East, and upon all that will follow them it shall be laid also. Their Oath shall drive them, and yet betray them, and ever snatch away the very treasures that they have sworn to pursue” (*Silm* 9.78). Second, in chapter twelve about men, the narrator describes how the Elves and Men strove together against Morgoth but failed, and the narrator mentions one of the mechanisms by which

⁶ Throughout Tolkien's other writings on the oath, there is great consistency in it being described as unbreakable (*The Lays of Beleriand* 36, 162–63, 253–54, 259).

⁷ “Even the loss of the Silmaril aided [Melkor], for the Oath of Maedhros and the Doom of the Noldor caused his enemies to slay each other” (Foster 322–23).

they fail to be the oath of Fëanor, listed along with Morgoth's lies (12.94). Third, when Maedhros is gathering strength for the Nirnaeth Arnoediad, it is said that the oath prevented him from gathering more strength, especially that of Orodreth (Nargothrond) and Thingol (Doriath). Due to the acts of the sons of Fëanor which stemmed from their oath Orodreth is not allies with the sons, and they are openly enemies with Thingol (20.179).

How does the oath function? How does Tolkien present it as affecting those who took it? The language used consistently is that the oath has a power to force the action of the sons of Fëanor.⁸ Chesterton said that an oath included "the liberty to bind myself" (*Orthodoxy* 130). This is what we see consistently throughout *The Silmarillion*. The oath-takers are bound by their oath and feel forced to act upon it. Tolkien uses language which implies this binding power, and the plot shows characters being forced by their oath to act against their better judgment.

Twice it is said that the oath "drives" the sons. First in the curse of Mandos "Their Oath shall drive them," and then Finrod Felagund says to Beren about the sons of Fëanor, "the Oath drives them" (*Silm* 9.78 and 19.159). Twice it is said that the oath "constrains" them. First, following Fëanor's death when Maedhros is captured by Morgoth and tells the Noldor to abandon their war in exchange for Maedhros's freedom, the sons are unable to agree to these terms because "they were constrained also by their oath, and might not for any cause forsake the war against their Enemy" (13.98). Second, after Beren and Lúthien successfully take a Silmaril from Morgoth, the sons of Fëanor ask Thingol for it: "Maedhros and his brothers, being constrained by their oath had before sent to Thingol and reminded him with haughty words of their claim, summoning him to yield the Silmaril" (20.179). Once it is said that Maedhros "was bound by the oath," and thus he could not abandon the leaguer around Angband (13.102). The language Tolkien uses in these places clearly implies that the oath has binding power over the sons of Fëanor. These five places are the clearest linguistic signs of convergence between Tolkien and Chesterton concerning oaths—that the oath binds the oath-taker.

At three key additional places in *The Silmarillion* Tolkien uses other language which does not so clearly imply the binding power of the oath that Chesterton describes. But it remains clear in the plot that the oath forces the sons of Fëanor to act, thus its binding power is still present. Accordingly, using Chesterton's philosophy of oaths as a lens is helpful because it reminds the

⁸ Others have noted the driving power of the oath: "In Middle-earth the House of Fëanor, led by Maedhros, often tried to act with moderation, but the fateful pressure of the Oath of Fëanor subverted their intentions, and time after time the sons of Fëanor, impelled by their desire for the Silmaril, became enmeshed in treachery and violence" (Foster 258, emphasis added).

reader that the oath still binds the sons of Fëanor at these three pivotal moments. In these three places the oath drives the sons to do terrible deeds which they know are evil. These are the most critical acts which the oath drives them to commit. Importantly, before they commit these acts, they sometimes repent of the previous evil deeds which their oath drove them to do. This shows that Tolkien's understanding of the way that oaths function is thoroughly Chestertonian in that oaths limit the person's choices in the future and force the oath-taker to act according to his oaths, even against what he knows is right.

The first place this appears is when Dior possesses the Silmaril and the sons of Fëanor demand it back (this takes place after Thingol is killed by dwarves, the dwarves sack Menegroth, Beren reclaimed the Silmaril with the help of the Ents, and Luthien wears it until her death). When Dior refuses, the sons of Fëanor attack Doriath. The narrator describes the chain of events:

But now the rumor ran among the scattered Elves of Beleriand that Dior Thingol's heir wore the Nauglamir [a necklace with a Silmaril set in it], and they said: "A Silmaril of Fëanor burns again in the woods of Doriath"; and the oath of the sons of Fëanor was waked again from sleep. For while Lúthien wore the Necklace of the Dwarves no Elf would dare assail her; but now hearing of the renewal of Doriath and of Dior's pride the seven gathered again from wandering, and they sent to him to claim their own. (*Silm* 22.225)

While not explicitly saying that the oath drives them, it is clear that the waking of the oath is a causal factor in their demanding the Silmaril from Dior. Lúthien's beauty was too great and terrible. Her greatness made it impossible for them to reclaim the Silmaril, so they waited as they did when Morgoth held it (and while he still holds the other two). But now that the Silmaril has come to Dior, they have some chance to reclaim it (it is possible for them to reclaim it), and thus they try to.

The second time is when sons of Fëanor learn that the Silmaril is kept at the mouth of the river Sirion by Elwing and attack the elven havens to reclaim it. Tolkien writes:

Now when first the tidings came to Maedhros that Elwing yet lived, and dwelt in possession of the Silmaril by the mouths of Sirion, he repenting of the deeds in Doriath withheld his hand. But in time the knowledge of the oath unfulfilled returned to torment him and his brothers, and gathering from their wandering hunting-paths they sent messages to the Havens of friendship and yet of stern demand. Then Elwing and the people of Sirion would not yield the jewel which Beren had won and Lúthien had worn [...]. And so there came to pass the last and cruelest of

the slayings of Elf by Elf; and that was the third of the great wrongs achieved by the accursed oath. (*Silm* 24.236)

Again, there is no direct description of the oath driving the sons, but given that Maedhros repented of earlier deeds from the oath—slaying Dior⁹—and yet the sons again assault other elves, it seems that the oath drove them. Also, the narrator indicates that the unfulfilled oath had a causal role in making them ask for the Silmaril and then attack when it was not yielded. So, again Tolkien uses other language, but it remains clear that the oath is forcing the sons to act. This episode is especially important for it follows the sons' regret of their previous assault on Doriath (which the oath drove them to do), yet they assault the elven havens. This emphasizes the binding power of the oath.

The third time Tolkien uses other language to describe the oath driving the sons to act is after the Great Battle when the host of Valinor defeats Morgoth. The remaining two Silmarils are taken from Morgoth and Eönwë keeps them until the host returns to Valinor. Maedhros and Maglor (the only sons of Fëanor left alive at this point in the story) “prepared, though now with weariness and loathing, to attempt in despair the fulfillment of their oath; for they would have given battle for the Silmarils, were they withheld, even against the victorious host of Valinor, even though they stood alone against the world. And they sent a message therefore to Eönwë, bidding him yield up now those jewels” (*Silm* 24.242). Eönwë replies that the evils deeds provoked by the oath have destroyed any right to the Silmarils that the sons formerly had—Eönwë does not say that their oath is void, only that their right to the Silmarils is void (24.242). He then instructs Maedhros and Maglor to return to Valinor to face the judgment of the Valar regarding their actions, their oath, and their claim on the Silmarils. At this point Maglor wants to return to Valinor and hopes to fulfill the oath through the mercy of the Valar. But Maedhros argues that if the Valar do not pardon them, then their oath would be impossible to fulfill. He also points out that Manwe does not have the power to release them from their oath since they made it to Ilúvatar, not Manwë.¹⁰ Maglor thinks that trying to fulfill the oath by force, again, would be a worse evil than leaving the oath unfulfilled, but he eventually yields to Maedhros and they attack at night and successfully regain the Silmarils

⁹ Maedhros also repented of this deed earlier in the story, immediately after his attack on Doriath (*Silm* 22.226).

¹⁰ This was mentioned previously as well: “The wise have said that the hour was not yet come, and that only one speaking in person for the cause of both Elves and Men, pleading for pardon on their misdeeds and pity on their woes, might move the counsels of the Powers; and the oath of Fëanor perhaps even Manwë could not loose, until it found its end, and the sons of Fëanor relinquished the Silmarils, upon which they had laid their ruthless claim” (*Silm* 23.233–34, emphasis added).

(24.242–43). Yet, the Silmarils burn their hands and Maedhros recognizes that Eönwë was correct. Their claim on the Silmarils was void due to their crimes. Maedhros then reasons that, due to no longer having a claim on the Silmarils, the oath is void (24.243). So, Eönwë's point that they no longer have a right to possess the Silmarils further implies that the oath is void.

Yet, despite the oath being void, it still drove them to act and steal the Silmarils. This is evidenced by the fact that they have previously regretted many acts that the oath drove them to commit, they tried to avoid further evils occasioned by the oath, and on this occasion they both are weary of the oath, but they still killed elves in order to steal the Silmarils. Maglor was not driven as strongly this time since he wanted to wait for the judgment of the Valar (the oath was not urgently driving him), this hints that the driving force of the now-void oath was indeed weaker. Thus, the oath's driving force had diminished, but clearly still had some power despite being void. This further implies that the oath was not completely void, contrary to what Maedhros seems to conclude as the narrator explains, "But the jewel burned the hand of Maedhros in pain unbearable; and he perceived that it was as Eönwë had said, and that his right thereto had become void, and that the oath was vain" (*Silm* 24.243).

It seems this can be explained by the fact that the oath simply names the Silmarils to Fëanor and his sons and does not explicitly base this claim on any rightful sense of ownership (such as the fact that Fëanor made them), "vowing to pursue with vengeance and hatred to the ends of the World Vala, Demon, Elf or Man as yet unborn, or any creature, great or small, good or evil, that time should bring forth unto the end of days, whoso should hold or take or keep a Silmaril from their possession" (*Silm* 9.73). Thus, when due to their crimes, the sons have lost any right to possess the Silmarils, their oath to try to possess the Silmarils still drives them. Basically, their oath was not well worded (i.e., based on justice) but instead was based on greed. It was based on an excessive desire to possess the Silmarils. Thus, the oath still has driving force (i.e., is not totally void) despite the right to possess the Silmarils being null. The narrator's prelude to these events also implies that the oath is not void:

Maedhros and Maglor would not hearken, and they prepared, though now with weariness and loathing, to attempt in despair the fulfillment of their oath; for they would have given battle for the Silmarils, were they withheld, even against the victorious host of Valinor, even though they stood alone against the world. And they sent a message therefore to Eönwë, bidding him yield up now those jewels which of old Fëanor their father made and Morgoth stole from him. (*Silm* 24.242)

This also portrays their claim to Eönwë as based on their right to the Silmarils, hence his response (that they no longer have a right to them) makes sense.

This fact (i.e., the bad wording of the oath which separates the oath from a rightful claim to possess the Silmarils), is a common motif in myth. John Holmes points out that such rash oaths bind the oath-taker to the letter of the oath and not to the spirit of the oath (Holmes 258). Sticking to the strict letter of the oath drives the sons to attack Eönwë.

Chesterton's philosophy of oaths makes it explicit that the oath binds the oath-taker; one cannot ignore one's oath. The words of the oath have power over the oath-taker. Without the explicit knowledge of this given by Chesterton, a reader, especially a modern reader without a rich appreciation for oaths and their importance in ancient and medieval society, could easily be confused by the behavior of the sons of Fëanor and their adherence to the oath despite all the evil it has caused (and which they readily admit and repent of). Alexander Bruce will be shown to make just this mistake. In the three crucial places examined above, the oath drives the sons of Fëanor to evil deeds which Maglor and Maedhros repent of, but they keep finding themselves unable to break the oath they now hate. The repeating theme of their attacks on fellow elves followed by regret, only to do it all over again, makes little sense apart from the binding power of the oath (i.e., apart from Chesterton's philosophy of oaths).

RESPONSE TO ALEXANDER BRUCE

What are the results of the oath of Fëanor? Consistently throughout *The Silmarillion* the results are evil. As previously seen, Morgoth likes the oath and knows it makes the sons fight against the other elves. Specifically, it is the chief and explicit cause that drives the sons of Fëanor to attack Beren and Lúthien, Dior at Doriath, Elwing at Sirion, and Eönwë after Morgoth's defeat.

Although the oath drives the sons to do many evil acts listed above, not all the sons are totally corrupted, specifically Maedhros and Maglor. As previously mentioned, Maedhros repents of the attack on Doriath and tries to find and rescue the sons of Dior who had been released into the wild (*Silm* 22.225–26). Later, he tries to avoid attacking Sirion because he repents of the attack on Doriath and does not want to repeat it (24.236). After the attack on Sirion, Maglor "took pity upon Elros and Elrond, and he cherished them, and love grew after between them, as little might be thought; but Maglor's heart was sick and weary with the burden of the dreadful oath" (24.237). Maglor, like Maedhros, repents and, like Maedhros tried to do with Dior's son, cares for Elros and Elrond (sons of Eärendil and Elwing). Both Maedhros and Maglor are glad when they see Eärendil's star with the Silmaril rise in the sky:

And when this new star was seen at evening, Maedhros spoke to Maglor his brother, and he said: "Surely that is a Silmaril that shines now in the West?"

And Maglor answered: "If it be truly the Silmaril which we saw cast into the sea that rises again by the power of the Valar, then let us be glad; for its glory is seen now by many, and is yet secure from all evil." (*Silm* 24.239–40)

Instead of being possessive and angry that a Silmaril is out of their reach, they are glad that many people can now enjoy its light and beauty. This shows that they are not totally corrupted and greedy for the Silmaril as Fëanor was, who locked them away in Valinor and denied the sight of them to others, which led to their capture by Morgoth (*Silm* 8.65).¹¹ Finally, as seen, Maglor tries to avoid doing further evil in pursuit of the Silmarils when Eönwë takes them and Maedhros is said to seek them with "weariness and loathing" (24.242). The fact that Maedhros and Maglor are not completely corrupted, but still do terrible deeds (attacking fellow elves multiple times) due to the oath highlights the power of the oath—that it is driving or forcing them to act. This is similar to Chesterton's novel *The Man Who Was Thursday*, wherein the characters take rash oaths (thus similar to the oath of Fëanor) but feel compelled to keep them, despite the evil outcomes from them (in *Thursday* these evil results are the anarchist plots potentially succeeding and hurting innocent civilians). Thus, both Tolkien and Chesterton portray their characters as compelled to keep rash oaths, despite the evil outcomes of doing so. This shows their shared belief in the binding power of vows.

Alexander Bruce disagrees with this moral analysis of Maedhros and Maglor and argues that they are ultimately villains: "Whatever their deeds of valor might have been, because of their commitment to the oath, in the end Maedhros and Maglor must be counted among the great foes of Middle-earth, as corrupt as Carcharoth, as corrupt as Morgoth himself" (Bruce 69). There are three issues with this reading.

First, it seems absurd to claim they are as evil as Morgoth. The narrator consistently presents these two as tragic and deeply flawed, but trying to be good. Indeed, after Maglor throws away his Silmaril he spends his remaining life in regret (*Silm* 24.243). Thus, while Maedhros may be more of a Judas-like character who commits suicide after his great sin in despair (24.243), Maglor is more of a Peter-like character who repents of his great sin (but unlike Peter in the gospels, Maglor never rejoins the community). Maedhros also did not participate in the burning of the Teleri ships at Losgar (9.80). Early in the *Silmarillion* when the narrator describes the princes of the elves, Maglor is described as a mighty singer and Maedhros as merely "Maedhros the tall," while other of the sons of Fëanor are described by less flattering terms—

¹¹ For an analysis of Fëanor's hiding of the Silmarils see Bernthal 108–09.

“Caranthir the dark” (5.50).¹² Second, Bruce’s reading overlooks the many times Maedhros and Maglor repent and try to avoid further evil (22.225–26 and 24.236–37).

Third, Bruce’s argument overlooks what I have tried to prove in this paper—the driving force of the oath. Bruce claims it was precisely the brothers’ “commitment to the oath” that made them villains; they chose to fulfill the oath and thus continued to choose evil deeds until the end (69). But, as I have argued, they were not so much committed to the oath (in fact they resented it and Bruce earlier admitted this [65]) as driven by it. Essentially, Bruce fails to see the binding power the oath has on them; he fails to see that they are not totally free to break their oath. Since they are driven by their oath, they are less free to ignore it. This suggests to us that we should rather pity them than condemn them. Especially in their final attack on Eönwë, Maedhros and Maglor very much appear to desire to be free from their oath but are themselves its prisoner. Certainly, it is an evil act to attack Eönwë and try to reclaim the Silmarils. But they are not as morally culpable for this act (because they are not totally free) as Bruce wants to say. Therefore, Chesterton’s philosophy of oaths helpfully enlightens how the oath functions in *The Silmarillion* by making its binding power more explicit and clearer. This shows that we should soften our moral condemnations of Maedhros and Maglor. Thus, one practical effect of examining the oath of Fëanor through the lens of Chesterton’s philosophy of oaths is that it tempers our moral judgment of Maedhros and Maglor by showing they are not totally free to choose their acts due to the binding power of their oath.

CONCLUSION

This paper has done several things. First, it has read the oath of Fëanor through the framework of Chesterton’s philosophy of oaths and has suggested that Tolkien may have been influenced by Chesterton’s philosophy of oaths by showing how strongly Chesterton’s philosophy is at work in the oath of Fëanor. Other oaths in Tolkien’s writings which could also be studied along similar lines: Thingol’s oath not to kill Beren, Beren’s oath to retrieve the Silmaril, and especially Gollum’s oath to serve Frodo.¹³ For both Chesterton and Tolkien, oaths are acts of freedom and will which bind the oath taker in the future. At the very least, this paper has demonstrated that Tolkien shares Chesterton’s view of oaths and their binding power. While in the real world, oaths do not absolutely necessitate or force our wills (people can break an oath), the presentation of the

¹² I read this as a moral descriptor and not a physical one.

¹³ For more on oaths in Tolkien see Holmes 249–61; for Gollum’s oath to Frodo see Donnelly 24–25; for a comparison of Pippin’s oath to Denethor and Merry’s oath to Théoden see Bernthal 227–29.

oath of Fëanor as having such true binding power highlights the seriousness of oaths in the real world.

Second, this paper has nuanced a claim by Alexander Bruce about the oath of Fëanor. Specifically, he argues that Maedhros and Maglor are ultimately villains due to the oath. But Maedhros and Maglor are not unambiguously villains in *The Silmarillion* and viewing their oath through the lens of Chesterton's philosophy helps reveal this to us by making it explicit, rather than merely implicit in the story, that their oath bound them.

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MATTHEW MCKENNA is a Ph.D candidate in Theology at Ave Maria University. He studies and teaches on the works of St. Thomas Aquinas, G.K. Chesterton, and J.R.R. Tolkien.



MODELLING THE FEAR OF GOD IN C.S. LEWIS'S THE CHRONICLES OF NARNIA

BRETT ROSCOE

PART OF THE VALUE THAT C.S. LEWIS SAW IN MYTHOPOEIC LITERATURE is its ability to *affect* readers, to evoke a rich emotional experience. He therefore believed a myth is not just something to be assented to, but something to be imagined and felt. "If God chooses to be mythopoeic," he writes, "[...] shall we refuse to be *mythopathic*?" ("Myth Became Fact" 59–60). In an article originally published in *The New Yorker*, he admits his hopes that *The Chronicles of Narnia* would have this mythopathic effect on readers: "I thought I saw how stories of this kind could steal past a certain inhibition which had paralysed much of my own religion in childhood. Why did one find it so hard to feel as one was told one ought to feel about God or about the sufferings of Christ? I thought the chief reason was that one was told one ought to" ("Sometimes Fairy Stories" 57–58). The Narnia stories, he suggests, have the potential to evoke religious affect in readers, helping them learn how they ought to "feel about God," but without the sense of duty that stifles such emotions. The goal of this article is to study one of these feelings about God—the fear of the Lord—as it is evoked by and represented in *The Chronicles of Narnia*. First I draw on psychological studies of emotion and the kinesic approach to literature developed by Guillemette Bolens to appreciate how the concrete imagery in Lewis's books evoke a fear of Aslan. Then I place this fear in the context of Rudolf Otto's *The Idea of the Holy*, looking at the influence this book had on Lewis's assumptions about the fear of God and his depictions of Aslan. My basic argument is that, in *The Chronicles of Narnia*, the physical encounters with Aslan invite characters (and by extension readers) to experience the fear of the Lord, an emotion that Lewis portrays as analogous to, though significantly different from, other kinds of fear.

That creative literature can arouse emotions in readers is not a new insight. Aristotle, for example, famously defined the Greek tragedy by its emotional effects, saying that it arouses pity and fear in the audience (54). But what more recent cognitive approaches to literature demonstrate is how much goes on in our brains underneath the surface when we read. Two insights in particular concern me in this study. The first has to do with the quick emotional and physiological responses that can be triggered by texts. Cognitive literary theorist Patrick Colm Hogan writes that there are three sources of emotion: (1)

innate sensitivities, (2) critical period developments (i.e. childhood experiences), and (3) emotional memories (57).¹ The first of these, innate sensitivities, is often exemplified in cognitive science with reference to fear. As cognitive scientist Joseph Ledoux puts it, "Each species is innately prepared to treat certain stimuli as threatening. Innate/prepared threats include pictures of people with facial expressions of anger or fear, or pictures of venomous animals like snakes and spiders" (203). Studies of the amygdala, a part of the brain that is activated when a person feels fear, demonstrate that it is sensitive and can be activated by an angry facial expression, a sudden sound or movement, or by the sighting of a dangerous animal. Our innate threat sensors are so sensitive, in fact, that they can arouse a fear state even before we are conscious of any fear. In one study, adults with fears of snakes or spiders were shown images of these threatening animals, but the images were shown so briefly that the adults did not notice them consciously or report any feeling of fear, and yet their minds reacted with a fear state nonetheless (Kagan 105).² We might say that the subjects had a "'ghost' feeling," a partial, unconscious experience of fear.³ As this and other studies demonstrate, the cause of the activation does not need to be real; a mere picture or mental image is sufficient. And, as will be demonstrated below, The Chronicles of Narnia provide plenty of such threatening images of the lion Aslan, focusing on his roars, his teeth, and his claws and thereby evoking an experience of fear.

The second insight of cognitive approaches to literature that concerns me here is the growing realization that reading—like thinking in general—is an embodied experience. As Raymond W. Gibbs puts it, "the brain does not work in isolation, but is part of an organic whole that includes the nervous system and kinesthetic sensations of the body in action" (279). Studies using fMRI scans have demonstrated that when a person reads action words like "kick," "chew," or "run," their motor and premotor cortex is activated in a way similar to how they would be activated if the person were physically performing the motion (Hauk, et al. 301–07; Pulvermüller, et al. 793–97). This effect is called "motor resonance," "the process by which action observation activates the same neural substrates as those recruited when a perceiver performs an action by themselves" (Bellock and Lyons 21). The experience of motor resonance suggests that readers create perceptual simulations when they read, enacting the spatial orientation, movements, and gestures described by a text. This insight from neuroscience has been applied to literary texts by Guillemette Bolens in

¹ This threefold division is similar to Jerome Kagan's typology of fear. Kagan identifies three kinds of fear: fear of innate threats, conditioned (learned) fear, and fear of the unfamiliar (89–95).

² Cf. Ledoux 203–05.

³ I have taken the phrase "ghost feeling" from Terence Cave (36).

The Style of Gestures. Bolens develops a kind of reading called “kinesic analysis,” a method of reading that pays especial attention to the ways in which texts “trigger sensorimotor perceptual simulations in the reader” (28). This kind of reading foregrounds minute details of gesture, facial expression, motion, and bodily orientation, details that are often passed over in analyses of literary texts. In *The Chronicles of Narnia*, it is precisely details such as these that allow readers to create perceptual simulations of the strength and power of the lion Aslan and to enact the trembling, freezing, running away, and stumbling of the characters who encounter this fearsome, divine presence.

Such an approach, I believe, can do justice to the concrete ways Lewis portrays God in this series. Jesus is famously portrayed as Aslan, a lion, and while the lion might be a reference to the “lion of Judah,” one of Jesus’ biblical titles (*ESV Bible*, Rev. 5:5),⁴ and while the lion might symbolically represent qualities of God—qualities such as strength, power, and royalty—at the same time the image of the lion is not something to be abstracted and discarded. This is the very mistake made by the Narnian horse Bree. Sharing his “knowledge” of Aslan with the Calormene girl Aravis, Bree explains that when Narnians call Aslan a lion, they “of course” do not actually mean he is a lion:

“No doubt,” continued Bree, “when they speak of him as a Lion they only mean he’s as strong as a lion or [...] as fierce as a lion. Or something of that kind. Even a little girl like you, Aravis, must see that it would be quite absurd to suppose he is a *real* lion. Indeed it would be disrespectful. If he was a lion he’d have to be a Beast just like the rest of us. Why! [...] If he was a lion he’d have four paws, and a tail, and *Whiskers!*” (*The Horse and His Boy* 14.200)⁵

What Bree does not realize is that, during this lengthy attempt to allegorize the lion, the actual lion himself has walked up behind him. And when Bree mentions the “absurd” thought of Aslan having whiskers, Aslan’s whiskers brush his ear, causing Bree to jump and run to the other side of the garden. It turns out that the very qualities Bree ridicules—the paws, the tail, the whiskers—are some of the most important qualities of Aslan. These physical qualities are, for example, emphasized in the prophecy of Aslan’s coming, a prophecy the Pevensie children hear in *The Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe* (LWW):

⁴ Lewis himself makes this biblical connection (*Letters* III.160).

⁵ All citations to *The Chronicles of Narnia* books are to chapter and page number.

Wrong will be right, when Aslan comes *in sight*,
At the *sound of his roar*, sorrows will be no more,
When *he bares his teeth*, winter meets its death,
And when *he shakes his mane*, we shall have spring again.
(8.79, emphasis added)

Lewis repeatedly emphasizes the physical qualities of Aslan, never letting his readers forget that Aslan is, in fact, a lion, complete with mane, teeth, and claws. And in so far as Aslan is a lion, he is, from a human standpoint, a danger and a threat, or, in other words, something to be feared. In a letter Lewis admits that his Narnia stories were inspired by his “nightmares about lions” (*Letters* III.807), suggesting that he associated this animal with the emotion fear. And it is the threatening, fearsome qualities of lions that are emphasized in *The Chronicles of Narnia*.

Aslan’s mouth is foregrounded through the frequent roars and rumblings. When the White Witch suggests that Aslan might not be true to his word, Aslan does not argue or offer any assurances; instead he puts on a display of power: “‘Wow!’ roared Aslan half rising from his throne; and his great mouth opened wider and wider and the roar grew louder and louder, and the Witch, after staring for a moment with her lips wide apart, picked up her skirts and fairly ran for her life” (*LWW* 13.144). The mouth opening “wider and wider” draws our attention to one of the most dangerous parts of the lion, a detail that is not lost on the Witch, nor on the Pevensie children. The children want to ask Aslan about his discussion with the Witch, but Aslan’s “face was stern and everyone’s ears were still ringing with the sound of his roar and so nobody dared” (14.145). The roar is thus experienced as a fearsome event by both enemies and friends of the lion. In fact, anyone, even an endearing character like Lucy, can become a target of the lion’s roar. While looking through a magical book, Lucy is tempted to use a spell that she knows she should not. Before she gives into the temptation, though, she sees something she does not expect:

[W]hen she looked back at the opening words of the spell, there in the middle of the writing, where she felt quite sure there had been no picture before, she found the great face of a lion, of the Lion, Aslan himself, staring into hers. It was painted such a bright gold that it seemed to be coming towards her out of the page; and indeed she never was quite sure afterwards that it hadn’t really moved a little. At any rate she knew the expression on his face quite well. He was growling and you could see most of his teeth. She became horribly afraid and turned over the page at once. (*The Voyage of the “Dawn Treader”* [VDT] 10.154–55)

Here the sound of growling is not necessarily heard, but it is nevertheless experienced through the facial expression of the lion, who bares his teeth in a threatening gesture. Aslan often refrains from speech, instead using growls and other gestures to communicate. In *Prince Caspian* (PC), Lucy sees Aslan, but does not follow him because the other members of her party do not believe Aslan is there. Upon meeting Aslan, Lucy starts making excuses for her behaviour, and these excuses are only met with physical messages: "I saw you all right. They wouldn't believe me. They're all so—" From somewhere deep inside Aslan's body there came the faintest suggestion of a growl" (10.142). This growl, which is more felt than heard, is Aslan's way of telling Lucy that she should not blame others for her own shortcomings. Apparently, the growl can say more than one thing, and Aslan communicates through it on more than one occasion. In *The Last Battle* (LB), he roars a command to wake the giant Time (13.170), and then later he growls to challenge the false teaching that Aslan and Tash are the same god (15.188–89).

Often these roars and growls result in shaking or trembling of some sort, showing Aslan to be an unsettling presence both emotionally and physically. In *Prince Caspian*, for example, Aslan commands silence in a voice that even moves the ground: "'Peace,' said Aslan in the low voice which was nearest to his growl. The earth seemed to shake a little and every living thing in the grove became still as stone" (15.216–17). The humans and animals respond to this shaking with one of the most typical responses to fear. According to Ledoux, most animals, including humans, have three choices when reacting to fear: "freeze first; flee if you can; and fight if you must" (54). When the animals and humans hear Aslan's roar, they feel the earth shake and they become frozen in fear. Whether by freezing suddenly, running away, or trembling and shaking, humans, animals, and the land itself respond in bodily fear to Aslan's roars and rumbles.

The other weapons of the lion, his claws, are also foregrounded in these stories. They are sometimes mentioned directly and sometimes hinted at by mention of the lion's paws. The main characters in *The Horse and His Boy* go on a mission of urgency in a race to warn the king of Archenland about an imminent attack. Somehow, though, they find themselves going slower than they need to, lacking the motivation to run as fast as they can, at least until the lion Aslan gives them the "new strength of fear" (11.164), chasing after them from behind, snapping at them with his mouth and even attacking Aravis: "The lion rose on its hind legs, larger than you would have believed a lion could be, and jabbed at Aravis with its right paw. Shasta could see all the terrible claws extended. Aravis screamed and reeled in the saddle. The lion was tearing her shoulders" (10.144). We later discover that Aslan is not trying to kill Aravis; he is instead trying to punish or discipline her for causing her stepmother's servant to be beaten

(14.201–02). For Aravis, then, the discipline of God mentioned frequently in the Bible (for example in Prov. 3:11–12 or Heb. 12:5–6) is not some abstract idea but a bodily experience made concrete by the swipes of the lion’s claws. Similarly, in *The Voyage of the “Dawn Treader,”* Eustace is transformed into a dragon, and he finds that the only way to get rid of his scales and become human again is with the help of Aslan’s claws. After the experience, Eustace says, “I was afraid of his claws, I can tell you [...]. The very first tear he made was so deep that I thought it had gone right into my heart. And when he began pulling the skin off, it hurt worse than anything I’ve ever felt” (7.108–09). Here Eustace learns that “to put off [the] old self” and “to put on the new self” as Paul describes Christian transformation in Ephesians (4:22, 24), is much more difficult and much more painful than changing t-shirts, and any reader who has ripped off a scab or a band aid can imagine—and through this mental simulation somewhat experience—Eustace’s pain.

Even when the claws are not mentioned explicitly, they are hinted at by the mention of Aslan’s paws and the gestures he makes with them. When the Pevensies first meet Aslan, the lion’s paws quickly become the focus of the narrative: “The Lion shook his mane and clapped his paws together (‘Terrible paws,’ thought Lucy, ‘If he didn’t know how to velvet them!’)” (LWW 12.129). A little later, when speaking with Peter, Aslan lays his paw on Peter’s shoulder, and the narrator points out that “though it was velvety it was very heavy” (LWW 12.129). By telling us the paw is velvety, the narrator reminds us that there are dangerous claws hidden in it, and the weight of the paw suggests the strength behind those claws.⁶

There are, admittedly, numerous scenes in the Narnia books that describe an intimacy between Aslan and other characters, who touch his fur and his mane, kiss him and receive licks of his tongue, and even play with him. After Aslan is killed on the Stone Table, he comes back to life and begins to play with Lucy and Susan. The girls run around trying to catch Aslan’s tail, and they roll around together in a “laughing heap of fur and arms and legs” (LWW 15.164). But even this playful description never completely loses sight of the lion’s power and potential danger. Lucy has a hard time deciding whether playing with Aslan is “more like playing with a thunderstorm or playing with a kitten” (15.164). Details like this, or the combination of intimate experiences of Aslan with the roars and growls described above suggest that the dangers of the lion may be backgrounded, but they never disappear completely. Lucy, Susan, and other human and animal characters can become intimate with Aslan, but not familiar with him; he is not an animal to be taken for granted.

⁶ An argument could similarly be made that Aslan’s gentle carrying of Jill in his mouth reminds readers Aslan has dangerous teeth and jaws (Lewis, *The Silver Chair* [SC] 8.117).

The lion Aslan may symbolically represent God, or more specifically Jesus Christ, but he is experienced physically by characters and imaginatively by readers as a lion, a wild animal whose strength and size is itself a threat to humans, and this threat is a constant in the Narnia books. Even though various characters learn to trust and depend on Aslan, there is never any assurance that this lion is completely safe. In an often-quoted part of *LWW*, Susan and Lucy, surprised to hear that Aslan is a lion, ask whether he is safe, seeking some sort of assurance, but that assurance is never given:

"Ooh!" said Susan, "I'd thought he was a man. Is he—quite safe? I shall feel rather nervous about meeting a lion."

"That you will, dearie, and no mistake," said Mrs. Beaver, "if there's anyone who can appear before Aslan without their knees knocking, they're either braver than most or else just silly."

"Then he isn't safe?" said Lucy.

"Safe?" said Mr. Beaver. "Don't you hear what Mrs. Beaver tells you? Who said anything about safe? 'Course he isn't safe. But he's good." (8.79–80)

Instead of trying to rid Susan and Lucy of fear, Mrs. Beaver says that "knees knocking," a physical sign of fear, is the appropriate response to such a being. In *The Silver Chair*, when Aslan asks Jill to drink from a stream of water, Jill asks for similar assurances of safety, and these assurances are again denied:

"Will you promise not to—do anything to me, if I do come?" said Jill.

"I make no promise," said the Lion.

Jill was so thirsty now that, without noticing it, she had come a step nearer.

"Do you eat girls?" she said.

"I have swallowed up girls and boys, women and men, kings and emperors, cities and realms," said the Lion. (2.22)

Aslan does not respond with "Don't worry. I won't hurt you" or any other such assurances, but instead with a comment that would only make Jill more uncomfortable. When characters encounter Aslan—the God-figure in the stories—fear is an important emotion, not something to overcome and get rid of.

However, important as the concrete details of Aslan are, this fear of God is for Lewis more than *just* a fear of lions. In portraying the experience of God as he does in these books, Lewis reveals an understanding of the fear of the Lord that is influenced by Rudolf Otto's *The Idea of the Holy*, a now-classic study of religious experience published in German in 1917 and first translated into English in 1923. While Corbin Scott Carnell claims that Lewis read and was influenced by Otto's book in the 1920s (96), I believe Adam Barkman is correct

when he argues that Lewis first encountered the book in 1936 since this is when, in a letter, Lewis mentions purchasing a copy (Barkman 123; Lewis, *Letters* II.204).

Lewis's subsequent correspondences and nonfictional writings provide evidence of the favourable impression this book made on him. In one letter he claims that he was "deeply influenced" by Otto's book (*Letters* III.980). In two letters he recommends the book to others (II.528–20, III.125–26), and on other occasions Lewis makes mention of the "numinous," a term coined by Otto and popularized by his book. In a letter to Martyn Skinner dated December 31st, 1959, for example, Lewis challenges Skinner to make his writing "numinous," assuming this is a quality of powerful storytelling (*Letters* III.1118–19).⁷ In *The Problem of Pain*, Lewis mentions Otto by name and lists the numinous as one of the three strands or elements of "developed religion" (4–9). Later, in an essay originally published in 1952, Lewis cites Otto's book and says that "the seed of religious experience" is located "in our experience of the Numinous" ("Is Theism Important?" 189). Then, near the end of his life, when *The Christian Century* asked him what books had influenced him most, Lewis listed ten books, including Otto's *The Idea of the Holy* ("Ex Libris" 719).

According to Barkman, however, "influence" might be too strong of a word. Barkman argues that Lewis's thinking had already developed in ways that were merely re-affirmed by Otto's book (Barkman 132). Nevertheless, Barkman admits that certain of Otto's ideas, such as the description of the *mysterium tremendum*, seem to have left a mark on Lewis (129).⁸ The connection between Lewis's works and Otto's the numinous has been noted before, but usually with only a cursory treatment.⁹ One important exception, the study by Barkman, provides an extended treatment of the topic, but whereas his focus is on how Otto's book relates to Lewis's concept of joy, my focus in the rest of this article will be on how Otto's concept of the numinous can help us understand the fear of God in the Narnia books.

Both Lewis and Otto are interested in religious experience, in how people encounter the divine. Otto's book is largely about a quality of religious experience that he calls "numinous," a difficult concept that includes various emotional responses to the divine, including the fear of the Lord. He claims that the numinous cannot be precisely described by language, and so any study of the numinous must proceed through metaphors and analogies, comparisons

⁷ Also see a letter to Sister Penelope where he comments on Penelope's description of a haunted island in relation to Otto's book: "I was interested in your account of the haunted island of your childhood—a good example of what Otto would call the lowest grade of the 'Numinous'" (*Letters* II.285).

⁸ The *mysterium tremendum* is discussed in more detail below.

⁹ See, for example, Como 74, 234–35; Duriez 357; Christopher 117; Carnell 57, 96; and the slightly more extended discussion in Downing 33–34, 109–10, 128–30.

and contrasts. "This X of ours," he says, meaning the numinous, "is not precisely *this* experience, but akin to this one and the opposite of that other" (Otto 7). So when Otto talks about an emotional aspect of the numinous that he calls the "*mysterium tremendum*," he explains the concept with recourse to everyday emotional terms like fear, but he stresses that these "ordinary" emotions are analogies of the numinous: "'Tremor' is in itself merely the perfectly familiar and 'natural' emotion of *fear*," he says, "But here the term is taken aptly enough but still only by analogy, to denote a quite specific kind of emotional response, wholly distinct from that of being afraid, though it so far resembles it that the analogy of fear may be used to throw light upon its nature" (13).

In the same way, Lewis portrays the fear of the Lord as a numinous, emotive experience that is related analogically to ordinary fears. The fear of the Lord is indeed "what is often called fear, but of a different kind" (*The Problem of Pain* 5). In *The Problem of Pain*, Lewis points to *The Wind in the Willows* for an example, quoting a part of the story when Rat and Mole approach the god Pan:

"Rat," he found breath to whisper, shaking. "Are you afraid?"
 "Afraid?" murmured the Rat, his eyes shining with unutterable love. "Afraid? of *Him*? O, never, never! And yet—and yet—O, Mole, I am afraid!" (Grahame 7.77; Lewis, *The Problem of Pain* 6)

Rat is not afraid and yet afraid because he is experiencing a numinous fear, an experience akin to but different from regular fear. Similar language can be found scattered throughout *The Chronicles of Narnia*. In *The Silver Chair*, when Jill first encounters Aslan, she is at first—and understandably—afraid because she is in front of a lion. But when that lion speaks, her emotional experience takes on a numinous quality: "Anyway, she had seen its lips move this time, and the voice was not like a man's. It was deeper, wilder, and stronger; a sort of heavy, golden voice. It did not make her any less frightened than she had been before, but it made her frightened in rather a different way" (2.22). In *The Voyage of the "Dawn Treader"*, Eustace likewise experiences a strange fear, even though he is in the shape of a strong dragon. He says, "[The lion] came nearer and nearer. I was terribly afraid of it. You may think that, being a dragon, I could have knocked any lion out easily enough. But it wasn't that kind of fear. I wasn't afraid of it eating me, I was just afraid of *it*—if you can understand" (7.106–07). A final example can be found in *The Horse and His Boy*, when Shasta finds himself face-to-face with the lion: "Shasta was no longer afraid that the Voice belonged to something that would eat him, nor that it was the voice of a ghost. But a new and different sort of trembling came over him. Yet he felt glad too" (11.165). In all these examples, the characters describe their experience as one of fear, but they also distinguish that fear qualitatively from regular fear.

The final example above also suggests how these two fears are different, for Shasta experiences a gladness at the same time that he is afraid. Similarly, Peter, Susan, and Lucy upon seeing Aslan feel “as glad as anyone can who feels afraid, and as afraid as anyone can who feels glad” (PC 11.153). This strange combination of emotions points to another part of the numinous as Otto describes it in *The Idea of the Holy*. Otto argues that there are two sides to a numinous experience, the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, or the daunting and the fascinating: “The daemonic-divine object may appear to the mind an object of horror and dread, but at the same time it is no less something that allures with a potent charm, and the creature, who trembles before it, utterly cowed and cast down, has always at the same time the impulse to turn to it” (31). We can see this paradox at work in *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*, when Peter says of Aslan, “I’m longing to see him [...] even if I do feel frightened when it comes to the point” (8.80). Similarly, when Digory and Polly first encounter Aslan in *The Magician’s Nephew*, they experience a combination of fear and desire:

The children could not move. They were not even quite sure that they wanted to. The Lion paid no attention to them. Its huge red mouth was open, but open in song not in a snarl. It passed by them so close that they could have touched its mane. They were terribly afraid it would turn and look at them, yet in some queer way they wished it would. (9.116–17)

This mixture of fear and desire or *tremendum et fascinans* is also displayed somewhat humorously by Hwin, one of the talking horses in *The Horse and His Boy*. When Hwin approaches Aslan, she is “shaking all over” with fear, but she approaches nevertheless and says, “Please [...] you’re so beautiful. You may eat me if you like. I’d sooner be eaten by you than fed by anyone else” (14.200–01).

This paradoxical fear and attraction is one of the most important qualities that separates the fear of God from other types of fear. Lewis describes the difference between regular fear and fear of God in his essay “Is Theism Important?”:

We have in English an exact name for the emotion aroused by the Numinous, which Otto, writing in German lacked; we have the word Awe—an emotion very like fear, with the important difference that it need imply no estimate of danger. When we fear a tiger, we fear that it may kill us: when we fear a ghost—well, we just fear the ghost, not this or that mischief which it may do us. The Numinous or Awful is that of which we have this, as it were, objectless or disinterested fear—this awe. (189)¹⁰

¹⁰ The example of a tiger and a ghost is repeated in Lewis, *The Problem of Pain* 5.

This awe is so similar to fear that Lewis repeats the word “fear” at the end of the passage, even after having made a distinction between the two terms, but they are at the same time significantly different. Base or regular fear, for Lewis, is a self-directed emotion that encourages people to look out for their own safety. This kind of fear is usually demonstrated by the morally deprived characters in the books, characters who encounter Aslan and run away from him to save their lives. In *Prince Caspian*, for example, Aslan, accompanied by Bacchus and the dancing Maenads, leads a rowdy procession through a town, and all of the townspeople respond with one of two responses to the sight of Aslan: people either run away from or join the procession, and their responses imply a judgement about their moral character. For instance, when they come upon a school with an overly strict teacher, one student (Gwendolyn) is drawn to Aslan, whereas the teacher and the rest of the students—whom the narrator criticizes as “dumpy, prim little girls with fat legs”—all run away (14.200). This same divisive effect—some fleeing, some approaching—is seen repeatedly as Aslan makes his way through the town.

Returning to *The Magician's Nephew* we see a similar contrast between the fear of Digory and Polly on the one hand and the fear of the Witch and Uncle Andrew on the other:

Though [Aslan's] soft pads made no noise, you could feel the earth shake beneath their weight.

The Witch shrieked and ran: in a few moments she was out of sight among the trees. Uncle Andrew turned to do likewise, tripped over a root, and fell flat on his face in a little brook that ran down to join the river. The children could not move. They were not even quite sure that they wanted to. The Lion paid no attention to them. Its huge red mouth was open, but open in song not in a snarl. It passed by them so close that they could have touched its mane. They were terribly afraid it would turn and look at them, yet in some queer way they wished it would. (9.116-17)

In this passage, both the children and the adults are afraid, but they experience this fear differently. The Witch and Uncle Andrew try to run away; the children, though frozen with fear, at the same time do not want to run. They even wish that the lion would turn his attention to them, demonstrating both the *tremendum et fascinans* of an encounter with the numinous. As the narrator later explains, “What you see and hear depends a good deal on where you are standing: it also depends on what sort of person you are” (10.136). Uncle Andrew, because of the “sort of person” he is, does not see the numinous when he looks at Aslan; all he sees is a lion who might attack him, and so he tries to run away. The children, on the other hand, look at the lion and experience a similar fear, but also something more than fear.

This strange combination of emotions is aroused by the *numen*, Otto's term for the source of numinous experience, which in this case is Aslan, who is both dreadful and desirable. "People who have not been in Narnia," the narrator explains, "sometimes think that a thing cannot be good and terrible at the same time" but that is a mistaken assumption that an experience of Aslan can "cure" (LWW 12.126). Aslan is regularly described as both "terrible" and "beautiful", the first term not meaning "bad" but "terrifying" or "dreadful."¹¹ In fact, Lewis frequently uses the word "terrible" in *The Chronicles of Narnia* to denote the *mysterium tremendum* of the *numinous*, the fear-like emotion evoked by an encounter with the spiritual or the divine. And so with a world of images, filled with magical beings, talking animals, and a divine lion, Lewis provides his readers with imaginative simulations of encounters with God, and these simulations evoke the very emotions that young Christians might be told they "ought to feel" but cannot feel because they ought to. Stripping the fear of God from its "Sunday school associations," the books provide affective training, arousing fear so that readers can, through the concrete, embodied analogy, experience a fear of a different kind.

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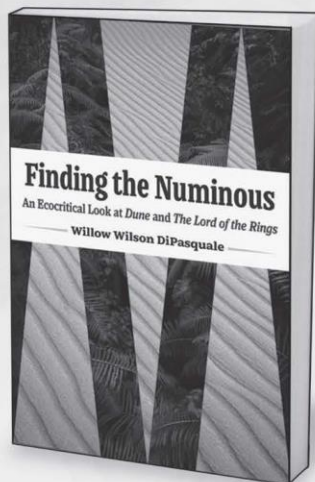
¹¹ See *The Horse and His Boy*, 11.166, 14.200; LB 15.188.

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BRETT ROSCOE is Associate Professor of English at The King's University in Edmonton, Canada, where he teaches courses in general and medieval literature. His research interests include medieval wisdom literature, cognitive approaches to literature, and intersections of literature and theology.



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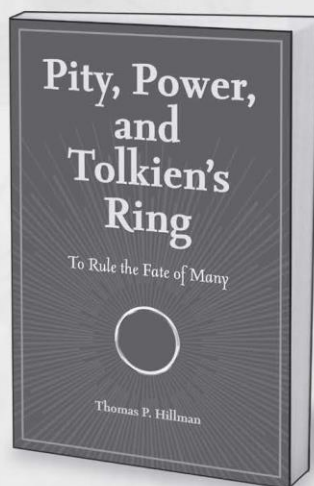
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EASTING AT THE THRESHOLD: EUCCHARISTIC EROTICISM AND HOMONATIONALISM IN DIANE DUANE'S *The Tale of the Five*

TAYLOR DRIGGERS

INTRODUCTION

IN HIS ESSAY "ON FAIRY-STORIES" (1947), J.R.R. Tolkien suggests that by re-arranging and offering variations on elements of the primary world, fantasy can reinvigorate our appreciation of everyday things "such as stone, and wood, and iron; tree and grass; house and fire; bread and wine" (69). The eucharistic applicability suggested by the inclusion of bread and wine in this formulation is likely no accident; as a devout Catholic, Tolkien's theorization of fairy-story, by his own acknowledgement, shares a complex relationship with his understanding of the Christian story of salvation. Alana M. Vincent goes so far as to link fantasy to the Eucharist by way of the Catholic principle of sacramentality. While "sacraments, such as the Eucharist [...] confer grace immediately" (23), within a Christian framework literature can be understood as *sacramental*, a facet of everyday life that awakens a sense of the numinous and "leaves the soul disposed toward the reception of grace" (24). Fantastic recovery in particular carries a sacramental potential to "inspire entirely new dimensions of theological understanding" (25) because "the aura of mystery which pervades the fantasy world is well situated to illuminate the real world by proxy" (43). While fantasy is incapable of serving as a direct stand-in for the eucharistic sacrament per se, a Christian theological reading of fantasy positions it at the threshold where the material concerns of everyday life turn towards communion with the divine, a communion that remains rooted in fleshly acts centered around the fulfilment of bodily needs and desires (eating and drinking) even as it gestures toward transcendence.

Fantasy's ability to critically reimagine the primary world, and matters of the body in the primary world in particular, also enables it to re-vision sacramental practices from the margins of gendered and sexual difference, uncovering subversive queer alternatives to the doctrines that govern them.¹ After all, if recovery consists in "viewing the Other not as an extension of one's self, but as an entity both outside of and equal to one's self" (Vincent 47), then the sacramental revelation enacted by fantasy can also challenge dominant

¹ See Taylor Driggers, *Queering Faith in Fantasy Literature*.

expressions of theology to commune with, brush up against, and commingle with the image of God as embodied by the sexual other often institutionally barred from receiving the material and spiritual goods of communion in the first place. As a sacramental production, fantasy that takes up this queer theological task can dispose theology towards the grace of what Marcella Althaus-Reid has described as “God, as a stranger at the gates of Hegemonic Theology, amongst loving expressions of relationships at the margins of the defined decent and proper in Christianity” (*The Queer God* [Queer] 171).

Diane Duane’s ongoing fantasy series *The Tale of the Five* (1979–present) explicitly articulates a queer sacramentality, with specific applicability to the Eucharist, along these lines. In this essay, I demonstrate how *The Tale of the Five* emphasizes acts of eating and drinking as important components not only of its secondary world’s Goddess-based religion, but also of its characters’ pansexual, polyamorous relationships. These instances provocatively link religious devotion with the pursuit of erotic pleasures and relational formations deemed indecent within many primary-world expressions of Christianity. The Goddess’s affection for humanity and humanity’s love for the Goddess spill over into queer sexual encounters between humans, which in turn are revealed as extensions or permutations of the former, and human characters additionally experience personally transformative sexual encounters with the Goddess. Yet the series’ adherence to standard conventions of popular fantasy at the time of writing, rooted in fantasies of monarchy, race, and nation in a manner that exists in uneasy tension with, and raises serious questions about the limits of, its queer theological imagination.

The Tale of the Five is part of a body of fantasy literature explicitly aimed at addressing issues of gender and sexuality emerging in the 1970s, 1980s, and 1990s, alongside works such as Elizabeth A. Lynn’s *The Chronicles of Tornor* (1979–80), Samuel R. Delany’s *Neveryon* cycle (1979–87), Ellen Kushner’s *Riverside* novels (1987–2006), Mercedes Lackey’s *The Last Herald-Mage* trilogy (1989–91), and Laurie J. Marks’s *Children of the Triad* series (1989–91). Of these, only Duane’s and Kushner’s series are set in worlds in which non-heterosexual orientations are the default norm across all areas of society.² *The Tale of the Five* is set in a secondary world called the Middle Kingdoms and consists of three novels—*The Door into Fire* (1979), *The Door into Shadow* (1984), and *The Door into Sunset* (1992)—in addition to the novelette *The Levin-Gad* (2018) and the novella *The Landlady* (2019), with at least one more spinoff novel, *The Librarian*, and a fourth main series novel, *The Door into Starlight*, still to be published at the time

² Marks’s series is a difficult one to categorize, since most of its main characters are intersex nonhumans. While nonheterosexual unions between these characters and other species exist, the humanoid Walkers are implied to live in a default patriarchal society.

of writing.³ Despite the series' fluid and expansive approach to sexuality, as well as its unique cosmogony, it has received virtually no scholarly attention from either queer or religious studies-informed scholars of fantasy. The religion of the Middle Kingdoms, structured as it is around the tripartite goddess motif of "Maiden and Mother and Wise Woman" (Duane, *The Door into Fire* [Fire] 11) and animistic magic rituals associated with the earth, draws some notable influences from neo-Pagan beliefs and practices. However, these are also intertwined with heterodox, but nonetheless clear, variations on Christian doctrines and theological concepts, such as the belief that humans "are made in the Goddess's image" (*The Door into Sunset* [Sunset] 70), the concern with a deity who is incarnated in human flesh and exists alongside humanity, and its investment in motifs of eating, drinking, and transubstantiation that gesture toward eucharistic sacrament.

In the latter case, the sharing of food and drink becomes a sacramental act that draws together, and blurs boundaries between, religious devotion; filial and platonic love; erotic desire; sexual pleasure; and bodily transformations, expansions, and multiplications in a manner that prefigures Linn Marie Tonstad's queer reading of the Eucharist and its relationship to the Body of Christ. In Tonstad's formulation, the multiplication of the body of Christ to co-inhere in bread and wine (and therefore the labor of those who produce them) and its subsequent distribution among the bodies of believers creates a complex and potent image of loving coinhabitation within the church as the Body of Christ that transgresses bodily, identitarian, geographical, and institutional boundaries without assimilation into an undifferentiated sameness. To analyze *The Tale of the Five* in terms of the Eucharist and the body of Christ is by no means to suggest that a Christian reading is the only available one of its religious imaginary; in fact, its syncretic blend of Christian and feminist neo-Pagan influences makes such a claim impossible. Rather, eucharistic theology is merely one area of many—though a significant one—in which the series enters into conversation with primary-world religious observation.

And yet, as much as its worldbuilding and narrative evocatively suggest this queer portrait of religious life, *The Tale of the Five* also betrays it to some extent. The fact that a major narrative arc of the series involves restoring one of the protagonists, Freelorn, as the rightful hereditary monarch of the nation of Arlen, coupled with the mystical import attributed to noble bloodlines and titles throughout, jars awkwardly with and in some instances alters the meaning of its otherwise radical eucharistic theology. While these narrative

³ Other works by Diane Duane set in the Middle Kingdoms include the novelettes *Parting Gifts* (1981), *Lior and the Sea* (1985), and *The Span* (1999), but as they do not concern any of the principal characters of *The Tale of the Five*, they are beyond the scope of this study.

attributes are far from unique in the broader context of twentieth-century fantasy more generally, these aspects of the texts become more disconcerting when, beginning with *The Door into Shadow*, a significant portion of the narrative conflict involves protecting the Middle Kingdoms from an othered race that threatens their stability. This note of dissonance provokes consideration of the need for fantasy's queer theological imaginaries to take care that they challenge rather than merely extend the logic of western Christian triumphalism.

GOING (IN)TO TOWN: SEXUAL, MATERIAL, AND SPIRITUAL GOODS OF THE MIDDLE KINGDOMS

Chapter 6 of *The Door into Sunset* opens with an epigraph from a fictitious text telling the tale of a woman who roams the earth seeking the Goddess, but is unable to find her. Returning home, dejected, to an empty larder, she ventures into the Darthis city marketplace, where she encounters

a Woman wearing that Cloak which is the night sky, and with a basket over her arm, and bread in it and wine. And the woman looked at the Goddess in amazement, and the Goddess sighed and smiled, and said to her, "It's such a nuisance, but sometimes you just have to go into town." And She kissed the woman, and was gone . . . (*Sunset* 124)

This scene communicates much about the eucharistic and incarnational theology that characterizes the Middle Kingdoms' cosmogony. Both evoking and subverting the biblical account in which the prophet Elijah encounters God not in the great wind or the earthquake or the fire, but in "a sound of sheer silence" (1 Kings 19:12, NRSVUE), the Goddess is found not in the remote corners of the earth but among ordinary women in the bustling marketplace. The eucharistic motif of bread and wine appears here both to underscore the incarnate nature of the Goddess's existence—since in the eucharistic sacrament bread and wine correspond to the body and blood of the incarnate Christ—and to signify the material goods that they literally are. As a setting for this exchange, the market is particularly laden with meaning for queer theology. Althaus-Reid's Marxian analysis of traditional theology, for instance, observes that "[e]conomic desires walk hand in hand with erotic desires and theological needs" (*Indecent Theology* [*Indecent*] 166) and that

theology deals with a market of souls and the definition of their needs: sacraments, prayers, ritual ordinances and an allegiance to beliefs which regulate people's lives, in order to effectively distribute the spiritual goods of redemption or forgiveness or even eternal life amongst them, the spiritual clientele. (166–67)

As in the Eucharist, material and spiritual goods, here distributed directly by the Goddess herself, appear simultaneously in bread and wine at the moment of fulfilment for the unnamed woman's material needs and theological desires. And yet, the Goddess's playful, almost camp remarks to the woman (it is not at all difficult to imagine this line being casually tossed off in a drag performance) avoid conflating the Goddess with the marketplace itself. The sly suggestion that "[i]t's such a nuisance" to go into town but that "sometimes you just have to" positions the Goddess as immanent within the everyday business of economy and its material goods, but lovingly transcending any regulatory system structuring it (although, as I demonstrate later, this becomes complicated when considering the political structures that govern the Middle Kingdoms as a whole).

The encounter with the Goddess in the marketplace is instructive in tracing the links between worship of the Goddess, the shared consumption of food and drink, and the exchange of queer sexual pleasures. I argue that *The Tale of the Five* is permeated with instances of transubstantiation and transfiguration in which relations and encounters slide freely between these categories or inhabit more than one simultaneously. The series is already notable from a queer standpoint thanks to the open and dynamic nature of its sexual landscape. While inhabitants of the Middle Kingdoms are subject to a divine obligation to have at least one child in their lifetime—similar to, yet distinct from, the injunction to "[b]e fruitful and multiply" in the biblical creation narrative (Gen. 1:28, NRSVUE)—their sexual lives otherwise are open and varied, with most characters taking on multiple partners of all genders. The central pairing in the series initially appears to be a gay romance between two of the central protagonists, Herewiss and Freelorn, but these characters' romantic and sexual lives branch out over the course of the texts to encompass multiple relationships of varying types and durations with characters of multiple genders. These entanglements also continually reshape the dynamic between these two men even as they remain committed to one another. Already we can see here a fluid and shifting sexual landscape that markedly contrasts with what Althaus-Reid analyses as the regulatory frame of sexual "decency" that dictates who is worthy of receiving material and spiritual goods within Christian institutions (*Indecent* 167–68).

Yet even beyond this, *The Tale of the Five's* world and narrative are marked by constant bodily transgressions and surprises: a human and dragon can occupy the same body and become lovers, human subjectivities can expand to inhabit the tectonic plates beneath a mountain range, and a one-night stand can bring one face-to-face with the divine. At the time when the series' narrative takes place, the world is at a critical juncture in the constant struggle between the Goddess who creates and loves, and Her fallen offspring the Shadow who

devours and destroys, and as such, the rules and norms that govern the world are shifting even further. Herewiss is the first man in centuries to wield the mystical power of the Blue Fire usually reserved for women, and one of his sexual partners is a fire elemental named Sunspark, for whom sexuality and romantic love should be impossible and whose physical appearance shifts fluidly between human and nonhuman forms as well as between genders. Throughout the series, human bodies and subjectivities expand, change shape, and multiply through various magical and divine means to exceed and destabilize the bounds of self-identity. Always weaving Her way through these experiences of queer excess and impossibility is the Goddess, who plays an active role in the sexual lives of all Her creations.

A WONDERFUL EXCHANGE: EUCHARISTIC EROTICISM

The Door into Fire establishes that “[o]nce in a lifetime, a person will know the joy of being held in the Goddess’s arms,” although “She comes as just another person, with human quirks and wrinkles; sometimes She comes in the form of someone you know—perhaps even your own loved” (*Fire* 45–46). Later in that novel, Herewiss, Freelorn, the sorceress Segnbora, and the rest of their travelling companions happen upon an inn in the wilderness, where the woman who keeps the inn agrees to let them stay the night in exchange for sex in place of money, an apparently commonplace occurrence within the Middle Kingdoms’ sexual economy. After sitting down to a sumptuous meal, the companions depart to their respective rooms, with Segnbora chosen to go to bed with the innkeeper per their agreement. However, the innkeeper surprises each of the others in turn by appearing to all of them simultaneously at Moonrise, where they each eventually recognize her as the Goddess, and she spends the night with them.

As in the encounter with the Goddess in the marketplace, here the Goddess first appears in the midst of everyday exchanges before exceeding them in the abundance of the material, sexual, and spiritual gratification She bears. The initial sexual arrangement She negotiates with Segnbora as the innkeeper becomes multiplied sevenfold among the company and leaves them fulfilled far beyond any normal sexual encounter. Reminiscing about the experience afterward, Segnbora contrasts it with ordinary sex in which, “give as you will, there’s only so much that can be shared in one evening, or one day, before the body gives out, gets sore, gets tired,” whereas the Goddess’s attentions satisfied “all of me, all the depths, the corners, the little fantasies I never dared” (*Fire* 160). The bounty of the Goddess’s table at the inn and the rest and shelter She provides for the travelers gives way to a fulfilment of sexual needs beyond the usual bounds of possibility within human relations, which in turn leaves the company spiritually enriched and edified for their journey.

The bountiful multiplication and loving commingling of divine and human bodies in this exchange, and its mediation through the hospitality of the meal table, bears a strong resemblance to Tonstad's queering of the eucharistic feast. Rather than the straightforward transmutation that characterizes traditional readings of transubstantiation, Tonstad proposes an additive model that she refers to as "impanation" to make sense of the presence of the body of Christ within the Eucharist (240). In this model, "the Word assumes a bread nature in addition to a human nature" that is freely distributed among, and comes to dwell within the bodies of, all who take part in the feast (240). This additive understanding of the Eucharist challenges us to see the distribution of spiritual goods as intimately bound up with the free sharing of material goods, since "the multiplication of the breaded Christs means enough Christ for all" (242), and signals the form of good relations that the grace of Christ initiates among humanity. As Tonstad puts it,

our participation in (taking part in) Christ brings us together in face-to-face relations that show us to each other more clearly—or at least have the potential to do so, for better and worse. The sufficiency of the eucharist, and the intensified relationships among humans that it symbolizes and makes possible, suggests reconfiguration of the conditions of bodied, material existence themselves. (242)

Christian theology tends not to explicitly imagine God as pursuing sexual relationships with humanity in the same way that the Goddess does in *The Tale of the Five*, and certainly Tonstad's reading of the Eucharist makes no literal claims to this effect either. Yet Tonstad, following Althaus-Reid, is heavily invested in showing how Christianity's theological metaphors and practices are always already sexual in nature; their inherent sexuality simply tends to be invisible within a society that accepts patriarchal and heterosexual views of reality as natural. The Eucharist is no exception. Althaus-Reid, for instance, identifies that in the Catholicism of her youth, the traditional pose in which one receives the Eucharist involves kneeling at the altar, which places the communicant in proximity to the priest's penis (*Queer* 11). A whole matrix of power relations is thus implied by this gesture, linking the Catholic Church's enforcement of patriarchal and heterosexual gender relations to the innumerable instances of sexual abuse within the Church that have come to light in the past few decades, as well as the Church's historical role in colonial exercises of domination and conquest. As Althaus-Reid puts it, "hierarchical church models [are] constructed from the axis of priests' penises" (12). Similarly, at stake for Tonstad is finding an alternative to patriarchal redemption models in which the church is positioned as the submissive bride to Christ the penetrative bridegroom. The prevailing image in her eucharistic theology is

instead one of loving coinhabitation, where “[t]he body’s limits do not disappear, but spatial location becomes coinhabitable, and the colocality of different bodies—presence in the same place at the same time—transforms the nature of relationality and community” (239). Impanation thus envisions a form of loving relation in which communicants commingle with God and one another without assimilation or loss of particularity.

The additive logic of impanation materializes in Duane’s series in the way the Goddess multiplies herself to initiate pleasurable relations with the human characters; in the way that these encounters in turn intensify the close bonds that the protagonists share while preserving the distinctions between them; and in the way that food and drink serve as reminders of this love and intimacy. *The Door into Sunset* expands on this notion in its conclusion with a seven-way wedding between Herewiss, Freelorn, Segnbora, the fire elemental Sunspark, the resurrected dragon Hasai, Queen Eftgan of Darthen, and her husband Wyn, in which they all vow “to do right by one another, as the Goddess would were She marrying in (which of course She was)” before partaking of sacral wine (*Sunset* 377). While this latter instance is the only depiction in the series of an official religious sacrament in which the act of drinking signifies a good relation with the Goddess as among and within the loving relationships of Her creation, instances of eating and drinking elsewhere in the series serve as articulations of this relationship that exist on the sacramental threshold between everyday life and religious observance.

LOVERS AND THE LOVING-CUP: THRESHOLD THEOLOGY

Herewiss’s own encounter with the Goddess at the inn is mediated by a shared cup of Brightwood white, a wine significant to Herewiss’s homeland. Later, under the influence of the Soulflight drug that the Goddess gives him to help unlock his Fire, Herewiss perceives within the wine

the cries of ecstatic agony uttered by the vines as their burden was ripped from them, and [...] the silver touch of rain. He caught the langorous thoughts of one of the young girls who had helped to press out the vintage, and he felt how it had been for her, the night before, under the pomegranate trees with her lover. [...] The tangled, vivid selfhoods of bees and vintners and young girls flowed down his throat like cinnamon fire, and left an aftertaste like a summer dawn. (*Fire* 252)

For Herewiss, the simple act of drinking a cup of Brightwood white is revealed to be a sacramental act in which he comes into profound contact with other lives, including nonhuman ones. This revelation embodies what Tolkien identifies as the sacramental role of recovery in fantasy, insofar as it involves “seeing things [...] as things apart from ourselves” (67). Though it occurs via fantastical means,

the realization is ultimately a mundane one regarding the interconnectedness of all life. The sacredness of wine even in everyday contexts is further underscored by the events of *The Levin-Gad*, in which Liri, the bouncer at a tavern, saves Herewiss from the Shadow by smashing a bottle of wine, which, “flaming like sunlight made molten, splashed and sprayed everywhere. [...] In the flare of liquid light the darkness’s limbs flailed out and it went down like so many dropped rocks, sprawling crooked and limp on the slaty floor” (7.38).

Drinking wine, via the ceremonial object of the lovers’-cup, is also the means by which lovers in the Middle Kingdoms pay homage to their love for each other and the Goddess made manifest in and through that love. In *The Door into Fire*, the cup’s role in daily life is established as follows:

It was the Goddess’s cup, the cup poured for Her at each meal to remind those who ate that all set before them was, one way or another, the product of Her love—as were the people with whom they ate. When the meal was done, if there were lovers there, the youngest of them would drain the cup together in Her name. If one was alone, one said the Blessing for the Sundered and drank it in his own name and the name of his lover, wherever that one might be. (*Fire* 216)

The lovers’-cup features in most scenes featuring Herewiss and Freelorn and, eventually, their five other spouses, serving as a reminder to the reader as well as the characters themselves of the Goddess’s presence within and mediation through the love between them. In both name and function, it invites comparison to the loving-cup used at love-feasts within the Methodist Christian tradition. Both theologically coextensive with and liturgically distinct from the official sacrament of the eucharistic feast, the love-feast can be read as an example of what Rachel Muers and Rhiannon Grant have termed “threshold practices”: that is, “practices that are, theoretically and institutionally, neither church nor non-church” (47). The use of “threshold” here implies the liminality of such practices—the point at which worship crosses over into the work of everyday life, and vice-versa—but also, and importantly for an account of quasi-eucharistic practices, etymologically evokes the threshing-floor, a space where the theological values of a community are “threshed out” like wheat and constituted via everyday encounters (47).

Instituted by Methodism’s founders, Charles and John Wesley, in the eighteenth century, love-feasts were thought at the time to be a revival of the early church practice of the Agape, which Frank Baker characterizes as “a common meal symbolizing the union of Christians with their Lord and with each other” (62). Central to the Methodist reimagining of this practice was the loving-cup, “a two-handled mug passed round from hand to hand” from which participants share a drink of what initially would have been wine, and later, as

the practice has evolved, water or tea (Baker 15). Although the love-feast is not a substitute for the Eucharist, it shares many of its theological concerns: from the standpoint of bodily theology, the passing of the loving-cup provokes a meditation on what it means to share in the Body of Christ as made up of a gathering of bodies that exist in relation to each other. As a quasi-liturgical object designed for the sharing of drink, the loving-cup mediates profoundly intimate physical contact that crosses bodily boundaries between participants as it passes between lips, signifying participants' unity in partaking of the meal while maintaining the difference that enables their loving interrelation.

In transforming the loving-cup into the lovers'-cup, Duane explicitly eroticizes this quasi-liturgical object and by extension names desire, in all its unpredictability and all its forms, both as a central part of religious observance and as a crucial site at which characters in the series turn from theological reflection to engagement with each other in the world.⁴ Sitting athwart the line between religious observance and everyday life, the cup is a ritual means of acknowledging the presence of the Goddess in the hospitality of the meal table, the community and common labor of all those present, and the intimacy of those joined in erotic and romantic love. It also represents, for the romantically unattached, a messianic hope for the Goddess's love expressed as erotic longing, as they "call on the Loved Who Will Be to await [their] coming" (*Fire* 216) when they drink of the cup. Here, not only are queer desire and sexualities named as revelatory incarnations of the Goddess's love, but hospitality itself is reframed as a complex and multi-directional flow of love, desire, and care-oriented labor. Importantly, the lovers'-cup's status as a threshold object, both liturgical and mundane in function, would seem to imply that the eucharistic theology of *The Tale of the Five* is liberated from the forces that normally regulate the flow of spiritual, material, and sexual goods in the primary world.

ROYAL BINDINGS: THEOLOGICAL HOMONATIONALISM

The queer utopianism and radical eucharistic theology potentially suggested by *The Tale of the Five's* worldbuilding make for strange bedfellows with its narrative, which is in large part concerned with restoring Freelorn to his hereditary position as King of Arlen. Nearly every principal character in the series claims noble lineage to an extent that jars with the non-hierarchical communion suggested by the series' eucharistic motifs; most egregiously, the entire plot of *The Landlady* concerns Segnbora's quest to restore her family name

⁴ As Baker's historical account of the love-feast relates, the potentially erotic dimensions suggested by the feast's name and the intimate gesture of passing the loving-cup did not escape the notice of Methodism's early detractors, and accusations of sexual excess were common in anti-Methodist propaganda (32–33).

and maintain her land holdings. The restoration of a rightful monarch, marking a reign of peace and a happy conclusion to the narrative, is a common feature within post-Tolkien fantasy literature of the twentieth century, taking its cues both from the crowning of Aragorn in *The Lord of the Rings* and the more generalized feudal setting of much fantasy written in this vein. Queer and feminist fantasy fiction of the time had varied approaches to the question of monarchy. Lackey's *Herald-Mage* trilogy centers on a gay man living in a heteronormative patriarchy, but, like Duane's series, takes its monarchical setting at face value, with the world of Valdemar ruled by a benevolent king. Even the resolutely anarchist Ursula K. Le Guin concludes *The Farthest Shore* (1972), the third volume in her *Earthsea* series, with the good king Lebannen's coronation, although its sequel *Tehanu* (1990), published two years prior to *The Door into Sunset*, casts significant doubt on whether this has any bearing on the lives of everyday people, especially women, in *Earthsea*. (Le Guin would later remark that "too many modern fantasies are intolerably trivial and complacent in their half-baked feudalism" [316]). Delany's *Neveryon* cycle and Marks's *Triad* novels are notable outliers, with the former rigorously interrogating its Robert E. Howard-esque setting with realpolitik and a frank treatment of homosexuality and sex work, and the latter set in a world that is politically very far removed from any primary-world historical analogue. Meanwhile, Elizabeth A. Lynn's *Watchtower* (1979), published the same year as *The Door into Fire*, slyly subverts its own narrative of feudal conflict as part of its critical contention with heteropatriarchal violence; here, the ostensible rightful heir refuses the throne and departs to live in the anarchic commune of Vanima, with radical social change also to come in the realm of Tornor. To interrogate the collusion between religion and monarchy in *The Tale of the Five* is therefore not to single the series out relative to the rest of the genre, but rather to examine its performative function—in other words, what it means and does—as part of a theological imaginary.

Leaving aside the incoherence of a world as sexually open as the Middle Kingdoms—where lineage, inheritance, and familial structure should therefore be far messier matters than depicted—being ruled by hereditary monarchies and preoccupied with noble lineages, it is especially strange that this system of governance appears to be divinely sanctioned. Not only is Freelorn personally invested in winning back the throne from his usurping half-brother, Cillmod; his ascent is crucial for maintaining the magical Royal Bindings forged from the alliance between Darthen and Arlen that keep the Shadow at bay. In *The Door into Shadow*, the stakes of installing Freelorn as King become apparent when the Bindings come under direct threat; the text makes clear that "[t]he end of the Royal Bindings was unthinkable. Such a calamity would turn the Shadow loose in the Kingdoms as It hadn't been loose in

centuries" (*The Door into Shadow* [Shadow] 147). The Goddess's struggle is thus yoked to Freelorn's quest for the throne. An Arlene commoner remarks to Freelorn, travelling through the Arlene countryside in disguise, that "the young king is an instrument of the Goddess, a tool of Hers," and that "[s]uch a one's to be pitied, poor thing" (*Sunset* 163). Similarly, when advising Freelorn on the responsibilities of rule, Eftgan declares that "even if I do die, the Goddess who gave me this responsibility will hold me responsible still" (88). That hereditary monarchs are positioned by the narrative as specially ordained instruments of the Goddess's will, and that moreover they are to be pitied for this responsibility, is an odd recapitulation of the divine right of kings, and a rather galling reframing of the real power monarchs wield. Where the eucharistic threshold practices commonplace in the Middle Kingdoms hint at a dissolution of institutional forces that regulate the distribution of spiritual, material, and sexual goods, monarchy rears its head as yet another regulating body in the market of souls.

It would be tempting to read this facet of the series as merely in conflict with its otherwise egalitarian queer worldbuilding and theological imagination. Yet I contend that when *The Tale of the Five's* fascination with monarchic rule is examined alongside its eucharistic imaginary via Jasbir K. Puar's critique of homonationalism, a different and more complicated picture emerges. As theorized by Puar, homonationalism is the process by which "[a]spects of homosexuality have come within the purview of normative patriotism, incorporating aspects of queer subjectivity into the body of the normalized nation" (46), often to legitimize military and imperial incursions into non-western territories by western states. We can see this process literalized in the way that the queer eucharistic motif of impanation extends to the ritual involved in maintaining the Royal Bindings. As Freelorn and Eftgan spill their blood upon the earth and declare themselves embodiments of the lands of Arlen and Darthen, respectively, Segnbora hears their chanting as "the Goddess speaking to Herself: one Lover speaking to the Other, in solemn celebration of Their eternal relationship" (*Shadow* 304). Here, Freelorn and Eftgan's blood also becomes the land while they in turn also become the Goddess speaking back to the land and to Herself, the commingling of bodies that accompanies communion with Her here extending to the national body. This motif continues in *The Door into Sunset* when Freelorn increasingly perceives a mystical connection between himself and the landscape of Arlen, leading to an understanding of kingship as "[t]he sense that your fleshly body and that earthy body were the same, and that earthy body and the Goddess's were the same: that you were Her lover [...] and the land's lover too" (*Sunset* 177–78). What seems to materialize here is a form of erotic religious nationalism, where erotic desire and religious devotion translate into erotic fidelity to the nation-state.

This sense of religious homonationalism becomes more disquieting when it is directed against the othered race of the Ladha, who are more commonly referred to as “Reavers” throughout the series. The Ladha are first properly introduced in *The Door into Shadow* as a faceless horde enlisted by the Shadow to pillage the lands of the Middle Kingdoms. They are a curious construction of the text in that, while they do not map cleanly onto Ebony Elizabeth Thomas’s theorization of the “Dark Other,” the racialized monster inhabiting the margins of western fantasy (19), they share some points of commonality. Descriptions of them tend to foreground their difference and their seeming primitivism; they are a nomadic, tribal people whose “language was utterly different from any spoken in the Kingdoms” (*Shadow* 132), and who “wore no trews or breeches, but [a] strange long undivided shin-length garment,” wielding “crude curved swords in rude sheaths” (86). These would seem to hearken to a racialized evocation of non-western cultures in contrast to the Middle Kingdoms’ medieval European-inflected one, similar to the depictions of barbarian cultures that Helen Young critiques in Robert E. Howard’s *Conan* series (see Young 26–28), yet *The Door into Sunset* conspicuously takes pains to describe their “fair hair” (*Sunset* 87) and “pale” faces (90).⁵ They are objects of fear and loathing, initially appearing as a threat to the stability of the Middle Kingdoms’ queer utopia; we are told that “[h]istorically, there had never been much use in talking to Reavers” and that their constant raids on the farms and wheat fields of the Kingdoms mean that “[i]t was rare to know anyone from the south [...] who did not hate them with the same resigned and impersonal hatred one usually resigned for plague or root-wilt” (86–87).

Following the racial counter-reading strategy proposed by Thomas, “[reading] literary and cultural texts from the perspective of the monster” (22), we may ask how the Reavers figure into the sacred banquet of the Goddess, whether the goods She proffers also extend to these strangers at the gates and whether the secondary world of the texts can in turn recognize the Goddess’s grace within and among them fully, and not just fleetingly. The series’ move to rehabilitate these characters beginning in *The Door into Sunset* prolongs rather than resolves these questions. A diplomatic meeting with a Ladha chieftain

⁵ On this point, however, it bears mentioning that, as Young states, “[w]hiteness [...] is not just the state of bodily being dependent on phenotypical features, but also encompasses culture” (10). Likewise, Puar conceives of racialization “as a figure for specific social formations and processes that are not necessarily or only tied to what has been historically theorized as ‘race’” (xii). Thus, the Ladha can still be read as racialized figures even as their phenotypical descriptions would seem to distance them from Thomas’s conception of Dark Otherness.

reveals to Freelorn that the Ladha raids were due to hunger; he demands of Freelorn,

what gives you right to keep all the good for yourselves, to shut us out for ever? Our beasts have little, our children die; here the grass is green and the sun is warm, so why must we die and you live? (*Sunset* 92)

That the Ladha are kept in poverty and starvation while, in the rest of the series, expressions of the Goddess's love abound with images of consumption in abundance and plenty is conspicuous. While this encounter does result in Freelorn granting the Ladha a more fertile plot of land within Arlen's borders to settle, this is done only in exchange for their tacit support of his bid for the Arlene crown. The text does not linger on this exchange much further, and when it does come up, it is in terms that preserve the presumed innocence of the Kingdoms, their rulers, and their inhabitants. When a party of Ladha turn up to the royal wedding at the novel's conclusion, Freelorn chalks up their past cultural and racial animosities to the fact that "we didn't know any better" (378).

Such a pat dismissal of past injustices, coupled with the fact that this new arrangement positions Arlen as the paternalistic benefactor instructing the primitive Ladha in proper agricultural techniques, preserves hierarchies of power between the two cultures. In this way it echoes the self-congratulatory message of inclusion that Tonstad identifies within many nonhomophobic liberal Christian institutions, one that does not humble itself before the grace of God as the stranger at the gates but instead seeks "to be left as the good in our (own) goodness, as those mediating the goods we already enjoy to those we identify as others" (270). With *The Librarian* promising to center around Freelorn embarking on a quest with a Ladha ally, the full story of the Middle Kingdoms' relationship with the Ladha is yet to be told. Yet the one that already exists tells of a queer theological community unwilling or unable to part with a sense of its own supremacy and privileged access to the divine, or with the national bodies that regulate that access.

CONCLUSIONS

In speaking to the queer potentiality latent within all fantasy, Jes Battis acknowledges that fantasy "can also merely recapitulate homophobic and patriarchal tenets" (261). Yet grappling with queer fantasy's capacity to reproduce homonationalist conceptions of queerness forces us to contend with the further possibility that any given text—much like any given queerness—may contain a mixture of radical and reactionary elements that demand to be read in the context of each other. *The Tale of the Five* articulates a eucharistic theology that radically re-maps the relationship between the goods of queer

sexual pleasure, divine communion, and the sharing of food and drink. In this imaginary, divine, human, and nonhuman bodies coincide with each other in a loving coinhabitation at the threshold of religious observance and everyday life that leaves all fulfilled beyond imagining. Yet the fluidity of bodily and identitarian borders suggested by this figuration fails to translate into a dissolution of national, cultural, and racial ones. Instead, both social status and national superiority are essentialized via, ironically, the same fantastical devices through which the series' queer religious imaginary is conceived. Read from the perspective of queer Christian theology, this homonationalist fantasy suggests the danger of queer expressions of Christianity that do not sufficiently unsettle the self-identity of the church and the histories of white Christian supremacy, colonialism, empire, and class oppression with which both the church and theological conceptions of gender and sexuality are unavoidably bound up.

By contrast, Tonstad argues for a queer theology in which "[t]he failure, rather than the success, of the church is the means of its symbolic pointing toward the body of Christ that lies outside the walls in whomever the church understands at its others" (271). That the theology of the Middle Kingdoms occupies a space of bodily chaos that can break primary-world codes of gender, desire, and identity, but not those of monarchy and nation, indicates that fantasy's queer theological potential exists in fraught relation to what Young has identified as the "habits of Whiteness" and troubled histories of racialization in the genre (Young 10). With this in mind, queer theologians may approach fantasy both as an object of critique and as the grounds on which to continue to seek to tell a different story about Christianity: one in which the distribution of the goods of the body of Christ is not the sole domain of kings and nobles; in which the church bears witness to its failure and humbles itself in the face of its others; in which stewardship of the goods of creation is articulated in terms other than blood and soil.

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TAYLOR DRIGGERS holds a PhD in English Literature from the University of Glasgow. He is an independent scholar currently researching how fantasy characters model reading and archiving practices that can inform queer history-making and kinship-building in our world. Taylor is the recipient of a 2024 Le Guin Feminist Science Fiction Fellowship, and his debut monograph, *Queering Faith in Fantasy Literature* (Bloomsbury Academic, 2022), was a finalist for the 2023 Mythopoeic Scholarship Award in Myth and Fantasy Studies.



PANDEMIC MYTHMAKING: COVID-19 AND MYTHOLOGICAL SYMBOLISM IN INDIAN FOLK ART

ISHANI ANWESHA JOSHI AND
SATHYARAJ VENKATESAN

INTRODUCTION

The use of mythology in art dates back to ancient civilizations, where myths served as cultural reservoirs that preserved collective beliefs, values, and archetypes. In the context of COVID-19, artists have drawn upon these mythological traditions and archetypes to tackle multifaceted issues arising from the pandemic. Ancient myths that resonate with contemporary circumstances and express societal anxieties and resilience during the COVID-19 pandemic contribute “to the collective grand narrative on contagion” (Venkatesan). The archetypes embedded in mythologies offer a universal language that transcends specific cultural contexts, which allows artists to evoke deep-seated—and often subconscious—connections with their audience. By employing universal themes in mythological stories, artists tap into the collective unconscious to craft narratives that speak to the common humanity within us all.

Incorporating folk art traditions, with their deeply rooted cultural symbols and narratives, within the corpus of COVID art enriches the visual language of the pandemic by lending the themes a renewed depth and significance while also placing such artistic creations on a broader civilizational canvas. COVID folk art forms a part of the larger corpus of ResiliArt, a term borrowed from a “UNESCO initiative of the same name which addresses the concerns of artists and arts organizations impacted by the pandemic” (The Marg Foundation). Through a comprehensive analysis of Durga Bai Vyam’s “*Samura Manthan*” and Rupsona and Bahadur Chitrakar’s “*Corona Rakshasa*,” this article aims to investigate how Indian mythological stories in folk art have fused with pandemic-related themes to create a new visual register during COVID-19 pandemic. By analyzing the interplay of mythological motifs and contemporary themes, the article attempts to unravel the levels of meaning, symbolism, and emotion that these artists have introduced in their works.

Simultaneously, by infusing folk art with modern themes, folk artists have created a vernacular modernism by blending the traditional and the modern, hence, reflecting distinctive regional identities while engaging with global modernity. A term borrowed from an edited volume on architecture

titled “Vernacular Modernism: Heimat, Globalization, and the Built Environment,” vernacular modernism advocates that modern architecture, instead of eradicating local traditions and styles, integrates them into its design and creates a unique amalgamation of the regional and the global (Umbach and Hüppauf). The essence of such a juxtaposition is seen in various disciplines, and in the context of this article, in folk art such as Vyam’s “*Samudra Manthan*” (2021) and Rupsona and Bahadur Chitrakar’s “*Corona Rakshasa*” (2021). Incorporating folk art traditions, with their deeply rooted cultural symbols and narratives, within the corpus of COVID art enriches the visual language of the pandemic, lending the themes a renewed sense of depth and significance. In doing so, contemporary events acquire fresh forms of expression, while folk art is revitalized, becoming more relevant and attuned to the present.

INDIAN FOLK ART DURING THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC

Folk art refers to visual arts made in the context of folk culture, which refers to “products and practices of relatively homogeneous and isolated small-scale social groups living in rural locations” often associated with “tradition, historical continuity, sense of place, and belonging” (Revill). By this definition, folk art encompasses a wide range of creative expressions, including folk painting, sculpture, music, dance, and more. Unlike traditional painting and academic art, typically taught in formal art schools and dedicated university departments worldwide, folk art is primarily learned through apprenticeships with local folk artists, who may or may not hold a mainstream art degree. Rooted in tradition, historical continuity, sense of place, and cultural practices of communities, folk art is often passed down through generations and reflect the values and identities of the people practicing it. Employing natural materials such as wood, straw, clay, and others, folk art utilizes traditional art forms and motifs to depict stories and characters ranging from mythological gods and heroes to nature, and in recent times, even the modern lifestyle.

India has several folk art traditions, especially folk painting traditions, that are unique to specific regions of the country. For instance, *Madhubani* paintings (also known as *Mithila* paintings), named after the eponymous village in Bihar and traditionally used to decorate walls, floors, and furniture, is characterized by bright colors, horizontal and vertical sectioning, geometric patterns, little to no blank space, two-dimensional images, and stylized (at times distorted and abstract) figures. In contrast, *Warli* painting, originating from the *Warli* tribe, an *Adivasi* (tribal) community in Maharashtra, uses simple geometric shapes, stick figures, and a limited color palette (generally black and white) to depict day-to-day life and nature. *Cheria Scroll* painting, a stylized form of *Nakashi* art from Telangana, was used by wandering storytellers to predominantly narrate stories from mythology and folk culture. Similarly, *Phad*

painting from Rajasthan consists of large-scale artworks, typically ranging from twenty to thirty feet, painted on handwoven, coarse cotton cloth. These paintings feature figures with prominent, almond-shaped eyes facing each other, rendered in a flat, stylized manner, and are framed by intricate borders, often depicting mythological narratives or stories of local deities. Other notable folk painting traditions in India include *Sanjhi art* (Uttarakhand), Tanjore painting (Tamil Nadu), and Bhil painting (Madhya Pradesh). Many of these folk-art traditions, like the *Warli* and *Cheria Scroll*, have been recognized as a region-specific cultural treasure through the Geographical Indication (GI) tag.

In India, where much of the rural and tribal social structure is steeped in practices passed down through generations via folk wisdom, folk art assumes a pivotal role in disseminating information about COVID-19 and shaping desired behavioral responses. From “building social awareness to humorous interpretations,” artists from nearly every major folk tradition in India “have come up with their own view of the pandemic and its protocols” (Gangopadhyay). For instance, combining the aesthetics of *Warli* paintings with the theme of COVID-19, Amit Dhombare painted *Corona ek Vishva Mahamari* (Corona, a global pandemic), Ramesh Hegadi painted *Save the World from Corona*, Anil Chaitya Vangad created *Life in Covid-19*, and Sanjay Parhad painted *Corona 2020*. Om Prakash Dhurve’s *Total Lockdown* and Choti Tekam’s *Social Distancing in Covid* in the *Gond* (a prominent tribal community) art tradition are a few other COVID-related folk paintings. Furthermore, D. Vinay Nakas used the *Cheria Scroll* folk art style to illustrate *Stories of Covid-19*. Prakash Joshi, in his *Phad* painting *Humanity to Community*, illustrates masked people maintaining social distancing and going about daily activities, such as buying groceries, feeding livestock, and receiving COVID aid while wild animals such as deer roam freely in the forest in the absence of human beings. Similarly, *Madhubani* artist Pushpa Kumari’s *Covid Bride* illustrates a bride getting married even as an airplane zips “across the paper, representing people travelling and transmitting the virus, and a series of trains” ferry “migrant workers home, at the bottom of the work” (Bhuyan).

Apindra Swain, from Odisha’s famous artists’ village Raghurajpur, drew *Pattachitra* paintings, such as the *Covid Code of Conduct*. Unlike their counterparts in Odisha, *Pattachitra* artists in West Bengal (called *Patuas*) such as Sonia Chitrakar and her father “created a scroll song on safety norms that prompted the state government to ask them to travel from village to village, showcasing their *Pattachitra* and song to create awareness” (Bhuyan). Similarly, Swarna Chitrakar, Gurupada Chitrakar, Yakub Chitrakar, Jaba Chitrakar, Khaleda Chitrakar, and Rani Chitrakar, among others, have composed songs and *Pattachitra* paintings on COVID-19 and shared the videos online on the Youtube channel *The Scrollpainters of Naya, Pingla*.

DURGA BAI VYAM'S "SAMUDRA MANTHAN"

"*Samudra Manthan*" (2021) is a *Gond* painting by Durga Bai Vyam, one of the leading artists working in the *Pardhan-Gond* tradition of tribal art. "*Samudra Manthan*," loosely translated as 'the churning of the ocean,' engages with motifs drawn from the Indian myth of *Samudra Manthan* to construct a complex intertextual framework that establishes parallels with the realities of the COVID-19 pandemic, simultaneously serving as an allegorical commentary on the necessity of precautionary measures and broader discourses on environmental degradation and ecological harmony. Vyam's painting appears in the 2021 pictorial diary (titled *Indian Art Traditions in Transition*) published by the Marg Foundation for the Indian multinational conglomerate, The Tata Group. Drawing inspiration from the art practiced in her native village of Burbaspur in Madhya Pradesh (India), Bhopal-based Durga Bai Vyam captures the essence of her indigenous heritage in her art. Vyam has contributed to several books, including *The Night Life of Trees* (2006), *One, Two, Tree!* (2003), *Sultana's Dream* (2005), and *Bhimayana: Experiences of Untouchability* (2011). For preserving indigenous cultural heritage and her contributions to sustain and popularize *Gond* art, Durga Bai Vyam was awarded the Padma Shri, India's fourth-highest civilian honor, in 2022.

Traditionally, *Gond* (derived from *Kond*, meaning 'green mountain') art is associated with the *Gond* tribal community of India. *Gond* art presents a range of goddesses, rivers, trees, a variety of animals (tigers, deer, peacocks, fish, garden lizards), fantastical creatures (such as Anand Singh Shyam's cat with four grinning heads), tribal gods (with abstract and at times grotesque forms) and occasionally mainstream Hindu gods in bright colors. Apart from nature (especially trees), *Gond* art heavily draws on stories and symbolism from Hindu mythology and folk tales. Though *Gond* paintings are two-dimensional with no horizon and depth, the patterns impart the "illusion of texture and movement in figures that are rendered flat" (Chatterji 111). Initially drawn on mud, stone walls, and courtyards of homes, *Gond* art later gained popularity through Jangarh Singh Shyam, who first drew *Gond* art on canvas and paper, thereby paving the way for its internationalization as a distinct art form. Each artist uses their own distinctive pattern like pointillist dots, fine dashes, semicircles, and minute waves, among others, which becomes their "unique signature" style ("*Indian*" 3:39). Therefore, even if two artists draw the same figure, the art would be different based on the kinds of pattern they choose to work with. Such preoccupation with individual style and pattern, however, is not organic as it rarely grows out of creativity; as *Gond* artist Anand Singh Shyam highlights, "At first Narmada Prasad and I both did *bindi* (dot) work like Jangarh, but when we saw that his work was selling and ours was not we decided to change our style" (Chatterji 1). They began "using different kinds of lines instead," since city

visitors to their exhibitions made them self-conscious about style, leading every *Gond* painter to now choose a distinctive pattern as their signature (1). Vyam's painting exhibits a hybrid pattern characterized by an intricate interplay of elongated lines, short dashes, and parabola-like motifs, creating a dynamic and textured visual composition.

Vyam's painting deftly reimagines the churning of the primordial ocean as a metaphorical representation of the global crisis engendered by the COVID-19 pandemic. Though various versions of *Samudra Manthan* can be found in Indian epics such as the *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana*, and scripture such as *Kurma Purana*, *Bhagavata Purana*, and *Brahma Purana* among others, the myth is popularly associated with the *Vishnu Purana*. *Puranas* (meaning 'ancient' or 'old') are the Hindu scriptures containing encyclopedic information about the universe's origin, mythology, genealogy and exploits of gods, goddesses and kings, astronomy, geography, and religious sites among others. Similarly, the Hindu *Mahapuranas* (meaning 'greater *Puranas*') are influential religious texts that transmit knowledge through various anecdotal stories. One of the eighteen *Mahapuranas*, *Vishnu Puran* centers around the stories involving one of the key deities in Hinduism, known as the preserver of the world, *Lord Vishnu*, and his various *avatars* (incarnations). Containing 126 chapters and 23,000 verses in Sanskrit (ancient Indian language), *Vishnu Purana* is one *Mahapurana* that has survived the test of time and has been preserved and widely translated into English, German, and other regional Indian languages.

According to the original narrative, the churning of the milk ocean (mythical ocean in Hindu mythology) was facilitated by *Lord Vishnu* in his *Kurma* (tortoise) incarnation. In post-Vedic literature, the *Kurma avatar* is the second incarnation—among the *Dasavatara* (ten incarnation)—of *Lord Vishnu*, who appears to stabilize a sinking *Mandara* mountain. Using *Mount Mandara* as the churning rod and *Vasuki* (King of Serpents) as the churning rope, the *Devas* (celestial beings) on one side and the *Asuras* (demons) on the other, churned the ocean for the divine nectar of immortality, *Amrita*. The churning revealed various celestial treasures (varying from nine to fourteen in different versions of the text), such as the *Goddess Lakshmi* (the divine consort of *Lord Vishnu*), *Kamadhenu* (the wish-fulfilling cow), *Apsaras* (divine women), the deadly poison *Halahala* (which *Lord Shiva* heroically consumed to safeguard the cosmos), *Chandra* (the moon), *Varuni* (the goddess of wine), *Parijata* (night-flowering jasmine plant), gems such as the *Kausthubha* (worn on the chest of *Lord Vishnu*) and *Chintamani* (wish-fulfilling gem), and finally *Amrita*.

Drawn on paper using acrylic colors, Vyam's "*Samudra Manthan*" depicts a long serpent coiled around the figure of a woman at the center of the painting. Vyam's striking portrayal serves as a poignant reminder of the fragile balance of life and the global interconnectedness, especially, between human

health and the natural world. Humans and animals are seen simultaneously holding onto the head and the tail end of the snake, much like the *Asuras* and *Devas* in the original mythic story of the *Samudra Manthan*. Through her vivid imagery, she depicts human figures grasping the head of the snake—symbolizing the *Asuras* or demons—while various animals gather near its tail, representing the *Devas* or celestial beings. This powerful juxtaposition highlights the enduring tension between chaos and harmony in the shared ecosystems that sustain us. In depicting humans as a metaphorical equivalent of demons, Vyam holds humans responsible for ecological disbalance, pollution, and environmental degradation and urges them to work with (and not against) other organisms surrounding them. Indian mythologist Devdutt Pattanaik highlights the unique nature of the *Samudra Manthan* episode in Hindu mythology, where *Devas* and *Asuras* harmoniously unite to accomplish a shared objective. Unlike a competitive game of tug of war that focuses on strength and rivalry, churning requires a meticulously orchestrated collaboration, wherein one group pulls while the other releases (“Symbolism” 2:00–2:41).

Such a well-choreographed collaboration highlights the posthuman interdependence between humans, animals, microbes, and the environment, challenging anthropocentrism by positioning humans as one actor in the broader ecological network. Posthumanism is a “mode of thinking about the intersecting human, nonhuman, and technological worlds that has gained theoretical currency in the late twentieth and twenty-first centuries, especially in the wake of ecological consciousness and environmental campaigns that call into question the role of humans in shaping the fate of the Earth” (Nayar). The COVID-19 pandemic served as a stark reminder that even an invisible virus like SARS-CoV-2 can deeply impact global human existence. Following the pandemic, there has been a renewed emphasis on traditional modes of living that aim to strike a balance between human needs and the well-being of other living beings and the environment. The posthuman perspective aligns with the ethos of *Gond* folk art, which Vyam uses to reaffirm human being’s interconnectedness with the natural world and the importance of universal well-being. Hence, in simultaneously depicting animals and humans working together, Vyam establishes the fundamental relationality and entanglement of all living beings in our interconnected ecosystem.

Vyam is proficient in the motifs that characterize the *Gond* art form, such as “the undulating trees, the striking plumage of birds and the delicate features of forest animals” (Shankar). Concurrently, Vyam elevates these motifs beyond mere representations of mythic or folk tales by imbuing them with metaphorical significance. For instance, Vyam superimposes the figure of a salwar-clad (long, loose-fitting tunic and trousers worn in India) woman on the outline of a tree with spread roots and branches to signify mother nature on

whose branches reside human beings. Vyam interestingly depicts houses (with people inside them) hanging from the branches of this woman-tree, signifying that we are only a single leaf, fruit, and flower of a tree representative of nature. In so doing, the artist deliberately conjures a vision of our interconnected, networked existence in a well-painted tapestry as delineated in the painting. Though humans are not the central focus in Vyam's painting, the visual underscores the idea that every individual is an integral part of a larger ecosystem, sustaining diverse life forms and that individuals have the social responsibility to adhere to pandemic guidelines.

On the extreme top left corner of the painting, Vyam depicts a man drinking from a blue-colored leaf. This striking image reminds one of *Lord Shiva* drinking the poison *Halahal* (one of the 14 treasures of *Samudra Manthan*), which turns his neck blue. As a metaphor, this image is representative of all the negative consequences of the pandemic, such as contracting the disease, death, deteriorating mental health, stress, and anxiety, among others. Similarly, in the extreme top right corner of the painting, Vyam depicts a man beating a metal instrument with a stick. This image refers to a common practice in India during COVID, when people used to come out to the balconies of their houses and beat utensils, clap, and blow conch shells to thank the front-line workers, especially doctors, for their service to the community. The painting also features a pot representative of the *Amrit Kalash* (pot containing the nectar of immortality), on top of which is a lit clay lamp. Both the pot and the lit lamp are positive symbols that tie in with the image of individuals staying at home to convey how adhering to COVID-19 precautions can help combat the pandemic successfully. By leveraging the emotive power of folk art, Vyam skillfully conveys hope, resilience, and unity, encouraging viewers to confront the challenges of the COVID era with renewed strength and solidarity. Ultimately, "*Samudra Manthan*" is a poignant testament to the enduring capacity of art to transcend time, culture, and circumstance to offer solace and inspiration in the face of adversity.

"CORONA RAKSHASA": DRAWING MALEVOLENCE

Rupsona and Bahadur Chitrakar's "*Corona Rakshasa*" (2021) is a *Pattachitra* painting from the Indian state of West Bengal, published in the *Indian Art Traditions in Transition*. By invoking the imagery of a *Rakshasa*, a Sanskrit word denoting a malevolent demon in Indian mythology, folklore, and religious traditions, the artists underscore the sinister and menacing nature of SARS-CoV-2 that transcends geographical boundaries. Belonging to a lineage of *Patuas*, traveling storytellers who used scroll paintings to narrate (and sing) mythological tales, Rupsona and Bahadur Chitrakar are a daughter-father artist duo from the *Naya* village of *Pingala* block in west *Medinipur* district of West

Bengal. Starting painting at the age of six, Rupsona Chitrakar learned the *Pattachitra* from her father and grandmother and has since exhibited her paintings on various national and international platforms. In terms of form, “*Corona Rakshasa*” embodies the distinctive stylistic features of *Pattachitra* painting, including elongated and slightly hooded eyes, delicate brush strokes, colorful composition, and aesthetically refined figures. The depiction of the Corona demon, the dragon, and the human characters all exhibit the characteristic slender and elongated forms associated with this traditional art style.

A combination of the Sanskrit word *patta* (woven) and *chitra* (art), *Pattachitra* is a folk art form from Odisha and West Bengal and is distinguished by its intricate mythological narratives painted on cloth, dried palm leaves, and in later times, canvas, featuring detailed borders, bright colors, sharp details, and lacquer coated surfaces. While the *Pattachitra* tradition in Odisha remains primarily focused on visual art, its counterpart in West Bengal, particularly within the *Patua* tradition, integrates both music and painting as part of its performative tradition. The scroll format of *Pattachitra* enables the vertical depiction of sequential images, a structural feature that “allows for a succession of frames,” thereby “expand[ing] the spatial field of the pictorial narrative” (Chatterji 215). The act of “rolling and unrolling the painted scroll” to reveal one frame at a time further introduces the “suggestion of movement and temporal depth” (215). Typically ranging from 10 to 20 feet in length, *Pattachitra* scrolls are “lined with fabric on the back to give them their characteristic rolled shape and make them more comfortable to carry and preserve” (Zanatta and Roy 61). Traditionally, *Pattachitra* scrolls were not intended for commercial sale; instead, they were repeatedly used by artists in various storytelling performances. However, with the advent of new forms of entertainment and the gradual decline of the traveling storyteller tradition, *Pattachitra* paintings have increasingly been commodified.

Rupsona and Bahadur Chitrakar’s “*Corona Rakshasa*” visually articulates the pervasive impact of the SARS-CoV-2 virus by representing the pandemic at its most fundamental, viral level, emphasizing its global spread and catastrophic consequences. Set against a striking yellow background, the painting features a red-hued demon with horns and elongated nails alongside a dragon-like figure that encircles the Earth, which is nestled within its coiled body. Two human figures are positioned at the bottom left and right corners, further grounding the composition in a human-centric perspective. Notably, the *Corona Rakshasa* is composed of numerous individual virus cells, a motif that extends to the similarly red-colored dragon above it. This visual representation evokes the myth of *Raktabija*, a demon from Hindu mythology whose spilled blood generates endless clones of himself, thereby symbolizing the virus’s

widespread proliferation and ability to self-replicate, underscoring the insidious nature of the pandemic.

The myth of *Raktabīja*, derived from the Sanskrit words *rakta* (blood) and *bīja* (seed), narrates the rise and fall of a formidable demon of the same name who, through a boon granted by *Lord Shiva*, acquired the ability to generate identical replicas of himself, equal in form and strength, whenever a drop of his blood touched the ground. *Raktabīja*'s myth is part of *Devi Mahatmya* or *Devi Mahatmyam*, a seminal text within the *Mārkaṇḍeya Purāṇa* that contains the oldest myths regarding female deities who are depicted as powerful (and even wrathful) gods. Though *Lord Shiva*'s boon renders *Raktabīja* nearly invincible, *Goddess Kali* (Goddess of death and destruction), acting at the behest of *Goddess Durga* (a major Hindu goddess), consumed every drop of his blood directly from his body and his innumerable clones on the battlefield, thereby ensuring his ultimate demise. However, such relentless violence plunged *Goddess Kali* into an uncontrollable frenzy of destruction, setting her off a rampage that halted only when she stepped on *Lord Shiva* (her husband), awakening from her bloodlust and, in a moment of realization, biting her tongue, an image central to her iconography.

By depicting the *Corona Rakshasa* in the likeness of *Raktabīja*, the painting underscores the inherent challenges of containing the COVID-19 pandemic at its source, as the SARS-CoV-2 virus replicated at exponential spread and continuous mutations lead to the emergence of multiple variants in the later stages of the pandemic. At the viral level, there existed no definitive means to halt its spread, leaving individuals reliant on precautionary measures that, while necessary, remained only partially effective due to the airborne and invisible nature of the virus. This characteristic rendered accidental transmission highly plausible, reinforcing the perception of the virus as an almost invincible force. However, much like the mythological defeat of *Raktabīja* by *Goddess Kali*, the eventual development and distribution of vaccines such as Moderna, AstraZeneca, and Covishield played a crucial role in mitigating the virus's impact. These vaccines effectively transformed the SARS-CoV-2 virus from an existential threat into a largely manageable health concern.

The imagery of the dragon in the painting holds significant symbolic weight, as it represents China, where the SARS-CoV-2 virus is widely believed to have originated. The dragon, depicted in red to mirror the corona demon, is composed of countless viral particles, signifying the initial proliferation of the virus within China before it spread globally. This interpretation is further reinforced by the multi-colored globe resting on the curve of the dragon's body, visually suggesting the virus's global reach and capacity to traverse borders. The two figures in the lower part of the painting represent the global population observing the unfolding of the COVID-19 pandemic. Additionally, the pervasive

nature of the virus is emphasized through the border of the painting, which is populated by various stylized anthropomorphic depictions of the virus, further reinforcing its omnipresence and global impact. The repetition of these individualized viral faces across the painting's borders suggests a sense of inescapability, emphasizing the virus's ability to multiply, mutate, and persist despite human efforts to contain it.

Notably, the virus in the painting is represented through two distinct visual strategies: first, as minute circular particles dispersed across the body of the dragon and certain parts of the *Corona Rakshasa*, and second, as anthropomorphized, individualized faces integrated into the body of the corona demon. In the first instance, the depiction of the virus as tiny particles in the painting aligns with its biological reality as a microscopic pathogen, emphasizing its omnipresence thereby reinforcing its near-imperceptibility, uncontrollable spread, and capacity to embed itself within hosts in ways that challenge human perception and control. In the second instance, the anthropomorphized face transforms an invisible pathogen into a recognizable, almost mythical antagonist and evokes the longstanding human tendency to attribute agency and malevolence to diseases. In conclusion, by employing both microscopic realism and mythic personification, the painting bridges scientific understanding and cultural imagination, underscoring the idea that the COVID-19 pandemic is not just a biological and virological phenomenon but also a collective socio-cultural experience.

CODA

Artists infuse mythological elements into pandemic-themed works to bridge temporal and cultural gaps and tap into a collective reservoir of shared emotions and experiences. Since mythologies are not just stories that entertain but also metaphors that encompass age-old wisdom, values, and philosophies, artists all over the world deployed different mediums of representation (such as cartoons, comics, and folk art) and repurposed mythological stories to illustrate COVID-related issues. Through mythological retellings, artists can contextualize these emotions, drawing parallels between ancient tales of chaos, disease, and heroism with the current pandemic's challenges. Vyam ingeniously weaves the mythical tale of the *Samudra Manthan* into her artistic narrative, utilizing its allegorical power to advocate for the adoption of COVID precautionary measures. Moreover, Vyam criticizes the current neo-capitalist societal framework that prioritizes human interests to the detriment of other species and advocates for a more sustainable way of life that acknowledges and accommodates a networked and relational existence. Similarly, Rupsona and Bahadur Chitrakar's "*Corona Rakshasa*" draws on the Indian myth of *Raktabija* and uses the motif of a demon to frame the SARS-CoV-2 virus not merely as a

biological entity but as an active, threatening, and malevolent entity. Furthermore, the *pattachitra* painting highlights the all-pervasive nature of the SARS-CoV-2 virus and alludes to the difficulty in containing and managing the viral spread. Put together, the utilization of mythological elements in both these paintings has enabled a richer exploration of the pandemic's impact, transcending geographical boundaries to establish a universal connection with the audience.

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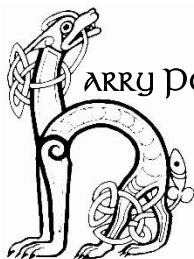
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ISHANI ANWESHA JOSHI is a research scholar in the Department of Humanities and Social Sciences at the National Institute of Technology, Tiruchirappalli, India. She specializes in Graphic Medicine, Health Humanities, Pandemic Studies, and Comic Studies. Her research articles have been published in various indexed journals such as *Medical Humanities*, *Visual Studies*, *Perspectives in Biology and Medicine*, *Journal of Medical Humanities*, and *Journal of Graphic Novels and Comics* among others. Her forthcoming co-authored monograph, *Drawing the Pandemic: COVID-19 and Graphic Medicine*, is under contract with Palgrave Macmillan and is scheduled for publication in 2025.

DR. SATHYARAJ VENKATESAN is a Professor of English at the Department of Humanities and Social Sciences in National Institute of Technology, Tiruchirappalli (India). His research concentrates on graphic medicine, literary health humanities and American literature. He is the author of nine books and over hundred research articles. His recent co-authored/co-edited books are *India Retold* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2021) and *Pandemics and Epidemics in Cultural Representation* (Singapore: Springer, 2022).





HARRY POTTER AND THE GOBLET OF BEOWULF: ROWLING'S BEOWULFIAN ALLUSIONS, ANALOGUES, AND INVERSIONS

MARK-ELLIOT FINLEY

HE MUST PERFORM THREE TASKS, including battling a dragon, diving into hellish water, and fighting against a primordial evil figure in single combat. He is mythic but has character flaws. If this description were given to Generation Z or Millennial fantasy literature fans, they might assume this sketch belongs to “The Boy Who Lived”—Harry Potter—and specifically his three tasks in the Triwizard Tournament within J.K. Rowling’s *Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire*. However, if an Old English scholar were given this character description, Beowulf, King of the Geats, might come to mind.

In this essay, I suggest Rowling’s *Goblet of Fire* literarily echoes the Old English¹ epic poem *Beowulf*, while simultaneously updating the medieval epic to reflect the novel’s place within the modernized, Christian-influenced fantasy tradition. While Laurie Beckoff, in her blog on MuggleNet.com, links Beowulf’s swimming contest (lines 499–581) with Harry’s second task—the lake challenge—this essay engages in a sustained dialogue between *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire*. Both heroes engage in one-to-one combat (Beowulf with Grendel and Harry with Voldemort), venture into an unknown watery abyss (Beowulf diving into Grendel’s mother’s underwater cave and Harry rescuing Ron and Gabrielle from the merpeople in Hogwarts’s Lake), and fight a dragon (Beowulf’s final fight and Harry’s fight with the Hungarian Horntail). I argue

¹ I use the term “Old English” rather than “Anglo-Saxon” due to recent critical discussions surrounding the latter term and its racial undertones. David Wilton notes “the term [Anglo-Saxon] is an identity label associated with whiteness and is often the self-identification preferred by white supremacists” (425). Substitutes for “Anglo-Saxon” include, as Wilton notes, “Old English” or “early medieval English,” with use of the latter phrase commonly used “when one wants to blur the silos of periodization between Old and Middle English” (453). “Early English,” while a possible substitute, poses issues due to the “vagueness” of the term: “Not only is it already a term for the Gothic architectural style of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, it risks confusion with ‘early modern English,’ and there is no general agreement on what its chronological boundaries are, it being used to encompass anything prior to 1800” (453). For more on the term “Anglo-Saxon,” its linguistic history, racial undercurrents, and problematic usage within pre-Conquest/medieval studies, see Wilton.

Goblet of Fire, if read in parallel with *Beowulf*, presents us with mirrors and inversions of the Beowulfian duel sequence, highlighting thematic and characterological analogues between Harry and Beowulf. The fourth *Potter* novel, whether consciously or otherwise, reflects symbolic elements from the Old English epic poem, and such Beowulfian reflections allow us to further appreciate Rowling's unique themes, which sometimes align with and sometimes depart from the novel's Old English predecessor.

Beowulf and *Goblet of Fire* balance Christian and pagan elements² and have been read as hagiographies³ featuring a salvific redemptive epic hero⁴ casted within an archetypal mold,⁵ contributing to what Annie Hiebert Alton calls "a generic mosaic," as Rowling "fuses" genres together to "creat[e] something new" (159). I contend Rowling's "generic mosaic" can also incorporate allusions, or at least analogues, to the Old English epic, mapping Beowulf's challenges onto Harry's three tasks. This comparative reading progresses chronologically through Harry's three Triwizard challenges, illustrating how Harry's first task echoes Beowulf's third fight with the dragon and Beowulf's mere episode aligns with Harry's second task. Harry's final challenge, fighting the risen Lord Voldemort,⁶ borrows from the Grendel and dragon encounters, with Voldemort encapsulating Beowulf's first and third antagonists. While *Goblet of Fire's* instances of thematic and visual echoes from

² For more on scholarly reception to the Christian and pagan elements in *Beowulf* and *Harry Potter*, see the Appendix.

³ "[H]agiographies," writes Jordan Jones, "tell the stories of saints' lives and are written to edify readers or listeners. [...] [T]hey can focus on the death of the saint (these stories are called 'passions') or they can focus on the life of the saint (these stories are called 'vitae')" (2). For *Beowulf* as a hagiography, see Jones; for *Harry Potter*, see Hennequin.

⁴ For Beowulf as a redemptive salvific figure see Fisher 173, Taylor 233, Cabaniss 195–96, and McNamee 191. For readings refuting Beowulf as a Christian redemptive figure, see Finnegan 54 and Reynolds 28. Harry is also viewed as an epic hero, but not exclusively as a redemptive savior, even though he exemplifies salvific attributes. For treatments of Rowling's representation of heroism, see *Heroism in the Harry Potter Series*, edited by Katrin Berndt and Lena Steveker. For Harry's selfless actions, see Berman 48 and Rosser 240. For Harry's connection with Christian redemption and salvation, see Anatol xxiin4.

⁵ McNulty observes Rowling's "epic saga" pattern, as each novel can be traced onto Joseph Campbell's hero's journey (55), as does Boll (85). Pharr claims Rowling combines elements from the epic tradition and postmodern style into her heptalogy. Mills reads Harry as a Jungian archetypal child, a salvific figure facing the risk of death (7–8). Similarly, Helterman suggests we read Beowulf as a Jungian archetypal character (3).

⁶ Harry's third Triwizard Tournament task is the maze, consisting of Hagrid's Blast-Ended Skrewts (31.622, 625), a boggart (31.623), an anti-gravity enchanted mist (31.624), Victor Krum's Cruciatus Curse (31.626–27), and a riddling sphinx (31.628–30). However, Harry's true challenge is his duel with Voldemort.

Beowulf could be read as alluding⁷ to the epic, where I discuss Old English words or passages, such connections are at the most analogues.⁸ However, *Goblet of Fire* reflects yet transforms elements from *Beowulf* within its narrative, allowing us to further appreciate Rowling's piece as a work of mythopoetic literature.

THE DRAGON

Perhaps the dragons are the most obvious connections between *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire*. *Beowulf*'s dragon appears last in the epic's monster cycle, after waking up and realizing his treasure has been robbed. The dragon was "writhing with anger / When he saw the footprints of the prowler who had stolen [a cup] / Too close to his dreaming head" (lines 2288–90).⁹ Similarly, the Triwizard champions' first challenge is to get past their respective dragons and grab a golden egg (20.340–41). Lauren Berman claims Harry is comparable to mythic "dragon-slayers" who seek treasure guarded by an evil creature, like "Beowulf and the unnamed dragon he encounters in his final adventures" (61).¹⁰ Expanding on Berman's observation, I begin with connections between the dragon episodes, then examine shared thematic motifs present in *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire*, illustrating how *Goblet of Fire* uses the Beowulfian dragon episode for unique thematic ends.

In *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire*—understandably—anxiety pervades the heroes' encounter with their dragon. Hearing the dragon's destructive rampage upon his kingdom, *Beowulf*'s "mind was in turmoil, / unaccustomed anxiety and gloom / confused his brain" (lines 2331–33). The dragon's attacks present not only anxiety-ridden confusion for the old king, but also the threatening unknown. *Beowulf* conquered Grendel and his mother but never faced a foe as fierce as "the fire-dragon / [who] had rased the coastal region and reduced / forts

⁷ In Rowling's novel, all Beowulfian connections are at the most implicit allusions and at the least analogues. The text never explicitly mentions *Beowulf* or any Old English terms, but due to the sustained connections between *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire*, specific links, such as the matching tasks, can be termed allusions. I cannot, however, claim Rowling intentionally incorporated Beowulfian elements into her novel. However, this caveat does not preclude us from a fruitful comparative study between these works.

⁸ "[A]n analogue," writes Chris Baldick, "is another story or plot which is parallel or similar in some way to the story under discussion" (11). An analogue could be a literary echo, either intentional or unintentional, by the author.

⁹ Seamus Heaney's modern English *Beowulf* translation will be used, unless otherwise noted.

¹⁰ See Gibka 151–52 for similarities and differences between Rowling's dragons with the dragon in *Beowulf* and Smaug in Tolkien's *The Hobbit*. Gibka notes Rowling's dragons are not shown as greedy and do not want to guard the golden eggs, which is why they do not attack the surrounding area (151). Berman claims Rowling departs from the traditional, early medieval understandings of dragons as symbols of greed and sin, rather characterizing her dragons as not tied to either good or evil (45), but as neutral (54).

and earthworks to dust and ashes" (lines 2333–35). The dragon represents a new threat, Beowulf's last test of kingly courage. Likewise, Harry, having learned about the first task from Hagrid, is in "a state of nervousness so advanced that he wondered whether he mightn't just lose his head when they tried to lead him out to his dragon" (20.347). Harry, like Beowulf, learns about his opponent before the confrontation, but this prior knowledge yields to our heroes' anxiety. Harry thinks he might "lose his head" and Beowulf's "mind was in turmoil," demonstrating the dragons' effects on the heroes' mental states. Beowulf, having had combat experience ruling the Geats "well / For fifty winters" (lines 2208–09), "planned and plotted his revenge" against the dragon (line 2336).

By contrast, Harry feels completely unprepared for the dragon and the Triwizard Tournament on the whole. Whereas Beowulf had fifty years of ruling his kingdom to prepare for the dragon, Harry, a fourteen-year-old misfit, has only two months, near zero preparation time. While Harry has fought Voldemort and a basilisk in his first and second years, a full-grown dragon is a completely different challenge. Reading *Goblet of Fire* and *Beowulf* in parallel, we see how Harry's maturation process is contrasted and inverted with Beowulf's, demonstrating Harry's heroic intensification as he prepares for his fight with the dragon. However, regardless of the heroes' anxiety or how much preparation time they are afforded, both must face their gold-guarding dragons.

Beowulf's dragon dwelled amongst "a treasure-trove of astonishing richness" (line 2757), which showed "signs that someone had stumbled upon / the golden treasures" (lines 2301–02), causing the dragon to destroy the Geats' kingdom because a "gold-plated cup" was stolen (line 2282).¹¹ Likewise, Triwizard champions must take the golden egg which is guarded by their dragons (20.349). Each champion becomes a Beowulfian "prowler" stealing treasure from a brooding dragon (line 2289).¹² During their battles, Beowulf and Harry receive similar bodily injuries. Beowulf is caught "in a rush of flame and

¹¹ While outside the scope of this essay, in Rowling's seventh and final installment, *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows*, the trio break into Gringotts, requiring them to sneak past a dragon, which guards the vaults. Inside Bellatrix's vault, the friends steal one of Voldemort's horcruxes, "the cup that had belonged to Helga Hufflepuff, which had passed into the possession of Hepzibah Smith, from whom it had been stolen by Tom Riddle" (26.538). The sequence in *Deathly Hallows* provides a literary rhyme to the first task in *Goblet of Fire*, demonstrating possible Beowulfian influences throughout the series.

¹² In Rowling's text, the Hungarian Horntail does not escape the enclosure. But in the 2005 film adaptation, Harry, retrieving his Firebolt with a summoning charm, takes flight, causing the dragon to break from its chains and chase Harry around the school's grounds (1:00:20–1:02:44). While I am not claiming the filmmakers consciously pulled from the Old English epic, analogues also exist between *Beowulf*'s dragon raiding the Geats' kingdom and the Hungarian Horntail terrorizing the Hogwarts Castle in the film.

[the dragon] clamped sharp fangs / into his neck" (lines 2691–93). Similarly, the Hungarian Horntail injures Harry: its "tail came whipping up to meet him [...] and as he swerved to the left, one of the long spikes grazed his shoulder, ripping his robes—He could feel it stinging" (20.355). These observations invite deeper interrogation between these dragon episodes to uncover how *Goblet of Fire* shares and departs from Beowulfian themes. The first shared thematic motif exemplified in *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire* are the heroes' courage.

Beowulf's dragon duel underscores courage as an underlying thematic principle. Beowulf tells his retainers, "I shall win the gold / by my courage, or else mortal combat, / doom of battle, will bear your lord away" (lines 2535–37). If Beowulf's courage fails, he will meet "the doom of battle," accepting his death as a consequence for relinquishing courage. Rowling's fourth novel also structures the first task around the same virtue found in *Beowulf*. "The first task," says Barty Crouch, "is designed to test your daring, [...] so we are not going to be telling you what it is. Courage in the face of the unknown is an important quality in a wizard . . . very important" (17.281). While two champions are not surprised by the dragons (Harry and Cedric), courage is nevertheless required for the young wizards when facing the creatures. Similarly, Beowulf does not shy from danger; rather, the possibility of retrieving gold imbues his motivation with the kingly courage needed to face his final monster.

Arguably, Beowulf's courage leads to his pride. Beowulf states he "shall win the gold" (line 2535). Further, the poet claims Beowulf

was too proud
to line up with a large army
against the sky-plague. He had scant regard
for the dragon as a threat, no dread at all
of its courage or strength [...]. (lines 2345–49)

Some critics suggest Beowulf's pride must be purged during his dragon duel. Margaret E. Goldsmith claims Beowulf struggles with "the sins of the dragon" — pride—as he vaunts the claim that only he can win the dragon's treasure ("The Christian Theme" 95).¹³ Goldsmith posits Beowulf gave himself to the Christian God during prior battles (95), but in his final combat, the temptation of gold — possibly greed?—is symbolized in the dragon's hoard, alluding to Beowulf's pride (100). Beowulf must fight a literal dragon and the prideful dragon within.¹⁴

¹³ See Marshall 2–3 for other critics' readings of Beowulf's pride in connection with his desire for the dragon's gold.

¹⁴ Leyerle claims Beowulf becomes more prideful with each monster he defeats (101–02), but Baker notes Beowulf's action—risking his life for his kingdom—was not "irrational" as such defensive actions from Beowulf and his troops "must have exceeded the risk of

Pride tempts Harry, as well. Before his dragon fight, Harry must resist the pride coming with Gryffindor House “all treating him like some sort of hero” (18.288). The Goblet selected Harry, an inexperienced teen wizard, when Dumbledore’s Age Line supposedly prevented students under seventeen from competing. Harry, already “The Chosen One,” must constantly check his ego; as Hermione tells Harry, “it’s always you who gets all the attention[.] [...] [Y]ou’re really famous” (18.289–90). When Harry is selected as a Triwizard champion, Ron feels left out, and asks Harry how he did it, causing Harry to defend himself (17.286). Ron, Hermione observes, is “always shunted to one side whenever people see you [Harry], and he puts up with it, and he never mentions it, but I suppose this is just one time too many” (18.290). Thinking Harry lied to him, Ron becomes embittered, leading to a fight between the boys. Harry feels like “he could have coped with the rest of the school’s behavior if he could just have had Ron back as a friend” but he refuses to swallow his pride, deciding “he wasn’t going to try and persuade Ron to talk to him if Ron didn’t want to” (18.296), causing Harry to start “hat[ing] everything about Ron” (19.335). Harry’s stubbornness reveals his “streak of pride” (35.677).¹⁵ The first task pushes Harry to his limit, causing him to recognize his prideful tendencies: “it was time to shelve his pride and see if Cedric’s hint [taking a bath with the egg] was worth anything” (24.457). Harry’s pride is the dominating character flaw he battles against when coming to the dragon fight. Harry and Beowulf must face and rein in their pride, an attribute personified in their respective dragons.

Goblet of Fire, while borrowing the courage and pride themes from *Beowulf*, infuses original thematic elements into its Beowulfian dragon sequence. Harry grows in his confidence, interdependence, moral reasoning, and sense of fair play through his experience with the first Triwizard Task. Before facing the dragon, Harry, feeling utterly unprepared, speaks to Sirius through the Floo Network. Believing someone is trying to kill him through the Tournament, Harry states, “They’ll just have to stand back and let the dragons do their stuff” (19.334). Similarly, in the film adaptation, Harry exclaims to his godfather, “I’m

loss. We need to understand this aspect of the heroic economy” (218). For Baker, Beowulf acts according to traditional Old English kingly customs. And while Beowulf takes pride in being at the forefront of battles, standing as a fighting king until the last stroke (lines 2497–500), Baker acknowledges the Old English peoples did not critique this mindset (220).

¹⁵ Barty Crouch Jr. says this when revealing himself to Harry after the third task. While his comments reflect aspects of Harry’s character, the text demonstrates Harry’s need and willingness for interdependence with the coming of the first task. Ironically, Crouch Jr., in the guise of Mad-Eye Moody, gives Harry the idea to fly in the first task (20.344), leading Harry to enlist Hermione’s help with the summoning charm (20.345). However, Crouch Jr.’s words illuminate a character flaw against which Harry must defend.

not ready for this [the dragon and the Tournament], Sirius" (0:45:19–0:45:21), doubting his natural abilities. The novel highlights Harry's trepidation, allowing other characters to encourage him. Ironically, Barty Crouch Jr. (disguised as Mad-Eye Moody) emboldens Harry to "play to your strengths" (20.344). After Harry claims he lacks strengths, Crouch Jr. retorts, "you've got strengths if I say you've got them" (20.344). Crouch Jr. pushes Harry to ruminate on his abilities, causing Harry to realize his natural proclivity for Quidditch and uplifts Harry's morale, telling him, "You're a damn good flier from what I've heard" (20.344). Crouch Jr. speaks to Harry's strengths when he feels inadequate, highlighting Harry's need to realize his potential. Harry also demonstrates his need for interdependence during his preparation for the first task. After Crouch Jr. tells Harry to use his broomstick against the dragon, Harry realizes he needs Hermione's help (20.345). Hermione practices the summoning charm with him until a dictionary "flew across the room, and Harry caught it. 'Harry, I really think you've got it!' said Hermione delightedly" (20.347). Encouragement from others highlights the novel's interdependence motif exemplified through the Beowulfian dragon task.

The first task also illustrates the dragon's testing of Harry's "moral reasoning and instinctive sense of fair play" (Berman 62). Harry implicitly acknowledges his pride, making amends with Ron (20.358). Berman claims the dragon represents Harry's anger toward Ron following their fight and the Hungarian Horntail mirrors Harry's "internal struggle" (62). Such internalized toil might be read as Harry's struggle to dominate his prideful Beowulfian tendencies. Harry's triumph over the dragon, Berman claims, epitomizes Harry's ability "to tame his unruly passions" (62). In defeating the dragon, such passions, like pride, are defused and exemplify Harry's moral reasoning, the same reasoning allowing Harry to reconcile with Ron following the first task. Further, Harry's sense of fair play is illustrated when Harry tells Cedric about the first task (20.340–41), personifying his ethical morality, themes not necessarily present in Beowulf's final fight. While Beowulf recognizes his pride after the dragon fight, giving thanks "'To the everlasting Lord of All, / to the King of Glory'" (lines 2794–95), there is no mending of a friendship, as there is between Harry and Ron following the first task.

While Rowling's novel inverts Beowulf's duel sequence, within Harry's dragon task, internalized inversions are also present, specifically related to Harry's and Beowulf's contrasted character states. Beowulf's defeat by the dragon, as noted, seems foreshadowed by his prideful tendencies. Only by dying in battle with the dragon is Beowulf able to purge his pride. While Harry battles with pride when entering his battle with the Hungarian Horntail, the narrative inverts the Beowulfian model by having Harry not only come out of his trial alive, but also sees him purging his pride through meekness, actualized

in his forgiveness of Ron: "Harry knew Ron was about to apologize and suddenly he found he didn't need to hear it" (20.358). Whereas Beowulf's pride is purged through death, Harry's pride is released through forgiveness, seeing the continued friendship between him and Ron.

Not only does the novel invert the pride tendency present in *Beowulf*, but it also inverts the timeline of the hero's age in relation to maturation. *Goblet of Fire's* divergence from the Old English epic emphasizes Harry's expedient maturation, as Beowulf faces the dragon after having ruled the Geats "well / For fifty winters" (lines 2208–09). While an exact age is not given by the poet, we might assume Beowulf to be around seventy years old at the time of the dragon fight, if he fought Grendel around the age of twenty. Beowulf fights his penultimate foe after having lived a long life, ruled a nation, and defeated numerous foes. Harry, conversely, is about fifty-six years younger than Beowulf and lacks refined battle experience, being but a young teenager. The novel's inversion of Harry's age at the time of his dragon fight suggests Harry's eminent need for maturation, especially when read in parallel with *Beowulf*. Harry's maturation process, while rushed in comparison with Beowulf's, is underscored by his reliance on others and his willingness to forgive, thematic elements brought to bear in light of such inversions from *Beowulf*. The novel's linkages with the Beowulfian dragon fight within Harry's first task mythopoetically add thematic elements to the narrative, departing from and inverting the Old English poem. While Rowling's themes are original, we can read the Beowulfian dragon duel as a conduit for unique moralistic messages within the novel, a pattern continued in the Triwizard Tournament's second task.

THE LAKE

While the novel inverts the battles, presenting Beowulf's last challenge with the dragon first in the Triwizard Tournament, *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire* intersect in their second tasks. Beowulf and Harry venture into a mere, an undertaking holding visual, symbolic, and thematic allusions and analogues between the works. In *Beowulf* and *Goblet of Fire*, the heroes' lakes are linked with ice. Hogwarts's Lake is "a great, iron-gray mass of chilly water" with "dark and icy depths" (26.483). Hogwarts's Lake is dark with "icy depths"; likewise, while Beowulf's mere boils, it has icy associations: "They [Grendel and his mother] dwell apart [...] / where cold streams / pour down the mountain" (lines 1357, 1359–60). The poet continues: "a frost-stiffened wood waits and keeps watch / above a mere" (lines 1362–63). Icy coldness defines the atmosphere surrounding Harry's and Beowulf's meres. The lakes exude cold despair, turning away all thoughts of hope.

Another symbolic image links *Beowulf* with *Goblet of Fire*: the hart. In *Beowulf*, the poet makes a comparison, showing how terrible the mere is:

On its bank, the heather-stepper halts:
the hart in flight from pursuing hounds
will turn to face them with firm-set horns
and die in the wood rather than dive
beneath its surface. That is no good place. (lines 1368–72)

Robert Emmett Finnegan acknowledges the hart “unnaturally performs a kind of suicide” in turning to face the dogs rather than diving into the mere (47). The hart, or stag, holds medieval Christological iconographic associations and Marcelle Thiébaux observes the medieval Christ was often depicted as “the transpierced stag” (46). But the hart in this scene does not act in a recognizably Christ-like manner, as Finnegan acknowledges; fear and suicide are not character attributes associated with Christ. However, inclusion of the hart within the scene at least recalls Christological iconography, even if the literal hart does not perform Christ-like actions. While the hart faces the hounds valiantly with “firm-set horns,” it is scared to jump into the mere. Fighting the hounds represents a lesser terror for the hart than venturing into the mere, which “is no good place.” The hart’s inclinations towards the mere are contrasted with Beowulf, who “was impatient to be away, and plunged suddenly: / without more ado, he dived in the heaving / depths of the lake” (lines 1493–95). Beowulf does what the hart cannot, taking on symbolic significance through his juxtaposition with a Christological symbol. While the frightened hart’s actions might not completely symbolize attributes linked with Christ, Beowulf’s fearlessness and sacrificial action of venturing into the hellish mere work in symbolic tandem with the Christological hart image. The hart prefigures a more fully realized Christ-like action on Beowulf’s part.

The hart also holds significance for Harry, as Harry’s Patronus (wordplay on “patron,” or saint), is a “silver stag” (31.623). Harry shares his Patronus with his late father, James Potter, and Nadine Böhm claims Harry’s Patronus demonstrates Harry’s “desired presence” of his father (129). In addition to Böhm’s observations, Rowling, through medieval iconography, associates Harry as a salvific character, possibly even Christ-like. Howard Helsinger writes, “Throughout the Middle Ages stags were allegorized in terms of the bestiary account emphasizing the legendary antipathy of stags and serpents” (164). Harry’s stag Patronus could link him with Christ and prefigure his confrontation with Voldemort, the serpent standing in “antipathy” to the stag. Harry, following Beowulf’s lead, “pulled off his shoes and socks, [...] and waded out into the lake” (26.493). Whereas the hart would rather die by the hounds, Harry, the stag, willingly ventures into the lake’s depths, fusing the hart and Beowulfian imageries into one. Harry is both Beowulf and the Christian hart.

Beowulf's and Harry's meres also share associations with burning. The *Beowulf*-poet describes "At night there [at the mere], something uncanny happens: / the water burns" (lines 1365–66). The mere is also a "hot gore / [...] wallowing up" (lines 1422–23). Similarly, in Hogwarts's Lake, while cold, Harry "felt the skin on his legs searing as though this were fire, not icy water" (26.493). When Harry defends himself, "his wand, instead of sending sparks at the grindylows, pelted them with what seemed to be a jet of boiling water" (26.496). Hogwarts's Lake parallels the burning mere in *Beowulf*, but that which hides beneath the waters' depths solidifies links between Rowling's novel and the Old English epic poem.



Fig. 1. Grindylows in Hogwarts's Lake during the second task, from the 2005 film adaptation (1:39:49-1:40:20).

Beowulf's mere "was infested / with all kinds of reptiles. There were writhing sea-dragons / and monsters slouching on slopes by the cliff" (lines 1425–27). Just as Beowulf dives into a monster-infested abyss, similarly Hogwarts's Lake contains creepy creatures. While Harry predominantly encounters merpeople, he is also attacked by grindylows: "Harry twisted his body around and saw a grindylow, a small, horned water demon, poking out of the weed, its long fingers clutched tightly around Harry's leg, its pointed fangs bared" (26.495). Aia Hussein notes the name "grindylow" could "be derived from [...] Grendel [Grendel-grindylow]." While grindylows may or may not link with Grendel's name, the attack on our heroes furthers such connections. The "water demons" assault Harry as he goes down to the merpeople's territory. Creatures also attack Beowulf while swimming down to Grendel's mother's lair: "a bewildering horde / came at him from the depths, droves of sea-beasts / who attacked with tusks and tore at his chain-mail / in a ghastly onslaught" (lines 1509–12). Beowulf is assailed underwater and so is Harry: "By the time he had grasped it [his wand], two more grindylows had risen out of the weed, had seized handfuls of Harry's robes, and were attempting to drag him down" (26.496). Harry's robes are the Beowulfian version of chainmail, as the water demons assault Harry. Beowulf and Harry are violently broadsided while swimming down into watery depths.

These creatures personify Beowulf's mere and Hogwarts's Lake as hellish. Finnegan notes Beowulf's mere is presented as "a type of hell" because it is Grendel's and his mother's lair, "monsters formally aligned with Cain, himself a type of devil or Antichrist" (46).¹⁶ Trenton J. McNulty observes Hogwarts's Lake's "death-connection[.] [...] [T]he text describes the underwater world of the merpeople as a demonic, underworld realm" (57). Richard A. Spencer similarly notes a "close parallel" between the second Triwizard Task and Aeneas's journey to the underworld in Book VI of Virgil's *Aeneid* (54). Harry fights off "water demons" and encounters merpeople with "grayish skin and long, wild, dark green hair. Their eyes were yellow, as were their broken teeth" (26.497). Beowulf does not battle merpeople but encounters his second monster in Grendel's mother, "that water-witch, / a great mere-wife" (lines 1518–19).¹⁷ The Old English *mere-wif* is used to introduce Grendel's mother. *Wif*, according to the Bosworth Toller Anglo-Saxon Dictionary, refers to "a woman" or "a female person" (i).¹⁸ *Mere* in Old English translates to "a mere, lake" (ii); thus, *mere-wif* can be translated as mere-wife. Beowulf faces a mere-wife and Harry confronts merpeople ruled by a "chief merperson, a particularly wild and ferocious-looking *female*" (26.505; emphasis added). Both meres are ruled by monstrous, devilish mere-wives, positing the lakes as representations of hell.



Fig. 2. Mermaids in the 2005 film adaptation (1:38:23).

These hellish landscapes are the necessary atmospheric backdrops for Beowulf's and Harry's salvific baptisms. After Beowulf cuts off Grendel's head (line 1590), he returns to the surface bringing with him his "prize, / the mighty load he was lugging to the surface" (lines 1625–26). This act cleanses the mere, becoming no longer a boiling, infested pool, but a "settled" lake (line 1630). Such cleansing

¹⁶ See Fisher 176–77 and McNamee 197 for further discussions on the mere's hellish landscape in *Beowulf*.

¹⁷ Liuzza's translation.

¹⁸ *Wif* can also mean "a married woman" or "a wife" (iii).

action, for the Christian reader, could invoke baptismal associations, as Beowulf surfaces from a newly purged mere with the evidence of a defeated demon. M.B. McNamee claims the scene drips with Christian baptismal “liturgical echoes,” more familiar to the Old English audience than to modern readers (196) and Finnegan claims the mere’s purging can be read through “[b]aptismal typology and liturgy” (47).¹⁹ Not only has Beowulf gone through a spiritual gauntlet in the underworld, but he has come back a new man, expelling the demons from Hrothgar’s kingdom. Beowulf travels to hell, defeats a demon, and brings back proof of the demon’s defeat, performing a baptism for himself and the land.

Harry follows the same narrative structure in his second task. The golden egg’s song states,

*We’ve taken what you’ll sorely miss,
An hour long you’ll have to look,
And to recover what we took,
But past an hour—the prospect’s black,
Too late, it’s gone, it won’t come back. (25.463)*

Taking the song seriously, Harry thinks Ron and Gabrielle will die if not saved within the hour. While Harry is allowed to rescue Ron, his allotted captive friend, Fleur, the Beauxbatons’ champion, was attacked by grindylows and her sister, Gabrielle, is left without a rescuer. Harry, after attempting to take Gabrielle, is confronted with a merperson: “‘You take your own hostage,’ one of them said to him. ‘Leave the others . . .’ ‘No way!’ said Harry furiously[.] [...] I don’t want *them* to die either’” (26.499–500). Harry disobeys the merpeople’s commands, grabbing Ron and Gabrielle (26.501). By denying the merpeople’s directives, Harry defeats the merpeople in their own realm, like Beowulf did to Grendel’s mother, bringing people back from the depths, analogous to Beowulf’s actions, albeit Harry’s friends are alive, contrary to Grendel’s corpse head.

But it is this departure which solidifies *Goblet of Fire*’s salvific and baptismal symbolism. Harry gives the hostages a new birth as they come to the lake’s surface. Even Harry experiences new life. Resurfacing, Harry “gulped it [air] down, feeling as though he had never breathed properly before, and panting, pulled Ron and the little girl up with him” (26.502). The air makes

¹⁹ While the mere episode can be read as a baptism, Finnegan cautions against reading Beowulf as a Christ figure:

It is one thing to recognize suggestions of baptism here, but quite another to see Beowulf as a type of Christ. [...] [W]e would agree that a Christian audience might see the hero as a type or precursor of Christ. But the abstract is not the poem itself, and the details of the work preclude such an easy identification in whole or in part. (47)

Harry feel new, as if he was not breathing (or living) quite properly before. It is only after Harry ventures into hell and returns with the others that he is truly revived and given a new birth. This imagery reflects baptism liturgy and the heroic salvific motif of venturing to the underworld. Spencer, comparing Harry with Aeneas, notes “the murky worlds of peril and death” show them as “saviors [...] of their people” (55). McNulty claims Harry’s descent into the Chamber of Secrets, wherein he “enters the underworld and undergoes a figurative death before being reborn into the land of the living,” prefigures the second Triwizard Task (56). Beowulf and Harry fit the salvific archetype, demonstrating what Charles Huttar terms the “principle of voluntary self-sacrifice on another’s behalf [...] tak[ing] the form [...] of a descent into the underworld, a journey to danger and death, to perform a rescue” (131).²⁰ Beowulf acts as a salvific sacrificial figure, in that he destroys Grendel’s mother, who represented a threat to Hrothgar’s hall, effectively rescuing the Danish society from a devilish villain. However, Harry, in his explicit rescue mission, embodies a Christian expansion upon the Old English exemplar, seeing how Harry dives into hell, rescues multiple individuals, and returns with them to the surface. Whereas Beowulf emerges with Grendel’s decapitated head, Harry surfaces with rescued and revived life in the figure of Ron and Gabrielle, suggesting a Christianized development upon the Beowulfian model. While saving the Danes, Beowulf reappears with death, while Harry comes back with renewed life for his friends.

In the second task, *Goblet of Fire* does not depart significantly from its Beowulfian linkages, rather staying consistent with the chronological placement of the mere challenge and its symbolic motifs. But in Harry’s third and final Triwizard task, I argue Harry’s challenge is a combination of Beowulf’s first and third combatants, as Voldemort embodies aspects of Grendel and the dragon concurrently. Rowling’s novel follows the Beowulfian duel sequence and inverts it simultaneously.

VOLDEMORT AS GRENDL AND THE DRAGON

The Triwizard champions’ final challenge, a maze, is a conduit for Harry’s true task: his confrontation with the risen Dark Lord. Voldemort’s introduction invokes dragon imagery, drawing parallels with Beowulf’s dragon:

²⁰ Huttar’s analytical context is C.S. Lewis’s *The Chronicles of Narnia*. However, following Griesinger’s lead, I make connections between Lewis’s “deeper magic” and Harry’s actions. See Griesinger 466–67 for her use of Lewis’s “deeper magic,” self-sacrifice, and her incorporation of Huttar’s observations in relation to Rowling’s series.

The thing Wormtail had been carrying had the shape of a crouched human child, except that Harry had never seen anything less like a child. It was hairless and scaly-looking, a dark, raw, reddish black. Its arms and legs were thin and feeble, and its face — no child alive ever had a face like that — flat and snakelike, with gleaming red eyes. (32.640)

Voldemort's physicality recalls snakes, linked with death in Rowling's series (Berman 53). Wendy Hennequin observes a correlation between Voldemort's action with "his vices: pride, anger, selfishness, arrogance, power hunger, sadism, and murder" (75). These traits echo Beowulf's dragon who "guard[s] heathen gold" (line 2276) and "burn[s] bright homesteads [...] / that scared everyone, for the vile sky-winger / would leave nothing alive in his wake" (lines 2313–15). Due to his snake-like physicality and dragonish character, Kerrie Anne Le Lievre claims Voldemort is "the dragon (Latin *draco*: serpent, dragon) which Harry, in his role as defender, must defeat to protect his people" (32).²¹ Such elements mirror Beowulf's situation and actions in his final fight against the "sky-winger." Kenneth Sisam observes Beowulf seeks to contain the evil dragon, for if the creature escaped, Beowulf's retainers would be at the dragon's mercy (136). Beowulf and Harry are both working to contain the dragon. While most Old English scholars identify Beowulf's dragon as explicitly a dragon²² and Voldemort is a man (albeit one who has irreversibly corrupted his soul), character and physical linkages open interpretive possibilities for reading Voldemort as analogous to Beowulf's dragon.

The following is the Old English describing Beowulf and the dragon in combat: "Stið-mōð gestōð wið stēapne rond / winia bealdor, ðā se wyrm gebēah / snūde tōsomne; hē on searwum bād" (lines 2566–68). Heaney translates this passage into "Unyielding, the lord [Beowulf] of his people loomed / by his tall shield, sure of his ground, / while the *serpent* looped and unleashed itself" (lines 2566–68; emphasis added). Heaney translates the Old English word *wyrm* to serpent, which, according to the Bosworth Toller Anglo-Saxon Dictionary, means either "a reptile, [or a] serpent" (i).²³ Obviously, Beowulf fights a large, reptilian-like monster, and while the Old English does

²¹ Dragons and snakes have close literary associations, as Berman observes: "It is important to note that even though the term 'dragon' is designated by the Latin *draco* while 'snake' is designated *serpens*, in many literary texts and sources the symbolism of 'serpent,' 'snake,' and 'dragon' are either synonymous or closely related" (45). See Rose 327 for discussion on dragons and their mythic connections with snakes and Gibka 146 for serpents' transformation into dragons within medieval literature.

²² Taylor claims the creature might be a "man-dragon or beast-dragon—Levithan, Python, or fire-drake" (229).

²³ Liuzza translates *wyrm* as worm, but describes the beast as "coiled, burning, [and] slithering" (lines 2567, 2569), recalling snake imagery associated with Voldemort.

use the word *draca* at certain points in the poem to refer particularly to a dragon,²⁴ with usages of *wyrm*, the Old English resists neat closures, refusing to delineate the final monster exclusively as a dragon. I do not claim Rowling intentionally referenced the Old English in *Beowulf* when crafting Voldemort; however, such a linguistic and literary analogue reveals Harry as a modern Beowulf fighting the dragon.

In Beowulf's and Harry's confrontations, there are rounds of fighting. Beowulf fights three rounds with the dragon (lines 2542–91, 2592–2687, and 2688–2711), and Sisam notes "Each round represents an attack [...] against which Beowulf must stand firm, yielding no ground" (136).²⁵ Beowulf tries containing and subduing the dragon, as the creature has proven deadly in its attack on Beowulf's people. In contrast, the novel differs from the dragon containment motif, as *Goblet of Fire's* narrative crux is Voldemort's rise to power. While Le Lievre claims Harry is crafted as a protector, and a case could be made for his efforts to contain Voldemort, as Beowulf attempts in his confrontation, a more likely reading acknowledges Harry's efforts to survive. His focus, if ever on Voldemort's containment, quickly shifts to surviving a duel with the great dark wizard. Beowulf's primary goal is containing and subduing the dragon, effectively preventing the dragon from continued attacks upon his kingdom, whereas Harry's primary objective is survival. Voldemort is reborn; the cat's already out of the bag. During their fight, Voldemort uses the three Unforgivable Curses, each representing a round in their duel. First, Voldemort uses the Cruciatus Curse on Harry (33.657–58), then the Imperius Curse (34.661–62), and finally the Killing Curse, which Harry defends against with a disarming charm (34.663–69). In Beowulf's and Harry's final battles, their fights are divided into three separate rounds, paralleling Harry's fight with Beowulf's dragon duel.

²⁴ *Draca* or variations of the word can be found on lines 892, 1426, 2088, 2211, 2273, 2290, 2333, 2402, 2549, 2689, 2512, 2825, 3040, and 3131. Interestingly, *draca* is juxtaposed with *wyrm* in lines 1425–26 and 1429–30: "wyrm-cynnes fela, / sellice sǣ-dracan, [...] / on segl-rāde, / wyrmas ond wil-dēor." My translation: "Many of wormkind / strange sea-dragons, [...] on sailroad serpents and wild animals." See the Vulgate's Psalm 73:13–14 for another instance of dragons in the sea (sea serpents). My thanks to Dr. Nicole Discenza for assistance with the Old English translation and finding additional appearances of *draca* in connection with sea creatures.

²⁵ It should be acknowledged, contrary to Sisam's observations, Beowulf *does* yield ground, specifically during the first round with the dragon when his sword fails him: "For the son of Ecgtheow, it was no easy thing / to have to give ground like that and go / unwillingly to inhabit another home / in a place beyond; so every man must yield / the leasehold of his days" (lines 2587–91).

Voldemort can be read analogously alongside Beowulf's dragon and also with Grendel, Beowulf's first combatant. Grendel and Voldemort share similarities, particularly in relation to their eyes and darkness. The *Beowulf*-poet describes "a baleful light, / flame more than light, [that] flared from his [Grendel's] eyes" (lines 726–27). The flame in Grendel's eyes recalls a red fire emanating from his pupils: "while Grendel is alive the baleful glow of his eyes in the dark is noticed" (Sisam 133). Similarly, Voldemort has "gleaming red" or "livid scarlet eyes" which "gleamed still more brightly through the darkness" (32.640, 643, 644).²⁶ The darkness surrounding Voldemort and Grendel makes their eyes piercing, but also characterologically analogous. Alton notes Voldemort symbolizes "darkness [and] confusion" and "his name, with *volde* being the Old English word for earth or land and *mort* the French word for death" reinforces such symbolism (218). Voldemort also has a modern Old English epithet, "the Dark Lord",²⁷ and is embodied by the darkness: "small animals [...] had met their deaths by a dark shadow that possessed them" (33.655). As Voldemort is a "dark shadow," Grendel is "that dark death-shadow / who lurked and swooped in the long nights / on the misty moors" (lines 160–62).²⁸ Both villains personify darkness and are "dark death-shadows." And as Beowulf and Grendel have a fair fight, so too do Harry and Voldemort.

In his dragon fight, Beowulf exclaims to his retainers "This fight is not yours, / nor is it up to any man except me / to measure his strength against the monster / or to prove his worth" (lines 2532–35). Similarly, Voldemort, when dueling Harry, tells his Death Eaters, "Do nothing! [...] Do nothing unless I command you!" (34.664). Rowling crafts an inversion, aligning Voldemort with Beowulf, as both characters demonstrate pride, wanting to fight their combatant alone. The *Beowulf* poet also notes, "As long as either lived, / he was hateful to the other" (lines 813–14) echoing the prophecy in Rowling's fifth installment: "EITHER MUST DIE AT THE HAND OF THE OTHER FOR NEITHER CAN LIVE WHILE THE OTHER SURVIVES" (*Order of the Phoenix* 37.841).²⁹ Voldemort's characterological and physical attributes shared with Grendel and the dragon illustrate *Goblet of Fire*'s fusion of Beowulf's first and third fight into Harry's third task. The novel also follows and departs from thematic elements

²⁶ See also 33.645–46, 651–52, 656, 658, 34.659, 661, 664–66, and 669 for further instances of Voldemort's red eyes.

²⁷ For further discussion on "Dark Lord" as a modern fantasy equivalent of an Old English epithet, see McDonald 45–50. Davis also connects Grendel and Voldemort with darkness (32).

²⁸ See also lines 86–87 and lines 275–77 for additional instances associating Grendel with darkness.

²⁹ I draw from Davis's observations of the literary prophetic echoes between *Beowulf* and *Order of the Phoenix* (42–43).

introduced in *Beowulf* within Harry's final challenge. *Goblet of Fire* and *Beowulf* illustrate themes of giving and impending doom in their conclusions. But contrary to *Beowulf*, Rowling, acknowledging the coming war, closes her novel with hope.

Harry follows *Beowulf*'s thematic lead by emulating Beowulf's gift-giving. Beowulf dies following his fight with the dragon and "give[s] thanks / that I behold this treasure here in front of me, / that I have been allowed to leave my people / so well endowed on the day I die" (lines 2795–98). Joseph E. Marshall notes the *Beowulf* poet highlights "Beowulf's ideal lordship by describing his penchant for dispensing treasure" (4), citing instances where the Old English describes Beowulf as "a giver of treasure" (5).³⁰ Marshall claims Beowulf's gift-giving represents a renewed life, as the treasure will allow his kingdom "to rebuild": "Beowulf gives the Geats a chance to survive" (6).

Harry becomes a Beowulfian *goldgyfan* (gold-giver) (line 2652), when he "pulled open his trunk and drew out his Triwizard winnings. 'Take it,' he said, and he thrust the sack into George's hands" (37.733). Harry selflessly gives his thousand Galleons to the Weasley twins as a gift towards their entrepreneurial enterprise: "You take it, and get inventing. It's for the joke shop. [...] We all could do with a few laughs. I've got a feeling we're going to need them more than usual before long" (37.733). Harry as a *sicgyfan* (treasure-giver) (line 2311) stems from the imminent doom facing the wizarding world following Voldemort's return, another thematic echo from *Beowulf*:

A Geat woman too sang out in grief;
with hair bound up, she unburdened herself
of her worst fears, a wild litany
of nightmare and lament: her nation invaded,
enemies on the rampage, bodies in piles,
slavery and abasement. Heaven swallowed the smoke.
(lines 3150–56)

Goldsmith observes the epic's ending foreshadows the Geats' coming doom and destined enslavement, receiving "no good from the dragon's hoard" ("The Christian Perspective" 88). Similarly, William Reynolds notes *Beowulf*'s ending includes "the first mention of the Swedish wars," conflicts which will annihilate the Geats following Beowulf's passing (37). *Goblet of Fire* analogously echoes *Beowulf* with a doomful foreboding following Voldemort's return and the

³⁰ Marshall identifies "*goldgyfan* (gold-giver) in line 2652; *goldmine* (gold-friend) in lines 2419 and 2584; *willgeofa* (will-giver) in line 2900; and *sincgyfan* (treasure-giver) in line 2311" (5). Marshall further claims, "Nowhere does the *Beowulf*-poet employ an epithet that denotes the hero's tendency to hoard or guard treasure" (5).

promise of war. Dumbledore says at the final feast, "Lord Voldemort's gift for spreading discord and enmity is very great. [...] [W]e are all facing dark and difficult times" (37.723–24).

While Voldemort's return might bring the promise of war, Rowling resists concluding her novel in utter despair. *Beowulf* promises a coming catastrophe but *Goblet of Fire* ends "eucatastrophically."³¹ Dumbledore embodies a Tolkienian eucatastrophic turn in his encouraging final speech:

[U]nless the few of us who know the truth do not stand united, there is no hope for any of us [...] we are only as strong as we are united, as weak as we are divided. [...] We can fight it [Voldemort's return] only by showing an equally strong bond of friendship and trust. Differences of habit and language are nothing at all if our aims are identical and our hearts are open. (37.723)

Resisting a Beowulfian fate, *Goblet of Fire* flips the analogue, extolling hope in the novel's conclusion. Hennequin interprets Rowling's novels as infusing hopeful "reassurance" for her readers, falling in line with the Christian comedic tradition where evil doers' weapons lack power (77). *Goblet of Fire* defies the doom prefigured by *Beowulf*, as Rowling situates her novel within the comedic fantasy tradition. Brian Attebery notes fantasy tales open with conflict but eventually resolve, as dismal elements like death and horror "must not be the final word" (15). Rowling, unlike the *Beowulf* poet, refuses to allow death and despair the final word in *Goblet of Fire*. Rather, hope, even in the face of horror, embodies Harry's mythopoetic tale.

CONCLUSION

Goblet of Fire, when read alongside *Beowulf*, presents us with sustained yet inverted literary echoes from the Old English epic poem. The novel, when read from this comparative perspective, transforms Beowulf's story within Harry's world, as the medieval legend emphasizes the novel's unique themes and illustrates *Goblet of Fire* as a work firmly rooted with the mythopoetic tradition. This essay, elucidating allusions and analogues present between Rowling's novel and *Beowulf*, encourages the continued bridging across literary histories, between early medieval English literature and modern fantasy. When

³¹ As Tolkien wrote, a "eucatastrophic tale," "however wild its events, however fantastic or terrible the adventures, [...] can give to the child or man that hears it, when the 'turn' comes, a catch of the breath, a beat and lifting of the heart, near to (or indeed accompanied by) tears, as keen as that given by any form of literary art, and having a peculiar quality" (75–76).

See Griesinger 462 for discussion of Tolkien's eucatastrophe and reading *Harry Potter* as a "eucatastrophic tale"; see also Johnston.

ancient literature is read alongside modern fiction, the possibilities for interpretation, appreciation, and reflection give nourishment to our students' intellectual maturation.

As previously noted, I am not the first to put Harry and Beowulf into conversation. Margaret Cotter-Lynch sets Alcuin of York's ninth-century argument against reading heroic literature (like *Beowulf*) next to debates surrounding Christianity and Harry Potter: should Christian children be allowed to read Rowling's novels? Cotter-Lynch uses the *Beowulf* and *Harry Potter* debates as an example for her students to "learn to widen their consideration beyond individual texts," as they discuss the essential use of literature in culture and how some of "those uses are contentious." While my analysis focuses on the texts themselves rather than their reception, I follow Cotter-Lynch's lead. *Beowulf* and *Harry Potter* come from different time periods but putting them in conversation further engages students' interests and appreciation for texts and their cultures. Cotter-Lynch notes such debates hide "the covert purpose of investing students in their love for *Beowulf* as a poem." Inversely, by introducing the Old English poem through Harry's glasses, students might find the "deeper magic" hidden in *Beowulf* and *Harry Potter* alike.

APPENDIX: CHRISTIAN AND PAGAN ELEMENTS IN BEOWULF AND HARRY POTTER

Griesinger notes there are those who would burn Rowling's books "to protect children from the Antichrist" (457). While Rowling incorporates elements which "are decidedly pagan and even anti-Christian," Griesinger claims Rowling's narratives uphold "Christian values and truth" (458). There are those deeply critical of Rowling, such as Abanes in his *Harry Potter and the Bible: The Menace behind the Magick*. However, Singer critiques Abanes for misquoting the text, causing errant interpretations (25).

Beowulf has a more complex relationship with paganism and Christianity, with Marshall acknowledging the poet's difficulty in reconciling the text's Christian and pagan elements (1). This paper does not thoroughly explore pagan and Christian elements in *Beowulf* and *Harry Potter*. However, I acknowledge this conversation, while taking a Christian reading of both texts. Reynolds observes there are about seventy Christian-like passages in *Beowulf*, with one rebuking "the Danes' ignorance of the Christian God" (27). For more on *Beowulf* and Christianity, see McNamee 191, Niles 5, Goldsmith's "The Christian Perspective in Beowulf," Whallon's "The Christianity of 'Beowulf,'" and Irving Jr.'s "Christian and Pagan Elements."

Harry Potter has also been read through a Christological lens. Singer argues for "clear evidence of Christian morality" throughout the heptalogy, claiming the series is structured around the "psychomachia [...] transl[ed]

directly as ‘battle of the soul’” (26). While the heptalogy carries Christian themes, Singer acknowledges these elements might be hidden through Rowling’s “secularized language, setting and characters” (36). While not exhaustive, see also Anatol xxiin4, Mills 3, Garza, Mohammed, Saxena, Johnston, Griesinger, Ciaccio, and Bell. For Harry as a Messianic figure, see Hennequin 67 and Singer 35.

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MARK-ELLIOT FINLEY studied secondary English education at the University of Tampa and earned his master's degree in literature from the University of South Florida. He is continuing graduate studies at USF, working on his doctorate in English literature. Mark-Elliott's research interests intersect between the Early Modern period and modern fantasy Christian literature.



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BOOK CULTURE AND NARRATIVE IN MARTIN'S *A SONG OF ICE AND FIRE*

MARIA DAMKJÆR

INTRODUCTION

IS THE SECRET TO SURVIVAL HIDDEN IN A BOOK? If so, what happens if that book is imperiled by neglect, war, or simply the passing of time? In many contemporary fantasy series, books are included in the worldbuilding as significant objects that might (or might not) contain vital information that could help save civilization. Equally, books within fantasy worlds might (or might not) survive. Many contemporary fantasy series include a set of fantasies and anxieties about books, about information transmission, and about the persistence or entropy of knowledge. I call this set of concerns a book culture; and the book culture within diegetic fantasy worlds, I argue, reflects current questions about the longevity of civilization. In this article, I will discuss George R.R. Martin's *A Song of Ice and Fire* (1996—) and ask: what do books represent?¹ What other forms of record-keeping and knowledge preservation exist in the fantasy world, and why? What are the limitations of the different kinds of knowledge transfer, and how does that play into the narrative? Supported by book history and theories of knowledge, and with a special focus on narrative technique, I will examine the intricacies of book culture in Westerosi society. More broadly, I want to posit that contemporary fantasy authors are both fascinated by texts, and also troubled by their limited chance of survival over the very long periods that the genre tends to sketch. Deep time is hostile to book knowledge, but it is the very loss, or disappearance, of knowledge that poses the greatest challenges to fantasy realms. Contemporary fantasy is occupied by the assumption that knowledge must be sought where it is hidden; that book learning is marginalized and dismissed; that there is a scarcity of both books and knowledge more generally; but that the 'hidden truth' might not, in the end, be trustworthy. In short, transmission of information is threatened; and as the thing at stake in *A Song of Ice and Fire* is nothing less than the survival of human civilization, these anxieties speak to contemporary fears about societal transience and preservation.

¹ Giacomo Guidici has written an excellent chapter that focuses only on the *Game of Thrones* HBO show, where he argues that writing is symbolically connected to power. Apart from one point in my analysis, I will mostly leave the HBO series *Game of Thrones* (2011–2019) out of the discussion.

Within each fantasy world, books occupy a social, cultural and economic space, but what are the intricacies of that space? Are books privileged, or are they marginal? As Nicholas Birns has argued, fantasy might be defined by the difficulty with which information is transmitted within its worlds ("When You Have Read It" 58).² Books are often scarce in fantasy worlds, and neither messages nor books travel seamlessly or quickly between people. But that does not necessarily mean that books are precious: on the contrary, books are often ignored, not least by those in power, in Martin's epic series. The world's diegetic readers, those with true appreciation for the delights of the library, are invested with a certain underdog quality. Are book people good people? What does that mean for extradiegetic readers of fantasy often fiercely committed to reading long book series and, in the age of social media, displaying bookcases full of physical books? We expect, for this group of readers especially, a certain investment in books as significant objects. What is the appeal for contemporary fantasy readers of a literature where books are neglected? More, what does that say about our investments in the cultural significance of the book? Does the narrative trope that requires characters to recover lost and vital knowledge reflect a desire in our world to fetishize books, to cast them as culturally significant objects?

In short: how much does the treatment of books within a fantasy series reflect metafictionally on the status of books in our own world? As Marie-Laure Ryan has pointed out, fantasy literature tends to be immersive, with very little breaking of the fourth wall, that classic trait of metafiction (4–10). Martin's writing in *A Song of Ice and Fire* is an exploration of immersion, Joseph Rex Young has shown (see for example 74–77). But metafictionality can be implicit or metaphoric, according to Andrea Macrae (18–19). When characters in *A Song of Ice and Fire* treasure or discard books, I would argue that the narrative is implicitly commenting on what it means to be a reader, a book lover, and on how books fit into our world. This might mean that our investment in material book culture turns out to be nostalgic for a privileged past where, in reality, few had access to books; or to fetishize certain kinds of knowledge; or to valorize readers because reading is perceived to be under threat in contemporary society. The way a fantasy series communicates with its own readers *about* reading may be flattering or consoling or cognitively dissonant. After all, many fantasy series, including *A Song of Ice and Fire*, allow readers to vicariously witness the destruction of books and libraries; what appeal does such a literature of loss have to contemporary book lovers?

Epic fantasy as a genre is about the deep impact of past events, often long forgotten (Sangster 20). But how do characters in fantasy novels access the

² As opposed to science fiction, where information is generally easy to transmit.

past, and how can they trust what they find? The novel form itself is inherently about gradual revelation; it orders a set of events but often withholds key information from characters or readers. Fantasy novels are sometimes about quests, but often they are also about moving from an incomplete or naive understanding of the world to a more complete one. That journey involves recovery; of lived experience (a witness who was alive and can attest to past events) or of transmitted information (books or other data technologies). Matthew Sangster points out that “[f]antasy creators of numerous stripes—makers and remakers of fictions inevitably derived from the languages and customs of our world—are fascinated by the processes through which language, fantasy and belief collaborate to define and redefine the parameters of culture and imagination” (58). However, from the inception of epic fantasy in J.R.R. Tolkien’s *The Lord of the Rings* and associated texts, the possibility of preserving the past in written form has been a topic of apprehension. As Vladimir Brljak has argued, “Tolkien’s mature fiction is centrally concerned precisely with [the] inability of the text to ever take us to that vanished, irretrievable ‘there,’ from which even living memory was but the first remove” (6). While Tolkien invested himself in a “pseudobibliographical metafictional interface” (6)—the idea that the novels are in fact translations of originals written by characters in the story—Brljak argues that this creates not immersion, but distance, between the reader and the events. However, as Gergely Nagy has argued, through his elaborate metafictional frameworks, Tolkien “represents and creates cultural processes and contents in terms of textual activities, by the device of various sorts of texts and their interrelations” (642).³ Tolkien’s interest in the minutiae of textual transmission was to persevere in much epic fantasy, and while his deep knowledge of bibliography is unique, some authors display sensitivity in how they imagine and construct the production, transmission and preservation (or not) of the material book.

Books are technologies that are underpinned by institutional investment of labor and significance. As D.F. McKenzie has pointed out, “[a] book is never simply a remarkable *object*. Like every other technology, it is invariably the product of human agency in complex and highly volatile contexts” (4). As Eric Hayot lays out in *Information: A Reader*, there are three basic social processes at work around “information”: “storing, organizing, and communicating” (Hayot 8). The first process, storing, requires a form, either material or immaterial, in physical matter or in human memory, all of which

³ Birns argues that although Gandalf visits archives to discover the history of the One Ring, the hobbits, and therefore also the reader, find history on the road (*Literary Role* 9). Peter Grybauskas has explored the “untold tales” of Tolkien’s work: “the frames, the edges, allusions, lacunae, the borders between story and un-story, gaps and spaces between vast Ages and miniscule periods in an ellipsis” (xvii).

require systems, rituals, and investments of time. It will have taken labor and resources to put together a library in Westeros. In *A Song of Ice and Fire*, storage happens in libraries that belong to families (for example the Starks) or to organizations (the Night's Watch, the Citadel, the royal library at the Red Keep), and which are not publicly accessible. Books denote status, and only a small percentage of the population can even read; books are unevenly distributed.

The book as an object, as a cultural and social *thing*, speaks to the literary world's deeper assumptions about knowledge, and about the survival of information from one age to the next. By extension, this article is also about contemporary anxieties about preservation. Since most epic fantasy is concerned with long timespans, it is tempting to see the description of books, texts, and other transfers of information, as a continual engagement with the inevitability of our own civilizational loss, given a large enough timescale. How much will be lost; how much is lost every day? What if somehow what was lost actually held the power to extend or renew a civilization; what if cultural memory was somehow the *most* important thing? There is a tinge of defiant nostalgia in the investment in books, storytelling, and scholarship that permeates contemporary fantasy literature. Does this nostalgia express a feeling of loss of centrality, a marginalization of book learning at the expense of technical innovation and quick consumption of information?

MANUSCRIPT BOOK CULTURE IN WESTEROS

Valyrian swords are precious, highly valued, and forged in magic. They do not rust or deteriorate, they are difficult to damage or reforge, and they give their owners a clear advantage over both mundane and supernatural enemies. Valyrian swords embody, in their seemingly incorruptible forms, ancient knowledge, now impossible to reconstruct.

Valyrian *scrolls*, on the other hand, are almost universally ignored in Westeros. A few key book lovers mention them and consider them precious: when Tyrion instructs a young septon at Winterfell: "Be gentle with the Valyrian scrolls, the parchment is very dry," he is naming bookish objects that both have an incalculable age and great physical fragility (GoT 82).⁴ The septon does not speak, but seems startled that anyone would care. More often than not, scrolls are described as "crumbling" (CoK 385). Valyrian scrolls are exceedingly rare: in *A Feast for Crows*, we learn that "[s]ome of the old Valyrian scrolls down in the locked vaults [of the Citadel] were said to be the only surviving copies in the world" (16). When Sam recounts his discoveries in the library of Castle Black —

⁴ In what follows, I will use the following abbreviations: GoT for *A Game of Thrones*, CoK for *A Clash of Kings*, SoS1 for *A Storm of Swords* 1, SoS2 for *A Storm of Swords* 2, FfC for *A Feast for Crows*, DwD1 for *A Dance with Dragons* 1, DwD2 for *A Dance with Dragons* 2.

a scene I will come back to below—he lists off: “works that even the Citadel doesn’t have, scrolls from old Valyria, counts of the seasons written by maesters dead a thousand years . . .” (CoK 82). The scrolls from old Valyria form only one item on a long list: they represent the oldest surviving book technology, but their contents are rarely mentioned. Their survival across four centuries or more has not made them central to contemporary culture in the way that swords are. Instead, Valyrian scrolls are background clutter, an elevated form of detritus. Unlike the swords, they seemingly have no inherent magic to keep them pristine. Both swords and scrolls represent now inaccessible knowledge, material survivors from a culture destroyed by catastrophe, but only the scrolls are marked narratively as irrelevant. With a few exceptions, nearly all of them remain narratively rolled-up, or reduced to crumbling materiality, falling apart in characters’ hands. They are signs for information that no one reads, markers for the deep past and for the limits of memory.

Most of the books that are in practical use in the series are in codex form. Book culture in *The Song of Ice and Fire* is a manuscript culture. Among the technology that Martin depicts, the printing press is absent. Both parchment and paper are mentioned in relation to books and letters, suggesting that both must be in use. However, we see no working authors, book-binders, and almost no booksellers. There is an oblique reference by Cat of the canals (Arya) to a bookseller in Bravos (FfC 572), and Sam sees outdoor book stalls and working scribes in Oldtown (FfC 767), but those are the only references to book commerce. None of the book-loving characters in the series are seen buying a book; not even Tyrion, who could afford it. We do not learn where he got his wedding present to Joffrey—since it was extremely rare, it would not have been from any common bookseller, and might have come from the Casterly Rock library, assuming such a thing exists.

Martin overwhelmingly describes books as “old,” “dusty,” “leather-bound,” and “heavy.” In Winterfell, Tyrion is reading a “heavy leather-bound” book, a “hundred-year-old discourse on the changing of the seasons by a long-dead maester” (GoT 82). The book Ned reads that clues him to the inherited traits that should be present in all Robert’s children is also “a ponderous tome” (GoT 246) with “brittle yellow pages,” with “dusty lists of weddings, births, and deaths” (GoT 266). Metonymically, the “ponderous” and “dusty” hundred-year-old book bleeds over to the contents as well. Several leather-bound books are mentioned in Riverrun, Harrenhal and Castle Black in *A Clash of Kings*—castles seem to have books, a sign of inherited wealth and status. Often designated as “great leather tomes” (SoS2 160), books are almost always associated with physical age, with historical chronicles of events long passed, and with irrelevance to most of the characters. There is no balancing proliferation of “new,” “fresh” books, and only one light-weight book—King

Daeron's *Conquest of Dorne*, which is "slender" (SoS1 163), but still old. For whatever reason, books are depicted as already-there: persisting, but not renewing. It is not a given that Martin intended to portray a dying or already-dead book culture; it may simply be an omission, within the many, many deeply layered depictions of the gradations of Westerosi society, that he shows no writers, scriptoria, or book-binders. There are also no scenes of wine-making, in spite of the fact that wine is ubiquitous. But it is certain that Martin depicts books as already-ancient, often accumulated by older generations or even ignored for a century. Tyrion and Sam are the only young book-lovers, and both are marginalized.

I would argue that this is not an oversight from Martin's side: the foundational point about Westeros is that information is sparse, ignored, fragmented, and contradictory. A thriving book culture would not necessarily counter that, but nevertheless the disregard for book learning is, I would argue, a sustained metaphor for misrule and dangerous forgetfulness (see Hunter). Book production does make information *material*, transmissible, and portable. Westeros, we might infer, has not invested its resources towards the material instantiation of information. Book culture is described as a long decline, reduced to the obsession of a few widely derided book lovers, who live in a book world that is left behind by previous generations, but which slowly crumbles as they turn the pages or unroll the scrolls. The people that populate this story are living in history; many of them make history; all of the older main characters have participated directly in changing its course. A decade and half before the story starts, Robert Baratheon overthrew the Targaryen dynasty and took the throne for himself; the story revolves around the uncertain succession after Robert dies. For people feeling themselves to be living in active history, the past is irrelevant. If a society's twin preoccupations are war and winter, it will tend to focus on weapons and food, not on books. The aura of books, including their age, is suggestive of past ideals that will become increasingly embattled and irrelevant as the civil war progresses; Martin is using elegiac book culture to craft the sense of an ageing society ill-equipped to handle the challenges to come.

BOOK LOVERS; BOOK INDIFFERENCE; BOOK BURNING

Sam and Tyrion are the two main book lovers in *A Song of Ice and Fire*. Both are marginalized socially even if they are from privileged backgrounds, mainly because neither has the body type or liking for martial prowess, a set of skills highly prized in the violence-centric society of Westeros. As pointed out by Mikayla Hunter, "there seems to be an inverse relationship within Westerosi society between physical ability and academic interest" (48). Books tend to be associated with individual characters, rather than institutionalized repositories: while Maester Luwin lives in close proximity to Winterfell's library tower, his

solar (study) is crammed with books that seem to speak peculiarly to his character: Bran describes Maester Luwin's "[t]ottering piles of books [that] covered tables and chairs" (GoT 711), his "clutter of books and scrolls and bottles" (CoK 399). Similarly, Maester Cressen's solar at Dragonstone is comfortably bookish: Cressen is settled "behind his books and papers" in front of "the parchment he'd been reading" (CoK 2, 18). Both maesters are practical and versatile scholars, but their relationship with books is foundational to their characters: they "cram" books together, they "pile" them up. In other words, they are bibliophiles. Books in large numbers have positive connotations. Morally suspect maesters, on the other hand, are rarely mentioned in relation to book culture: Pycelle's solar is characterized instead by a meticulous store of potions and poisons, as seen by the book lover Tyrion (CoK 239).⁵

Characters who align with traditional "heroic" traits tend to be indifferent to books.⁶ Ned Stark only reluctantly reads the book of lineages by Malleon, a "dusty [list] of weddings, births, and deaths" (GoT 266). Jon Snow, as we shall see below, humors Sam's enthusiasm for the Castle Black library but does not take part in it; his mind is on the coming journey north. Mikayla Hunter argues that "Jon's slow-growing appreciation for the value of education is central to his character development over the course of the series," but initially, he is less than enthusiastic (49). And while Davos learns to read for duty, after he has been named Stannis's hand, he explicitly rejects reading for pleasure as a part of that endeavor. "My lord, perhaps you would like to try a bit of *Conquest of Dorne* as well?" [Pylos] slid the slender leather-bound book across the table. 'King Daeron wrote with an elegant simplicity, and his history is rich with blood, battle, and bravery. Your son is quite engrossed' (SoS2 163). Davos rejects the idea explicitly because it is too enjoyable: "Davos enjoyed a good story as well as any man, but Stannis had not named him Hand for his enjoyment, he felt. His first duty was to help his king rule, and for that he must needs understand the words the ravens brought. The best way to learn a thing was to do it, he had found; sails and scrolls, it made no matter" (163–64).

Davos's rejection of the *Conquest of Dorne*—the only book to be described as thin, and one of the few "engross[ing]" books ever mentioned—has immediate narrative consequences, too: the letter he reads for his lesson propels the plot forward, leading to Stannis's decision to travel to the Wall. There is no time for the heroic reader. This is mirrored by the trajectory of Rhaegar Targaryen. Ser Arys Oakheart (disguised as Arstan Whitebeard), tells Dany that

⁵ Maesters in general are not seen as a repository of crucial knowledge. Brian Cowlshaw argues that "[m]uch of what the maesters 'know' is wrong; much that is essential to know, they deny, ignore, or mistakenly consider a tale for children" (62).

⁶ For the vexed question of the "hero" in *A Song of Ice and Fire*, see Johnston, "Grief."

Rhaegar as a boy was “bookish to a fault,” but that “one day Prince Rhaegar found something in his scrolls that changed him.” Out of the blue, he told the master-of-arms that “I will require sword and armor. It seems I must be a warrior” (SoS 111). When Rhaegar accepts the call to be a hero, he rejects the call of books. Significantly, his epiphany came from scrolls, not books—a hint that Rhaegar was consulting ancient knowledge.

The destruction of books is not a central theme of *A Song of Ice and Fire*, and books are never destroyed to eradicate cultures, to stamp out troublesome knowledge, or to punish knowledge communities. Melisandre burns effigies of the seven gods, she burns people, and characters express alarm at both of those actions, but she never burns books.⁷ The largest book-burning in the series, by volume of destruction, is the fire in the Winterfell library tower, but even that is not a deliberate biblioclasm, but a diversion by Bran’s would-be assassin. The way it is narrated is markedly distanced, through the eyes of a character—Catelyn—who is not worried about the library, but only about Bran’s safety:

Fire, she thought, and then, *Bran!* “Help me,” she said urgently, sitting up. “Help me with Bran.” Robb did not seem to hear her. “The library tower’s on fire,” he said. Catelyn could see the flickering reddish light through the open window now. She sagged with relief. Bran was safe. The library was across the bailey, there was no way the fire could reach them here. “Thank the gods,” she whispered. Robb looked at her as if she’d gone mad. (GoT 125)

The narrative technique here is to let Catelyn, as the focalizer, filter the information through her: the fire is far away, and in the face of her real concern, Bran’s safety, the fate of the library is immaterial. Both those that set the fire—the hired assassins—and Catelyn the focalizer, see the fire as incidental to their real concerns. The books are collateral damage.⁸ This ironic distance to an event that Martin’s readers might be expected to care about is symptomatic of the status of books in the series: people in this world do not always value the same (bookish) things that modern readers might care about.

The only characters who deliberately destroy books are Joffrey—who hacks a priceless illuminated chronicle by Maester Kaeth to pieces as a taunt of his uncle Tyrion—and Roose Bolton.⁹ While Joffrey’s book destruction shows

⁷ It is possible that this is a function of the relatively late introduction of the central religious text of the new religion, *The Seven-Pointed Star*, into the narrative; it does not appear until *A Feast for Crows* (414).

⁸ Larsen interprets the burning of the library as much more significant than I do (48).

⁹ Joffrey’s book destruction happens in SoS2 (231–33).

him to be petty, drunk on power, and insecure, Roose Bolton's scene of book burning, witnessed by Arya, is more enigmatic:

Roose Bolton was seated by the hearth reading from a thick leather-bound book as she entered. [...] Bolton turned a few more pages with his finger, then closed the book and placed it carefully in the fire. He watched the flames consume it, pale eyes shining with reflected light. The old dry leather went up with a *whoosh*, and the yellow pages stirred as they burned, as if some ghost were reading them. (CoK 810)

The scene is disturbing both because of the measured and dispassionate way Bolton burns the book, and because we never learn his reasons. Bolton never expresses any opinions that would explain this action, and he does not act like a zealot. His book-burning does, however, represent his disregard for conventional ethics, and his tendency to allow or perpetrate wanton destruction and suffering. His casual decision to partially read a book, and then consign it to the flames, also represents the danger that war poses to books. Presumably this book belonged to the Whent family but was left behind when Harrenhal was taken. Books, like people, rely on political stability and the protection of local lords to survive. Roose Bolton's book destruction is less a reference to biblioclasm than it is a representation of the incidental destruction of all forms of knowledge when society falls into chaos. It most mirrors, not other book burnings, but the fate of the smallfolk of the riverlands, mistreated by successive armies from both sides of the conflict.

THE LIBRARY AND THE METADATA

In *A Clash of Kings*, Jon finds Sam in the Castle Black library, which at first paradoxically seems like a place of bookish plenty: "The air smelled of paper and dust and years. Before him, tall wooden shelves rose up into dimness, crammed with leather-bound books and bins of ancient scrolls" (CoK 84). It is a scene of book abundance, but every step of it reveals that it is tinged with loss. The library is a doomed treasure trove:

Sam yawned. "Maester Aemon sent me to find maps for the Lord Commander. I never thought . . . Jon, the *books*, have you ever seen their like? There are *thousands*!" [Jon] gazed about him. "The library at Winterfell has more than a hundred. Did you find the maps?" [...] [Sam] shoved some scrolls aside to reveal a dusty volume bound in rotted leather. "*This*," he said reverently, "is the account of a journey from the Shadow Tower all the way to Lorn Point on the Frozen Shore, written by a ranger named Redwyn. It's not dated, but he mentions a Dorren Stark as King in the North, so it must be from before the

Conquest." [...] "There's more maps. If I had time to search . . . everything's a jumble. *I* could set it all to order, though, I know I could, but it would take time . . . well, *years*, in truth." "Mormont wanted those maps a little sooner than that." Jon plucked a scroll from a bin, blew of the worst of the dust. A corner flaked off between his fingers as he unrolled it. "Look, this one is crumbling," he said, frowning over the faded script. "Be gentle." Sam came around the table and took the scroll from his hands, holding it as if it were a wounded animal. "The important books used to be copied over when they needed it. Some of the oldest have been copied half a hundred times, probably." (84–85)

While the books at Castle Black are falling apart, the passage contains a more oblique echo of loss: the reader knows that the Winterfell library tower was burned in the assassination attempt on Bran. Just at the moment Sam has found a huge library, we are reminded that libraries can burn. But there is a more immediate threat. Ultimately, it is not book-burning, but neglect, that is the greatest danger to a library. As Matthew Battles has argued,

[b]efore the flames, before theft and censorship, the fate of books is bound up in the constant shuffling and transformation of the word in all its uses. [...] The libraries of Alexandria probably shared a modest fate, moldering slowly through the centuries as people grew indifferent and even hostile to their contents. [...] Ignored by the generations to whom they were indecipherable, the scrolls would have been damaged by alternating periods of moisture and aridity, eaten by the troublesome fauna and flora that have evolved especially to live in the library, stolen, lost, and, yes, burned. (31, 32)

The material in Sam's hands was meant to be "copied over," i.e. integrated into a self-renewing book culture that carried knowledge from one material embodiment into the next: in other words, a scriptorium. Sam knows that the library used to be maintained by a staff of scribes and copyists, maester librarians, cartographers, and chroniclers. The Night's Watch must once have produced, organized, and preserved knowledge, but now, after a century of funding cuts, those efforts have stopped. They seem to have left no catalogues: in this library, as in many other fantastical libraries in literature, Janet Brennan Croft's observation holds true: "we seldom see the use of higher-level finding aids like catalogs, indexes, cross-reference lists, and so on. The key to finding anything in the collection seems to exist primarily in the vast memory of the person in charge of it—or the good luck, instincts, and perseverance of the person doing the digging" (90). We must assume that the maps Sam finds are

out of date, but there is no alternative: knowledge production, as well as its preservation, has stopped.

The scene pulls in two directions: it gives us tantalizing glimpses of untold detail, but allows Sam no narrative time to explore it:

"I found drawings of the faces in the trees, and a book about the tongue of the children of the forest . . . works that even the Citadel doesn't have, scrolls from old Valyria, counts of the seasons written by maesters dead a thousand years . . ." (CoK 86)

Sam only has time to give a list; metadata, if you will, only the outline of what might be in the archive. The list enumerates both ancient material (Valyrian scrolls) and long-forgotten scholarly enquiry (at some point, someone tried to record the faces in the heart trees). Information, in other words, has a deep history in the diegetic world, but no narrative future. To modern eyes, the "counts of the seasons written by maesters dead a thousand years" look like vital environmental data, given the parallels between the threatening Long Night and climate change.¹⁰ This scene represents the promise of answers, fullness, and completion, but defers them: Martin holds out the trope of the library as "a location for endless discovery," in Michelle Anjirbag's formulation, but then deliberately disappoints it (80). For the reader, this is a case of deferred book gratification. Both Sam and the reader end up feeling what Carolyn Steedman has called "archive fever":

You know you *will not finish*, that there will be something left unread, unnoted, untranscribed. [...] Your anxiety is more precise, and more prosaic. It's about PT S2/1/1, which only arrived from the stacks that afternoon, which is enormous, and which you will never get through tomorrow. (18, emphasis in original)

Sam's list is about that immediacy of archive fever; instead of the vast and amorphous archive, he focuses on the few texts he has had time for. When Jon questions the value of a bill for dried cod, Sam exclaims: "You can learn so much from ledgers like that, truly you can. It can tell you how many men were in the Night's Watch then, how they lived, what they ate . . ." (CoK 86). An instinctive historian, Sam understands what details mean. But there is never enough time in the archive.

Kristine Larsen has claimed that books, in *A Song of Ice and Fire*, hold the potential to solve the problems facing its main characters: "Sometimes the wisdom of the departed is the very thing that will assure our survival, [for

¹⁰ Climate allegory is discussed in Di Paolo and Laukkanen.

example] through the transmission of knowledge” (52). We do not know if, in the two books still to be published in the series, the answers to the various mysteries will be solved by reading books. *A Dance with Dragons* sees Sam researching the Others and Aemond leaving Jon a book that mentions Azor Ahai. The problem is always that the individuals who learn things from books are just that: individuals, fragile, and in danger. Sam and Aemond are driven disastrously off course on their way to Citadel book heaven; Jon applies the Azor Ahai myth only to Stannis and his counterfeit burning sword, and is then assassinated by his own sworn brothers. Knowledge needs to be instantiated into a person, preferably someone with the power to act on it, before it is useful, but those people, in *A Song of Ice and Fire*, are vulnerable. In the TV series, Jon is resurrected and Sam learns of Jon’s Targaryen parentage from a diary held in the Citadel, but we do not know if that would be the outcome in Martin’s projected final books, nor whether Sam having that knowledge, or even Bran learning it from his tree network, would actually change anything. What is certain is that in the book series, books alone are inert, and humans, once they have absorbed book knowledge, are vulnerable and often isolated. It is not just access to books that is a problem, but whether you understand what you have learned, and whether you will live to apply it to your, and the world’s, problems.

CHRONICLES AND THE USE OF HISTORIOGRAPHY

Book culture in Westeros is undoubtedly modelled on a medieval and early modern European template, but it is colored with an implicit but powerful impression: in Westeros, those who wield power seem indifferent to the written word. The monarchy employs no chroniclers (or at least, they are not mentioned), and the culture of history writing seems to have either died out, or been enclaved in the Citadel, outside of narrative reach for most of the five books. The opening sentence of *Fire and Blood* tells us about “the maesters of the Citadel who keep the histories of Westeros,” suggesting that history writing is confined to the ivory tower and not encouraged, funded, or even much noticed by the political rulers of King’s Landing.¹¹ Jaime Lannister writes in the White Book, a list of Kingsguard knights and their deeds, which is the only hint we have of any written source that references Robert’s Rebellion and the fall of the Targaryen dynasty (SoS2 435).¹² If historiography is undertaken at the Citadel, it still remains absent from the consciousness of the rulers in King’s Landing. When history books are mentioned in passing—Tyrion is reading “Beldecar’s

¹¹ The extradiegetic book *Fire and Blood*, published in 2018, doubles as a diegetic chronicle, written by Maester Gyldayn, but its diegetic year of publication is unclear.

¹² The White Book bears echoes of the warrior chronicles of, for example, Jean Froissart. See Given-Wilson 99–111.

History of the Rhoynish Wars" (SoS1 166), for example—their creation is always a thing of the past. King Daeron wrote his *Conquest of Dorne* to celebrate his own achievement, and it is a book still discussed for its inaccuracy: it is both called "vainglorious" (DwD1 267) and "boastful" (DwD1 346), and in Dorne it clearly rankles that the Young Dragon exaggerated his achievements (FfC 678). The book achieved its aim by making Daeron a byword for clever military tactics and youthful daring in most of the Seven Kingdoms—but not in Dorne.

Such propagandistic use of history writing, however, seems to have died out. Renly Baratheon, whose brother had taken the throne by force, at one point explains how little chronicling or historical legitimacy have played into his brother's rule:

Renly shrugged. "Tell me, what right did my brother Robert ever have to the Iron Throne?" He did not wait for an answer. "Oh, there was talk of the blood ties between Baratheon and Targaryen, of weddings a hundred years past, of second sons and elder daughters. No one but the maesters care about any of it. Robert won the throne with his warhammer." (CoK 319)

Renly is making a self-serving point here, because he is himself trying to take the throne after Robert's death. Arguably, since the Baratheon genealogical claim was so feeble that it had to resort to "second sons and elder daughters," there was not much point in trying to win the argument that way. But he is not wrong about the status of history writing in Westeros. There is no mention of an official chronicle of Robert's Rebellion or of his rule; or of any attempt to legitimize his takeover. Aerys's crimes are everywhere talked about, but we do not see them documented or set down for posterity.

This forms an intriguing contrast to medieval European history. Gabrielle Spiegel has described how the French kings used history writing, undertaken at the monastery of Saint Denis, to consolidate their power over the many semi-independent regions of France, and to streamline their dynastic right to rule (209). Chris Given-Wilson, while he argues that overwhelmingly English kings did not sponsor history writing between the thirteenth and fifteenth centuries, shows how Edward I and John of Gaunt both seemingly requested that monasteries send them chronicles—and monks to explain them—to legitimize their rights to (respectively) Scottish overlordship and the English throne (Given-Wilson 65, 70, 75). The chronicler Jean Froissart, who was employed by Philippa of Hainault, queen to Edward III, wrote extensively of the early events of the Wars of the Roses, much of which he lived through, and some of which he would have witnessed at her court (Castor 11, 242; Devaux). Later in the Wars of the Roses, Yorkist propaganda writers used the chronicle forms to argue for Edward IV's right to rule, and his ascension was supported by

extensive genealogies (Radulescu 406; Alan). As Raluca Radulescu argues, “the period of time after Edward IV’s ascent to the throne was characterized by an increase in the number of royal pedigrees and chronicles. Edward needed both to justify his claim to the throne and to gather popular support for his future military campaigns in order to recover territories in Scotland and France” (407). A near-contemporary propaganda account of Edward IV’s exile and return, “The Historie of the Arrivall of King Edward IV,” was most likely written by a servant in his court (Ross 432–33).

Edward IV is one of the primary historical models for Robert Baratheon, but Robert and those around him seem to have invested no time or energy in any such legitimisation of his claim. Past events do matter. At the start of *A Game of Thrones*, the adult characters have lived through violent and contentious events, and those events continue to colour their interpretation of current events, their motivations, and their actions. They have lived, and are living, in history. But that history is neither justified by, or committed to, a broader tradition of written history. Books are not weapons: only weapons are weapons in Westeros.

ORAL CULTURE AND NARRATIVE LOSS

Like Tolkien’s Middle-earth, Martin’s diegetic world is “a mixture of oral and literate cultures” (Lee 51). As Walter Ong has pointed out, “in functionally oral cultures the past is not felt as an itemized terrain, peppered with verifiable and disputed ‘facts’ or bits of information. It is the domain of the ancestors, a resonant source for renewing awareness of present existence, which itself is not an itemized terrain either” (97). To write a novel series about oral culture is a contradiction in terms, of course: novels participate in written culture, and when they portray mechanisms that make the past “resonant” through the spoken word, the result is often elegiac. That irony—that the novel evokes modes of transmission that cannot realistically be recorded—is alive in the narrative fabric of *A Song of Ice and Fire*. In Martin’s epic series, oral and written cultures coexist, but neither seems adequate to maintain a link with past knowledge.

We see the failure of both oral transmission and book culture when Lord Commander Mormont realizes that the Others truly exist. He exclaims to Sam:

We *never knew!* But we must have known once. The Night’s Watch has forgotten its true purpose, Tarly. You don’t build a wall seven hundred feet high to keep savages in skins from stealing women. The Wall was made to *guard the realms of men* . . . and not against other men, which is all the wildlings are when you come right down to it. Too many years,

Tarly, too many hundreds and thousands of years. We lost sight of the true enemy. (SoS1 451)

Mormont here uses a “we” that transcends history: the Night’s Watch becomes a chain of guardians somehow charged with remembering; one long consciousness capable of “forgetting” its purpose and the threat which it was created to fight. Mormont encompasses himself in this “we,” a collapsing of generations that were meant to keep memory alive as much as fight a supernatural foe.

The problem is that the objective truth, which we know the Others to be, has been relegated to, literally, old wives’ tales, represented by Old Nan. She is an easily dismissible figure, being both old and a woman, and one who seems to be losing her grasp on the linear progression of time. Bran, a precocious eight-year-old, is right at the cusp of starting to question her authority. When he angrily tells her “I hate your stupid stories,” she reacts calmly: “My stories? No, my little lord, not mine. The stories *are*, before me and after me, before you too” (GoT 321). Her timescale is inhuman, but she stands as an instantiation of knowledge that goes beyond the individual: “[s]he had lived so long, Mother had told him once, that all the Brandon Starks had become one person in her head” (GoT 231–32). This collapse of all the different Brandons is not just a mirror of Mormont’s enduring “we,” but also of the tree network that Bran will eventually access; another form of temporal collapse, but a magical one. In other words, what it takes for memory to be kept live is an extra-rational, sometimes magical commingling with the past, a state of temporal flux that runs counter to the dominant rationalist attitude. As Jessica Walker has argued, “[c]yclical history is perhaps the most powerful force in Martin’s series” (81). Old Nan’s stories of the Long Night are warnings about its return, but she lives on the margins of a world that believes itself to be rational.

The truth is literally fantastical, but the general tenor of Westerosi society is that oral culture is a tale, not truth. Westerosi song culture bears this out. Sansa is obsessed with “songs” (always plural in her focalized chapters) that weave heroics into daily life, but lives to learn that the songs are lies. Around her, martial society uses songs to pretend the world is more heroic than it is, but realists like Sandor Clegane have learned to mistrust the fantasy of the enchanted past brought into the glorious present. Gabrielle M. Spiegel has argued that in oral culture, “human action is best understood by comparison with the legacy of stories about the past, and the fundamental goal of oral recitation is, precisely, to revivify the past and make it live in the present” (184). On many levels of Westerosi high society, this remains a comforting lie: bread and circuses to keep the masses faithful. For the powerful, the past tends to stay

safely in the past, the dead stay dead, and heroes only come back through trickery (as when Renly's ghost supposedly joins the Battle of the Blackwater).

On a metafictional level, however, the songs achieve a narrative power: they foreshadow and interweave. "The Rains of Castamere" is used to foreshadow the Red Wedding; "The Bear and the Maiden Fair" precedes Brienne's violent meeting with a bear in a *mêlée* ring; "Hands of Gold," ostensibly a satirical song about Tyrion's relationship with Shae, becomes a prophecy about her murder at his hands. In other words, the knitting together of past and present through songs happens ironically, in the narrative structure, around a series of characters who do not see their lives as tales, and who have mostly learned to distrust the songs. They do not have access to the kinds of parallels that the songs metafictionally suggest, until they are smacked in the face with them and have to survive (or die).

This metafictional play with readerly knowledge and character skepticism extends to the narrative structure of the first two books. *A Game of Thrones* starts with a prologue focalized by a member of the Night's Watch who sees one of the Others (also known as White Walkers). The chapter ends when the Other kills him. In the next chapter, focalized by Bran, the last witness to this supernatural attack is beheaded by Ned for desertion. Significantly, Bran hears, but quickly forgets, his last words, and they are not relayed (GoT 12). This loss of knowledge symbolizes the inaccessibility of what we readers have seen, but characters never will. For the rest of the book, characters continually deny what we know to be true, namely that the Others have returned. In other words, the reader is invited, from the beginning, to mistrust received wisdom and to tentatively believe in the "hearth tale" and the myth. The second book, *A Clash of Kings*, starts with a similar metafictional demonstration. Uniquely in the book series, the book opens with an event that can be witnessed from all over Westeros and Essos: the red comet. But crucially, everyone interprets it to suit their own purposes: for some the comet is Lannister red, for some it heralds the success of Mormont's quest beyond the wall, and so on. As Brian Cowlshaw argues of the red comet sequence, Martin "displays consecutive examples of how knowledge is contingent at best, or wish fulfilment at worst. [...] He virtually begs us to nurture doubt in him as a reliable storyteller" (66). I would suggest that what we are being invited to doubt is not necessarily the storyteller, but the very idea that there is a place of truth at all. Everyone in Westeros has opinions, but the narrative denies us certainty. As Johnston and Battis argue, "Martin's diversity of perspectives reminds us that the game of thrones is also a game of knowing, a puzzling chain of views that are sometimes linked, but which often fail to make contact at crucial points, just as our own perspective as readers cannot possibly hold everything together" (9). These two book openings demonstrate, metafictionally, two central tenets about the series' portrayal of

knowledge: accepted truths are wrong, and yet a people so divided will never agree, even on things they can see with their own eyes. Oral tradition might seem full in Westeros, but is in fact full of breakages, misinterpretations, and lies. To the characters who populate the world, there are no incontrovertible signifiers: no message or symbol that can be read and understood by everyone equally. Not even direct experience can coordinate all those diverse perspectives into agreement, let alone oral culture or written culture.

The narrative structure of *A Song of Ice and Fire*—each chapter focalized by a specific character—gives readers access to experiences that are never recorded or shared in the diegetic world, and which are constantly leeching out of that world with each death of a POV character. The effect of the narrative structure is not only that individual perspective is coded as vital, but that it is frustratingly and achingly personal. Information is radically dispersed; knowledge is fragmented; those who have experienced the same events, but experienced them very differently, may be scattered across wide distances, never to meet and compare their stories. Ned's death is emblematic of this failure: throughout *A Game of Thrones*, his chapters have revealed aspects of the past while tantalizingly shrouding others, since Ned either refuses or is unable to fully revisit Lyanna's death in his mind. The result is that his death not only denies Jon knowledge of his parentage, but denies the reader truth as well. Throughout the books, and especially in prologues and epilogues, we hear chapters from characters as they are about to die; each time, an individual truth is winked out, whether it belongs to a migraine-ridden lesser scion of House Frey or the head of a great house.¹³ None of the experiences narrated can be contained within the book culture *or* the oral culture of Westeros: no one documents those experiences. As Farah Mendlesohn has argued, "[i]mmersive" fantasy is "overwhelmingly concerned with the entropy of the world" (61). In the case of *A Song of Ice and Fire*, what is disappearing is individual experience.

This is symbolized in *A Feast for Crows* by the "hedge septons" who wander between remote villages. In the eyes of the faith, they are there to bring the light of the Seven to the villagers, not to commit them to book culture: they neither census-take, register births, deaths, and marriages, or impose any other kind of bureaucracy. Septon Meribald, who accompanies Brienne for a while, is illiterate, "but he knew a hundred different prayers and could recite long passages from *The Seven-Pointed Star* from memory, which was all that was required in the villages" (FFC 414). As the High Sparrow intimates to Cersei, his own role as hedge septon was simply to bear witness to those lives; lives now lost because of war: "I tended to half a hundred little villages too small to have a septon of their own. I walked from each one to the next, performing marriages,

¹³ Merrett Frey is executed by the Brotherhood in the epilogue of *A Storm of Swords* 2 (542–54).

absolving sinners of their sins, naming newborn children" (FfC 473).¹⁴ Hedge septons represent narrative attention to the otherwise unnoticed. It is Meribald who articulates one of the most evocative themes in *A Feast for Crows*, the deep damage the war has brought to the common people, by explaining the "broken men," herded off to battles they do not understand and then abandoned (FfC 420). However, such peripatetic septons are themselves vulnerable, and not all of them get to King's Landing alive, as the High Sparrow did. A dwarf septon is murdered because Cersei has offered a price for Tyrion's head; his killers admit that "he *said* he were a sparrow" while also transparently caring not at all whether they got the right man or not, as long as they have a chance of a reward (FfC 268). Many readers might not even notice that this is probably the kind septon Brienne met in Duskendale earlier in *A Feast for Crows*, who had been the only survivor when his monastery was sacked by sellswords (FfC 154). This loss of a single individual is nothing in the grand scheme of the slaughter both portrayed and implied in the book, but it points to the destruction of networks of knowledge within the kingdom. Every organizing principle and small bureaucracy, even as small as a wandering septon, is in danger. The unnamed septon's death is thus not just an individual loss, but a loss of institutional and social knowledge. The books even conjure entire voids of experience, symbolized by the silent sisters. A religious order which readies dead bodies for burial, the silent sisters take a vow of silence (FfC 520). "*The silent sisters do not speak to the living*, Catelyn remembered dully, *but some say they can speak to the dead*. And how she envied that . . ." (CoK 518). Their role in *A Song of Ice and Fire* is to represent the unrepresentable experience; the un-communicated life. They are information lacunae in a novel series obsessed with giving voice to marginalized information.

TREE LIBRARIES AND LOST EXPERIENCE

Knowledge is personal, limited, restricted, and essentially incommunicable; book culture in Westeros seems irrevocably focused on the far past. The result is that the books series is elegiac not for a lost golden age, but for the knowledge falling away with every destroyed village, holdfast, and library *and* with every life lost. As Carolyn Steedman has pointed out, the archive is not memory, and the two must not be confused (68). Metafictionally, *A Song of Ice and Fire* is an exploration of the gap between the two.

It may seem strange to evoke Westerosi book culture only to argue that it is a narrative stand-in for failure; and yet, it is through that failure that we see how knowledge is conceptualised in the books. What kinds of knowing, learning, and "reading" are valuable in this world? What kind of information

¹⁴ For a thematic link to the Franciscan order, see Błaszczewicz.

can be trusted? When Bran gains access to the tree network, he sees the past through his own eyes, but he has access to what Jojen very explicitly describes as a substitute for a library:

"A reader lives a thousand lives before he dies," said Jojen. "The man who never reads lives only once. The singers of the forest had no books. No ink, no parchment, no written language. Instead they had the trees, and the weirwoods above all. When they died, they went into the wood, into leaf and limb and root, and the trees remembered. All their songs and spells, their histories and prayers, everything they knew about this world. Maesters will tell you that the weirwoods are sacred to the old gods. The singers believe they *are* the old gods. When singers die they become part of that godhood." (DwD1 526)

While the book series is fascinated with the mutability of textual transmission and memory, it seems in the fifth book to circumvent textuality in favor of a privileged magical individual, "reading" the memories of individual consciousnesses of the singers. The trees are repositories, seemingly of the "*song of earth*" (DwD1 203, emphasis in the original). The library is a metaphor only, since there is "no ink, no parchment, no written language." It is a metaphor for knowledge of the environment, *ecoscientia*, which is transspecies in that it both incorporates singers, humans, and seemingly plants. Personal experience is magically subsumed into the memory of the earth, suggesting that the environment needs Singers to experience (and die), and humans—Brynden the three-eyed raven, and now Bran—to access those experiences. But tree memory is not a replacement for book culture; rather, I see it as a metaphor for the narrative conventions of the novel, a storytelling genre that records both actions and thoughts, even those that characters do not have access to. When a person dies, their unique perspective also dies out of the world, and it takes literal magic, in the form of a transtemporal tree network, to access a faint afterimage of their experiences.

Meanwhile, the physical books are left to gather dust and mites in forgotten libraries; in Martin's unfinished epic, personal experience is more immediate, if also more vulnerable, than book culture. The continual emphasis on age, on unreadability, on scrolls as stand-ins for inaccessible knowledge adrift in time, seems to set books in stark contrast to first-hand experience. But in reality, maybe the message is that books must in fact *not* be neglected—that they only become inadequate when they are not used. Inert books must themselves be experienced—read and, crucially, actively interpreted—before their contents can have an effect on the world. In Martin's world, book knowledge (or any other knowledge) is only useful if it is instantiated in a

person—it only *becomes* knowledge when it is acquired—but heartbreakingly, the people who come to know the truth are vulnerable and unprotected.

Fantasy literature has often been accused of being inherently conservative (McGarry and Ravipinto). And it is true that much fantasy literature is riven with sadness for the loss of ages passed. But I believe this article has shown that the feeling of loss is not inevitably coupled with toxic nostalgia for a golden age of balance and benign rule, but rather evoked to work through complex questions about how the past perserveres into the present. Fantasy book series are notoriously long and fantasy readers are assumed to feel positive about the concept of the book, no matter whether they themselves consume paperbacks, hardbacks, e-books, or audio. Why then does Martin continually evoke the *frisson* of books destroyed or books ignored? My claim is that his book series portrays books as residual objects to work through that feeling of loss. Anxieties about decline of knowledge are also anxieties about the future, and about the flimsy bulwark a library forms against entropy. Fantasy literature as a genre works with the interlacings of past and present, the messages left behind by those who are no longer alive, and the decay, garbling, and possible manipulation of those messages in impermanent, vulnerable material forms.

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MARIA DAMKJÆR (PhD, Dr.Phil.) is an Associate Professor at the University of Copenhagen. She gained her PhD in English Literature at King's College London. She has specialized in Victorian literature, with an interest in the materiality of the text, book history, genre, and temporality. Damkjær is the author of *Time, Domesticity and Print Culture in Nineteenth-Century Britain* (Palgrave, 2016) and *Fiction on the Page in Nineteenth-Century Magazines* (Oxford University Press, 2025).



he BRIGHT SWORD AND ITS SHARPNESS: SWORDS, SYMBOLISM, AND MEDIEVALISM IN *THE LORD OF THE RINGS*

GAVIN S. DAVIS

SWORDS ARE PARADOXICAL OBJECTS that hold in tension both aesthetic beauty and repulsion. On the one hand, swords project glamor as finely crafted objects of self-display and social power, adorning the belts of countless heroic figures in history and literature alike. On the other hand, it must be recognized that swords are weapons that kill, maim, and injure—a purpose-built tool for the morally complex business of homicide. How one goes about resolving this paradox has much to say about one's personal ideology. When discussing the ongoing crises in Middle-earth, Faramir offers his own ideology towards war and weapons, succinctly summed up with the statement: "I do not love the bright sword for its sharpness, nor the arrow for its swiftness, nor the warrior for his glory. I love only that which they defend [...]"—a statement which is also considered to express J.R.R. Tolkien's own personal attitude towards weapons (*LotR* IV.5.672; *Letters* 337, #180; Croft, "War" 471). But Faramir is only one individual in a world rich with distinct characters, cultures, and swords. What can be said about the other cultural attitudes towards swords represented in *The Lord of the Rings*?

Tolkien represents the sword as an ideologically loaded object with shifting symbolic significance between the cultures of Rohan, Gondor, and Hobbits in *The Lord of the Rings*. These changes in significance produce three kinds of medievalism—post-medieval reconstructions of the Middle Ages—that each facilitates different postures towards the cultural imagination of the medieval world.¹ Through the Rohirrim, Tolkien depicts a medievalism of spectacle—an idealized world of valor to be marveled at from the safe distance that separates the Secondary World of fantasy from our own.² With Gondor,

¹ The seminal definition of medievalism provided by Leslie Workman is the "process of creating the Middle Ages" and "the study not of the Middle Ages themselves but of the scholars, artists, and writers who [...] constructed the idea of the Middle Ages that we inherited" (quoted in Utz and Shippey 5, emphasis theirs, and Workman 439). These quotes and their critical context are cited and discussed more thoroughly in Matthews 7. For a more thorough discussion of medievalism, see Matthews.

² Tolkien uses the terms "Primary World" and "Secondary World" in "On Fairy-stories" to distinguish between the Primary World of the reality we experience and the Secondary World of sub-created fantasy.

Tolkien's medievalism critiques the shortsightedness of a culture that prioritizes the sword's functional utility over the values that would characterize its symbolism and govern its justified use. Finally, *Hobbits* offer a third interaction with medievalism as their characteristic unfamiliarity with swords connects their experience with that of the similarly non-medieval reader. By filtering the warrior-cultures of Middle-earth through the experiences of Hobbits, *The Lord of the Rings* closes the space between the Secondary World of fantasy and the Primary World of reality, turning the reader's attention to their own experience of the imagined medieval past. Without providing easy answers, *The Lord of the Rings* interlaces contrasting ideological perspectives into a sophisticated imagination of the medieval sword that, rather than solving the paradox of the sword's beauty and complexity, subsumes the whole with spectacle, critique, and self-reflection.

WORDS: "USEFUL TOOLS TO THINK WITH"

The methodology of this paper combines recent developments in the study of swords by cultural historians with theories of medievalism to structure our understanding of Tolkien's substantial contribution to the cultural imagination of the medieval sword. Swords are currently enjoying a renaissance of scholarly investigation in the fields of archaeology and history which seek to uncover the sword's social functions as a highly symbolic cultural object. While such investigation directly relates to the study of swords in medieval literature, the same methods contribute to our understanding of the continued, developing symbolism of swords in medievalism and in Tolkien's fantasy.

Accompanying a new wave of scholarly interest in the study of the medieval sword, Kristen Neuschel's *Living by the Sword* (2020) reworks the structures used to understand swords as culturally significant objects with diverse meanings to argue that *what* swords mean may not be as productive as considering *how* they mean. Neuschel writes, "Objects are not merely the product of thought, [sic] they become in turn shapers of thought and of feeling. Things, especially certain things, are useful tools to think with, to shape thought, habits, behavior—culture, in short. In this way, objects are like texts: they are out in the world, detached from the producer, gaining and giving meaning in action in the human lifeworld" (9). While Neuschel applies this framework to the historical swords of the Middle Ages, the concept of swords as textual objects that carry meaning detached from their users also applies to the reimagined signification of swords in medievalism. In other words, the systems that determine what swords "mean" have not ceased, but persist in medievalisms that perpetuate and reinvent the past. If medievalism is the "process of creating the Middle Ages" (Workman, qtd. in Utz and Shippey 5) and swords—icons of the Middle Ages in their own right—are useful tools to think with, then an

understanding of the sword in its cultural context provides insight into both the culture as well as the nature of that culture's engagement with the memory of the Middle Ages.

Using this framework, Tolkien's engagement with the medieval sword (and Tolkien's medievalisms generally) may be analyzed according to the different mechanisms by which Tolkien's works use, intervene into, and are themselves received into the cultural memory of the Middle Ages. First, we can attune to the preexisting literary conventions that Tolkien mobilizes to ground the swords of his Secondary World in a sense of reality. This kind of study—not unlike the early comparative studies that connected the swords of Old English literature with their archeological counterparts—identifies the connections between source material (overwhelmingly medieval, in Tolkien's case) that are invoked in the creation of an author's symbolic language—in other words, “Resonances of Medieval Swords and Sword-lore in J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*,” to borrow the subtitle from Whetter and McDonald's substantial contribution to this line of inquiry.³

Second, we may discern how Tolkien provides his own contribution to the cultural imagination of swords through adaptation and original representation in his literature. Rather than studying what swords have meant historically before Tolkien, this line of inquiry considers Tolkien's own intervention into the meaning of swords. Whetter and McDonald hint at such analysis, noting that swords can mark the transition from the familiar world of the hobbits to the adventures of the heroic world (24), but other scholarship has explored Tolkien's contributions more thoroughly, such as Janet Brennan Croft's analysis of Tolkien's named weapons and Michael Brisbois's analysis of the social significance of swords, represented especially by the semiotics of Andúril.

Third, we may observe how a changing readership accesses Tolkien's intervention from different perspectives. Tolkien's impact on the modern cultural imagination of swords has shifted over time as it shares space with other works of medievalism. While *The Lord of the Rings* left an indelible impression on the development of high-fantasy that is difficult to overstate, it nevertheless makes up an increasingly smaller percentage of high-fantasy available to the consumer market. Still, many popular medievalisms contain traces (perhaps several degrees removed) of Tolkien's contribution to the popular imagination

³ While Whetter and McDonald offer the most comprehensive study of medieval sword-culture invoked by Tolkien, see also Beach. For comparative studies between the archaeology and literature of early medieval swords, see Davidson 121–28; Brunning 111–38.

of the Middle Ages. Just as the reception of Tolkien's works has changed over time, so has the nature of Tolkien's contribution to medievalism.

To investigate the second and third of these mechanisms, we now turn to how three major cultures in *The Lord of the Rings*—Gondor, Rohan, and the Hobbits—each exhibit different ideological priorities towards swords and their symbolism, and how these representations shape the nature of *The Lord of the Rings* itself as medievalism.⁴ These different representations of swords fit into the greater whole of Tolkien's work by offering a compelling imagination of swords as objects of spectacle *and* criticism that engage directly with our contemporary distance from medieval sword culture.

THE ROHIRRIM: SINGING, SWORDS, AND SPECTACLE

Nowhere else in Middle-earth are swords more visually striking than in Tolkien's depiction of the Rohirrim. Through their spontaneous use of swords as symbols of fealty, their poetry, and their battlefield valor, Rohan's sword culture steeps their weapons in symbolism that enriches their value both to the user and to the reader. This culture, drawn from the often tragic warrior cultures preserved in Old English poetry, is not without its complexities. However, within *The Lord of the Rings*, Rohan's sword-wielding warrior culture treats the audience to a fantasy of idealized martial valor rendered as spectacle.

Central to Rohirric culture is the social work performed by the sword as a symbol of fealty between a lord and his warriors, representing both the strength of the lord to rule his people as well as the loyal service of the lord's warriors. The chapter "The King of the Golden Hall" demonstrates this symbolic work as the narrative moves from the absence of weapons to the dramatic presentation of swords, signifying the restoration of Théoden as king and the renewal of the Rohirric court. The outset of the chapter prompts attention to weapons as Gandalf counsels his companions against drawing their swords to avoid unnecessary suspicion from the wary and warlike people (III.6.507). Disarmament increases when the weapons of Legolas, Aragorn, Gimli, and Gandalf are demanded from them at the doors to Théoden's hall, marking a narrative low-point of anxiety and isolation as would-be allies have their weapons removed. This focus on disarmament is contrasted by the subsequent

⁴ Besides considerations of length, the omission of elves, dwarves, and orcs requires some justification: although elvish swords feature prominently in the *Lord of the Rings*, they are most often wielded by non-elvish characters. Moreover, any comprehensive study of elvish sword-culture ought to engage with *The Silmarillion*, and is therefore outside the scope of this project. Similarly, dwarvish culture is primarily represented in *The Hobbit*, and even then rarely engages with swords. The relationship of orcs with weapons—though an intriguing line of inquiry—would require a consideration of Tolkien's metaphysics which is also well beyond the focus of this study.

rearmament of Rohan following the restoration of Théoden to good counsel by Gandalf. Notably, it is not the reintroduction of light or hope that finally returns Théoden's strength, but the restoration of a sword to Théoden's hand by Éomer:

Slowly Théoden stretched forth his hand. As his fingers took the hilt, it seemed to the watchers that firmness and strength returned to his thin arm. Suddenly he lifted the blade and swung it shimmering and whistling in the air. Then he gave a great cry. His voice rang clear as he chanted in the tongue of Rohan a call to arms.

Arise now, arise, Riders of Théoden!

Dire deeds awake, dark is it eastward.

Let horse be bridled, horn be sounded!

Forth Eorlingas!

The guards, thinking that they were summoned, sprang up the stair. They looked at their lord in amazement, and then as one man they drew their swords and laid them at his feet. 'Command us!' they said. (III.6.517)

Éomer's spontaneous presentation of his sword to Théoden elicits three major effects on both the narrative's development and our understanding of Rohirric sword-culture: first, the symbolic act of accepting a sword from faithful retainer renews Théoden and Éomer's relationship which had been marred by Gríma's influence. Second, Théoden's personal strength returns to him, signifying his renewed agency and authority as a warrior-king. Third, this leads to the sudden mustering of the Rohirrim who respond to their king's call to arms by laying their own swords at the feet of their lord. This dramatic sequence reveals the sword's centrality to Rohan's warrior culture which the narrative uses to signify the king's ascendant personal authority and renewed relationship with his retainers.

An appreciation of the full significance of these dramatic exchanges of swords requires an awareness Rohan's roots in Old English poetry which establish the conventions of traditional warrior-culture to which Rohan (mostly) adheres. Although Tolkien dismisses the similarities between Rohan and the early medieval English in the appendices to *The Lord of the Rings*, this note has fooled no one, and the close resemblance between Rohan and traditional Old English literature is well attested in secondary scholarship.⁵ A prominent feature

⁵ "This linguistic procedure [connecting Rohan's depiction as linguistically similar to Old English] does not imply that the Rohirrim closely resembled the ancient English otherwise, in culture or art, in weapons or modes of warfare, except in a general way due to their circumstances" (*LotR*.App.F.1136n). Major scholarly contributions on the similarities between Rohirric culture and Old English literary culture include Shippey 90–97 and

in Old English poetry is the relationship between the lord and his thegns (early medieval warrior aristocrats), signified by the symbolic exchange of weapons and other gifts as the warrior promises fealty and loyal martial service in exchange for the lord's promise of leadership and protection. Medievalists primarily associate this social organization (sometimes called "the heroic code") with earlier, continental warrior cultures which are remembered nostalgically in the Old English renditions of Germanic legend, although it occurs as a literary phenomenon in other genres as well.⁶ In these texts, weapons manifest the values of traditional warrior culture by symbolizing the warriors' oaths of fealty and equipping them to perform deeds of valor in fulfillment of those oaths. In *Beowulf*, weapons signify Beowulf's renown upon his arrival at Heorot, and exchanges of gifts of weapons cement his service to Hrothgar and celebrate Beowulf's accomplishments. The symbolic presentation of a sword reignites a blood-feud during the Finnsburh episode contained within *Beowulf*, a moment which Tolkien compares with precedent from Old Norse literature in which swearing on swords was a customary way of making oaths of fealty (*Finn and Hengest* 133). In the *Battle of Finnsburh* fragment, *swurdleoma*—"the gleam of swords"—describes the spectacle of Hengest's retinue fighting to the death for the honor of their slain lord.⁷ *The Battle of Maldon* and *The Battle of Brunanburh* follow this literary tradition by rendering later Old English kings, lords, and warriors in the fashion of legendary figures, depicting them as sword-wielding warriors willing to die for their lord, and Tolkien considers the words of Beorhtwold from *The Battle of Maldon*, "Will shall be the sterner, heart the bolder, spirit the greater as our strength lessens," to be the "finest expression of the northern heroic ethic."⁸ In short, the "heroic code," symbolized by the exchange of swords and their subsequent use, provides a social purpose for the warrior-heroes of early medieval English literature, establishing the precedent for the behavior of the Rohirrim.

But despite their similarities in martial culture, at least one major factor distinguishes the traditional warrior culture of Old English legend from its counterpart in Tolkien's fantasy: the martial culture of Germanic legend is overwhelmingly represented as tragic. In *The Battle of Maldon*, nearly all the English warriors (and all the ones with honor) are slain by vikings—a pointed criticism of the heroic spirit which was discussed by Tolkien in "The Homecoming of Beorhtnoth" and his accompanying essays. The Finnsburh

Kightley. Whitt doesn't deal directly with Rohan but identifies major thematic elements that are readily apparent in Rohirric culture.

⁶ For more information, see O'Keeffe, Bremmer, and Woolf.

⁷ Text and translation from Tolkien, *Finn and Hengest* 148–49.

⁸ "Hige sceal þe heardra, heorte þe cenre, / mod sceal þe mare þe ure maegen lytlað." Text and translation from Tolkien, "The Homecoming of Beorhtnoth" 5, 20.

episode is remembered as brutally tragic in both *Beowulf* and the fragment, and *Beowulf* itself ends with the death of its eponymous hero, leaving his nation leaderless and on the brink of war. As symbols of the idealized heroic code, Old English weapons are also problematized: Beowulf's famous swords fail him in battle (twice), a return of violence is foreshadowed by the recognition of an heirloom sword by a rival warrior, and upon Beowulf's death, a minstrel imagines a time when the sound of the harp shall be replaced by "a cold spear grasped in the morning" (*Beowulf* 3021–27).⁹

In stark contrast to the tragic warrior figures of Old English poetry, Rohan's warrior culture juxtaposes the business of swords with mirth, using swords to create a spectacular eucatastrophe at the Battle of the Pelennor fields. In Tolkien's lifted prose that moves "The Ride of the Rohirrim" into "The Battle of the Pelennor Fields," Théoden—the once ineffectual old king, bent with age and despair—is compared to "a god of old, even as Oromë the Great in the battle of the Valar when the world was young," and his battle cry is "a sword-day, a red day, ere the sun rises!" (V.5.838). Detail and metaphor further elevate the actions of the horsemen who express their joy through song as they charge onto the fields of the Pelennor: "and they sang as they slew, for the joy of battle was on them, and the sound of their singing that was fair and terrible came even to the City" (V.5.838). When the battle turns against the Rohirrim, Éomer defies despair with a grim humor, but this defiance turns again to even greater elation when hope returns to the battle through the arrival of Aragorn's host:

These staves he [Éomer] spoke, yet he laughed as he said them. For once more lust of battle was on him; and he was still unscathed, and he was young, and he was king: the lord of a fell people. And lo! Even as he laughed at despair he looked out again on the black ships, and he lifted up his sword to defy them.

And then wonder took him, and great joy; and he cast his sword up in the sunlight and sang as he caught it. (V.6.847)

Notably, Éomer manifests both defiance *and* joy in the hope of victory through his sword as he raises it against his foes and playfully throws the weapon in his exuberance, using the sword to express a full range of emotion. The narrative further deepens the association between swords and Rohan's valor by likening Éowyn to a sword during her great deed of courage: when she cuts down the Witch-king, Éowyn is described as a "maiden of the Rohirrim, child of kings, slender but as a steel-blade, fair yet terrible" (V.6.842). Finally, the funeral song

⁹ "Forðon sceall gār wezan / monig morgenceald mundum bewunden" (Therefore shall the spear shall be grasped in the grip many a cold morning). Text taken from Fulk, et al.; English translation is my own.

for Théoden memorializes Rohan's juxtaposition of joy with the action of swords which repeats Éomer's lines from the battle, cementing the connection between Théoden's victory with the symbolism of the sword (V.6.847):

*Out of doubt, out of dark, to the day's rising
he rode singing in the sun, sword unsheathing.
Hope he rekindled and in hope ended;
over death, over dread, over doom lifted
out of loss, out of life, unto long glory. (VI.6.976)*

This close association between joy and the sword indicates the ideological underpinnings of the sword for the Rohirrim: it is not only a tool of battle, but a symbol of a warrior's promised service to his lord through deeds of valor on the battlefield. When the sword is used to accomplish deeds of valor, it provides the joy of fulfilled purpose and moral accomplishment, even when martial victory is not guaranteed. The catastrophe of the destruction of Gondor is averted by the courageous behavior of the Rohirrim in the face of certain doom, and the sudden aversion of that doom creates the ideal circumstances for eucatastrophe—the "sudden, joyous 'turn'" that Tolkien considered the mark of a good fairy-story ("On Fairy-stories" 75). Departing from the tragedy and gloom traditionally associated with warrior culture in Old English poetry, the arrival of singing, sword-wielding warriors marks the climax of Rohan's achievement, creating a spectacle of swords at the pinnacle of their martial and symbolic function.

Rohan's sword culture should therefore be considered a medievalism of spectacle because its aesthetic beauty is uncompromised, even though the narrative context resists a full endorsement of its underlying ideology. Tolkien's recreation of an Old English warrior culture revives the ancient aesthetic value of the sword as a symbol, but despite the glamor of joyous, singing horsemen, this image of fantasy is not to be mistaken for a holistic depiction of war or a comprehensive peacetime ideology. Following the Battle of the Pelennor Fields, Rohan's warrior culture has little to contribute to the survival of Middle-earth, especially since their warlike ideology struggles to maintain relevance during the aftermath of the War of the Ring. This is acutely expressed by Éowyn's struggle to reintegrate to peacetime society following the termination of her ability to participate in the War of the Ring. Éowyn's final renunciation of the Rohirrim's warrior culture has been received as both an indictment of a culture that glorifies war as well a somewhat unconvincing change of character considering Éowyn's earnest justification for the necessity of warriors a few pages earlier (Dickerson 37–39; Croft, "War" 469). But while *The Lord of the Rings* does contain other more articulate critiques of martial culture that resist full endorsement, Rohan's aesthetic beauty in its moment of accomplishment

remains intact: the sword is both fair *and* terrible. Even Faramir—while acknowledging the tragic elements of her martial ethos—declares Éowyn “high and valiant and have yourself won renown that shall not be forgotten,” expressing his admiration for her embodiment of the heroic ethic before her subsequent change of heart (VI.5.964). In short, Tolkien’s depiction of Rohan’s sword culture preserves the sword’s ancient beauty as a symbol of faithfulness and valor derived from Old English literature, but localizes this idealization to specific narrative circumstances. Rohan’s joyful fulfillment of its martial purpose by riding to the defense of Gondor forms a moving spectacle, but one that is admired from a carefully situated distance between the Primary and Secondary Worlds.

Although the swords of Rohan represent a fantasy drawn from an idealization of the medieval past, the surrounding narrative maintains a critical distance that preserves the possibility of further nuance to an ideology centered on weapons and their use. Éowyn’s interactions with Faramir hint at such criticism as she reconciles herself to a world without a need for battlefield heroes, but Tolkien’s primary criticism of swords as objects of power comes from the other voices and cultures of Middle-earth.

GONDOR: FRACTURED SWORDS AND SHATTERED SYMBOLS

While the Rohirrim represent an idealization of sword culture with a unified symbolic and martial purpose, Gondorian culture at the beginning of *The Lord of the Rings* has a more fractured sense of the sword’s symbolic potential that isolates its utility as a weapon from the social symbolism that would govern its use. This separation, in addition to Gondor’s excessive emphasis on the need for weapons, problematizes the sword as glorious in-and-of itself. This separation of the sword’s symbolism from its utility does not dismiss the need for martial victory, but creates the need for the restoration of rightly-ordered values—a restoration that comes with the return of Gondor’s rightful king. As a representation of a medieval past, Gondor depicts pointed criticism of warrior culture along with Tolkien’s solution in the form of an idealized king.

The clearest diagnosis of Gondor’s decline comes from Faramir, whose comparative analysis of Gondor and Rohan identifies the Gondor’s treatment of martial culture as an end in itself as the root of his people’s dwindling status. In his telling of the history of Men, Faramir traces differences in cultural values that distinguish “the Middle People” of the Rohirrim from the “High” men of Númenor and their remnants in Gondor. Between the cultures, Faramir considers excessive emphasis on martial valor to be problematic when treated as a “good in itself,” becoming a kind of crux that distinguishes “Middle” from “High”:

Yet now, if the Rohirrim are grown in some ways more like to us, enhanced in arts and gentleness, we too have become more like to them, and can scarce claim any longer the title High. We are become Middle Men, of the Twilight, but with memory of other things. For as the Rohirrim do, we now love war and valour as things good in themselves, both a sport and an end; and though we still hold that a warrior should have more skills and knowledge than only the craft of weapons and slaying, we esteem a warrior, nonetheless, above men of other crafts. Such is the need of our days. (IV.5.679)

In this passage, Faramir expresses the diminished relative status of Gondor using the language of weapons. Faramir acknowledges the pragmatic necessity of “the craft of weapons and slaying” given the circumstances of wartime, but implies the need for other values beyond martial skill-of-weapons to balance a society and govern the appropriate use of those weapons. As put by Matthew Dickerson, “Faramir sees the love of war, the practice of war as a sport, and the esteeming of the warrior not as signs of the current glory of Gondor, but rather as signs of its fall” (60). This separation between a weapon’s martial utility and greater purpose is most clearly evident in Faramir’s previously quoted statement, “I do not love the bright sword for its sharpness, nor the arrow for its swiftness, nor the warrior for his glory. I love only that which they defend,” which orients the moral justification for the weapon’s use around the object of defense (IV.5.672). By calling the sword “bright,” Faramir seems to acknowledge the aesthetic beauty in an object so strongly associated with valor. But the value of the sword’s sharpness—the quality which turns the sword from a symbol to a weapon—is contingent upon the object of the sword’s use. Divorced from a clear sense of moral purpose, Faramir has little love for the sword.

Despite his sophisticated personal ideology, Faramir is an outlier in the struggling kingdom of Gondor that is consumed by the pragmatic need for weapons in its fight for survival. Boromir, rather, is considered a paragon of Gondor’s martial culture, but Boromir is nevertheless enamored by the Ring’s martial potential, providing further evidence of the moral decline at the heart of Gondor’s martial culture. At the Council of Elrond, Boromir makes his case for the need of weapons: “The Men of Gondor are valiant, and they will never submit; but they may be beaten down. Valour needs first strength, and then a weapon. Let the Ring be your weapon, if it has such power as you say. Take it and go forth to victory!” (II.2.267). When Elrond rejects such an idea based on the Ring’s power to corrupt the heart, Boromir relents with deep reluctance, saying “Then in Gondor we must trust to such weapons as we have” (II.2.267–68). Boromir’s reasoning builds on the premise that the only thing preventing Gondor from victory against Sauron is the magnitude of Gondor’s power, represented here by the potency of their weapons. Boromir fails to see in this

instance that might—be it valor or a potent weapon—may make for martial victory, but not the moral victory that those gathered at the Council of Elrond are seeking. This desire for weapons and power is explicitly connected to Boromir's tragic fall as it arises again in the midst of Boromir's final assault on Frodo: "[H]is talk dwelt on walls and weapons, and the mustering of men; and he drew plans for great alliances and glorious victories to be; and he cast down Mordor, and became himself a mighty king, benevolent and wise" (II.10.398). As described by Dickerson, Boromir's obsession with military victory and his assault on Frodo makes a worldview that glorifies war complicit in the subsequent breaking of the fellowship (60–62). While Rohan's spectacular military victory will later be convenient for the survival of Minas Tirith, Boromir's neglect of the moral frameworks that would constrain the use of weapons results in his inability to comprehend the moral danger posed by the Ring of Power.

Gondor's disconnect between weapons and the morality that would govern their use manifests in the fractured symbolism of the sword. While fealty and service characterize the symbolic and martial work of Rohan's swords, a comparison of Merry's and Pippin's respective declarations of fealty to Théoden and Denethor reveals the diminished symbolic weight of Gondor's swords. Merry's oath of fealty to Théoden is informal, simple, and sincere: Merry asks if he may lay his sword as on Théoden's lap as token of his service, having been prompted by a sudden love for the old king. Théoden accepts, bids Merry rise an esquire of Rohan, and commands him to take his sword and bear it to good fortune (V.2.777). While informal, Merry's attitude matches the spontaneity of the other, earlier symbolic exchanges of weapons between Théoden and his retinue, and the simple promise and the exchange of the sword is sufficient symbolism to convey the earnestness of the relationship. In contrast, coldness marks Pippin's declaration of fealty to Denethor, and the sword's isolated martial function diminishes the symbolic weight of the sword during Pippin's ritual of fealty. When he offers Denethor his sword, Denethor says, "Give me the weapon!" and proceeds to question Pippin on its provenance. That Denethor calls it a weapon rather than a sword distills the object's value to its use on the battlefield, stripping the sword's procurement of the fealty, loyalty, and service that the weapon's exchange could otherwise suggest (V.5.756). When Pippin formally swears his service, the sword is symbolically placed on Denethor's lap and Pippin takes the hilt, but must swear a host of additional oaths and assurances since, in contrast to Merry's exchange of oaths, the sword alone is not a sufficient symbol of their exchange. The sword, distilled to its martial utility, has limited social symbolism and must be supplemented by additional assurances.

Aragorn's return as the rightful king of Gondor and bearer of the Sword Reforged resolves both Gondor's need for weapons as well as its cultural crisis by symbolically restoring martial valor to its appropriate place. Aragorn pragmatically rescues Gondor from its immediate crisis by leading the Dúnedain of the North, the sons of Elrond, and a coalition of the southern fiefdoms to lift the siege of Minas Tirith. While doing so, the narrative displays Aragorn's martial prowess in its fullness as he wields his famous sword with its deep provenance: "the Flame of the West, Andúril like a new fire kindled, Narsil re-forged as deadly as of old" (V.6.848). But more significant than the practical use of Aragorn's famous weapon is the identity of its wielder that the sword represents. As demonstrated by Michael Brisbois, Aragorn, as bearer of the heirloom sword of Elendil that was broken and reforged, becomes with his sword a symbol of the millennial renewal brought about by the return of the king (Brisbois 98). Brisbois's analysis provides a more thorough reading of the semiotic significance of Andúril than can be supplied here. But while avoiding a full repetition of Brisbois's argument, it is worth reiterating both the importance of Andúril to Aragorn's identity as well as the distinct limitations of Andúril's significance. Andúril is a recurrent symbol of Aragorn's kingly heritage and the martial strength he uses to rescue his kingdom from the forces of evil. However, Andúril is *not* the final sign that proves Aragorn's legitimacy. Rather, it is Aragorn's role as a healer that identifies him as the rightful heir to the throne of Gondor (Brisbois 100–01). Aragorn's martial identity as the bearer of Andúril and Savior of Gondor is subservient to his primary identities as "the Elfstone" and "the Renewer" (V.8.863). The unnamed Warden of the houses of healing marvels at the complexity of this individual and struggles to comprehend how one so skilled in swords could also be a healer (VI.5.958), but by demonstrating his healing skills as "a lore-master, not merely a captain of war," Aragorn validates his identity as the Renewer, suitable to lead the kingdom to a time of peace (V.8.865). Aragorn's coronation ultimately represents these reordered values when his many titles are listed out in increasing significance: "Here is Aragorn son of Arathorn, [...] bearer of the Star of the North, wielder of the Sword Reforged, victorious in battle, whose hands bring healing, the Elfstone, Elessar of the line of Vandalil, Isildur's son, Elendil's son of Númenor" (VI.5.967). In Gondor under the rule of Aragorn, swords retain their practical use, but their moral framework is restored by the return of a king whose symbolism submits the martial function of swords to the governing values of restoration and renewal.

Gondor's medievalism functions differently from Rohan's because Gondor's redemptive arc represents, in a way, Tolkien's attempt to "fix" a fault he recognizes in medieval literary warrior cultures. Brisbois's study of Aragorn's relationship with his sword notes Aragorn's significant departure

from earlier medieval models that would have emphasized the military authority of a king, a difference which underscores the magnitude of the medievalism's intervention into the historical past (Brisbois 99–101). Tolkien is well aware of the suffering associated with warfare and the self-destructive tendencies of chivalric culture—issues he addresses directly with “The Homecoming of Beorhtnoth Beorhthelm’s Son,” which have been studied in Tolkien scholarship.¹⁰ Many of Tolkien’s criticisms of warfare are associated with the increasing separation between commanders and the location of battle, and Tolkien consistently saw the increasing mechanization of warfare as morally perilous to those who would attempt to use such depersonalized devices as airplanes or atomic bombs.¹¹ But unlike Rohan’s spectacle in which the ideological problems of weapons are momentarily deferred by the narrative context, Gondorian sword-culture represents the hollow moral justification for weapons that are valued for their power, and the futility of valor pursued for its own sake, personified in the tragic figure of Boromir. Tolkien’s medievalism reproduces the moral hazards of weapons which are found in medieval world and modernity alike, but Tolkien intervenes through the figure of an idealized king (and foreshadowed by the ideological musings of Faramir) who subordinates the practical necessities of weapons to the superior values that would govern their justified use, thereby creating a medievalism that aspires to what could have been.

HOBBITS: SWORDS IN A SWORDLESS CULTURE

In a manner analogous to our own, largely swordless modern times, the swordless-ness of Hobbit culture starkly contrasts the martial cultures of Rohan and Gondor. Hobbits, as noted by Tom Shippey, are an intermediary between the modern reader and the fictional medievalism of Middle-earth, helping to bridge the distance between the two worlds by representing modern interests in the unfamiliar world of medievalist fantasy (6–7). Whetter and McDonald incorporate the symbolism of swords into Shippey’s argument, observing that “swords serve as a bridge between the hobbits and the heroic world and heroism,” functioning as a semiotic marker for the transfer of the hobbits from the familiar world to the world of adventure (Whetter and McDonald 24–25). But this observation, made in passing in Whetter and McDonald’s article, is worthy of closer attention due to the essential contribution of Hobbit culture’s swordless-ness to the overall function of *The Lord of the Rings*’s medievalism. The swordless Hobbit culture provides an in-world representation of our familiar, modern world which the hobbits leave and return

¹⁰ See Reinhard.

¹¹ See Croft, *War* 100–04; Tolkien, *Letters* 168, #101.

to, but just as the hobbits each return changed from their journey, so too has their estimation of the sword. These changed perspectives on the sword are not uniform across the experience of the hobbits, but all contribute to the hobbits' collective ability to successfully recover the Shire from corruption with minimal casualties or moral loss. In this manner, the return of swords to the Shire brought by the hobbits becomes an in-world manifestation of medievalism—relics of a medieval past reconfigured and deployed to a moment defined by the present. In so doing, the hobbits' experience with swords reflects the reader's experience with the medievalism of the perilous realm, providing a morally resonant interface between the primary world and an imagined, medieval experience.

Technically, swords were likely present in the Shire by the time of Bilbo's 111th birthday, although the distance between the sword's martial utility and its present existence illustrates the object's change in meaning from that of a weapon to that of an object of memory. In the foreword to the second edition (appearing for the first time in 1966), Tolkien writes:

At no time had Hobbits of any kind been warlike, and they had never fought among themselves. In olden days they had, of course, been often obliged to fight to maintain themselves in a hard world; but in Bilbo's time that was very ancient history. [...] So, though there was still some store of weapons in the Shire, these were used mostly as trophies, hanging above hearths or on walls, or gathered into the museum at Michel Delving. The Mathom-house it was called; for anything that Hobbits had no immediate use for, but were unwilling to throw away, they called a *mathom*. (*LotR* Prologue.5)

This insight into Hobbit hoarding habits suggests that the nature of the sword-object had shifted for Hobbits by the time of the War of the Ring. Unlike the swords of the Rohirrim which are rich with their symbolism of fealty and service, or the weapons needed by Gondor in their desperate hour, the swords of Hobbit culture have become *trophies*, objects of memory with latent utility, having been transformed in essence and in function to the status of meaningful wall décor. This fundamental change from weapon to something else is signaled linguistically by the reintroduction of the word, *mathom*, which is a resurrection of the defunct Old English word *máðum*, which carried the meaning of “a precious or valuable thing (often refers to gifts), a treasure, jewel, ornament” (Bosworth). This object is still “a useful tool to think with,” but the nature of the object is only tangentially related to the similar objects born by the warriors of Gondor and Rohan. The transformation of the Shire's swords from weapons to *mathoms* is so complete that they are wholly absent from the inventory of weapons gathered by the hobbits in their fight against Sharkey's ruffians (VI.8.1008–09). It could be argued that the list of improvised farm-tool weapons

used by the hobbits represents the “some store of weapons” referenced in the prologue, but this is unlikely since the tools have too much pragmatic, non-weapon value to be wall décor or put away in a museum. It is more plausible that the swords were hidden in plain sight, or simply didn’t come to mind when the need for weapons arose. Such is the extent of the hobbits’ peaceful, pastoral existence at the time of the War of the Ring that a dedicated weapon of war cannot readily be found amongst them, and the mere appearance of swords in the hands of the four hobbits is enough to break the ranks of the ruffians when they first (nearly) come to blows (VI.8.1005).

The journeys of Frodo, Sam, Merry, and Pippin further illustrate the unfamiliarity of Hobbits with swords as they are represented as both inexperienced and unglamorous in their handling of swords. The four hobbits set out for Bree without weapons, and are only supplied with the mysterious swords of the Barrow-downs by Tom Bombadil following their near catastrophe with the Barrow-wights. Even then, the need for these strange objects surprises the hobbits: “Their new weapons they hung on leather belts under their jackets, feeling them very awkward, and wondering if they would be of any use. Fighting had not before occurred to any of them as one of the adventures in which their flight would land them” (I.8.146). Bilbo, perhaps the most experienced Hobbit with swords, stores his sword in a box which he “fumbles” through to find Sting, which he presents to Frodo by rather indelicately stabbing it into a nearby beam.¹² Frodo and Sam “fumble for their sword hilts” when threatened by Faramir’s host, and although Sam is able to make effective use of his sword against Shelob and Gollum, this is due more to the intensity of his fury than any latent skill he had with the blade (IV.5.681, IV.9.726–27, IV.10.728–29).

The hobbits’ unfamiliarity with swords sharply contrasts the heroic, Old English aesthetics of Rohan and the war-weary chivalric culture of Gondor, but this unfamiliarity reproduces the reader’s own interface with the world of medievalism. Like Hobbit culture as described in the prologue, the swords of today are largely alien objects—they are invoked in stories and sometimes used as decor, and only some sub-cultures use modified swords in sport or recreation. For us, as for Hobbits, swords have no immediate use, and hundreds of years separate the present from the last time swords played a significant role on a battlefield. The use of swords in war is a distant memory, turning the bladed weapons into a relic of the medieval past invoked in medievalism. For the hobbits, as for us, swords have become useful objects to think with, arming the

¹² The literary significance of this “sword in the stone” moment is discussed by Flieger. Despite the moment’s literary significance in signaling “the emergence of the hero,” it still demonstrates the awkwardness of the hobbits’ relationship with swords (Flieger 55, 48).

characters of our medieval fantasies and sometimes decorating our walls, even if their martial purpose has long since disappeared.

Representing modern attitudes towards swords through the hobbits changes the mechanism of the medievalism by shifting focus onto the audience's own engagement with the Secondary World. Instead of looking directly at an imagined Middle Ages where the use of swords is glamorized or the problems of chivalry are addressed, readers look at versions of themselves interacting with the medieval world as the hobbits filter through the cultures of Middle-earth. By reflecting the reader's own experience of medievalism through its adventurers, *The Lord of the Rings* narrows the distance between the imagined medieval world and the characters with which readers can identify. Importantly, this mediation is not uniform, but reflects differences in each of the hobbits' experiences with the cultures and perils of Middle-earth: Merry and Pippin each use their swords to swear their services to two different kings for very different reasons, Sam becomes ever more defensive of his friend and master, and Frodo turns out nearly a pacifist. Taken as a whole, the hobbits' mediation provides critical structures for navigating the complexity of Tolkien's contribution to the cultural imagination of the medieval sword since there is no obviously "correct" way to engage with a perilously beautiful weapon, but a host of possibilities that the hobbits incorporate together to accomplish their ultimate purpose: Merry and Pippin orchestrate the defense of the Shire; Sam dutifully defends his loved ones, with force if necessary; and Frodo serves as a moral center that restrains the excessive use of violence. Like the hobbits, we are not to arrive at the end of a journey through the perilous realm unchanged or having received a single, moral lesson that reduces swords to uncomplicated objects of valor or violence. Rather, through the hobbits, readers are invited to reckon with new ways of considering swords as useful, beautiful, and dangerous.

TOLKIEN'S SWORDS: OBJECTS TO THINK WITH

Recent scholarship has developed the sword as an entry-point for investigating cultural history, and previous Tolkien scholarship has shown swords to be integral to the "symbolic construction of Middle-earth" (Brisbois 97). More than clever world-building, Tolkien fashions the many swords of *the Lord of the Rings* into multivalent signifiers that present a sophisticated relationship with the medieval Secondary World. The image of hobbits fumbling for their swords is worlds away from that of warrior-heroes clutching desperately for power, or singing, sword-wielding horsemen, crying "Death!" as they charge the ranks of Mordor—and it is the inclusion of all of these together that produces Tolkien's mature imagination of the medieval sword. The narrative does not overly privilege one or another of these attitudes towards

swords but puts them into conversation with each other, holding them in tension. This tension is unresolved even at the end of *The Lord of the Rings*, as Frodo's reluctance to use weapons is balanced by the pragmatic willingness of Merry and Pippin in the scouring of the Shire. Because the paradox of a sword's aesthetic beauty and implicit violence is likely never to be fully resolved in the real world, the lack of resolution to *The Lord of the Rings* facilitates the story's enduring resonance across a wide range of ideologically disparate audiences. In the end, *The Lord of the Rings* incorporates the paradox of swords as simultaneously lethal and beautiful objects by subsuming that paradox in a range of intertwined ideological approaches. Throughout, Tolkien's treatment of swords as complex signifiers creates an ideologically robust medievalism that offers profoundly sophisticated structures for appreciating the dangerous beauty of an enduring symbol of the medieval past.

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GAVIN S. DAVIS received his Ph.D. in English from Penn State in 2025 following the completion of his dissertation, *Reading the Old-Sword: The Narrative Work of Swords in Tenth-Century England*. He has presented on the swords of *Beowulf* and the medievalism of combat mechanics in *Dungeons & Dragons*, and will soon launch an educational YouTube channel that teaches medieval literature and theories of medievalism to audiences online.





ALAN GARNER'S *ELIDOR*: THE "ANTI-NARNIAN FANTASY"?

LAURA N. VAN DYKE

IN 2021, BRITISH FANTASY WRITER ALAN GARNER wrote in *The Guardian*, "I never enjoyed CS Lewis's *The Chronicles of Narnia*. I read the books with horrid fascination. They were, in my opinion, and remain, nasty, manipulative, morbid, misanthropic, hectoring, totalitarian and atrociously written" ("The Books of My Life"). Garner's vehement statement likely raised some eyebrows, particularly given how closely his own books have been linked to Lewis's in the minds of many readers for six decades now. His children's fantasies in particular have parallels not only to Lewis's Narnia stories, but also to Tolkien's writing; this association is not surprising, given that Garner was a student at Magdalen College, Oxford, and while there he had as tutor Colin Hardie, a Dante scholar and a member of the Inklings.¹ Hardie was a close friend of Lewis, which is likely why Garner sent his first published novel, a children's fantasy novel entitled *The Wierdstone of Brisingamen*, to Lewis to read in 1960. At Oxford Garner met both Lewis and Tolkien, which is part of why many readers have assumed Garner was continuing their work with his own fantasy novels (Hayes).

Although Garner had left Oxford by the time he wrote his first novel (Lewis, too, had left and taken up a chair at Cambridge), Garner sent Lewis a copy for him to read (Howe). In a letter to Roger Lancelyn Green on 15 September 1960, Lewis wrote, "Have you seen Allan² Garner's *The Wierdstone of Brisingamen*? Not bad, tho' too indebted to Tolkien.³ He seems to be a fairly near neighbour of yours—Alderley, Cheshire" (*Letters* III.1247). Lewis likely wrote to

¹ While Colin Hardie (1906–1998) is today not as well known as many other members of the Oxford Inklings group, Humphrey Carpenter lists him as one of the nineteen "official" members in *The Inklings* (255–59); a fellow and tutor in Classics at Magdalen College from 1936 until 1973, Hardie was invited in the 1940's by C.S. Lewis to join both the Tuesday and Thursday gatherings (Bratman 237).

² This misspelling of Alan Garner's name is typical of Lewis, who is never a careful speller in his letters or personal diaries.

³ Lewis is right to point out this connection; while critics like Neil Philip have pointed out that the parallels between *The Wierdstone of Brisingamen* and *The Lord of the Rings* often derive from a sharing of sources rather than from a direct influence, it does seem as if Garner was adopting the high epic style of writing that Tolkien used, which in his voice tends to sound "ponderous or precious" (29). By the time Garner wrote *Elidor*, his third novel, this overly formal, artificial style is gone (29).

Green about Garner's novel because Green was a prolific writer and researcher in the areas of children's literature, fantasy, and mythology; Green also clearly read Garner's works, since his book *Tellers Of Tales: Children's Books and Their Authors from 1880 to 1968*⁴ includes both Lewis and Garner as noteworthy modern-day children's writers, indicating he saw an affinity between their stories.⁵

It is evident that there were significant points of connection between Lewis and Garner, although Garner has consistently disavowed any notion of influence. Nevertheless, he conceded in a 1989 interview that he may have "picked things up" without being aware of it; to the question of whether he had read "any modern writers," he states,

Not until I'd written several books myself, and then I read T.H. White. I might even have picked things up on the fringe, without knowing. I didn't know Charles Williams, but my tutor at Oxford was one of the Inklings. Thus I was on the fringe of all of that, and I've no doubt that my tutor talked about things that C.S. Lewis had said the night before. (qtd. in Thompson)

Similarly, in 1966 Garner wrote to his publisher: "I've said that, having finished *Elidor*, I noticed it was THE anti-Narnian fantasy, but this was done unconsciously" (qtd. in Howe). Garner's relationship with the literary legacy of the Inklings is clearly a complicated issue for him. What made him, though, label his novel "THE anti-Narnia"? This is what this article will explore. I will argue that while Garner saw distinct differences between his *Elidor* and Lewis's Narnia books, alongside these differences are significance points of confluence, which make his novel ultimately complementary to rather than antithetical to Lewis's fantasy books.

On the surface, *Elidor* (1965) certainly parallels Lewis's Narnia stories—written during the previous decade, between 1950 and 1956—in some noticeable ways. As Catherine Butler puts it, the novel certainly "appears at first to be retreading Narnian territory" ("Modern Children's Fantasy" 227); the most obvious similarity is simply that the ensemble cast of characters in Garner's fantasy is also made up of four siblings. *Elidor* is also a portal fantasy, where the four children leave post-war England and enter a secondary world to complete

⁴ Originally published in 1946, this title refers to a revised and expanded edition that was published in 1969.

⁵ Nine years after this exchange, Roger Lancelyn Green lent Poulton Hall, his house on the Wirral, for use in Peter Plummer's television adaptation of *The Owl Service*, filmed in 1969, which suggests that by this time he and Garner were on relatively close terms (Ellen Garner et al., *Filming the Owl Service*, 13).

a quest and prevent the forces of evil from taking over. While the primary narrative frame of *Elidor* is set in Manchester and northern Cheshire and is more urban in setting and tone than most children's fantasy of the post-war era, including Lewis's,⁶ the secondary world of *Elidor* is a setting inspired by the Celtic past, sharing some of the medieval tropes that fantasy stories like the Narnia books made so popular. In a Welsh folktale, *Elidor* was a priest who journeyed to a golden castle in a land where the sun was dim.⁷ In *Elidor* the novel, Garner describes the golden walls of the castle Gorias and the half-lit sky of the land of *Elidor*. A kind of Otherworld, *Elidor* is represented as having been, in its glory, the land of *Tír na nÓg*, the Irish Land of Youth. Its four castles were the four cities of the *Tuatha Dé Danaan*, the first inhabitants of mythic Ireland. Garner, though, grounds his fantasy in the primary world: the novel's protagonists do visit *Elidor*, but only very briefly; most of the novel's action occurs in Cheshire. The house the four children move into in the beginning of the story is based on the house in which Garner himself spent his childhood (Garner, "Edge of the Ceiling" 9), and the setting of the novel occurs in and around present-day Manchester, lending an atmosphere of realism to this fantasy.

The four children in Garner's novel are Nicholas (the oldest), Helen, David, and Roland (the youngest). We learn in the opening chapter, "Thursday's Child," that their parents are in a transitional period of moving to a new house, and their placial liminality is underscored when they stand in the middle of Manchester and, out of boredom, decide to explore Thursday Street. Tony Watkins points out that, as the chapter heading's allusion to the children's nursery rhyme reminds us, Roland is "Thursday's child," and "Thursday's child has far to go" (58). Roland is the hero of this tale, and much like Lucy Pevensie he is more attuned to spiritual reality than his siblings, who find it difficult to sustain belief in *Elidor* once they have returned home. Nicholas dismissively comments that Roland "is always imagining things" (*Elidor* 11), a comment that the rest of the family repeats (71). Later in the novel, Nicholas decides that the children's memories of their time in *Elidor* were simply the result of a "mass hallucination," brought about by shock (89), a dismissal that Roland finds as

⁶ Garner's conscious distancing of his work from that written by both Lewis and Tolkien likely originates at least in part from class differences coming into play as well: for instance, see Butler's claim in her chapter "Modern Fantasy Literature" that Garner was intentionally moving, in *Elidor*, away from the "middle-class and London-based" (228) protagonists of previous fantasy.

⁷ Neil Philip writes that Garner accessed this story via the medieval story of "Elidor and the Golden Ball" by Giraldus Cambrensis, in which fairyland seems to be a symbol of lost innocence; Garner misunderstood *Elidor* to be a synonym for fairyland, when in Cambrensis's story it is the personal name of the protagonist (159n2).

distressing as Lucy Pevensie does her siblings' refusal to believe she has found a magical land on the other side of the wardrobe door in *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*.

The epigraph for the novel comes from *King Lear*: "Childe Rowland to the Dark Tower came—". Shakespeare's reference to the old Scottish ballad was picked up by Robert Browning in his poem, titled the same, about the doomed quest of the knight Rowland. Interestingly, Walter Hooper gave the title *The Dark Tower* (1977) to one of Lewis's posthumously published and incomplete manuscripts, a reference to the same Browning poem. In the ballad or tale from which the line comes, Rowland is one of four siblings, with two brothers and one sister, who, while playing next to a church, is kidnapped and taken to the "dark tower" by the king of Elfland. In *Elidor*, Roland, too, is one of four siblings, and it is while they are playing together at exploring Thursday Street that they encounter a strange church.

In Garner's novel, Thursday Street is in a part of Manchester where old housing is being demolished in order to make way for new developments. It is a wasteland of poverty, absence, and despair; the houses are "empty, and broken" (10), with no signs of care: "Grass grew in the cobbles everywhere, and in the cracks of the pavement. Doors hung awry. Nearly all the windows were boarded up or jagged with glass" (10). Then, though, the children spot a building that catches their attention: "Alone and black in the middle of the wasteland stood a church" (12). In this juxtaposition lies symbolic and literal power. The children learn later that while it is not easy to cross between their world and Elidor, "there are places where they touch," including this church, because it was once "battered by war, and now all the land around quakes with destruction. [It has] been shaken loose" (43). In other words, "Wastelands and boundaries: place that are neither one thing nor the other, neither here nor there—these are the gates of Elidor" (43). Lewis's four Pevensie children initially cross into Narnia via a wardrobe, but in the chronologically-earlier book *The Magician's Nephew* Digory and Polly enter Narnia from the Wood Between the Worlds, a hauntingly evocative place that is also neither here nor there, but what Digory calls one of the "in-between places" (III.37) that is only a threshold to the "Other World" (36). The first land they visit from this threshold is the ancient world of Charn, a ruined wasteland only half-lit by a dull light (IV.41).

In Garner's *Elidor*, the wasteland the four children enter is also a dim place, characterized by "gloom and stillness" and lit by a "dull" sky; the light has a "brittleness" to it that hurts Roland (24). Malebron, the "maimed king" of the wasteland of Elidor, who is a kind of Fisher King archetype as well as a Merlin figure, tells Roland the story of Elidor's fall:

The darkness grew [...]. It is always there. We did not watch, and the power of the night closed on Elidor. We had so much of ease that we did not mark the signs—a crop blighted, a spring failed, a man killed. Then it was too late—war, and siege, and betrayal, and the dying of the light. (*Elidor* 32)

Once, Elidor was a place of golden light, with four castles: "Findias . . . Falias . . . Murias . . . Gorias. [...] Men who walked like sunlight. Cloth of gold. Elidor" (33). Malebron tasks Roland with saving Elidor: "[You will] save this land! You will bring back light to Elidor!" (33). Malebron is a strange and often aloof figure, who seems both uninterested in the children and unwilling to offer them explanations for the state of the land or clarification of some of his enigmatic statements. However, he does tell them that each castle once held a Treasure—a spear, a sword, a cauldron and a stone—and that the Treasures held the light of Elidor; "They are the seeds of flame from which all this land was grown" (34). It is these treasures he charges them with recovering.

Roland's brothers resist Malebron's emphatic demands on them, reluctant to make personal sacrifices for a world that, to Nicholas, is "all mud and dust and rock. It's dead, finished" (82). But to Roland, Elidor is "the most important thing there is" (129), and it is largely through his courage, as well as through Helen's compassion for Findhorn the unicorn, that "life" springs again in Elidor and the "morning" comes. In his first novels, Garner often struggled to conclude his plots. Here too, *Elidor* ends abruptly: the children have a momentary vision of light returning to Elidor, but they remain in their world, and the last lines of the novel simply read,

[Roland] cried his pain, and snatching the cup from Helen, he threw it and the railing at the windows. Nicholas and David threw their Treasures. They struck together, and the windows blazed outwards, and for an instant the glories of stone, sword, spear, and cauldron hung in their true shapes, almost of trick of the splintering glass, the golden light. The song faded.

The children were alone with the broken windows of a slum. (159–60)

It is difficult to know how to interpret this strange ending to the story. Neil Philip calls it "profoundly ambiguous," and admits he finds it "unsettling" despite recognizing that it is the "most powerful thing Garner had written up to that point" (15). Tony Watkins, in an early article on the novel, confesses that the "ending is enigmatic" and he is "not sure" he has understood it completely:

But in so far as the land of Elidor seems to be symbolic, on one level of Roland's childhood psychic experience and on another to symbolize the

mythic world which modern ways of thinking and living have forgotten, the ending points in two directions. First, it suggests that restoring life to Roland's former psychic condition in childhood is not enough—in a sense, Roland has grown beyond Elidor without his realizing it. Secondly, Garner realizes that there can be no simple return to the ways of thinking that the mythic world represents. (63)

Watkins's astute observation that the novel ultimately treats the viability of returning to the "mythic world" is born out by Garner's own writings about myth. In describing myth, Garner writes "I should like to define 'myth' as the dream-thinking of the people" ("Voice in the Shadow" 150). However, he immediately follows up this definition by noting the difficulty that the modern mind has with reconciling mythic dreaming and the "thinking" we associate with the operation of the intellect. In the world today, most of us encounter myth in written, not oral, forms. Thus most of our experience of myth is "through the written word; that is: after the myth has entered history, linear time, been written down in linear words, thought of in lines" (150). For moderns trapped in linear time, we struggle to experience the full power of myth: "We pay a price for our literacy," Garner says (151). The myths we have today, that have come to us mediated through history and literature, "are the secular versions" of myths, versions that are only dim echoes of the full, numinous myth (154). Garner does seem to believe that we can sometimes access real myth, or real dreaming, through writing—as long as the writer is a visionary or a poet who can write, he says, with enough "ambivalence [and] paradox that enables us to interpret what is being said, and what we read, just as we would if we were dreaming. That is the way, via the poet, to the myth, to the truth" (155).

The ambiguity of *Elidor's* conclusion is arguably Garner's way of opening up his novel—a novel with flaws but also with visionary moments that border on the mythic—to this kind of interpretative act. Unlike the high fantasy of Tolkien, where the magic associated with the elves is fading as *The Lord of the Rings* ends, leaving the reader with a bittersweet sense of loss and melancholy, Cat Ashton argues that the second generation of British fantasy writers,⁸ including Oxford educated writers Susan Cooper and Alan Garner, are more likely to consider the nature of magic in a world that was rapidly changing, rather than passing away; thus, their stories propose a new relationship with the legendary past, "one that draws inspiration from it but prefers that the legends

⁸ Critics frequently place Garner alongside other post-war British children's fantasy writers such as Susan Cooper, Penelope Lively and Diana Wynne Jones, all of whom attended Oxford in the 1950s and were participants in what is sometimes referred to as the 'second Golden Age' of children's literature (Butler, *Four British Fantastsists*, 199).

themselves and the values derived from them be left safely in the past" (78). At the end of *Elidor*, the reader is left unsettled: what is the status of enchantment? What Ashton calls "the fantasy element" is, in this book, "intrusive, disruptive, and dangerous, [...] interfere[ing] with the lives of the children and mak[ing] them objects of pursuit and attack" so that, when magic finally loosens its hold on the four siblings, the result is relief, not triumph (92). Ashton concludes: "The landscape in Garner's works seethes with magic, and knowing its history enriches the lives of those who inhabit it, but one should not wish for the mythic past to encroach on the mundane present" (93).

One of the strangest aspects of *Elidor*'s treatment of myth and magic is the portrayal of the unicorn Findhorn. As in Narnia, where the four children are the fulfillment of an ancient prophesy,⁹ in *Elidor* Malebron tells Nicholas, David, Helen and Roland that they are the subject of a prophecy, or what he calls the "fragment of a dream: a dream that no sane man could bear to dream: a waking memory of what was to be":

*And they shall come from the waves.
And the Glory of Elidor shall pass with them.
And the Darkness shall not fade.
Unless there is heard the Song of Findhorn.
Who walks in the High Places. (45)*

The children discern right away the ambivalence of this cryptic prophesy: even if they "win" against the forces of darkness, the glory of Elidor still will pass away. As Roland says, "things'll be worse, not better," and Malebron agrees, though he adds, "We are not at the end but at the beginning," and with their help in finding Findhorn Elidor can perhaps have, again, at least some "islands in the darkness" (46). Findhorn is eventually revealed to be a unicorn, whose song does indeed bring light back to Elidor. However, Findhorn is not an Aslan figure who, after a sacrificial death, returns to life; Findhorn's death is violent and tragic, and does not appear to readers to be a death he consents to freely. Neil Philip points out that, in an early version of *Elidor*, Garner wrote Findhorn as a lion, one who dies willingly (59). The final version of the text, though, perhaps to distance *Elidor* from *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*, depicts Helen cradling a dying unicorn's head in her lap. Helen is crying, and the unicorn stares up at her, silent and wounded: when Roland looks in his eyes, he cannot describe what he sees because "it was almost too strong to bear" (158). The song Findhorn sings, after the children at last compel him to sing, is

⁹ *When Adam's flesh and Adam's bone,
Sits at Cair Paravel in throne,
The evil time will be over and done. (The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe VIII.76)*

described as containing both “beauty and terror,” and bringing a bright light but yet being “not enough” to save Elidor; the children need to send their Treasures back through the doorway to Elidor as well (159), making it unclear what role Findhorn’s death really played.

It is also unclear what the final status of Elidor is. Garner himself, in interviews following the publication of *Elidor*, seems to vacillate on its nature: in 1979 he told Neil Philip that the whole “metaphysics of *Elidor* is closely connected with Platonic philosophy,” and Roland’s narrative arc is a problematizing of the allure of this ideal: “when Roland looks into the eyes of the dying unicorn he sees the Platonic archetypal reality and realises that in order to secure Elidor, which he thought was reality but was only a parallel strand of Plato’s shadows at the back of the cave¹⁰ [...] he has sacrificed reality” (qtd. in Philip 48–49). Like Philip, I do not find Garner’s statements here to be borne out by the novel¹¹; it is not apparent in the narrative that Roland is wrong to work for Elidor’s freedom (or that he is “egocentric,” as Garner also claims). However, the maimed king of Elidor, Malebron, is a figure who indeed has “a sinister undercurrent,” and speaks to the children in a demanding and overly authoritarian tone; Garner gives him sentences full of exclamation marks, leading Philip to describe him as “egotistical, unyielding, almost psychotic” (50). Nicholas, Roland’s oldest brother and the most skeptical of the children about Elidor, says about Malebron that he is “self-centered,” doesn’t care about the children’s safety, and has no right to expect them to sacrifice their whole lives to guard the Treasures (*Elidor* 82). At this point in the novel, many readers likely share Nicholas’s evaluation.

Elidor is not safe; it never becomes home for the children, even for Roland who is its fiercest defender. It is here, arguably, that *Elidor* most departs from the spell Lewis weaves in the Narnia books and perhaps leads Garner to

¹⁰ It is worth considering this statement alongside Lewis’s use of the cave allegory in chapter twelve of *The Silver Chair* where the Narnian Underland is clearly Plato’s Cave and the Overworld functions as what Garner refers to here as “reality.” While Lewis’s debt to Plato is clear from his fiction, as James Bryson has pointed out Platonism played a significant role in leading Lewis to Christianity, and it remained a perennial influence on his thinking, going back at least to his work in the early 1920’s on the Cambridge Platonist Henry More, about whom Lewis began working on a doctoral dissertation (1–2). Like Garner, Lewis writes fiction that engages with the “allure” of the Platonic ideal, but unlike Garner he does not attempt to “problematize” that allure but to avidly explore its philosophical and theological implications for sublunary life.

¹¹ To some degree Garner invites interpretations of his work that disagree with his own. While Garner does on occasion speak as an interpreter of his works, he also insists that he writes “imaginative fiction,” which he defines as fiction that is “for ambivalence, not for instruction”: “When language serves dogma, then literature is lost. [...] There can be no one meaning for a text. Even that of the writer is but an option” (“Aback of Beyond” 27).

calls his novel the "anti-Narnia." While both Garner and Lewis are deeply mythic thinkers, Lewis comes to myth via his theological convictions; Garner, an avid reader of Carl Jung,¹² accesses myth through the psychological, not the religious, dimension. In his essay "The Edge of the Ceiling" Garner recalls a childhood illness that caused him to spend long days lying on his bed, in his room, staring at the ceiling above him. As he stared, he describes slipping in and out of a dream-like state, accessing the "world of the ceiling" which was a mythic space for him:

The world of the ceiling was three-dimensional, objects were solid, visual perspectives true. I never ate or drank in the ceiling (as I later found was the rule for the Other World). There was no wind, no climate, no heat, no cold, no time. The light came from no source and was shadowless, as neon; but before I knew neon. And everywhere, everybody, everything was white. It was the genesis of the dead land of Elidor. (11)

It is significant that Garner draws an explicit connection to this visionary state and the land of Elidor. He later writes, in the same essay, that he "felt not that I entered a world, but that a world entered me" (14).

Narnia is not a dead land, like Charn and like Elidor, but a land teeming with life: it is more wish-fulfillment than "Other World," at least as Garner describes it. More precisely, Narnia is an imaginative analogy of what Lewis wants to point readers towards—a heaven that is a fulfillment of the longing Narnia elicits. What Lewis often pursues in his Narnia stories, as in all his imaginative writing, is the sensation of *sehnsucht* that was so integral to his personal journey; the search for joy, or that "unsatisfied desire which is itself more desirable than any other satisfaction" (*Surprised* 18), is what animated much of his fiction and is what continues to draw many readers to Narnia. Significantly, Garner has read enough Lewis to recognize this as one of Lewis's central concerns. He refers to "what C.S. Lewis calls 'joy'" in his essay "Inner Time" (118), as well as in "The Voice that Thunders" when he discusses "what C.S. Lewis cunningly calls 'joy'" (225), and recounts his decision to "pursue the Lewisian 'joy'" (230). Narnia is escapist fiction in the sense Tolkien describes in "On Fairy-stories"; it points towards a world to which readers *want* to escape to, not as the flight of a deserter but as the escape of a prisoner. Tolkien and Lewis were both in agreement that fiction, especially the faery story or fantasy literature, feeds what they saw as a healthy impulse to be dissatisfied and maladjusted to an enclosed, human-built prison of a world; thus it is not their

¹² Garner read Jung prior to writing *Elidor* and has said that the Jung's writing represents "the most impressive *modern* thought" that he has encountered (Alan Garner, "A Bit More Practice"; quoted in Butler, *Four British Fantasists*, 144).

fictional worlds that Tolkien or Lewis want readers to escape to—they do not want their reader's desire to be "stopped" at their fantastical worlds, but to find in their sub-creations impetus to go beyond them. Similarly, characters in Narnia want to go "further up and further in"; like the chivalrous mouse Reepicheep, they want to go to Aslan's Country, a land beyond the Narnia that for Lewis is, like our own earth, one of the Shadowlands. As Jewel the Unicorn says when he arrives at Aslan's Country, "I have come home at last! This is my real country! I belong here. This is the land I have been looking for all my life, though I never knew it till now. The reason why we loved the old Narnia is that it sometimes looked a little like this" (*Last Battle* XV.161). For Lewis's characters to achieve "joy," they need to leave their world. This is key to Lewis's entire formulation of *sehnsucht*; it is a desire "which no experience in this world can satisfy," because we were "made for another world" (*Mere Christianity* 137). This longing for our "true country" is what Lewis's fantasy books are intended to elicit; all symbolic expressions of the inexpressible truth that the "object of life" is to "press on to that other country and to help others to do the same" give voice to it (137).

Garner's posture towards the Other World is quite different. While it is the object of desire and longing, at times, it is also often the source of fear and anxiety. And most importantly, it is not a transcendent realm but an immanent world that is intersecting and overlapping with our world. Cat Ashton argues that at the end of *Elidor*, when magic loses its hold, "the effect is relief, rather than triumph" (92). She continues: "The landscape in Garner's works seethes with magic, and knowing its history enriches the lives of those who inhabit it, but one should not wish for the mythic past to encroach on the mundane present" (93). Garner has frequently written and spoken about his deep connection to place and his decision to set many of his narratives in and around Alderley Edge, Cheshire, where he grew up and continues to live. He writes in "Achilles in Altjira" about coming "from a line of working-class rural craftsmen in Cheshire" (120) and seeing the "physical immobility" of his family as the lifeline for his sense of self: "My family is so rooted that it ignores social classification by others. On one square mile of Cheshire hillside, Alderley Edge, the Garners *are*. We know our place. And this sense of fusion with a land rescued me" (123). Alderley Edge is core to Garner's identity. In a time when, as Paul Kingsnorth puts it, more and more of us are "citizens of nowhere," products of a globalized capitalist machine that so often produces deracinated people disconnected from any real roots in a specific, localized place, Garner is radically counter-cultural ("Citizens"). Among twentieth-century and contemporary British writers, in particular, Garner sits almost alone; few writers are rooted as

firmly in a *place* as he is.¹³ In another essay, Kingsnorth attests to the power of Garner's evocation of the local:

A question that has been jabbing at me for some time is: how could a novel be written in which a living landscape was not just a backdrop, but a character: an actor in the drama, rather than its scenery? Are there novels in which non-human places are sensate? In which the mind of the world is made manifest in the places its human characters walk through? Having just tried to write one myself, I have been looking for precedents. So far, I have only discovered two writers who seem to even approach the question. [...] [T]he writer who has done most to explore the notion of a sensate landscape, though, is Alan Garner. The living, jolting, magical power of places is at the heart of almost everything he has written for the last five decades. A moor, a hill, a ridge, a wood: in Garner's books these are not landscapes but conduits to an older, wilder magic. History tugs at them, and they tug in turn at the feet of the innocent people who happen to walk across them. ("We imagine")

Thus it is not surprising that for Garner, the allure of finding his "true country" is less appealing than for Lewis. Garner's "true country" is Cheshire—a place that was once North-West Mercia, a landscape that gave us the language of *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, but now there is, Garner laments, no literature that "feed[s] from its soil" ("Achilles" 124), apart from his own writings. A persistent theme in Garner's fiction is the presence of the land in the lives of his characters. Garner's characters live on or around Alderley Edge: readers can walk the paths and lanes they walk, and see the same caves, trees, and woodlands they saw, making Garner's stories deeply immersive. This is likely part of the reason why readers respond the way they do to his novels; *Elidor*, said Neil Gaiman, "changed the way I saw the world" (83). Susan Cooper, a British fantasy writer with whom Garner has much in common and to whom he has often been compared, acknowledges that while all writers of fantasy today cannot help but "dip into old Tolkien's Cauldron of Story," Garner remains distinctive for his "mythic energy" (34–35). As Ursula Le Guin, too, has said, Garner is "more mythmaker than fantasist," and, Cooper continues, "the myth that he makes is carved out of the land to which he belongs, the land from which he and his people came, the land in which he lives. And expressed, of course, in its language. He is above all a writer of place, of a very particular place, and of the music that is its speech" (35).

This distinctiveness is likely why Garner is consistently averse to questions about literary influence posed by interviewers. Garner insists "I've no

¹³ In the context of American literature, Wendell Berry is similarly place-based.

interest [...] in being compared with other writers and their work" (qtd. in Almond 9). When he was asked shortly after publishing *Elidor* about what he thought of the growing popularity of the fantasy genre, he stubbornly insisted on his claim to literary isolation¹⁴: "I'm not aware of it—I don't read [fiction]. I'm sorry, the fantasy market, I know it exists but I don't know what it is . . . [Because] critics start to be rather ignorant people, they start to say Tolkien, Tolkien, Tolkien" (Partington 23, qtd. in Taylor 176). In this light, Garner's statements about Lewis's Narnia books take on more context. It's likely Garner was, understandably, weary of comparison with Tolkien as well as with Lewis, and so exaggerated his differences with both writers. Yet, all three clearly share a deep interest in myth and in the potential of fantasy literature to evoke secondary worlds rich in wonder and enchantment. While Garner saw *Elidor*, in particular, as an "anti-Narnia" text readers today are more likely to see it as a complement to the mythopoeic tales of Lewis and his fellow Inklings.

Like Lewis, Garner too is concerned with the forces of modernist-inflected disenchantment. However, Garner approaches this disenchantment from a different angle than does Lewis. Whereas Lewis's Narnia stories frame the problem through a sacramental ontology that takes seriously the way the medieval social-cosmic model framed the "Other World," or the eternal world, as Heaven and so grounds his secondary world in a temporal setting reminiscent of this medieval past, Garner is much more attuned to the way that in the modernist world we have lost imaginative contact not so much with time as with place. Both Lewis and Garner use their fiction to challenge the techno-industrial reduction of the earth to mere matter, but they do it in different ways. It may be that in the twenty-first century, in the context of ever-increasing ecological crises that cut us off from the ancient patterns of nature and remove us more and more from our rootedness in what Yi-Fu Tuan has called the "topophilic sentiment," or our affective bond to our material environment (92–93), Garner's fantasy will take on particular resonance with contemporary audiences. *Elidor* is not an anti-Narnia, but it may be a kind of companion text to Narnia, one that confronts reductive materialism by imagining this world, here and now, as an enchanted Other World.

¹⁴ According to Garner, he does not feel at home with anything after *The Tempest* ("Achilles" 49), because the English literary style that developed after the early modern period and continues to this day "came from the library" and not from inherited culture and landscape; "In this way the academic world represented a suppression of individual style, which Garner witnessed first-hand when at Oxford. The heart and the head, emotion and intellect, 'just did not meet' he writes, '[and the] English graduates I have met . . . admit that they wanted to write, but they admit that because they were aware of the course behind them they daren't: there was nothing else to say" (Taylor 190–1).

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LAURA N. VAN DYKE teaches in the Department of English and Creative Writing at Trinity Western University, in Langley, British Columbia. She is a co-editor of *The Inklings and Culture* (2020) and helps to direct the Inklings Institute of Canada.



OTES

INTERVIEW WITH PROFESSOR JOHN MCKINNELL CONCERNING TOLKIEN'S LECTURES ON *BEOWULF*

ŁUKASZ NEUBAUER

JOHN MCKINNELL (b. 1942) IS PROFESSOR EODERITUS in the Department of English Studies and a Member of the Institute of Medieval and Early Modern Studies at the University of Durham. He grew up mostly in Scotland, where he received his secondary education at George Watsons College, Edinburgh, and went up to Worcester College, Oxford in October 1961 to read English. Professor McKinnell became attracted to medieval literature (Old Norse in particular), and, having gained his B.A. in 1964, spent eight months studying Icelandic manuscripts at the Arnarnagæan Institute in Copenhagen. In April 1965, he was appointed to a lectureship in English Language and Medieval Literature at Durham University, where he remained throughout his career, retiring as a professor in 2007. His two main fields of research interest are Old Norse eddic poetry and medieval drama. He is married, with three children and five grandchildren, and lives in Durham.

Łukasz Neubauer (ŁN): When and how did it happen that you came to be taught by Tolkien? In the early 1960s, at the time when you were studying as an undergraduate at Worcester College in Oxford, Tolkien had already retired (he would deliver his valedictory address on 5 June 1959).¹

John McKinnell (JM): I went up to Oxford in October 1961, two years after Tolkien had retired, and did not specialize in medieval literature until a year later, so my memory of him is based only on a few lectures that he very generously gave after he had officially retired. He gave a series of eight lectures on *Beowulf* in Michaelmas term of 1962 (14 October–8 December),² standing in for C.L. Wrenn during his absence on sabbatical leave (Scull and

¹ Tolkien's retirement speech, 'Valedictory Address to the University of Oxford, 5 June 1959,' delivered in the Merton College Hall, was published posthumously.

² Tolkien regularly lectured on *Beowulf* during his five-year employment at the University of Leeds (1920–25) and the twenty-year tenure as a Rowlinson and Bosworth Professor of Anglo-Saxon (1925–45). For more information on the specific courses of lectures he gave in those years, see Scull and Hammond, *Chronology* [S&H] (122 ff. [Leeds] and 142 ff. [Oxford]). Speaking of his return to lecturing, Tolkien modestly said that it "has proved a much greater burden than [he] expected" and that "[i]t has taken much more work that [he] guessed to shake off the dust of seventeen years off matter which [he] once thought [he] knew" (qtd. in S&H 631).

Hammond 630).³ In the following term (Hilary Term, 20 January–16 March 1963), he planned to continue with the *Freswæl* (i.e. the story of Finn, as it is told in *Beowulf* (ll. 1063–159) and the so-called *Finnesburg Fragment*) (Scull and Hammond 636),⁴ but only gave two or three of them because of his poor health.⁵ I knew him only from these lectures, so not on a personal level. Besides, he was based at Merton, while I was at Worcester College.⁶ I was lucky enough to have a variety of outstanding tutors for my medieval work, but they did not include either J.R.R. Tolkien or his son Christopher. Nevertheless, I went to lectures by both of them.

LN: Were you, at that time, more interested in Tolkien’s academic work or his fiction?

JM: The lectures at which I was present—scheduled to take place on Tuesdays and Thursdays at 11.00 a.m. (Scull and Hammond [S&H] 630)—were held in the largest available room in the Examination Schools building,⁷ and the room was so full that some people had to sit in the window seats. Since the room was T-shaped, this meant that not everyone had a very good view of the lecturer, and some members of the audience could not see each other.⁸ This was, of course, mainly because of the fame of his fiction, but, as for myself, I was equally interested in both sides of his work, and perhaps even

³ It could be that C.L. Wrenn, who, around that time, went to America, used this sabbatical leave to work on his monograph, *A Study of Old English Literature* (1967). In any case, it was certainly too late for him to work on the Tolkien *Festschrift*, *English and Medieval Studies Presented to J.R.R. Tolkien on the Occasion of his Seventieth Birthday* (co-edited with Norman Davis), which the Professor was presented with during a dinner party at Merton on 5 December 1962 (S&H 633).

⁴ Tolkien’s lecture notes on this matter were published in 1982 as *Finn and Hengest: The Fragment and the Episode* (edited by Alan Bliss).

⁵ Interestingly, neither Alan Bliss—“in Hilary Term 1963 he delivered a course of lectures under the [title ‘The *Freswæl* (Episode and Fragment)’]” (vi)—nor Scull and Hammond (636) make any mention of Tolkien’s health problems around this time (he was, however, reportedly taken ill with bronchitis during his post-term holidays in the second half of March), so that it appears he actually did fulfil his teaching obligations.

⁶ Merton, established in 1264, is one of the three oldest colleges in Oxford. The other two are University College (1249) and Balliol (1263). Worcester College, founded in 1714, is four-and-a-half centuries younger.

⁷ The Examination Schools is a large Victorian building, erected between 1876 and 1882, at the eastern end of High Street. For more information on its history, as well as exterior and interior design, see Tyack 249–55.

⁸ This was, in all likelihood, the so-called South Writing School room, whose windows overlook the backside of the buildings standing along the north side of Merton Street. Located on the first floor, to the right of the main staircase, it is said to have a capacity of 440 people.

more in his academic work, because I wanted to know more about his sources of inspiration.

ŁN: Professor Przemysław Mroczkowski, a Polish scholar who attended some of Tolkien's classes in the Michaelmas term of 1957,⁹ once said that his lectures "had a keen following, but they weren't [...] especially popular" (Grotta 78). Of course, in the second half of the 1950s Tolkien's popularity as a writer of fiction was on the upswing, but he was also, at the same time, a highly esteemed scholar who had made his name as an authority on Old and Middle English literature and language. You only went to a few of his classes, but what do you think of them? What was he like as a lecturer?

JM: His lectures were so absorbing that, after each of them, I found my notes quite sparse. I had simply become too fascinated to write more than a few lines, which usually amounted to less than a single side. I must say he had the kind of enthusiasm for *Beowulf* that inspired me to want to read it again. His lectures gave the impression of being affable performances among friends, probably because he assumed that his audience would have the same enthusiasm for the poem that he had himself.

ŁN: According to Humphrey Carpenter, Tolkien lectured "fluently, chiefly from his notes, but with occasional impromptu additions" (117). Indeed, he is said to have regularly made extended digressions, shifting his attention from the main topic of his class and, thus focusing on a word or phrase that happened to catch his philological eye. Did you have a similar experience when you attended Tolkien's lectures?

JM: I found his lectures fluent and interesting, but I was very young and inexperienced—at that time merely twenty years old—and did not notice him making any digressions. However, my overall impression was that he lectured primarily on various themes in *Beowulf* and used individual words and phrases mainly as examples or clues to make sure his students would acquire a broader understanding of the poem rather than as a succession of textual cruces (which would probably have been C.L. Wrenn's approach), so I suppose I did not regard them as digressions.¹⁰

⁹ For more information on Przemysław Mroczkowski and the history of his friendship with Tolkien, see my own article on "The 'Polish Inkling.'"

¹⁰ Reading through Professor McKinnell's notes from seven of Tolkien's eight lectures on *Beowulf* (I–II, IV–VIII; the notes on lecture III seem to have been lost), I have been able to identify (probably with varying degrees of success) the following subject areas discussed in Michaelmas term of 1962: (I) the poem's performative qualities, time and mode of its composition; (II) verse techniques; (IV) Christian and non-Christian elements; (V)

EN: Carpenter also claimed that the quality of Tolkien's lectures was affected by his uncommon quickness of speech and "indistinct articulation" (132), the latter of which the writer would ascribe to the tongue injury he once sustained during a rugby match (48). As a result, his students "had to concentrate hard in order to hear" (132) what he was actually saying. Mroczkowski even said that Tolkien's "speech was extremely difficult to follow, since it was all but inarticulate" (qtd. in Grotta 78). In the opinion of the Polish scholar, "Tolkien didn't care to articulate; he simply expected and assumed that you could follow him with ease" (78). Moreover, in the words of Nevill Coghill, who evidently enjoyed Tolkien's classes, it was sometimes hard to keep up with "this rapid machine gun fire of his lecturing" (qtd. in Grotta 77). Was your experience during the lectures you attended in any way comparable to those that are recalled by Tolkien's biographers?

JM: I did not find him hard to follow, although his delivery was indeed quite quick, but I suppose I was prepared to concentrate hard because I admired him, both for his academic work¹¹ and for his fiction.¹² (Incidentally, I also attended Coghill's 1961–62 lectures on modern drama, and his style was very different—much more leisurely and inclined to personal reminiscences of his own discussions with the dramatists he was discussing—equally enjoyable, but quite different from Tolkien.

EN: According to Carpenter, Tolkien would often commence his classes with a sudden cry of *Hwæt!*, the opening word of many an Old English poem (including *Beowulf*), which some students, mostly, it seems, novice undergraduates, would take to be "Quiet!" (133).¹³ Does that ring a bell to you?

JM: Oh, yes. I do remember one lecture which he not only began with *Hwæt!* but went on to recite—not at all times from memory, though—the first 150 or so lines of *Beowulf*.¹⁴ In Old English, of course, and without any translation. I

comments on the poem's multiple cruces (?); (VI) kingship and heroic ethos; (VII) peoples in *Beowulf*; (VIII) notes on the poem's characters.

¹¹ By 1962, Tolkien had published, amongst other things, his edition of *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* (1925, together with E.V. Gordon) as well as the essays *Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics* (1937) and *On Fairy-stories* (1947).

¹² By that time, Tolkien had already published most of his best-known works of fiction: *The Hobbit* (1937), *Farmer Giles of Ham* (1949), and *The Lord of the Rings* (1954–55).

¹³ In one of his commentaries on the specific words and phrases used in *Beowulf* (derived from the lecture notes), Tolkien defines *hwæt* (as it appears at the head of some poetic works in Old English) as "[a] genuine *anacrusis*—or a note 'striking up' at the beginning of a poem" (*Beowulf* 137).

¹⁴ If Professor McKinnell is right in his assessment of the length of Tolkien's in-class recitation, it would mean the poem's 'prologue' (*Beowulf* ll. 1–85) and at least a larger part

think the point was to give a sense of what the poem would have been like in live performance,¹⁵ and he was a very gifted performer of it. His delivery was rapid and exciting. Pausing for translation or explanation would have ruined the natural flow of it.¹⁶

LN: During his lectures, Tolkien is also said to have recited longer passages from various texts, from *Beowulf* to *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* and *The Canterbury Tales* (Bowers 3). As his former student—and, subsequently, writer and scholar—J.I.M. Stewart recalls, “he could turn a lecture room into a mead hall in which he was the bard and [those who sat in the audience] were the feasting, listening guests” (qtd. in Carpenter 133). Do you recollect any such ‘magical’ moments? And, if so, would he rather read these passages from his notes, the book, or would he rather quote them from memory?

JM: He normally had the text in front of him—in the case of *Beowulf*, it was, I think, Friedrich J. Klaeber’s edition (1943) rather than that of C.L. Wrenn (1953, later revised by W.F. Bolton)—but Tolkien did not seem to refer to it much, so he was probably reciting largely from memory, and the performative effect was exactly as Stewart recalls it. He did sometimes allude to other literary works—I remember one or two to *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*—which I think may have been on the spur of the moment. Incidentally, student rumor had it that Tolkien disliked Wrenn’s much drier style of teaching, and even that the character of Gollum was partly based on Wrenn, who was extremely short-sighted and had a habit of referring to unsatisfactory tutees (in their presence) as ‘it’ (‘it hasn’t even read . . .’ etc.), but that was, perhaps, only student gossip.

LN: You were also lucky to attend some of the lectures given by Tolkien’s youngest son (and his future literary executor), Christopher. When was that? Which classes were they?

JM: I went to Christopher’s lectures on the heroic code. I think it was in 1961–62, my first year at the university. I found them so useful that I went to them again in the following year.

of that section which deals with Grendel’s recurrent attacks on King Hrothgar’s hall Heorot (ll. 86–188).

¹⁵ In Professor McKinnell’s own notes, “Read intro. to stress the importance of sound” (I).

¹⁶ In the words of Zaleski and Zaleski, “Tolkien had a flair for theatrics, which would be revealed to the general public many years later in his audio recordings of excerpts from *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* [as well as, one should add, the entire text of *The Homecoming of Beorhtnoth*]” (215).

LN: It was certainly not easy for Christopher Tolkien to pursue the academic career, following in his father's footsteps. There must have been some people within the broadly understood academia who, advertently or not, measured his philological expertise against that of the long-time professor of Anglo-Saxon (Pembroke College, 1925–45) and English Language and Literature (Merton College, 1945–59). Nevertheless, would you say that there were some noticeable analogies between J.R.R. Tolkien's own lectures and the ones that were given by his son? Were Christopher's classes as informative and entertaining as those of his father?

JM: Again, I only experienced Christopher's lectures, not his tutorials (he taught at New College, becoming a fellow of that college in 1963, while I was at Worcester; at that time, University lecturers with no college fellowship were the most junior members of staff, and could be hired by a college to tutor their students with no security of tenure and rather poor rates of pay).¹⁷ He was good-looking, charismatic and a bit of a *matinée* idol, so the front row of his lectures was always full of admiring girls. I (and some of his other male listeners) used to sit in the back row and pretend not to be too impressed, but in fact his lectures were clear, fluent and interesting. I remember particularly how he used the *Hrafnkels saga* and the eddic poem *Atlakviða* to illustrate the heroic duty of vengeance, and this was part of what first attracted me to Old Norse literature.¹⁸ It also made me realize how different Germanic traditions influenced each other, and, in turn, led to much interesting discussion about the *Sifrit/Siegfried/Sigurðr* cycle with my friend and fellow Worcester student Chris Wells, later a fellow at St. Edmund Hall and Professor of medieval German literature.

LN: Do you think that either (or both) of the two scholars had any direct or indirect influence on your scholarly interests? Could your decision to pursue the academic path have been in any way determined or at least influenced by the author of *The Lord of the Rings* and/or his youngest son?

JM: I was certainly influenced by both of them—firstly by reading *The Lord of the Rings* when I was still at school. I remember, for instance, reading part of

¹⁷ Prior to his resignation in 1975, Christopher Tolkien had worked as a lecturer in English at St. Catherine's Society, Oxford (1954–59), University College, Oxford (1959–64), and New College, Oxford (1957–75). For a more detailed itinerary of his academic career and other notable events in his life, see McIlwaine (26–27) and Honegger (663–65).

¹⁸ Amongst Christopher Tolkien's scholarly publications in the field of Old Norse studies are two editions (as well as translations) of the *Hervarar saga ok Heiðreks* (1953 and 1960), an introduction to Gabriel Turville-Petre's notes and glossary to the very same text (1956), and article 'The Battle of the Goths and the Huns' (1955–56), whose focus is upon the central conflict of the saga.

it on a train journey from Edinburgh to visit my grandmother in Derbyshire and then looking out of the train window at the industrial wasteland between Leeds and Sheffield, and thinking ‘this is the land of Mordor.’ I did not then know that Tolkien’s early career had included a period as a lecturer at Leeds. At Oxford, Tolkien was famous and generally inspiring, but, in the end, it was Christopher who probably had more influence on me. Some years later I was asked to design a Heroic Age course for first-year students at the university of Durham, and so I based large parts of it on the structure and sequence of Christopher’s own lectures. This proved so successful that a similar module is still popular with Durham students.

LN: Thank you for your insightful answers concerning both Tolkiens.

JM: Thank you.

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ŁUKASZ NEUBAUER received his PhD in English philology from the University of Łódź. He is a researcher and lecturer at the University of Szczecin, Poland, where he teaches a number of literary courses. Apart from his publications dealing with various medieval as well as Christian influences and resonances in *The Lord of the Rings*, he has written papers on *The Battle of Maldon*, *Beowulf*, *Heliand*, Icelandic sagas and the so-called 'beasts of battle' trope in, particularly but not exclusively, Old Germanic poetry. His most recent publications include a monograph *The Long Shadow of Fáfnir: Dragons in the Works of J.R.R. Tolkien and C.S. Lewis. A Christian Perspective* (2023) and book of essays *The Songs of the Spheres: Lewis, Tolkien and the Overlapping Realms of their Imaginations* (2024).



"BETTER TO REIGN IN HELL": AMBIVALENCE AND ORCS IN THE LAY OF THE CHILDREN OF HÚRIN

MATTHEW THOMPSON-HANDELL

IN AN EARLIER ARTICLE,¹ I EXAMINED THE WAY in which J.R.R. Tolkien's unfinished *Lay of the Children of Húrin*² (written in alliterative verse mainly in the first half of the 1920s) demonstrates the aesthetic of the sublime, in the form described and formulated by Edmund Burke in his 1757 work *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful*. In that work, Burke provided several examples of sources of the sublime by quoting from John Milton's *Paradise Lost*.³ The significance of the sublime to Milton's work was also identified by the 18th century critic, poet and lexicographer Samuel Johnson, who said: "The characteristick quality of his poem is sublimity. He sometimes descends to the elegant, but his element is the great. He can occasionally invest himself with grace; but his natural port is gigantick loftiness. He can please when pleasure is required; but it is his peculiar power to astonish" (122–3). In terms of connections between Tolkien and Milton, all of this is quite tenuous. However, there is a passage in the *Lay of the Children of Húrin* which can, if one's ear is cocked at the right angle, be heard like an echo of a passage in Book I of *Paradise Lost*. Even if one hears it, that might be of just passing interest, one of countless literary resonances which have proved a fruitful hunting ground for

¹ "‘Their Limbs Were Loosened in Listening Horror’: The Sublime in the *Lay of the Children of Húrin*"; see bibliography.

² Published in *The Lays of Beleriand*, being the third volume of *The History of Middle-earth*.

³ Examples can be found in Burke's Part II, Sections III, IV and XIV, concerning obscurity and light.

Tolkien scholars during the last seventy years. But the echo in question may have a small part to play in the lively debate about the nature of Tolkien's Orcs.

The passage from *Paradise Lost* describes the moment when the unfurling of Satan's standard prompts the assembly of fallen angels to raise their voices and their weapons. The passage from the *Lay* describes the moment when the sight of Thangorodrim prompts the Orc-band to raise their voices and their weapons. The passages are reproduced here:

***Paradise Lost*, Book I, lines 535–49:**

Who forthwith from the glittering Staff unfurl'd
Th'Imperial Ensign, which full high advanc't
Shon like a Meteor streaming to the Wind
With Gemms and Golden lustre rich imblaz'd,
Seraphic arms and Trophies: all the while
Sonorous mettall blowing Martial sounds:
At which the universal Host upsent
A shout that tore Hells Concave, and beyond
Frighted the Reign of Chaos and old Night.
All in a moment through the gloom were seen
Ten thousand Banners rise into the Air
With Orient Colours waving: with them rose
A Forest huge of Spears: and thronging Helms
Appear'd, and serried Shields in thick array
Of depth immeasurable [...].

***Lay of the Children of Húrin*, lines 994–1007**

Like a throbbing thunder in the threatening deeps
of cavernous clouds o'ercast with gloom
now swelled on a sudden a song most dire,
and their hellward hymn their home greeted;
flung from the foremost of the fierce spearmen,
who viewed mid vapours vast and sable
the threefold peaks of Thangorodrim,
it rolled rearward, rumbling darkly,
like drums in distant dungeons empty.
Then a werewolf howled; a word was shouted
like steel on stone; and stiffly raised
their spears and swords sprang up thickly
as the wild wheatfield of the wargod's realm
with points that palely pricked the twilight.

There are of course differences in these two descriptions. The passage from *Paradise Lost* has a grander, almost bombastic tone, in the face of which the passage from the *Lay* appears rather more subdued and gloomy. It is however in the imagery of the assembled forces, and in their response to the power that rules them, that resemblances begin to appear.

The first of these can be seen in the martial imagery of the two passages. The fallen angels are described as “A Forest huge of Spears” while the Orcs are “fierce spearmen” (though also bearing swords). There is also an echo of Milton’s “Forest” where Tolkien describes how the weapons of the Orcs “sprang up thickly / as the wild wheatfield.” More profoundly, Milton’s fallen angels are so moved by the sight of Satan’s standard that they call out in “A shout that tore Hell’s Concave.” Though the voices of the Orcs do not carry the same force, the same dynamic can be seen when they catch a glimpse of Thangorodrim “mid vapours vast and sable” and are impelled to break into “a song most dire.” And just as Satan’s standard represents the sense of comradeship and belonging which binds the fallen angels together, so too do Thangorodrim—and its master, Morgoth—represent a place which the Orcs (to use Tolkien’s word) call “home.” Indeed, that word appears in one of the most remarkable lines in the passage in the *Lay*, a line which not only echoes the infernal setting of Book I of *Paradise Lost*, but also reinforces the sense of belonging—of worship even—that binds the Orcs to Morgoth: “and their hellward hymn their home greeted.”

All of this might be little more than a literary curiosity. Consider though that a major theme in the criticism of *Paradise Lost* concerns the nature of Milton’s depiction of Satan, or more particularly, whether he is (or should be seen as) a sympathetic or even heroic figure. This Satan may not be a man of wealth and taste, nor is he by any stretch monstrous in the way that Milton’s Sin and Death are. His silver-tongued rhetoric in the opening Books of *Paradise Lost* would have him raised up as a paragon of wronged virtue, a champion of the unjustly treated fallen angels. Much has been written by critics (including by C.S. Lewis in his *A Preface to Paradise Lost*) that Milton is not presenting Satan as the hero of the work, though the fact that this debate has consumed so much critical attention is a testament to the ambivalence of Milton’s depiction, an ambivalence rather neatly summed up by one critic in his edition of the work: “Is [Satan’s] heroism put in its place, or does it run off with the poem?” (Milton, xx).

Let us return then to Tolkien and the Orcs. Their depiction in the passage quoted above has a hint of something high-minded (if not quite noble) about it which, in the face of the evil that they undeniably represent, creates an ambivalence which is of the same type (though not to the same degree) as that which Milton creates. The hint lies in how the Orcs raise their voices in song, joining in a hymn—a hymn—to the longed-for home that they glimpse in the far distance. I am admittedly playing devil’s advocate, though the sense of

ambivalence is amplified by the imagery of the earlier campfire scene soon after Beleg joins Túrin and his band of outlaws: “Then a song on a sudden soaring loudly— / and the trees up-looming towering harkened / [...] Their blades were bared, as blood shining / in the flame of the fires while they flashed and touched” (ll.624–38). Here the outlaws raise their voices and their weapons in comradeship, just as the Orcs will do.

The passage considered above is but a fleeting example in an unfinished work, but it provides a glimpse of a more nuanced depiction of the Orcs, a topic which has been the subject of critical work in recent years. In a 2000 essay, Tom Shippey argues that Orcs are moral beings, examining their dialogue in *The Lord of the Rings* in order to highlight how they “recognize the idea of goodness, appreciate humor, value loyalty, trust, group cohesion, and the ideal of a higher cause than themselves, and condemn failings from these ideals in others” (186). In a 2010 article, Robert Tally argues that Tolkien “occasionally reveals a not entirely unsympathetic view of Orcs, in which what might be called their simple humanity becomes visible” (22). He finds this humanity in the dialogues between Shagrat and Gorbag (fearful but at the same time skeptical of the “Big Bosses”) and in the personalities and attitudes of the Orcs who are taking Merry and Pippin to Isengard.⁴ In a 2011 article, David Tneh also looks closely at the dialogue between Shagrat and Gorbag, drawing out elements such as humor and loyalty, as well as a desire for peace and comfort, in support of an argument that “the orcs do show some form of human behavior that we recognize and relate to” (42). What is particularly interesting is that the depiction of the Orcs in the *Lay of the Children of Húrin*, raising their voices in song at the sight of Thangorodrim, provides a further example of what one might call “human” behavior, but one whose high-minded quality is rather distinct from the earthy and colloquial dialogues in *The Lord of the Rings*. It would have been fascinating to see how Tolkien might have developed this thread of Orcish behavior—another reason to regret the abandonment by Tolkien of the *Lay*.

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⁴ Robert Tally's new monograph, *The Mismeasure of Orcs*, is expected to be published by McFarland later in 2025.

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MATTHEW THOMPSON-HANDELL is an independent scholar with a particular interest in responses to Tolkien's work, both critical and popular. He has written articles for the *Journal of Tolkien Research*, *Beyond Bree* and *Angerthas* (the journal of Arthedain, the Tolkien Society of Norway).



ST. JACK'S EXPERIMENT HOUSE FOR JUVENILE DELINQUENTS:
RESPONDING TO *ASLAN'S BREATH* BY MATTHEW DICKERSON
G. CONNOR SALTER

IN ROALD DAHL'S CHILDREN'S BOOK *MATILDA*,¹ Miss Honey asks the protagonist what books she likes. Matilda answers, "I liked *The Lion, The Witch, and the Wardrobe* [...] I think C.S. Lewis is a very good writer. But he has one failing. There are no funny bits in his books" (80).² As Robert C. Stroud observes, various online writers, most notably on the blogs *Like But Better* ("Nathan") and *Bookworms and Bluestockings* (Inkling) have critiqued Matilda's taste while offering compare-and-contrast discussions about Lewis and Dahl. One topic rarely explored in these discussions is how Lewis sometimes offers something Matilda finds very funny: revenge.

¹ Dahl's work has been controversial for some decades now, both due to anti-Semitic comments which led his estate to apologize "for the lasting and understandable hurt caused by some of Roald Dahl's statements" in 2020 ("Apology for anti-Semitic comments"), and to concerns about cruel language or cruel treatment of characters in his fiction. I do not condone Dahl's views but feel his global reputation makes it essential to consider the implicit philosophy within his work. I hope this paper helps to consider the implications of how Dahl treats characters.

² I wish to thank Edwin Woodruff Tait for directing my attention to this passage.

The topic of Lewis and revenge leads Matthew Dickerson to interesting territory in his recent book *Aslan's Breath: Seeing the Holy Spirit in Narnia*.³ Dickerson explores the final Experiment House scene in *The Silver Chair*, one of the “few scenes in Lewis’ writing that bother me in the sense that I think he got it wrong (from a moral or spiritual viewpoint)” (85). Throughout this book, Dickerson contends that Aslan’s breath or kiss represents the Holy Spirit. Hence, when Aslan kisses the foreheads of Jill Pole, Eustace Scrubb, and King Caspian before they “enter the school and with the flats of their swords and a switch they proceed to overcome and beat the gang of bullies and send them running” (85), the kiss must be seen “as an anointing, and his breath as a sending of the Holy Spirit” (86). This is divinely sanctioned violence.

The implications are troubling. We may think of Rowan Williams’s concern that “a lot of the time, [Lewis] inhabits quite uncritically the conventions of chivalric adventure, ‘knightly’ slaughter of the wicked” (44). Dickerson doesn’t flatly object to Lewis depicting Holy Spirit-sent warriors but worries that the Experiment House cleansing isn’t Christ-like. He notes that the scene features Aslan’s followers attacking those who don’t know him; while Christ upset members of his own religion (the Jews) by cleansing the temple, he was never violent to the Romans (Dickerson 85–86). Hence, the scene reads more like revenge than divine justice; less like comeuppance, more like Lewis “playing out his imaginative fantasies from his own awful boarding school experience” (85).

Dickerson’s point challenges scholars who may want to discuss Christ and justice in Lewis’s fiction without discussing pain. For example, Marek Oziewicz sees Lewis as primarily exploring compensational justice—which Oziewicz defines as emphasizing justice’s emotional and moral process, highlighting an unjust action’s consequences, seeing offenders as responsible human beings who must face the consequences of their actions, and finally reconciling offenders to others (54).⁴ He sees compensational justice in scenes like Edmund and Eustace facing their choices’ consequences before repenting (55–58). When offenders refuse to repent, compensational justice keeps them from continuing criminal activity—such as Governor Gumpus being fired in *The Voyage of the “Dawn Treader”* or Rabadash becoming a donkey who cannot leave Tashbaan in *The Horse and His Boy* (58–60). Oziewicz also reads cases where Lewis’s villains die or gradually suffer as compensational justice since the offenders see their fates are consequences of their actions: Jadis realizes in *The Magician’s Nephew* that she has gained an immortal but miserable life,

³ I must also thank Dickerson and the participants in his Inklings Folk Fellowship presentation on the book (“Aslan’s Breath”), especially Roy Wallen, for their wise responses to my questions about Dickerson’s argument.

⁴ For a summary of Oziewicz’s other work on this subject, see Dilbeck.

treacherous Miraz gets killed by treacherous Telmarines in *Prince Caspian*, and Tash kills Shift and terrifies Ginger until losing his power of speech in *The Last Battle* (61–62).

While Oziewicz's argument is compelling, Dickerson shows that not all Narnian justice is compensational. Shift and Ginger may see their punishment is clearly consequences for their actions, but neither the Experiment House students nor the Head have that opportunity. If compensational justice keeps offenders from repeating mistakes, then the fact that Head continues to be a busybody in other school jobs, and a busybody on the national stage when her friends "got her into Parliament where she lived happily ever after" (*Silver Chair* 16.216) is rather unjust. We may also consider smaller Narnian comeuppance scenes that aren't very compensational—like Aslan seeing a man beat a boy and turning the man into a tree (*Prince Caspian* 14.195). Compensational justice explains much of Lewis's moral framework in Narnia, but there are large, school-bully-sized, exceptions.

But if Lewis's vision of justice is multilayered, if he sometimes also offers retributive justice, which may verge on vengeance, a more fruitful discussion becomes possible. Dickerson is not the first to see the Experiment House cleansing as Lewis's revenge on real-life tormentors: Terry Lindvall notes in his landmark study *Surprised by Laughter*⁵ that the police assume the Head is insane, paralleling how Lewis's headmaster at Wynard School, Reverend Capon, was institutionalized (362). We may easily compare Lewis to Dahl here: as the Like But Better article notes, both men had terrible boarding school experiences. Helen Lewis observes how many Dahl stories feature retributive, perhaps vicarious, justice against bullies and schoolteachers. For example, Dahl turned his experience of being caned for allegedly cheating (*More About Boy* 129–38) into fiction in *Danny, the Champion in the World* (112–14). Danny's father is enraged at what happened (*Danny* 116–18), perhaps offering catharsis to Dahl, whose father died when he was three. Lewis's Christianity may have given him moral values that the secular Dahl didn't follow, but Dickerson challenges us to see that Lewis wasn't always Christlike about school trauma.

Furthermore, Lewis and Dahl enjoy combining retributive justice with humor, which means we must extend Dickerson's point: this is not just revenge, but comic revenge. Comic revenge provokes different reactions in readers than straight vengeance. It may seem more acceptable. Maria Nikolajeva argues that Dahl's children's books fulfill a classic function by being "disgusting in combination with humour" (Anderson). Dahl's revenge scenes (especially in

⁵ I have used the original 1996 edition here because it includes material on Lewis's story "The Shoddy Lands" excised from the revised 2012 edition.

Matilda) are often comic, as is the Experiment House cleansing. The Experiment House cleansing isn't even Lewis's darkest comic revenge. In *Prince Caspian*, Aslan and Bacchus pass a school and frighten "a number of boys who looked very like pigs," whom Lewis implies are transformed into pigs (14.196). Bacchus is under Aslan's guidance, so, like in the Experiment House scene, this is divinely ordained comeuppance. Given that Narnians avoid eating talking beasts but are not vegetarians (Myers 6), we assume the schoolboys eventually became food, a far worse fate than the Experiment House students being expelled (*Silver Chair* 16.216). Yet even the *Prince Caspian* scene is comic: "[f]ew can resist the enjoyment [...] of seeing a classroom of smug, stuffy, and conceited little brats in starched collars 'get theirs'" (Lindvall 165).

These examples challenge us to consider whether Lewis has a more provocative sense of humor than often discussed. Many scholars have considered Lewis's approach to humor, sometimes in unexpected works. For example, Joe Ricke has recently explored how Lewis deploys humor in his literary criticism.⁶ Scholars such as Peter J. Schakel have considered Lewis as a satirist, generally focusing on one of two books. Many mention *The Screwtape Letters*, as when Charles A. Huttar notes that the book offers "satire" and "moral instruction," two genres with "connections to an epistolary tradition going back to ancient times" (91). Others explore *That Hideous Strength*, as when James Prothero compares the novel to Jonathan Swift's satires (7, 13). Sanford Schwartz addresses how important it is to read *That Hideous Strength* as satire, particularly as Lewis wrote that he "wanted farce as well as fantasy" in this novel (185n7; c.f. "A Reply to Professor Haldane" 72).

Some scholars have seen Lewis offering dark comedy. Nancy-Lou Patterson sees humor in the N.I.C.E. dinner in *That Hideous Strength*, comparing it to the chaotic feast in Lewis Carroll's *Through the Looking-Glass* ("Banquet at Belbury" 8). Lindvall sees taboo humor in the scene when Uncle Andrew describes his experiments that made guinea pigs explode (274). Chris Armstrong's paper for the 2018 International Congress on Medieval Studies considers how Lewis emulates the humor in medieval mystery plays and Francis of Assisi's guidance to view our bodies as "Brother Ass" by treating death and desire humorously in works like *The Four Loves* ("Death, Desire, and the Sacramental Function of Humor").

By far, Lindvall offers the most detailed summary of Lewis offering comic comeuppance scenes. He mentions not just the Experiment House

⁶ Given Ricke's point that Lewis deploys satire in under-discussed ways within his literary work, more research must be done in this area. Ricke has offered an intriguing suggestion in an online conversation: first, scholars need an anthology of Lewis's humorist writings, from contributions to *Punch* to his essays; second, someone needs to produce a monograph focusing on Lewis as a humorist (not just his sense of humor, a topic that Lindvall covers well).

cleansing and the Telmarine schoolboys becoming pigs, but also a teacher and her spoiled girl students fleeing Aslan (Lindvall 259; c.f. *Prince Caspian* 14.193–194), Rabadash becoming a donkey (Lindvall 210–211; c.f. *Horse and His Boy* 15.208–211), Narnian animals terrorizing animal experimenter Uncle Andrew (Lindvall 211–212; c.f. *Magician's Nephew* 11.129–133), animals helping to kill the N.I.C.E. scientists who experimented on them at the dinner (Lindvall 358; c.f. *That Hideous Strength* 16.347–350), Tash killing Shift (Lindvall 332; c.f. *Last Battle* 13.143), and Malacandrians laughing at Weston (209–210; c.f. *Out of the Silent Planet* 19.128). While Dickerson considers how the shocking events affect the bullies, Lindvall prefers to highlight how the bullies' humiliation shows their flaws; for example, he highlights Experiment House's head teacher being shocked when the cleansing occurs as Lewis satirizing progressive educators (361). Rowan Williams concurs and is more critical: for him, "the facile satire against progressive education is too obviously Lewis indulging in partisan grumbling, and the trouncing of the school bullies is a forced and blustering bit of school-story cliché" (44).

While all of these scholars provide excellent insights, they stop short of considering just how dark Lewis can be. To say that Lewis offers darkly comic retributive punishments goes beyond satire; Jane Austen satirizes foolish minister via Mr. Collins but never has Mr. Collins suffer for his foolishness. To say that Lewis offers a comedy beyond satire, mixed with justice too vengeful to be Christlike, that mentions the body (riding crops hitting bullies, etc.) but not to remind us of "Brother Ass," means that Lewis is not just a talented children's author. He is a provocative children's author. Not unlike Dahl.

We may ask, do Dahl and Lewis parallel each other in other ways? They had more in common than the fact they were both world war veterans⁷ who lost a parent young and suffered in boarding school. For example, they both declined CBEs (Stroud; c.f. Flood). Their interest in pain may have had similar roots: critics have seen Dahl's emphasis on cruel punishments as sadistic (Leith) and Lewis's Philomastix letters to Albert Greeves discuss having teenage sadistic fantasies. We may ponder whether Lewis's darkest schoolboy revenge scenes show traces of his old sadism.

However, comparing Lewis to Dahl is especially fruitful if we consider how darkly comedic punishments combine humor with horror. Many have discussed horror's intersection with humor, from horror authors like M.R. James amusing their friends (*M.R. James: Ghost Writer*, 00:54:41)⁸ to writers like Richard

⁷ For a deeper look at Lewis and Dahl as world war veterans who became children's authors, see Reist and Snyder.

⁸ It may be worth noting here that Lewis's personal humor included pranks, as seen when he gave Walter Hooper a bath towel when he asked to use the bathroom (Neal).

Christian Matheson bridging the genres (and analyzing the genres' intersection in his essay "They Laughed When I Howled at the Moon"). Dahl often has an in-between place in this conversation. Adrian Schober connects his children's books to Gothic fiction (34–36), while Greg Littman calls Dahl a children's horror author for how he emphasizes threats (later fulfilled in detail) of bodily harm (174). In fact, Dahl is "perhaps the greatest writer of children's horror fiction" (173). The stories Littman sees as children's horror are the same stories that Nikolajeva sees as comic. Lindvall's words about how many readers will laugh at the schoolboys becoming pigs in *Prince Caspian* could easily apply to the naughty children punished in *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory*. One might say that Dahl's children's stories are horribly humorous.

The same mix of humor and horror, a mix placing the work between conventional categories, appears in Dahl's adult fiction. His short stories have appeared in over 30 horror anthologies, including *The Penguin Book of Horror Stories*. However, Alan Warren sees Dahl as an unusual horror writer, a specialist in "what the French term *contes cruel*, but without the bloodshed. He is one horror writer who rarely spills blood" (120). H.P. Lovecraft calls *contes cruel* "a class peculiar to itself [...] in which the wrenching of the emotions is accomplished through dramatic tantalizations, frustrations, and gruesome physical horrors" (50). Dahl's stories—for example, a woman killing her husband with a frozen leg of lamb and feeding it to the police in "Lamb to the Slaughter"⁹—feature bodily harm, but usually treat the violence as dark comedy. Since they are funnier than conventional horror, it's not surprising that Warren writes that Dahl's *contes cruel* stories "are not horrific in the usual sense," comparing him to Saki, John Collier, James Thurber, and Charles Addams (121). Dahl's fiction, whatever age group he directed it toward, was convention-breaking work existing between horror and humor, his unique mix especially noticeable when Dahl punishes characters for indiscretions.

Lewis could equally be considered a horribly humorous author. An increasing body of scholarship discusses Lewis as a horror author, from gothic horror in *That Hideous Strength* (Nicholson) to comparisons to Russell Kirk's ghost stories (Salter, "Russell Kirk and the Inklings"). The Mythopoeic Society's Winter 2022 Online Conference on The Inklings and Horror featured discussions ranging from how Lewis communicates horrific moments in the Chronicles of Narnia (Thompson) to the talking head in *That Hideous Strength* as body horror (Brians). As with Dahl, these horrible scenes are often comic. Schwartz

⁹ Ian Fleming gave Dahl the concept for this story (Conant 333). Given that Fleming has also been analyzed as featuring sadomasochism in his fiction (for a recent example, see Sharman), and that Dahl adapted several Fleming stories to film, there may be a larger discussion here about Fleming and Dahl as kindred spirits who enjoyed combining humor, horror, and sexual taboos.

highlights the “gruesome, carnivalesque violence with which the traditional order reasserts its authority” at the N.I.C.E. dinner in *That Hideous Strength* (97).

Lewis even edged toward Dahlesque risqué humor. Lindvall highlights the satirical academic double-talk in the short story “Ministering Angels” (358). Yet this tale about governments shipping women to the moon as astronaut concubines is also grotesque sex farce, deliberately “full of weird stereotypes, unkind moments, and unpleasant philosophies” (Mikalatos 1). Lindvall reads “The Shoddy Lands,” in which a man goes into a woman’s mind, as a satire of modern values (365); it could equally be read as playing with male voyeurism.¹⁰ The fact that neither character in “The Shoddy Lands” cares much for people (Mikalatos) means it can be read as dissecting misanthropy, a trait that Dahl and other *contes cruel* writers are often accused of.

Lewis was even capable of Dahlesque twists in stories like “The Man Born Blind,” also known as “Light.” Both versions of the story follow a formerly blind man wondering where the light is that so many people have told him about, ultimately falling off a cliff as he tries to catch it (*Dark Tower and Other Stories* 99–103; Starr 6–9). All the right plot twists for a *contes cruel* story.

Yet there are crucial differences between how Lewis and Dahl write horribly humorous stories. Where Dahl might have used twists to emphasize the dark comedy or the bodily suffering, Lewis often leans into a philosophical or spiritual theme. “The Man Born Blind” may have different overtones in “Light,” the version that Charlie W. Starr published (6–9), but neither version is a Saki-style dark comedy about (mis)communication. Lewis has other things he wants to say, primarily about language and the act of contemplation.

While Lewis often has villains suffer in comic ways, he usually doesn’t emphasize the bodily harm as strongly as Dahl does—at least not in his children’s stories. Villains who die from the consequences of their choices (Shift, Miraz, the White Witch) die without much description. When their wounds aren’t mortal, their injuries (Gumpus thrown from a chair, Uncle Andrew drenched in dirt and water, Rabadash stuck on a building) are minor. Even when Jill “plied her crop on the girls and Eustance and Caspian plied the flats of their swords on the boys,” (*Silver Chair* 16.215), Lewis leaves it unclear whether the plying breaks flesh. Lewis reserves his darkest villain punishment scene for the N.I.C.E. dinner, which covers “much of the last part of [*That Hideous Strength*]” (Patterson, “Banquet” 7), but occurs in a story addressed to

¹⁰ While Mikalatos notes that the main character isn’t attracted to the woman when he enters her mind and she looks like a giant, the giant-woman-tiny-man element may make Dahl fans recall Oswald Hendryks Cornelius talking about the allure of tall women and how many women “go absolutely dotty about tiny men” (*My Uncle Oswald* 18). Lewis plays with material that could be sexual but prefers to explore other points.

grownups, punishing villains explicitly described as following demonic entities seeking world domination.

Lewis also offers biblical allusions that Dahl rarely explores, even in his schoolboy scenes. Prothero compares the N.I.C.E. dinner in *That Hideous Strength* to Sodom's judgment (7), while Lindvall compares it to the Tower of Babel (358). As Jem Bloomfield has noted, Aslan via Bacchus turning schoolboys into a fleeing pig herd may allude to Jesus sending a pig herd into the sea at the Gadarenes (143–47). Particularly since Lewis leaves it unclear how much harm Jill's riding crop causes, the Experiment House cleansing resembles Jesus cleansing the temple in Jerusalem; Martyn J. Smith notes how many scholars have debated whether Jesus's whip of cords scourged or merely frightened people (80–82). Even in his least Christlike passages, Lewis can be rather biblical, which may explain Dickerson's point that Lewis's less-than-Christlike punishments are unsettling: they carry a "close, but not quite" quality.

If Lewis's horribly humorous punishments seem sadistic, it's worth noting that he generally reserves the worst physical experiences for his heroes. Since Patterson highlights how the N.I.C.E. dinner takes up "twenty-five pages" in her 1945 Bodley Head edition ("Banquet" 7), I checked my 1965 Collier box set of the Ransom trilogy. In that edition, the dinner covers 19 pages (*That Hideous Strength* 16.343–16.352). However, Ransom's fight with the Un-Man in *Perelandra* takes 30 pages (12.152–14.182). Since Oziewicz emphasizes Edmund's compensational pest-to-hero journey, I explored what happens when the White Witch takes Edmund captive. Edmund suffers immensely—being drenched with melted snow, struck on the face, tied up, whipped, and forced to walk past exhaustion and hunger—across 15 pages (*The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe* 11.107–18, 13.130–34).

If we measure suffering by gruesome detail instead of page count, Lewis's heroes still get the worst. Few wounds are more awkward than foot injuries, and the Un-Man gnaws at Ransom's foot with "the nasty, blunt teeth [...] which crush and grind more than they cut" (*Perelandra* 15.187). When Puggleglum stamps out the Green Lady's fire with his bare foot, Lewis tells us about the pain ("he knew it would hurt him badly enough; and so it did" [*Silver Chair* 12.158]), and underlines the ordeal cooked Puddleglum's flesh ("the sweet heavy smell grew very much less [...] what remained smelled very largely of burnt Marsh-wiggle" [ibid]). Lewis's most famous visceral scene is Aslan tearing off Eustace's skin for his undragoning ("Dawn Treader" 12.88–91). Lewis and Dahl both like having villains experience pain; but Lewis reserves the longest or most gruesome gauntlets to characters resisting evil or growing into goodness.

The pain that heroes suffer also means something more in Lewis's stories. Dahl's heroes suffer, but their pain rarely gets referenced after a scene.¹¹ Mr. Fox bemoans losing his tail (*Fantastic Mr. Fox* 15), but it doesn't stop him from agilely performing his greatest heist. Lewis lets his heroes have wounds affecting them long-term (Ransom's foot never healing, Puddleglum still limping at the book's end); the pain informs their ongoing journeys. As discussed elsewhere, Lewis uses biblical allusions to make his heroes' pain into sanctifying experiences (Salter, "Tellers of Dark Fairy Tales" 159–60). Ransom and Puddleglum become Christ figures through their foot wounds, echoing Genesis 3:15 when the (literal or symbolic)¹² serpent strikes the Messiah's heel. Lewis may like punishing his villains, but he cares more about having his heroes struggle to resist evil or grow into their heroic roles, struggles which undercut any sense that their prowess saves the day.¹³

In contrast, Dahl offers no consistent moral scheme to their heroes' pain. His short stories often feature people suffering for sins (the husband who deserts his wife in "Lamb to the Slaughter") or foolishness (the man with a back tattoo who trusts a generous stranger in "Skin"). But many stories offer no clear moral: "Gallop Foxley" describes a man recalling school bullying when he sees someone resembling his old prefect but the plot never resolves. Pain and its remembrance prove valueless. Dahl's children's books are similarly inconsistent. Marc Napolitano sees the naughty children suffering in *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory* as fitting Charles Foucault's theory in *Discipline and Punish* about enforcing conformity: the bland conformist Charlie experiences no pain but every other child gets punished according to their abnormal quirk (81–92). In *Matilda*, the reverse is true: her quirky magic powers save her. Pain rarely sanctifies in Dahl's stories either: Bruce Bogtrotter being forced to eat a giant cake in *Matilda* or James's aunts abusing him in *James and the Giant Peach* don't

¹¹ I have noted elsewhere how Dahl's attitude to pain influenced J.K. Rowling, who also offers an abused hero who doesn't experience plausible, long-term trauma (Salter, "The Wart, The Wizard, and the Cathedral" 74–75, 82, 89).

¹² The Green Lady turns into a serpent and the Un-Man is a tempting serpent figure. For more on the serpent imagery, see Patterson, "Halfe Like a Serpent," and Muth.

¹³ While not key to this discussion, the same could be said about Peter's terror when he kills a wolf in *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*. By emphasizing the hero's fear or treating the villains' pain comedically, Lewis undercuts celebrating his heroes' valor. Even his heroes who kill repulsive villains don't glory in it: Williams notes how when Jewel and Tirian kill the Telmarine slavers in *The Last Battle*, they "feel deeply ashamed. They have killed unarmed men, and for all that there is provocation, there is no glory about it" (44). Christian men's conferences may enjoy quoting the movie *Braveheart* alongside *Mere Christianity*, but Lewis never gives readers anything like William Wallace screaming "Freedom!" before entering battle. The difference may explain why Lewis often has heroes suffer, but rarely faces Mel Gibson's charge of being a sadomasochistic storyteller.

make the heroes grow. For Dahl, pain is a lesson in endurance and biding time to strike back, not a sanctification opportunity.¹⁴

Dickerson's point about *The Silver Chair* is valid. Lewis is not a perfect Christologist, and his fiction featuring school tormentors particularly show a tension between justice and vengeance in his theology. Depicting revenge with humor means that Lewis has rarely been labeled a children's horror author as Dahl has. Yet as librarian Kirsten Kowaleski observes, the difference between a scary book for children and a children's horror book is ambiguous ("Where Are the Scary Books?"). Lewis is often more provocative, more horribly humorous, than readers may realize.

Given Lewis's skill at depicting pain and how he didn't mind edging into risqué territory in stories like "Ministering Angels," he could have taken Dahl's route. Yet by preference or choice, Lewis stops short of the full focus on visceral pain or bleak comic twists that define *contes cruel* writers like Dahl, Saki, and Addams. In particular, his (frequent if not consistent) emphasis on compensational justice, and his preference for heroic pain that changes his characters place him just outside Dahl's circle. He offers "funny bits," but not quite as gruesome ones as Matilda's creator offers.

In fact, the Experiment House cleansing may show how Lewis manages to simultaneously be as transgressive as Dahl, yet also more redemptive. The school's bullies suffer, but get off lightly compared to the schoolboys in *Prince Caspian*. Eustace's central place in *The Silver Chair*, a much kinder boy than he was in *Voyage of the "Dawn Treader,"* shows that even Experiment House students can grow. We may read the pain that Eustace, Edmund, and the unnamed bullies experience in the first four published Narnia books as Lewis's own experiment: how best to discipline and reform schoolboys, becoming kinder with each attempt.

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¹⁴ The Fleming comparison may be helpful again here: James Bond undergoes rigorous physical pain throughout Fleming's novels, but the pain is never a sanctifying experience.

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G. CONNOR SALTER has a Bachelor of Science in Professional Writing from Taylor University. He has spoken on Inklings topics on several occasions, including "William Lindsay Gresham: Writer, Magician, Seeker" (November 3, 2023) and "The Lion and the Vampire: The Inklings and English Horror Films in Conversation," (October 29, 2021), both for Inklings Folk Fellowship. He has contributed to many publications, including *CSL: The Bulletin of the New York C.S. Lewis Society*, *The Lamp-Post*, *Fellowship & Fairydust*, *The Oddest Inklings*, and *A Pilgrim in Narnia*. His recent work includes "William Lindsay Gresham and Norse Poetry: A Surprising Discovery," (*CSL*, vol. 55, no. 1) and "Tellers of Dark Fairy Tales: Common Themes in the Works of C.S. Lewis and Terence Fisher" (*Mythlore* vol. 41, no. 1).



WEAVING WIKIPEDIA'S MIDDLE-EARTH WEB

IAN F. ALEXANDER

BEGINNINGS

THE ONLINE ENCYCLOPEDIA Wikipedia WAS FOUNDED IN 2001, just when Peter Jackson's films were bringing Middle-earth to a mass audience. It grew rapidly to become the world's largest and most-read work of reference. Articles on Tolkien and *The Lord of the Rings*, and on some Middle-earth characters such as Frodo Baggins, were started in 2001. The articles were initially short, uncited, and devoid of analysis. Gradually, the community created rules demanding that each claim be verified by a reliable source, and that each article's notability be demonstrated by multiple sources.

Most of the hundreds of Middle-earth articles in existence by 2019 were of in-universe topics like characters and places. They were written from a fan's perspective: accurate, but the few existing citations were to Tolkien's writings, with no independent sources to prove notability. A campaign of article deletion began: minor characters and places swiftly vanished.

COMPETITORS

Wikipedia's Middle-earth project exists alongside free sites like Tolkien Gateway. That site demands accuracy and even citations, but limits those to the Tolkien canon. All Middle-earth characters, locations, and objects described by Tolkien are taken to be worth covering, with no requirement for

independent sources; this results in large number of articles on minor subjects like the Dwarves of Belegost and Hildórien, for a total of over 12,800 articles. These are supplemented by almost 15,000 images, many of them made by fans ("Community Portal"). I find the Tolkien Gateway useful for details of characters and so on, where it is solidly reliable, and for tracking down primary sources. It does describe some real-world objects such as films, games, actors, and books (even scholarly ones); it links to external reviews but doesn't provide its own analysis or explore scholarly criticism in any way. In the special case of Peter Jackson's film adaptations, it describes differences from Tolkien's narrative without comment or citations (e.g. "*The Lord of the Rings: The Fellowship of the Ring*").

A WEB OF WORDS

Tolkien scholars do sometimes write about surface topics that would instantly be recognised by fans, such as characters like Frodo, but they're much more likely to be writing about underlying topics like themes. Their topics are what fans would consider speculation, on themes such as the nature of the hero, Northern courage, or the relevance of Arthurian chivalry; influences from Classical, Celtic, and Shakespeare all the way to modern sources; elements like artwork, maps, and poetry; and literary techniques like frame stories, the impression of depth, and interlacing. In 2019, there were hardly any Wikipedia articles on topics of that sort: one on magic, one on themes, one on influences, and one on fandom.

To cover the themes, influences, elements, and literary techniques in the scholarly literature, I created over 100 new Middle-earth articles between 2020 and 2024, on scholarly topics like "Heroism in *The Lord of the Rings*." I cited each one to multiple reliable sources ("Chiswick Chap," "Articles#Tolkien"). In the same period, I brought over 200 articles to "Good Article" status ("Tolkien Articles"). I revised around half of these from existing fan-style articles like "Aragorn," probably saving many of them from deletion, by adding scholarly discussion and sources.

The "Heroism" article consists mainly of analysis of the literary effect. I supported it with references to 7 Tolkien sources and 11 scholarly books and journal articles.

The "Aragorn" article, in contrast, provides a substantial in-universe account of the character's life and actions. I supported that with 28 references to chapters in *The Lord of the Rings*. The rest of the article consists of analysis: of the character's creation and names in English and Sindarin, and of the character's significance, including its possible historical basis, Aragorn's role as a Christ-as-King figure, and his status as a Romantic hero with physical stamina and lifespan beyond those of ordinary men. I made that verifiable with fourteen

secondary sources in the shape of scholarly books and journal papers, and a dozen primary sources for the quoted examples. I ended the article with an account of the character's appearances in film and radio adaptations, supported by 18 secondary sources, mostly news websites.

The resulting Wikipedia articles are neither like items on a fan website, nor quite like scholarly papers. Wikipedia's rule against "Original Research" forbids editors from adding anything in the way of opinions or conclusions inferred by reasoning from the cited materials (*Wikipedia*, "No original research"). On the other hand, writing an article is certainly a creative process. I selected sources, arranged materials, explained concepts, chose examples, and prepared illustrations, shaping something that did not exist before. I went further with extensive cross-linking, weaving all the articles into a newly coherent web. In a conventional encyclopedia, cross-references are made typographically, with phrases like "*see* **Hobbit**." In a Wiki, the reader clicks on a "**Hobbit**" hyperlink, and is at once taken to that article. The result, I believe, is a body of information accessible to a new and very large audience.

DIAGRAMS AND TABLES

In addition to cited text, I created at least 75 Middle-earth diagrams ("Chiswick Chap," "Diagrams"), and many tables embedded in articles, summarising scholarly analyses. The rules on illustrations are slightly more relaxed than those on claims in the text, but the same considerations apply: the material must be relevant, and any claims made must be supported by citations in the image caption. For example, Figure 1 shows a simple diagram that I made presenting Tom Shippey's textual explanation of the origins of the names "Huggins" and "Baggins". The diagram explains their surface similarity but their quite different etymologies (Shippey 8).

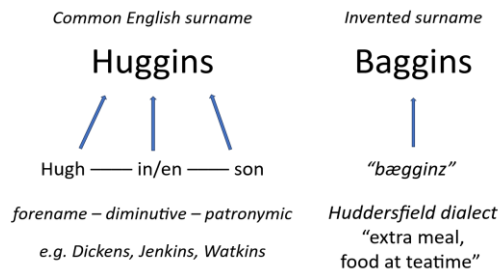


Figure 1: A diagram presenting a textual description by Tom Shippey. "Chiswick Chap," on Wikimedia Commons.

An alternative approach used in many Middle-earth articles is to summarize and display the outlines of a scholar's analysis using a table. For instance, Table 1 shows my table of Ben Reinhard's analysis of types of hero in the article "Heroism in *The Lord of the Rings*." My goal was to present the key elements of a scholarly analysis concisely for the general reader.

Type of hero	Example	Characteristics
Chivalric knight	Lancelot	Noble, French-style; powerful, armoured, on horseback; courtly love; success assured
Hobbit	Frodo Baggins	"modern, bourgeois, [...] small"; humble; success far from guaranteed
Ranger	Aragorn	"half-wild, mistrusted"; "stern in battle, gentle in hall"; ascetic; universally scorned

Table 1: A table from the article "Heroism in *The Lord of the Rings*," based on analysis by Ben Reinhard in "Tolkien's Lost Knights."

READERSHIP

Wikipedia's Middle-earth articles were together viewed over 7 million times in August 2024. The top 20 articles by number of views included those on Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, and *The Hobbit*, but also some actors in Peter Jackson's film series, namely Ian Holm (who played Bilbo), Christopher Lee (Saruman), and Elijah Wood (Frodo), and several film and television articles. The top Middle-earth character was Sauron, followed by Morgoth, Galadriel, and Isildur, all of whom feature in the Amazon series *The Lord of the Rings: The Rings of Power*, which has been showing since 2022; its series article was the top article in the month, with over 21,000 views a day (Wikipedia, "WikiProject Middle-earth/Popular pages"). There is considerable month-to-month turnover among the most viewed articles.

The top Middle-earth article on a scholarly theme is "Cosmology of Tolkien's legendarium," with over 1,400 views per day. It is followed by "Tolkien and race" at over 300 views per day, still equating to well over 100,000 views per year; "Christianity in Middle-earth" at over 240 views per day; and some way further down the list, "Sexuality in *The Lord of the Rings*" at over 100 views per day. The popularity of these themes shows that Wikipedia views broadly follow the trend identified by Karen Viars and Cait Coker, namely that Tolkien fans have "unsurprisingly focused on many of those topics Tolkien scholars are fond of today—homosexual overtones [...], racism [...], Tolkien's literary sources and forebears, and the roles of women in his world" (37).

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IAN F. ALEXANDER is a writer and a volunteer with London Wildlife Trust. He published *The English Love Affair with Nature* in 2015, and was the lead author on *West London Wildlife* (Supernova Books) in 2022. Since 2020 he has contributed to Wikipedia's Middle-earth project as "Chiswick Chap." Before his retirement, he was a systems engineer and the lead author of *Writing Better Requirements* (Addison-Wesley) in 2002, *Scenarios, Stories, Use Cases* (Wiley) in 2004, and *Discovering Requirements* (Wiley) in 2009.



WHAT WILL WE DO WITH THE CHRISTMAS PUDDING?:

JOY DAVIDMAN, WILLIAM LINDSAY GRESHAM, AND "CHRISTMAS IN THE WORKHOUSE"

G. CONNOR SALTER AND CLARK SHELDON

MOST INKLINGS SCHOLARS FAMILIAR WITH JOY DAVIDMAN (1915–1960) and her first husband William Lindsay Gresham (1909–1962) know they were both involved in American leftwing literary circles. They were active members of the Communist Party of the United States of America (CPUSA) from the 1930s until the early to mid-1940s, becoming far less active after they

became parents. Abigail Santamaria notes they likely met through a key leftwing writers' circle, the League of American Writers, in the late 1930s and that the first record of their appearing at the same event was in 1941 at the Fourth Annual Congress of the League of American Writers (118, 123).

Their politics informed their writing in various ways. Davidman was a poetry editor and contributor to the *New Masses* and edited two leftwing poetry collections: *They Look Like Men* and *War Poems of the United Nations*. Gresham volunteered to serve in the Spanish Civil War and served as a medic in the Abraham Lincoln Brigade, contributing one poem about his experience, "Last Kilometer," to *War Poems of the United Nations* (319). The poem has proved popular enough to be reprinted several times (Nelson 157, Biosca 177–80, Herrmann 13). While more detailed work has been published on Davidman's two novels *Anya* and *Weeping Bay* (Hammond 235–45, King 114–35, 143–52), including notes on how leftwing ideas inform those books, there is also room to discuss these political concerns in Gresham's fiction. Alan M. Wald has suggested that Gresham's two novels *Nightmare Alley* and *Limbo Tower* are informed by at least collectivist if not pro-communist concerns (Salter, "Joy Davidman, William Lindsay Gresham, and the American Literary Left" 1).

The leftwing politics becomes especially important when discussing some of Gresham's archival works. As G. Connor Salter and Sørina Higgins have reported ("Friar Jack the Sci-Fi Apologist"), the folder "Poems, 1941–1944" in the William Lindsay Gresham Papers in the Marion E. Wade Center at Wheaton College¹ shows that Gresham was a more prolific poet than previously assumed. The folder contains several never-published poems written by Gresham, two drafts of "Last Kilometer" (Gresham's only published poem during his lifetime), and several transcripts of famous leftwing poems by other authors. Since 2023, two of Gresham's original poems from this folder, "Rahnchild" and "The Friar of Oxford," have been published (see Salter, "William Lindsay Gresham and Norse Poetry," and Higgins and Salter, "Friar Jack").

One of the more interesting items in the folder is the following poem:

Christmas in the Workhouse

It was Christmas in the workhouse,
Happiest day of all the year,
And the paupers was contented
'Cause their guts was full of beer.

¹ Joe R. Christopher was the first writer to mention one of the folder's contents in print: he notes the existence of "The Friar of Oxford" in his review of the Don W. King-edited collection of Davidman's poetry, *A Naked Tree* (186).

The Master of the workhouse
 Strode through the dismal halls
 And cried, "A Merry Christmas!"
 But the paupers answered, "Balls!"

Then angry was the Master
 And he swore by all the gods
 That they'd have no Christmas pudding,
 The lousy bunch of twatts.

Up spake a war-scarred veteran
 Who had stormed the Khyber Pass,
 "You can tyke yer Christmas puddin', sir,
 "An' stick it up yer ass!!!"

Following the poem's ending line is an indented two-sentence note in parentheses. It describes the poem as, in the writer's opinion, "one of the better contributions of Great Britain to world culture in general and poetry in particular" and argues that "only a member of the British lumpen proletariat t [sic] can get the full effect of scorn, hate, disgust and respect for authority out of the last two lines."

To say the least, this poem is intriguing. Stylistically, it is very different from other contents in the folder. The other poems are primarily about Spain and in the same style as "Last Kilometer": harrowing first-person accounts of battlegrounds. "Rahnild" and "The Friar of Oxford" are exceptions to this rule, but also very different from "Christmas in the Workhouse": one is a faux Norse myth piece, the other an homage to Winnifred M. Letts's World War I poem "The Spires of Oxford" intermingled with science fiction imagery.

In fact, "Christmas in the Workhouse" has a long history that predates Gresham.

LOCATING "CHRISTMAS IN THE WORKHOUSE"

As Victorian history or literature specialists may know, "Christmas in the Workhouse" was originally a ballad by George Robert Sims titled "In the Workhouse. Christmas Day" (Sims 7). Sims first published his ballad in 1877 in *The Referee* (Jakobs 152). Many variations have appeared since then. Since the original ballad was published well before 1923 (the cutoff year in American copyright law) and the variations are mostly transmitted orally with no known lyricist, the poem and its many offshoots are necessarily outside copyright. Sims' original version, printed below, has a much more formal style than Gresham's transcript.

IN THE WORKHOUSE. CHRISTMAS DAY.

It is Christmas Day in the Workhouse,
And the cold bare walls are bright
With garlands of green and holly,
And the place is a pleasant sight:
For with clean-washed hands and faces,
In a long and hungry line
The paupers sit at the tables
For this is the hour they dine.

And the guardians and their ladies,
Although the wind is east,
Have come in their furs and wrappers,
To watch their charges feast;
To smile and be condescending,
Put pudding on pauper plates,
To be hosts at the workhouse banquet
They've paid for—with the rates.

Oh, the paupers are meek and lowly
With their "Thank'ee kindly, mum's"
So long as they fill their stomachs,
What matter it whence it comes?
But one of the old men mutters,
And pushes his plate aside:
"Great God!" he cries; "but it chokes me!
For this is the day *she* died."

The guardians gazed in horror,
The master's face went white;
"Did a pauper refuse their pudding?"
"Could their ears believe aright?"
Then the ladies clutched their
 husbands,
Thinking the man would die,
Struck by a bolt, or something,
By the outraged One on high.

But the pauper sat for a moment,
Then rose 'mid a silence grim,
For the others had ceased to chatter
And trembled in every limb.
He looked at the guardians' ladies,

Then, eyeing their lords, he said,
"I eat not the food of villains
Whose hands are foul and red:

"Whose victims cry for vengeance
From their dank, unhallowed graves."
"He's drunk!" said the workhouse
 master,
"Or else he's mad, and raves."
"Not drunk or mad," cried the pauper,
"But only a hunted beast,
Who, torn by the hounds and mangled,
Declines the vulture's feast.

"I care not a curse for the guardians,
And I won't be dragged away.
Just let me have the fit out,
It's only on Christmas Day
That the black past comes to goad me,
And prey on my burning brain;
I'll tell you the rest in a whisper,—
I swear I won't shout again.

"Keep your hands off me, curse you!
Hear me right out to the end.
You came here to see how paupers
The season of Christmas spend.
You came here to watch us feeding,
As they watch the captured beast.
Hear why a penniless pauper
Spits on your paltry feast.

"Do you think I will take your bounty,
And let you smile and think
You're doing a noble action
With the parish's meat and drink?
Where's my wife, you traitors—
The poor old wife you slew?
Yes, by the God above us,
My Nance was killed by you!

"Last winter my wife lay dying,
Starved in a filthy den;
I had never been to the parish,—

I came to the parish then.
I swallowed my pride in coming,
For, ere the ruin came,
I held up my head as a trader,
And I bore a spotless name.

"I came to the parish, craving
Break for a starving wife,
Bread for the woman who'd loved me
Through fifty years of life;
And what do you think they told me,
Mocking my awful grief?
That 'the House' was open to us,
But they wouldn't give 'out relief.'

"I slunk to the filthy alley —
'Twas a cold, raw Christmas eve —
And the bakers' shops were open,
Tempting a man to thieve;
But I clenched my fists together,
Holding my head awry,
So I come to her empty-handed
And mournfully told her why.

"When I told her 'the House' was open;
She had heard of the ways of *that*,
For her bloodless cheeks went crimson,
And up in her rags she sat,
Crying, 'Bide the Christmas here, John,
We've never had one apart;
I think I can bear the hunger, —
The other would break my heart.'
"All through that eve I watched her,
Holding her hand in mine,
Praying the Lord, and weeping,
Till my lips were salt as brine.
I asked her once if she hungered,
And as she answered 'No,'
The moon shone in at the window
Set in a wreath of snow.

"Then the room was bathed in glory,
And I saw in my darling's eyes
The far-away look of wonder

That comes when the spirit flies;
And her lips were parched and parted,
And her reason came and went,
For she raved of our home in Devon,
Where our happiest years were spent.

"And the accents, long forgotten,
Came back to the tongue once more,
For she talked like the country lassie
I woo'd by the Devon shore.
Then she rose to her feet and trembled,
And fell on the rags and moaned,
And, 'Give me a crust—I'm famished—
For the love of God!' she groaned.

"I rushed from the room like a
madman,
And flew to the workhouse gate,
Crying, 'Food for a dying woman!'
And the answer came, 'Too late.'
They drove me away with curses;
Then I fought with a dog in the street,
And tore from the mongrel's clutches
A crust he was trying to eat.

"Back, through the filthy by-lanes!
Back, through the trampled slush!
Up to the crazy garret,
Wrapped in an awful hush.
My heart sank down at the threshold,
And I paused with a sudden thrill,
For there in the silv'ry moonlight
My Nance lay, cold and still.

"Up to the blackened ceiling
The sunken eyes were cast —
I knew on those lips all bloodless
My name had been the last;
She'd called for her absent husband —
O God! had I but known! —
Had called in vain, and in anguish
Had died in that den — *alone*.

"Yes, there, in a land of plenty,
Lay a loving woman dead,
Cruelly starved and murdered
For a loaf of the parish bread.
At yonder gate, last Christmas,
I craved for a human life.
You, who would feast us paupers,
What of my murdered wife!

* * *

"There, get ye gone to your dinners;
Don't mind me in the least;
Think of the happy paupers
Eating your Christmas feast;
And when you recount their
blessings
In your smug parochial way,
Say what you did for *me*, too,
Only last Christmas Day.

SIMILAR VARIATIONS ON "CHRISTMAS IN THE WORKHOUSE"

The version of "Christmas in the Workhouse" in Gresham's folder does not appear to have been printed anywhere until now. A similar version (rude final line and the Khyber Pass reference included, but some words changed) is quoted in George Henry Wilkin's memoir *Certified* (179). A character played by Ed Asner recites another variation in the 1977 Christmas movie *The Gathering* (57:00–58:35), but this variation also changes some wording (for example, "And the paupers was contented" is rendered "And the paupers all was happy"). The fact that *The Gathering* features Asner's character attributing the poem to Rudyard Kipling (57:00–58:35) gives an idea how this Sims poem had survived and evolved in public memory until the general public forgot its origin.

But how did this poem arrive in Gresham's papers? Aside from a handwritten letter written to Gresham containing a poem, there is no clear evidence that "Poems, 1941–1944" features any documents that Gresham or Davidman received from others. Therefore, one of them presumably transcribed "Christmas in the Workhouse." Given that the poem (both Sims' original and this more profane variation) are leftwing protest anthems against managers exploiting workers, it is precisely the kind of poem that both Gresham and Davidman would have heard in 1930s–40s CPUSA circles. However, since the poem has many variations, it is hard to say exactly when they would have heard it. The folder is tentatively dated 1941–1944 because most of its poems appear to have been written after Gresham returned to America in 1938 from Spain.¹ As Higgins and Salter discuss, "The Friar of Oxford," was likely written several years later in 1946–1950 (Higgins and Salter 250–251).

The note attached to the poem may offer further clues.

¹ Five of these poems were recently published in *The Volunteer*, the magazine devoted to scholarship on The Abraham Lincoln Brigade (Salter, "Beyond the Last Kilometer."

CONSIDERING THE “LUMPENPROLETARIAT” NOTE

The note and the poem are both typed, which makes it impossible to use handwriting analysis to determine whether Davidman or Gresham wrote it or date its composition period based on how their handwriting styles evolved. Instead, one must consider whether the note’s language or style offers any hints.

The word “lumpenproletariat” is German for “rabble proletariat,” and a Marxist term for the very lowest social class (“Lumpenproletariat”). Therefore, this note could have been written by either Davidman or Gresham: any writer in 1930s–40s leftwing artist circles would have been familiar with the phrase.

Since the poem was British, and Davidman was a self-described Anglophile, she may seem the better candidate for writing the note. Don W. King was consulted and said he could not recall seeing the poem anywhere in Davidman’s papers and felt it was unlikely she transcribed it or wrote the note (“Weird Davidman Research Question”). He pointed out that “Christmas in the Workhouse” could easily be something Davidman received while editing the *New Masses* and rejected since it has a didactic tone; she regularly rejected such submissions and criticized the submitters for sending in propaganda instead of well-crafted work (ibid).

However, “Christmas in the Workhouse” seems unlikely to be a *New Masses* submission since the manuscript does not feature any address or other contact information on its header. Print magazines (both in the 1930s and today) nearly universally expect submitters to include such information.² It is also the common protocol for writers to state their opinions about the work being submitted (for example, why “Christmas in the Workhouse” is such a great example of Great Britain’s contributions to world culture) on an attached cover letter, not paste their comments on the poem itself. Therefore, this would be an exceptionally amateur submission to the *New Masses*. Even then, Davidman would follow the usual protocol: mail the poem back with a rejection notice, using the return address listed on the submission’s postal envelope. As many of her letters show, Davidman never suffered fools lightly. If a writer was foolish enough to submit something this badly formatted, it is hard to imagine her passing up the chance to cow that writer with an incendiary rejection notice.

One of this article’s authors, Clark Sheldon, has done extensive work on Gresham and has his own theory about how “Christmas in the Workhouse” entered Gresham’s files.

² For example, the only poem in “Poems, 1941–1944” that Gresham published, “Last Kilometer,” has his name and address and date added to the second draft, the version he presumably sent to Dial Press.

"CHRISTMAS IN THE WORKHOUSE" AND JOY DAVIDMAN

When initially asked about the poem ("Funny poem from Gresham archives"), Sheldon noted it is hard to say from the note's style whether Gresham wrote it. Gresham's normal writing style was chatty but it changed whenever Gresham was researching something. Given those factors, it seems more likely that the "lumpenproletariat" note is something Davidman wrote or that Gresham wrote with her in mind.

The second option raises a new query: what could Davidman have been working on which Gresham would think a profane leftwing protest poem was suitable for?

Of Davidman's projects, the most likely answer is her second poetry collection. *War Poems* contains 150 leftwing war poems from around the world, and "Christmas in the Workhouse" has a strong war theme, especially compared to Sims' original poem. The old man in the original becomes a "war-scarred veteran" and the line about how his "face was hard as brass" becomes a reference to how the veteran "Stormed the Khyber Pass."

"Christmas in the Workhouse" does not appear in *War Poems of the United Nations*, although two poems with similar titles are included: "Christmas" by Frantisek Halas (66) and "Christmas Song" by Rudolf Leonhard, the latter translated from German into English by Jean Star Untermyer (122–23). Therefore, it is quite possible that Gresham knew Davidman was seeking war poems and transcribed the poem (with the perhaps tongue-in-cheek note) for her to use, only for Dial Press to refuse its inclusion because of its profanity.

The fact that "Christmas in the Workhouse" is a British war poem makes it even more likely to be material for *War Poems of the United Nations*. According to Lyle W. Dorsett's book *And God Came In*, Davidman struggled to find British leftwing war poems for the collection, so she wrote some poems herself under two British pseudonyms, Megan Coombes-Dawson and Hayden Weir (43; c.f. Glycer 10–11).³ Weir even got a tragic backstory: alas, he "was killed in action in 1942" (*War Poems* 50). "Christmas in the Workhouse" not only fits the militaristic theme Davidman was seeking for her collection; its British origin filled a blatant gap in her collection.

If "Christmas in the Workhouse" is something Gresham collected for Davidman to use, it presents a new direction for Davidman-Gresham discussions. Much has been said about Davidman influencing Gresham's work. *Nightmare Alley* is dedicated to her. Sheldon has discussed elsewhere how much editorial feedback she gave on the book, how Davidman helped to create structure and other traits conspicuously absent from *Limbo Tower* (Salter,

³ The poem attributed to Coombes-Dawson is "For My Son" (*War Poems* 25). The two poems attributed to Weir are "Four Years After Munich" and "Peccavimus" (*War Poems* 49–51).

"Exploring William Lindsay Gresham"). However, outside of King mentioning that Gresham influenced a carnival scene and an alcoholic priest character in *Weeping Bay* (*Yet One More Spring* 149; c.f. *Out of My Bone* 123), little has been said about Gresham influencing Davidman. "Christmas in the Workhouse" may be positive proof of one occasion when the influence took the other direction.

FURTHER NEW DIRECTIONS FOR DAVIDMAN-GRESHAM RESEARCH

Time will tell if new research shows how "Christmas in the Workhouse" made its way into Gresham's files. As of this writing, King has published some of Davidman's uncollected letters (King, "Joy Davidman's Unpublished Letters"; cf. Salter, "The Women that C.S. Lewis Loved"), which may open possibilities for researching *War Poems* in more detail. Various archival projects on Gresham remain under-explored. For example, no one has published a collection of his letters. As noted elsewhere (Salter, "What Are Magic and Myth Good For?" 218), there is currently no complete bibliography of his published work. If either project comes to fruition, they may reveal new information about "Christmas in the Workhouse," and almost certainly new insights into the leftwing community that fostered Davidman and Gresham as young writers.

Whatever happens next with Davidman-Gresham scholarship, "Christmas in the Workhouse" is an entertaining read giving hints of their political connections and influences during an under-studied time in their lives.

It is also well worth stating for the academic record that while Sims did not write this version of "Christmas in the Workhouse," Rudyard Kipling did not write it either.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

Thanks to Brandt & Hochman Literary Agents, Inc., for permission to print snippets of marginalia on Gresham's poetry manuscripts for educational usage. While "Christmas in the Workhouse" is in the public domain, all of Gresham's original poetry is Copyright © by William Lindsay Gresham. All rights to those works are reserved by the Estate of William Lindsay Gresham and Brandt & Hochman Literary Agents, Inc.

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G. CONNOR SALTER has a Bachelor of Science in Professional Writing from Taylor University. He has spoken on Inklings topics on several occasions, including "William Lindsay Gresham: Writer, Magician, Seeker" (November 3, 2023) and "The Lion and the Vampire: The Inklings and English Horror Films in Conversation," (October 29, 2021), both for Inkling Folk Fellowship. He has contributed to many publications, including *CSL: The Bulletin of the New York C.S. Lewis Society*, *The Lamp-Post*, *Fellowship & Fairy dust*, *The Oddest Inkling*, and *A Pilgrim in Narnia*. His recent work includes "William Lindsay Gresham and Norse Poetry: A Surprising Discovery," (*CSL*, vol. 55, no. 1) and "Tellers of Dark Fairy Tales: Common Themes in the Works of C.S. Lewis and Terence Fisher" (*Mythlore* vol. 41, no. 1).

CLARK SHELDON, from Winnipeg, Canada is an independent researcher working on a biography of William Lindsay Gresham.



**"PERILOUS AND FAIR" IN "A BLEAK, BARREN LAND":
A FEMINIST RESPONDS TO DYLAN LEE HENDERSON'S ESSAY
ROBIN ANNE REID**

"I don't know about *perilous*," said Sam. "It strikes me that folk takes their **peril** with them into Lórien, and finds it there because they've brought it. But perhaps you could call her **perilous**, because she's so strong in herself. You, you could dash yourself to pieces on her, like a ship on a rock; or drown yourself, like a hobbit in a river. **But neither rock nor river would be to blame.**" (*LotR* IV.5.680, bolded emphasis added)

JANET BRENNAN CROFT AND **LESLIE A. DONOVAN** open their joint introduction to the first (and so far only) anthology on "*Women in the Works and Life of J.R.R. Tolkien*," with two quotes from *The Lord of the Rings*. The first quote is three

paragraphs from Faramir's and Sam's conversation about Elves (*LotR* IV.5.679–80). The second is the paragraph about Éowyn's challenge to the Witch-king before she kills the Fell Beast (V.6.841). I choose to quote Sam's insight about Galadriel, although I was tempted to start with Éowyn's defiant laugh and her claim that "no living man am I! You look upon a woman. Éowyn I am, Éomund's daughter. You stand between me and my lord and kin. Begone, if you be not deathless! For living or dark undead, I will smite you, if you touch him" (V.6.841).¹ Galadriel and Éowyn are both, if differently, perilous and fair, and both, judging by the varied critical interpretations made about them over the decades, are ambiguously gendered figures.²

Sam's analysis of the ambiguous nature of Galadriel's perilousness is a response to Faramir's lengthy comment about the history of declining interactions between Men [sic] and Elves in Middle-earth which has led him to conclude that: "I deem it *perilous* now for *mortal men* [sic] willfully to seek out the Elder People" (emphasis added). Yet Faramir's own ambiguous feelings in regard to Galadriel show in his next sentence: "Yet I envy you that have spoken with the White Lady" (*LotR* IV.5.680.679). In Faramir's sentence, *perilous* modifies "it" which is a dummy subject standing in for the phrase "mortal men [who are] willfully" searching for the Elves ("Dummy Subjects"). Faramir acknowledges his own longing to meet and speak with Galadriel despite the peril that he believes exists. Sam disclaims any authoritative knowledge about the *perilousness* of Galadriel, the individual, as opposed to that of the "Elder People." In this instance, the word carries the meaning of first definition in the Oxford English Dictionary (OED): "Dangerous, hazardous. . .causing or resulting in danger [...] also: spiritually dangerous."³ I suspect that Galadriel's

¹ Apparently male characters in Middle-earth share the all-too common assumption that the word "man" is deemed sufficient (mostly by men) to denote not only male human beings but also covers the default "human" (which in theory should include female human beings, but in practice often does not)!

² They are arguably among the more masculine of the named female humanoid characters, although I would include Lobelia Sackville-Baggins in their company based on Amy Amendt-Raduege's excellent essay, "Revising Lobelia," an essay which counters the stereotype of Lobelia as merely a shrew: "[c]loser examination reveals that [Lobelia's] character is more complex and compelling than is generally supposed. She *is* proud, stubborn, unwilling to accept less than her due, and eager to display her status to society: **all traits commonly found in the heroes of the medieval poems and sagas that Tolkien so diligently studied.** She is also intelligent, forthright, and capable of unexpected generosity" (77, bolded emphasis added).

³ From the online OED:

Perilous (adjective): 1.a c1300 "Dangerous, hazardous, fraught with peril; causing or resulting in danger; risky. In early use also: spiritually dangerous."

presumed spiritual dangerousness is primarily what Faramir and other male characters are most concerned about.

Sam then shifts to using the noun *peril* plus adding a simile to identify two possible types of *peril* he speculates may apply to Galadriel. The first is internal to the men seeking her, meaning their assumptions about the nature of Galadriel which they project onto her. The second is external to the men who enter the Golden Wood: it signifies Galadriel's own strength, her *peril*, which is inherent, and, additionally, in Sam's simile, functions the same way that rocks in oceans and rivers do at times. Those parts of the natural world can kill mortals, but neither rocks nor rivers intend to kill anyone. Sam's choice of words and use of figurative language assign some level of agency to the hypothetical mortal males who chooses to seek out Galadriel, to sail on the ocean, or to take a boat out on a river in spite of, or because of, their assumptions.

All the named characters in the scene where the Fellowship meet Galadriel are male except for Galadriel herself. Aragorn is the only one who has visited Lothlórien previously, and many, if not all of the group, have heard the stories about the Golden Wood and about the *peril* of Galadriel told in their home cultures; apparently no tales are told about Celeborn who, as an Elf Lord, is presumably also *perilous*, but, as a male, is presumably not *spiritually perilous*! All the male characters have different perspectives and assumptions about Galadriel, and the ones who are later willing to describe their responses to her greeting and testing illustrate how different individuals respond to the same experience.

While Sam is describing an encounter between (mostly) strangers meeting for the first time in Tolkien's sub-created world, I think that Sam's first definition of the perceived peril of Galadriel to "mortal men" (and, presumably, to mortal, and male, hobbits and dwarves) is analogous to how some male readers in the Primary World project stereotypes upon women's and/or feminists' interpretations of Tolkien's work. Unfortunately, this outdated

Perilous (adverb): c1440 (c1390) "Dangerously, terrifyingly. Chiefly as an intensifier: greatly, excessively, very; = **perilously** adv. (cf. **parlous** adv.). Now *rare* (*literary*)."

Peril (noun): there are five different types of definitions for the noun; three of the five fit with Faramir's usage.

1.a. ?c1225- "The position or condition of being imminently exposed to the chance of injury, loss, or destruction; risk, jeopardy, danger."

3. c1325- "A matter of danger; a dangerous matter. Now only in **it is peril**: it is dangerous (to do something). Now *archaic* and *rare*."

5. a1500-00 † "Bad luck, inauspiciousness; an instance of this. **days of perils**: unlucky or inauspicious days. Cf. *perilous* adj. A.3. *Obsolete*."

The two definitions relating to "peril" as a verb and to "peril" as a variant of "pearl" (noun and adjective) are not applicable to this discussion.

stereotype of women and/or feminist critics as shrewish man-haters appears early (in the second paragraph) of Dylan Lee Henderson's 2023 essay, "A Bleak, Barren Land': Women and Fertility in *The Lord of the Rings*," and shapes his overall argument. He opens his two-paragraph long "Background" section, which serves as a basic review of literature, by saying that "many feminist scholars [since 1971] have *condemned* Tolkien's depiction of women as *inadequate and denounced Tolkien himself as a misogynist*" (88, emphasis added). This sentence ends with a superscript number referencing a footnote citing my essay, "The History of Scholarship on Female Characters in J.R.R. Tolkien's *Legendarium*: A Feminist Bibliographic Essay" (Croft and Donovan, *Perilous and Fair* [subsequently *P&F*]). The footnote reads, in its entirety: "For a more detailed history of this debate, see Reid" (88n2). Henderson choosing to cite my essay at the end of a sentence that is his own argument implies that my essay makes the same, or similar argument, only with more "details" about the many feminists who have "condemned [...] and denounced Tolkien himself as a misogynist" (88).

While my essay does provide more details about more of the relevant scholarship than Henderson cites in his essay, my analysis of the scholarship differs a great deal from his. My goal in the essay, as with any bibliographic essay, is not to make an argument about Tolkien's work (let alone the author himself) but to analyze the types of arguments made in the scholarship about his work. In order to achieve that goal, I analyze changes in the "development of scholarship on [Tolkien's] female characters over time, including not only the increasing attention paid to these characters, but also a growing application of newer critical theories and methods" (13). My analysis includes, but is not limited to, all the essays in *P&F*, seven of which were reprints of earlier essays. But I also cover all the published essays *on* the topic that I could find in order to identify areas of agreement and of disagreement in the scholarship as well as gaps that needed filling. Some scholars do characterize elements of Tolkien's fiction as sexist, even misogynistic, but many do not, presenting a range of different arguments and drawing on different critical or feminist theories. At no point in the essay do I use loaded language like *condemn* or *denounce*.

My conclusion includes a suggestion for the future of Tolkien scholarship on women and female characters which is to: "move beyond the perceived need to defend Tolkien (whether the author, the body of work, or the human being) from the outdated stereotype of 'feminist critics' who exist only to rend and destroy" (39). It is frustrating to see this stereotype asserted nearly ten years after the publication of *P&F*, and even more frustrating because Henderson cites, in addition to my essay, seven of the fifteen chapters in the collection (this count includes the "Introduction") which present a more complex picture of the scholarship than he conveys.

Croft and Donovan's argument in "Perilous and Fair, Ancient and Modern, Luminous and Powerful" is similar to the one I make in my essay. They challenge the extent to which the stereotype of feminists attacking Tolkien is a weakness in the critical history; they acknowledge that some critics dismiss Tolkien's fictional women as stereotypes, claiming that his work "[seems] either to ignore women or to place them on unattainable pedestals [...] preserving cultural stereotypes of female roles, and reflecting antifeminist tendencies" (1). However, they point to other scholars who challenge those interpretations with "detailed, innovative scholarship that recognizes myriad positive contexts for Tolkien's female characters and argues more nuanced understandings of Middle-earth's women" (2). Acknowledging that the overall critical consensus tends to be "that the historical context of Tolkien's life prevents him from being considered a feminist of any sort [...] published discussion frequently interprets female characters in *The Lord of the Rings* and *The Silmarillion* as imbued with unconventional power" (2). They note that the earliest critical engagement with the topic of "female characters" originated in the early 1970s (citing Myers's 1971 essay, as does Henderson, and as I did) and reflects "philosophies central to the United States civil rights movements of the 1960s and 1970s that inspired interest in marginalized fiction [...] as well as new investigations of those works from feminist perspectives" (1). Later work, published in "the twenty-first century," in contrast shows that "scholars note increasingly that, where other works of modern fantasy or mythopoeic literature still offer fairly traditional presentations of female characters, Tolkien's women highlight less common and more affirming positions of power" (2).⁴

Croft and Donovan also note that some recent scholarship tends to "echo [the stereotypical claims] from the earlier period of Tolkien scholarship," rather than incorporating the different arguments from the later work. I agree with them that this reliance is "troubling after so much research effort and printer's ink has gone to correct similarly ill-informed positions" (2).⁵

⁴ I quote from the "Introduction" at some length to show the difference between Croft and Donovan's analysis of the conflicting critical positions compared to Henderson's claim of the four-decades-long feminist denunciations and attacks on Tolkien and his work that he follows with a brief acknowledgement in the next paragraph in which he notes the possibility that "Tolkien's female characters could be both *empowering and insipid* at the same time" (89, emphasis added).

⁵ The first feminist reading of Tolkien I am aware of is Edith Crowe's 1996 essay which was reprinted in *P&F*, "Power in Arda," which opens with the observation that "fantasy readers of my generation would have had precious little to read in the beginning if we had limited ourselves to works fully in tune with our feminist principles" (272). Having met and talked with Edith, I know that we are both more or less in the same generational cohort, are both feminists, both read a number of the same fantasy novels (mostly by men),

Henderson, like the example cited by Croft and Donovan, ignores the later work or, if citing it, mis-represents the overall arguments and selects quotes that fit the stereotype. In fact, he not only ignores Croft and Donovan's own analysis of the scholarship on women and Tolkien: he ignores almost half of the essays in *P&F* as well as mis-representing most of the ones he cites.⁶ I document examples of the mis-representations in a post in *Writing from Ithilien*, my Substack, because the list of examples I collected was too long to include in the published version of this article ("The Online Supplement").

While my bibliographic essay was out of date by the time the anthology was published, given the schedule of academic publishing, I think it provides a foundation for anyone who is interested in the question of women (or female characters) and Tolkien and who is willing to engage in the work necessary to see how earlier views have been expanded by later scholarship often drawing on different critical theories. Reading a bibliographic essay is not equivalent to reading and engaging fully with the original sources, as my comparison of excerpts from original sources compared to Henderson's quoting patterns in the "Online Supplement" shows, but bibliographic essays are a good start for a research process because they provide an overview, a bibliography, and analysis of the discourse patterns in the published scholarship at the time of writing. The question then for scholars becomes the extent to which scholarship published after the bibliographic essay continues to reflect those patterns, and whether or not gaps or areas of conflict identified in the bibliographic essay have been addressed, and what new arguments are being made (or could still be made). Engaging with the scholarship in this manner does not require agreement with the arguments, but, as I used to tell my students, the ethics of scholarship requires that they accurately summarize even those argument that they disagree with.⁷ The time I spent researching, writing, and revising that essay is why I was

and both read Tolkien for the first time in the mid-1960s. She spends the next four paragraphs of her essay covering different definitions of "feminism," something that Henderson (and many others) still fail to do. Their failure to realize that "feminism" includes a variety theories and praxes and consists of a centuries-long intellectual and political body of works that crosses national boundaries and languages and is best described by the plural, "feminisms," is a significant problem.

⁶ Although Henderson claims that the history of feminist denunciations goes back to 1971, he does not distinguish between the earliest scholarship and the later scholarship, completely ignoring the fact that Christopher Tolkien's extensive posthumous publications of his father's work as well as the development and circulation of later critical theories and methods exist. As a result, Henderson's claim about the "history" of feminist attacks is ahistorical, homogeneous, and static, assuming that the only text that is relevant to his argument is *The Lord of the Rings*.

⁷ While I am retired, which limits my access to the expensive subscription-only databases, I maintain a bibliography on feminist, gender, and queer scholarship on "Tolkien" (which

able to immediately question Henderson's use of selected short quotes (as opposed to accurate summaries of overall arguments) in support of his claim of a long history of feminist scholars attacking Tolkien's work and him.

In the second and final paragraph of the "Background" section, Henderson acknowledges that some "critics have insisted that, though only a few female characters appear in *The Lord of the Rings*, they play crucial roles or, in some cases, act as role models" (89). This claim moderates his earliest claim of a history of condemnation to some extent but falls short of conveying the range of arguments that have been made especially at the conclusion of the paragraph where Henderson evaluates the two conflicting claims ("feminist denunciation" vs. "critics" [who may or may not be feminists?] who praise some of the "few female characters") which he sees in the scholarship. Neither of the "antithetical" positions is "necessarily wrong," he admits, because "theoretically, Tolkien's female characters could be both *empowering and insipid* at the same time" (89, emphasis added).

This conclusion is an insulting dismissal of work done by scholars who see more than Henderson does in Tolkien's work (and who include more than *The Lord of the Rings* in their scholarship). Reducing a body of complex and often conflicting interpretations about female characters in the legendarium, some of which result from the differences in critical approaches and disciplinary methods chosen by the scholars, to a sexist stereotype of *man-hating feminists* can be achieved only by ignoring or dismissing the significant amount of evidence (in hard-copy and online) from women, non-binary, agender, and even some men fans and scholars.

Henderson's "Background" section, which are the second and third paragraphs of his nineteen-page essay, serves as the scholarly context which should provide the scholarly background that shows the originality of his overall argument in the essay. Henderson's argument appears at the end of the first paragraph of the essay where, after emphasizing the scarcity of female characters and their insignificance to the plot as mere appendages to the male characters, he makes this claim:

And yet, I would argue that the conspicuous absence of women in Tolkien's epic, while potentially unsatisfying, nevertheless shapes the reading experience by emphasizing the threat that Sauron's forces, with

includes scholarship on his legendarium and its adaptations, transformative works, reception, and fandom studies) on my Substack, *Writing from Ithilien*, which includes publications through 2024. I welcome additions to the bibliography which can be made in the comments there, or, if you have a more complete bibliography (or annotated bibliography, or bibliographic essay!) on other sub-fields of Tolkien research, I would be happy to host it, with credit to you, as a guest post.

their limitless growth, pose to the Free Peoples of Middle-earth, whose small and masculine populations seem shockingly sterile by comparison (88).⁸

The gap that Henderson perceives in the twelve publications he selected for his review of the scholarly literature (by thirteen writers, ten of them women)⁹ is that they “overlook the effect that women, and their absence have *on the reader and his [sic] conception of Middle-earth, a world that, without women and children, appears disturbingly sterile and depressingly barren*” (89, emphasis added).

Neither I, nor any of the scholars whose work I am familiar with, would disagree with the claim that the female characters are relatively few and are given less narrative time (and dialogue!) than the major male characters; that claim has been made for decades and is hardly original. Where we would differ, I think, is the claim about how Tolkien’s narrative choices “shapes [our] reading experience[s]” and our perceptions about Middle-earth (specifically that it is “disturbingly sterile and depressingly barren”), and the lack of evidence for anyone beyond Henderson and his hypothetical (ungenerous and male) readers sharing that perception. In addition, the use of the word “barren” as a metaphor for sterility not only has extremely negative denotations and connotations but was also historically more likely to be applied to the woman in a marriage who was assumed to be at fault; this assumption is yet another sexist stereotype.¹⁰ The problem of what specialists now call the “infertility stigma” that women

⁸ In “A Bleak, Barren Take: A Response to “Women and Fertility in *The Lord of the Rings*,” Clare Moore and Leah Hagan rightfully identify the racist connections between Henderson’s claim about the fertility of the Orcs compared to that of the White Free Peoples, an ideology which:

still persists in some dimensions of society today (for example, the stereotypes of the “welfare queen” or “anchor babies”) and, at its worst, forms part of the central tenet of the false White supremacist belief known as the Great Replacement, a conspiracy theory that believes that the immigration of people of color into a country will “replace” White people and their position of power [...]. Great Replacement ideology has influenced violent actions, from the events in Charlottesville in 2017 to Christchurch, New Zealand, in 2019 [...], hence the danger of it going unacknowledged in a peer-reviewed essay. (231)

⁹ The two men are Kenneth McLeish (1983) and Sam McBride who is the co-author with Candice Frederick of *Women Among the Inklings* (2001).

¹⁰ A quick search of the essay shows that the word “sterile” is used four times; “sterility,” three times; “barren” appears four times (excluding the twelve times it appears in the title which is repeated on multiple pages), and “barrenness” six times. Female characters are never described as sterile: they are barren, as is the land/world of Middle-earth. The accuracy of this claim is also dubious since a number of the female characters have had children, or go on to have children after the end of the novel (described in the Appendices); somehow, these characters just do not count since there are no babies described in the present of the narrative.

still experience today reflects the negative history of the word (Taebi et al.). Given how recent findings on the “‘urgent, global’ crisis of [dropping] sperm counts” (Hunt) have drawn attention to the diminishment of male fertility, it is worth asking why Henderson’s judgement is so gendered, especially in how Henderson describes Goldberry (and by implication other female characters)¹¹ as being solely responsible for the world’s sterility: “And yet, while Goldberry differs from Arwen and Galadriel, she, incredibly, has no children. The importance of this can hardly be overstated: Tolkien’s living symbol of feminine domesticity is, unless recently married, presumably sterile” (97).

There is, of course, no way to diagnose a fictional character’s reproductive capabilities, or lack of them, because they are only words on a page to be interpreted by readers (who will bring very different experiences to the reading) but if the lack of named characters who are identified as the children of Goldberry and Tom is to be declared a problem, I would like to argue that it is equally possible to assume that Tom, who is self-described as “old. Eldest that’s what I am,” who came into the world “before the seas were bent. [...] before the Dark Lord came from Outside” (*LotR* I.7.131), has a low sperm count due to his immense age (Harris et al., Hunt). There is only one male character associated with “sterility”: in Henderson’s last paragraph, he describes Frodo at the end of the novel as “[remaining] apart, a relic of sterility in a now-bountiful world” (103).¹²

Additionally, Henderson’s claim that none of the existing scholarship has noticed what he has, that the scarcity and barrenness of female characters (and the resulting lack of their children) creates a “conception of Middle-earth [as] disturbingly sterile and depressingly barren” (89), is inaccurate. I know of one essay by a woman scholar who analyzes a very different effect that the few female characters in the novel have upon at least one other reader’s perceptions of the land in Middle-earth in which they live: Maria Błaszkiwicz’s 2013 essay,

¹¹ Éowyn, although not married, is described as “young and beautiful and very human, [but] she, too, is sterile—psychologically” (97). I have a number of problems with Henderson’s reading of Éowyn which, because of the length needed to deal with them, are being developed elsewhere with some preliminary work done in my personal Substack (“Éowyn as An Exemplar”).

¹² While Henderson describes the world of Men, Dwarves, Ents, and Elves as sterile (102), he does not acknowledge that Tolkien’s description of the Shire, the number of children that Hobbit families tended to have, and the evidence of the genealogies in the Appendices make it clear that the Hobbits were an extremely fecund group before the discovery and destruction of the One Ring as well as after. I will also note that essays using queer approaches foreground how Bilbo and Frodo, as never-married and childless, are considered “queer” by the majority of the Hobbits around them. For an excellent discussion of just how often the word “queer” is applied to Bilbo and Frodo, see Kisor.

"Tolkien's Queen-Women in *The Lord of the Rings*," which I summarize in my bibliographic essay in *P&F*. Her argument differs from Henderson's (and a number of other scholarly publications) because she criticizes the scholarly tendency to read:

the scarcity of female characters in Tolkien's work as a sign of sexism or lack of authorial skill; instead, she argues that Tolkien's choice is "*a conscious design which aims not to diminish the importance of the female element but, on the contrary to glorify it*" [...]. Błaszkiwicz argues that Tolkien's careful construction of female characters associated solely with one specific type of sanctuary, places safe from evil (as opposed to resting places where characters may still be at risk), is an important thematic element. These "omphalic spaces" associated with a female character range from Farmer Maggot's house to Lórien and are contrasted with the dying and wasted lands in areas where no female characters are present. *She concludes that "Tolkien's design in The Lord of the Rings has been to highlight the exceptional and royal function of a woman, a source of life in all its senses"* (Reid, "History of Scholarship, Tolkien" 36–37, emphasis added).¹³

Clearly, Błaszkiwicz, who has a positive interpretation of the impact of Tolkien's female characters, is neither Henderson's default male reader, nor is she at all similar to his hypothetical "ungenerous reader [who] might say, *not entirely without justification*, that most of Tolkien's women belong to one of two types: the shrew and the goddess" (88, emphasis added).¹⁴ Henderson does not

¹³ I do not agree with her overall argument, any more than I do with Henderson's, because both rely upon the same sexist stereotype, that women's most important function is bearing children, and the failure to bear children (barrenness) has cultural significance beyond their personal experiences. While it would be interesting to compare similarities and differences between the two essays, their overall arguments, and the range of evidence chosen, that comparison is outside the scope of this response.

¹⁴ This unsupported and, I would say, ungenerous, assertion is one example of a number of derogatory claims about female characters that are scattered throughout the essay. These claims are never attributed to a published source, so, presumably, they come from the ungenerous readers Henderson projects. They are presented as unchallenged, and thus as (implied) facts or some universal consensus instead of debatable claims that must be supported by evidence. They include:

"Arwen, for example, exists as an extension of Aragorn's character in much the same way that, to put it bluntly, Farmer Maggot's dogs are an extension of his." (87)

"Galadriel, beautiful though she may be, is also ancient, and her children grown." (96)

"These female characters [Galadriel and Arwen] may be goddesses, but they are not fertility goddesses, and their beauty, though stunning, does not suggest youth or maternity." (96)

"When Éowyn disguises herself as Dernhelm and, abandoning her people, follows the king to war, she has not simply rejected a social role that does not appeal to her: she has endangered lives so that she may revel in slaughter. [...] [N]othing reinforces the

cite Błaszkwicz's reading of female characters and their relationship with the land in his essay which allows him to avoid having to refute her argument which does not fit into the patterns he describes in his "Background" paragraphs. However, his failure to acknowledge her work exists is not unique. Scholarship analyzing academic citation practices shows a systemic pattern of excluding of women's work (Healy, and Savonick and Davidson). This sort of exclusion, the refusal to see or to acknowledge the many readers who love to read and engage with Tolkien's work in ways that challenge such stereotyping, affects the quality and development of scholarship and makes it difficult to create spaces for exploring complicated questions about how to define the different categories, or types, of *sexisms* or *misogynies*, let alone the different types of *feminisms* which exist; how it may be possible for a work of literature to contain both feminist and misogynistic elements; and how systems of oppression intersect!¹⁵

However, there are signs that the scholarship on Tolkien's work is beginning to acknowledge the extent to which contradictory readings of Tolkien's work co-exist (in academia, popular culture, and fandom). Those contradictions are increasingly supported by the evidence from the posthumous publications that Christopher Tolkien began making available in 1977 (the publication date of *The Silmarillion*). As Verlyn Flieger points out in "The Arch and the Keystone":

We have pasted labels on [Tolkien], called him *a medievalist, a modernist, a post-modernist, a royalist, a fascist, a misogynist, a feminist, a racist, an egalitarian, a realist, a romantic, an optimist, a pessimist*. He's been variously characterized as *homophobic and homo-social in both work and life*. His fiction has been interpreted as *Boethian, Manichean, Augustinian and Aquinian*. He's been typed as *a radical and a conservative, a Christian apologist and a pagan, a Catholic who believed in Fairyland, a monarchist who exalted little people, a Tory whose political views leaned toward anarchy* [...]. The fact that all these labels can find a fit only adds to the confusion (6, emphasis added).

impression of barrenness that hangs over the novel like her shocking preference for war and death." (98–99)

"Sam, of course, finds Rosie Cotton, whose very name evokes images of blood-stained underwear and bedsheets and, by extension, menstruation and the tearing of the hymen." (102)

¹⁵ As an intersectional feminist, I know there are major unasked questions about the heteronormative Whiteness of the "perilous and fair" female characters in Tolkien's legendarium that are worth exploring; see Redmond for a start. However, that topic deserves much more space and thought than can fit into this response.

And it is these same forces creating this same friction that invite the disagreeing and debating Tolkien scholars and critics to find in Tolkien's work *what they are looking for*. I am not saying they're wrong. *I'm saying they're right. What they see is there, even when they're seeing contradictory things* (16, emphasis added).

Flieger's argument is supported by extensive textual analysis from across Tolkien's legendarium showing the extent of his contradictory statements in his fiction and nonfiction. Even more evidence of the impact of Tolkien's contradictory statements on the state of Tolkien scholarship is provided in Flieger's earlier essay about how scholars have ignored contradictions in what Tolkien says about religion ("But What Did He Really Mean?"), contradictions which have resulted in Christian and Pagan scholars cherry-picking some of the same quotes to support their argument about Tolkien's religious ideas and to, in effect, claim "Tolkien" for their side.

The existence of Tolkien's contradictory statements, leading to conflicting interpretations, is something I think Tolkien scholars should, ideally, keep in mind when presenting their own interpretative claims in the context of the relevant published scholarship. To do so requires critical thought about what specific evidence is given by scholars to support their claims as well as following Flieger's advice to keep in mind that analysis of evidence from the edited, selected, published letters must take into consideration elements such as the date of composition and the specific correspondent Tolkien addresses.

While Flieger notes that one of the many contradictory interpretations about Tolkien's work, and about him, is that of "misogynist vs. feminist," she does not explore that conflict in either of her two essays, being more interested in the "Christian vs. pagan" conflict in "But What Did He Really Mean." In "The Arch and the Keystone," a published version of her Guest of Honor presentation at Mythcon, written to be delivered to an in-person audience, she cannot stop to provide detailed examples of all the conflicting interpretations she identifies. Because the purpose of her argument in the talk is not to "prove" one side or the other correct but to argue that there is evidence in Tolkien's work for both (and more varied) interpretations, I do not think her essay is weaker for that focus; instead, she sets up a number of intriguing questions for us to explore.

I am one of a number of scholars in Tolkien studies (many of whom I know personally) who define ourselves as feminists. Building on the fifty-three years of work exploring the questions around Tolkien's female characters, we are currently in the process of considering not only Tolkien's own publications, but the growing number of adaptations of his work and how actual readers, not the hypothetical/default readers imagined by many scholars, respond to his work. For instance, Dawn Walls-Thumma has been running an online

longitudinal study of Tolkien fans for almost twenty years. Her work is available in *Cultus Dispatches* at the Silmarillion Writers' Guild. Walls-Thumma is the one of the few Tolkien scholars I know of who has done quantitative scholarship on Tolkien fandom, and the only one who has administered surveys over time. In her column on the demographic data she collected, she notes a change between the 2015 and the 2020 surveys: "The two surveys had 1,052 [2015] and 746 [2020] valid responses. The 2015 survey collected some demographic data; the 2020 survey collected more." In regard to gender, in the 2015 survey, 89% of the respondents were women, 6% were non-binary; 4% were men. In 2020, while 73% of the respondents were women, the significant demographic change was not a major increase in the number of men writing, but in the number of nonbinary respondents: 15% were non-binary, and 7% were men.¹⁶

When I first read *The Lord of the Rings* in 1965, I was told by my peers and the adults around me that "girls don't read science fiction or fantasy" apparently because we are girls.¹⁷ I did not consider myself a feminist until my late twenties, but even at age of ten I rejected any attempt to tell me what I could or could not read. I was in love with Éowyn and with Middle-earth. I still am. As a childfree woman who decided not to marry or have children when I was ten, I never noticed or particularly cared about whether the female characters had babies. Decades later, I incorporated my queer reader response to her in my essay on "Female Bodies and Femininities":

The author Tolkien constructed Éowyn to serve his purpose in his narrative, but her development through multiple revisions is complex. His very obvious dislike of the concept of a woman picking up arms to fight as men do is clear; yet he is the sub-creator who showed her voicing that impassioned statement to Aragorn criticizing his, and the Rohirrim, attitudes about women who are denied the chance for battle but can still be killed after the battle is lost. She fears a cage—bars that keep her from doing great deeds [...]. She expresses herself in the language of the heroic epic because that is the language she has; that is the language of her people and culture. Tolkien's own work revises the epic heroic model by embedding later, Christian, elements, but it is equally possible for a reader of Tolkien's work to read in sympathy with Éowyn and against

¹⁶ I participated in the most recent survey.

¹⁷ I was ten. Neither my peers nor the adults thought they needed to give any reasons for this claim although perhaps they considered the proof to be self-evident because of the nature of sexism in small-town Idaho in 1965. The only result of this directive was to add some additional evidence of my not being "normal." Luckily for me, my father was an SFF fan and encouraged my reading (including providing multiple trips to the public library). I have never denied that some women and some feminists do not like Tolkien/see his work as sexist; however, some feminists are #notallfeminists.

the grain of her sub-creator who once planned for her death because of her masculine qualities. Such a reader can imagine much more in the character than the author could show directly. There are gaps in every text, and the gaps in this text are large enough to allow for a queer reading. (Reid, "Light" 109–110).

Now, in 2025, sixty years after first falling in love with *The Lord of the Rings*, I am beyond tired of reading or hearing variations on the over-generalized claim that feminists/women/girls don't like/don't read Tolkien's work, or don't like/hate Tolkien, because sexism, a claim which is often presented as self-evident to the (often but not always) male authority.

Years ago, when I first read Edith Crowe's feminist essay, "Power in Arda: Sources, Uses and Misuses," I was so pleasantly surprised by the scope and feminism of her analysis that I wrote her a fan email! I consider her essay to be the first academic feminist essay on Tolkien ("feminist" meaning, written by someone who is willing to state she is a feminist and who uses feminist theories). Her conclusion is one that opens up the possibility of dialogue and engagement, rather than closing it off. I consider Crowe's essay to be required reading for anybody who wants to make any argument about "feminist readers" of Tolkien:

This, then, is why I conclude that a **person of feminist persuasion**, while not necessarily agreeing with Tolkien's attitudes *in toto*, can find much to appreciate in his work. Arda is a world in which females share power in spiritual and temporal realms, although not always to the degree one might wish. More importantly, **it is a world in which attitudes and values associated in the Primary World with the feminine are highly valued**. Indeed, these "feminine" values triumph at the end of the Third Age, though not always incarnate in female bodies. **Though Tolkien's road was his interpretation of Christianity, and Eisler's (and mine) our interpretation of feminism, the destination seems to have a great deal in common**. Our mutual task in the Fourth Age is to resist the temptation to divide and dominate, whether we characterize this misuse of power as that of the Blade or the Ring. May Varda look with favour upon our efforts (from 1996 *Mythlore*, 277, bold emphasis added).

Henderson paraphrases one small aspect of Crowe's overall argument in the second paragraph of his "Background" section: "Edith L. Crowe notes that, while Tolkien divides the masculine and the feminine into different spheres, he does not denigrate the feminine or prize the former over the latter, '*their relationship [being] one of linking, not ranking*' (89)." The partial quote Henderson includes in his paragraphs occurs three pages before the concluding paragraph I excerpt above. His single sentence does not mis-represent one of her arguments

(as I argue is the case for some of his other choices and document in “The Online Supplement”¹⁸), but a comparison of her original with his paraphrase shows that he fails to accurately convey her overall argument about feminist readers and the common ground we may find with Christian readers.

My exhaustion with the problem that Henderson is the latest example of is one of the reasons I began writing feminist and queer scholarship about Tolkien’s legendarium (and about the works of other fantasy writers, especially a number of the women who acknowledge Tolkien’s influence on their fantasy and whose work is, in my reading of it, not only transformative of Tolkien but critically engaged with different feminist theories). I also began writing feminist bibliographies because of the significant increase in published Tolkien scholarship during the 21st century, a growth many of us credit to the release of Peter Jackson’s films (Fimi 200). I think it impossible to read, or create, a comprehensive bibliography or complete analysis of the past seventy years of publications which means that there will always be choices made to exclude some publications. Since my experience leads me to believe that scholarship by women (or about feminist topics) which interest me greatly is more likely to be excluded, I thought it a useful project (Reid “History of Scholarship, Tolkien”; Reid “History of Scholarship, Bujold”). I am grateful to Janet and Leslie who allowed and encouraged me in my first attempt to develop this approach.

My bibliographies are feminist because they are written by “a feminist academic trained in cultural studies,” not because “the scholarship is defined as feminist, or written by self-identified feminists (although some is), or is even limited to authors who identify as women” (“History of Scholarship, Tolkien” 13). At no time do I make any argument regarding Tolkien’s personal feelings about women; in fact, I am not interested in the question of Tolkien’s own feelings or attitudes about women, or about “feminism” (especially if there is no definition of the word provided). I have no interest in trying to write biographical scholarship, or to do some version of analyzing his feelings/ideas/intent (as opposed to some limited analysis of his writing which can include quotes from his letters). Instead, I would rather write about his work, about how his work has been received and understood over the decades I have lived through, and about the fans and scholars now living who are creating new interpretations of his work, especially those of us who apparently are not supposed to exist, or at least, should not expect to be seen while existing.

¹⁸ In my Online Supplement, I compare the original sources to Henderson’s use of them and then provide excerpts from my bibliographic essay that he cites, misleadingly, on his first page.

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ROBIN A. REID is an independent scholar whose current projects include two anthologies which are forthcoming in 2026. The first is co-edited with Christopher Vaccaro and Stephen Yandell, "*There are many paths to tread*": *Queer Approaches to Tolkien's Middle-earth*, and the second is *Race, Racisms, and Racists: Essays on J. R. R. Tolkien's Legendarium, Adaptations, and Readers*. Her current project is a monograph on the feminist receptions of Tolkien's legendarium, working title, *The Web of Women*. Posts relating to that project can be found at *Writing from Ithilien*, her Substack.





REVIEWS

J.R.R. TOLKIEN: A VERY SHORT INTRODUCTION. Matthew Townend.
Oxford UP, 2024. 160 p. 9780192882042. \$12.99

CODING IN AT JUST OVER ONE HUNDRED PAGES, Matthew Townend's *J.R.R. Tolkien: A Very Short Introduction* may be concise, but it is a well-researched, clearly written and engaging analysis of one of the twentieth century's most creative and original writers. While Townend's focus is (not surprisingly) on *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*—what he calls two of the most frequently re-read books today—analyses of Tolkien's other lesser-known works, including academic writings and work that was posthumously published, are effectively integrated alongside the discussion. This recently included publication in the *Very Short Introduction* series is overdue (there was a C.S. Lewis *VSI* in 2019) but is a welcome addition to Tolkien Studies. I can see this *VSI* being particularly valuable for new readers of Tolkien who want to learn more about him and his writing, and for students who want a compact guide through Tolkien's major concerns. This would thus make an excellent resource for teachers and professors seeking to introduce Tolkien to new readers.

Townend takes a thematic approach rather than a chronological review of Tolkien's major writings, and so the book is structured into eight chapters that are arranged to explore recurring ideas in his body of work: 1) Reading Tolkien 2) Life and work 3) Stories 4) Faërie 5) Language 6) Sources 7) Middle-earth 8) Elegy. The first chapter is essentially a brief introduction or preface that sets out the wide-ranging effect of Tolkien's work. Townend notes that for many readers, *The Lord of the Rings* offers an experience of re-enchantment, opening the door to a world of myth, folklore, and fairy tale; for other readers, encountering Tolkien's world has led to an environmental awakening, or a newfound interest in language, or a renewed appreciation for art and craft, or has heightened their sense of justice for the small and often overlooked. Comparing Tolkien to other cultural phenomena like The Beatles or *Star Wars*, Townend argues, as many other scholars have, that Tolkien has "permanently altered the forms and flavours of popular culture" across several media—"not just fiction, with the explosion of the fantasy genre that followed in his wake," but in music, gaming, and film and television (2).

The second chapter, "Life and work," begins with a brief biography of Tolkien that effectively summarizes the key events in his life. Townend then offers a response to the question "What sort of a person was Tolkien?" by noting some character traits that emerge from comments both from people who knew him personally and from those who have studied him closely: he was "quite diffident" though "he could grow animated in conversation"; he was a "dedicated and affectionate family man" and someone who had a great love for the natural world; in terms of his politics he is best described as conservative but "with a fascinating admixture of the liberal and even radical"; he was both a procrastinator and a perfectionist to the point where he was a "chronic non-finisher of tasks;" he was sociable and yet independent, and often dealt with a lack of confidence in his work (10). Like most people, Townend concludes, "he was complex and contradictory" (10). An interesting observation Townend makes here is that Tolkien's deep Catholic faith gave him a consciousness of his own weakness that was reinforced by his experience in the First World War, from which he emerged with a sharp sense of his own moral limitations, in terms of both courage and endurance (10). This is a useful biographical insight that helps in framing what Tolkien is doing with his hobbit characters, in whom both courage and endurance are so memorably manifested.

Townend also emphasizes that although to many readers today Tolkien might look like a conventional and stereotypical Oxford don, it is important to remember that while he did spend thirty-five years in the professoriate, Tolkien always retained a sense of himself as an outsider and possessed "a warm sympathy for other outsiders": he had been an orphan, he had known poverty, he was born outside of England, his wife Edith was illegitimate, and he experienced prejudice as a result of his Catholicism (11). Tolkien was also not a professional writer—he wrote as a hobby, in his spare time, and was only tenuously connected to the literary world of publishers, prizes, and periodicals. He didn't write book reviews, and *The Lord of the Rings* itself became an unplanned, unexpected success through word-of-mouth, from the ground up because of actual readers, not as the result of a media campaign. Thus, Townend concludes that while Tolkien's works have been "canonized," at this point, "this has been a movement from below, by millions of readers" (16).

Chapter Three, entitled "Stories," offers a valuable look at the tension in Tolkien between storytelling and world-building. Townend states that Tolkien was "above all a storyteller," whose first instinct was towards narrative, rather than towards analysis (21). Townend rightly points out that these are two distinct modes of creativity, and that in Tolkien, the dynamic between story-making and system-making was a wellspring of imaginative energy and helped generate some of his most beloved and mysterious characters, like Gollum and

Beorn, who both initially arose out of Tolkien's story-making impulse in *The Hobbit* but then, later, in *The Lord of the Rings* are given further back stories and explication. He argues that as Tolkien aged, he was increasingly inclined towards system-making, and that this is one of the major reasons he was unable to complete the *Silmarillion* or bring together the body of legends he had been working on for nearly sixty years into an integrated whole. Tolkien was a literary pioneer, who brought together genres that had not before been combined in the way that he brought them together. So, for instance, aspects from fairy tale and aspects from realist fiction cohere in *The Lord of the Rings* and in *The Hobbit* (where Bilbo is a modern interloper into a legendary world, wearing a waistcoat and possessing "trousers with pockets") and this innovation was one of his greatest sources of difficulty (32). In *The Hobbit*, says Townend, no reader weeps when the fairy-tale-like goblins have their heads chopped off; but in the more realist *The Lord of the Rings*, Tolkien could not help taking seriously questions about the origins of orcs, or whether they had free will, or whether Morgoth was really able to create them. In effect, questions like this over which Tolkien hesitated led to an attempt to rationalize and explain the mythic content of the legendarium, a process that sometimes threatened to disenchant his tales of the very quality his younger self had so valued—the quality of Faërie (36). In a time when what audiences have come to call "world-building" is ever more foregrounded in contemporary fantasy, Townend's insights here are timely.

Chapter Four, "Faërie," treats the specific nature of the enchantment that Tolkien most sought to convey in his writing. Here, Townend appropriately begins with an overview of "On Fairy-stories" and proceeds to outline how Tolkien's theories are born out in the praxis of his primary texts, particularly those that lean towards fairy-story. Tolkien claims in his essay that one of the most profound longings of the human heart that fairy tales satisfy is the "desire to converse with other living things," and Townend shows how talking animals are found frequently in Tolkien's early works, from Tevildo the Prince of Cats, to Roverdandom, to Roäc the raven in *The Hobbit*. Tolkien argues in "On Fairy-stories" that stories primarily concerned with fairies, or with elves, are as a rule not very interesting, but that "most good 'fairy stories' are about the *aventures* of men in the Perilous Realm or upon its shadowy marches"; this mortal desire to encounter fairies is a constant motif in Tolkien's works, Townend emphasizes, from the first writings in *The Book of Lost Tales* that feature Eriol, later Ælfwine or "elf-friend" travelling to Tol Eresesëa, to the later tales of mortal men like Beren, Túrin, and Tuor (39).

"Language" is the title and subject of the fifth chapter, and here Townend's expertise in Old Norse and his interests in medievalism and philology allow him to offer a concise but very useful overview of Tolkien's

linguistic aesthetics and the multilinguistic character of the legendarium. While there exist many treatments of Tolkien's use of Quenya and Noldorin/Sindarin, Townend points out that in *The Lord of the Rings* we encounter other languages as well, including Dwarvish or Khuzdul, Entish, and the "Black Speech" of Mordor, as well as background hints as to the language of Númenor (Adûnaic) brought to Middle-earth from Númenórean exiles, that eventually became "Westron" or "Common Speech." Middle-earth is "thus a multilingual world," and Tolkien's stories are "filled with moments of bilingualism, translation, language contact, and diglossia (that is, language-switching according to context)—in addition to discourses on linguistic history" (57–58). This leads Townend to a discussion of the issue of translation, and the way Tolkien draws on different framing devices for his stories, beginning with the wanderer Eriol in *The Book of Lost Tales*, that remained a core aspect of Tolkien's mythology for many decades and led him to present his fictional texts as ancient stories he had translated rather than invented. While this posed increasingly complicated problems for Tolkien, it was also in many ways "a brilliant conceit," according to Townend, and superbly carried out by an author who was uniquely poised to do so.

The sixth chapter, "Sources," begins with a treatment of modern medievalism, and the way Tolkien's use of source material was revolutionary: unlike so many other writers who are unconsciously influenced by their reading, Tolkien's creative process involved a very deliberate act of adoption and adaptation. He was making "a new kind of literature out of medieval ingredients," not simply retelling medieval stories (65). However, Townend emphasizes that Tolkien wasn't exclusively a medievalist; his knowledge of the Latin and Greek classics was profound, and he was well read in post-medieval literature from Shakespeare to contemporary fiction. It is Old English, or Anglo-Saxon, though that Townend says especially saturated Tolkien's imagination, and he gives a detailed close reading of specific passages in *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* that echo passages in *Beowulf*. He also shows how Tolkien's source material manifests not only in word-forms but also in word-meanings, as with the word *reek*, from the Old English *rēc*, or what Townend calls a "Tolkienian favorite": *rēc* means "smoke," rather than the modern meaning of "smell," for which Tolkien prefers "stench," from the Old English *stenc* (71). So, for instance, Frodo sees that "Mount Doom was burning, and a great reek rising" (71). This subtle influence from medieval sources also explains some of Tolkien's distinctive diction. Townend argues that Tolkien had a preference for syntactic inversion or sentence-fronting, gained from his reading of William Morris especially, which is one of the most prominent features of his prose for many readers today: as examples, he cites the single paragraph when the Fellowship passes by the Argonath and the narrator declares that "Giants they seemed to

[Frodo]" and "Great power and majesty they still wore" versus the more standard "They seemed giants to Frodo" and "They still wore great power and majesty" (74–75). Because Tolkien's prose is so lyrical, often even poetic, this kind of formal analysis of his diction is helpful, and not engaged in often enough.

Townend titled chapter seven "Middle-earth," and in it he analyzes the ways in which Tolkien succeeds in drawing connections between our earth and Arda. While, as previously mentioned, Townend praises Tolkien's skills as a world-builder, he acknowledges here that Tolkien's world-building activities are not evenly distributed, but (naturally) reflect his own interests; so Middle-earth is very detailed in terms of its socio-linguistics and history, but less well developed in regards to its agriculture or economics (as G.R.R. Martin has famously complained). W.H. Auden was "bothered by the lack of pets in *The Lord of the Rings*," and there are indeed inevitable gaps in depicting a full world (85). However, Townend declares that where Tolkien most shines, apart from linguistics, is in botany. The world of Middle-earth is a world of biodiversity, and this is painstakingly rendered so as to feel as "real" as a fictional world can. Also realistic is Tolkien's portrayal of different cultures and their interrelationships with each other; the legendarium is full of stories of migration and movement, so that "[f]ew of the peoples of Middle-earth are associated with an inalienable homeland," meaning that Tolkien's stories probe at questions of xenophobia and prejudice (89–90).

The last chapter, "Elegy," looks at the genre in which Tolkien classified *Beowulf*—not an epic but a "heroic-elegiac" work—and applies this same generic category to *The Lord of the Rings*. As all readers of Tolkien know, this is a story of poignantly sorrowful loss and change, and our relationship to the text mirrors the experience of the members of the Fellowship as they travel through a Middle-earth covered with the physical remnants of the past, from old standing stones and burial chambers to ruined watch towers to broken roads hidden under weeds; these scenes give us "half-hidden glimpses of a 'vanished past,'" and contribute to the "ache of mortality" running all throughout Tolkien's mythology (99). That Tolkien understood the grief of this ache so thoroughly makes it all the more remarkable that his stories are also stories that champion the virtue of hope, or what Townend glosses as an implicitly Christianized hope (*estel*) that involves trusting in "the ultimate efficacy of divine providence" (102). Remarking on this sense of eucatastrophe is an appropriate way to conclude his introduction to Tolkien, as is his short discussion of *Leaf by Niggle* and the sudden, eucatastrophic turn at the very end of this stunningly profound "Christian fairy tale": "He gazed at the Tree, and slowly he lifted his arms and opened them wide. 'It's a gift!' he said" (qtd. 106–7). The Tree is not only a gift to Niggle, but to other travellers who come to value it as well, so that it turns

out to be “very useful indeed [...] as a holiday, and a refreshment” (qtd. 107). We can take Tolkien’s whole body of writings as the Tree, and agree with Townend that journeying to the worlds he created is indeed both a holiday and a refreshment.

LAURA N. VAN DYKE teaches in the Department of English and Creative Writing at Trinity Western University, in Langley, British Columbia. She is a co-editor of *The Inklings and Culture* (2020) and helps to direct the Inklings Institute of Canada.



TOLKIEN’S COSMOLOGY: DIVINE BEINGS AND MIDDLE-EARTH. Sam McBride. Kent, OH: Kent State UP. 2020. 272 p. 978-1606353967. \$55.00.

SAM MCBRIDE WRITES THE FOLLOWING in his Introduction to *Tolkien’s Cosmology: Divine Beings and Middle-earth*: “Exploring Tolkien’s legendarium will show the cosmological structure of Middle-earth, but also reveal moments in *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* when the metaphysical impacts the physical” (x). The book delivers on its promise to show the reader places within the stories of *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* likely to be influenced by spiritual beings who are described in *The Silmarillion* and the other volumes of the Legendarium. McBride’s book gives the reader a convincing description of the divine interventions of both visible and invisible powers from the earlier Ages of Middle-earth as they appear during the Third Age.

The voice of the book is so approachable and genuine that it was easy to forget that I was, in fact, reading a book, and not having a conversation with the author. I never felt that I was being lectured at by a literature professor. At the same time, McBride’s argument is founded upon a thorough knowledge of J.R.R. Tolkien’s works and of Tolkien literary criticism up to the writing of the book published in 2020. The conversational feel and erudition of the work make this book a serviceable tool to both novice and seasoned readers of the works of J.R.R. Tolkien. One of the many things I like about the author is that he is aware that he might be guilty of confirmation bias in some or many of his examples. His humility is laudable as he both makes his argument and seeks to be certain he carries it only as far as it is justified (x).

The author’s focus is to show the ways that *The Silmarillion* is a foundation to what appears in the stories of *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*. He emphasizes *The Silmarillion* because it provides the first description of Tolkien’s Legendarium after his death (xiv–xvii). McBride secondarily

references J.R.R. Tolkien's other works to secure all of the points of his argument. I wrote above that *Tolkien's Cosmology* can be a serviceable tool for different levels of readers. At one point the author observes of *The Silmarillion*, "Its mythological style makes it the most widely purchased unread book published under Tolkien's name" (xv). Personally, I was in my thirties before I was able to finish reading and then became entranced by *The Silmarillion*. I share the experience the author describes of many Tolkien fans who have reread *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* multiple times but cannot get through Tolkien's daunting work that looks like *The Old Testament* and doesn't feel like his other books the reader has come to love. Like other fans, I tried many times to read *The Silmarillion* and eventually made the conscious decision to never try again. By chance, I listened to audiobooks, ones I knew I was never going to read in print, while I created stained glass. A few hours into listening to *The Silmarillion* read by Martin Shaw and I stopped working on stained glass and simply listened to Tolkien's beautiful language and sequence of deep tales. At the end of the recording, I bought and read a print copy. That experience led to many re-readings of *The Silmarillion* and ultimately to my reading all of the volumes of *The History of Middle-earth*, some volumes as many as three times.

Sam McBride's *Tolkien's Cosmology* could give today's readers an experience similar to my own with the Martin Shaw recording to become a gateway to *The Silmarillion* and possibly the rest of the *Legendarium*. I suggest that *Tolkien's Cosmology* could be such a gateway to *The Silmarillion* because McBride's book is so approachable and pleasant to read that a novice can be introduced to Eru Ilúvatar, the Valar, the rebellion of Morgoth, the creation of Arda, and the downstream effects of Morgoth's rebellion to the history of all of the Ages of Middle-earth, and ultimately the stories in *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*. His introduction to the spiritual beings and creation story is followed by chapters providing convincing instances of divine intervention that McBride sees in *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*. The book ends, appropriately, with a chapter on Eucatastrophe.

For more seasoned readers *Tolkien's Cosmology* does a fine job of summarizing much of the *Legendarium*, which can be useful in reminding us of the roles of the cast of characters within Tolkien's works. There are times when McBride articulates and develops observations that a seasoned reader might have observed but not formally expressed during their own reading. It is likely that McBride will provide new observations for most experienced readers, which makes the book worthwhile.

Tolkien's Cosmology: Divine Beings and Middle-earth is more a piece of literary criticism than a reference work such as *The Lord of the Rings: A Reader's Companion* by Wayne G. Hammond and Christina Scull. McBride's book should not be expected to be as exhaustive or to be used in the same way as Hammond

and Scull's great reference work is used. Still, *Tolkien's Cosmology* can be used as an approachable reference work on Tolkien's Legendarium and on the connections between *The Silmarillion* and *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*. I believe its strength is in the author's ability to point to the many appearances of divine intervention from *The Silmarillion* into *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*. I agree with the author that his overall interpretation of *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* does add depth to a reader's experience of the three books discussed here.

Another useful point of this text is its connection with world religions. While it will be natural for religious people to be interested in the book, being so isn't necessary. Tolkien has many unbelieving or skeptical fans, who I think, will be just as interested, as religious people are, in McBride's description of Tolkien's divine beings from *The Silmarillion* influencing *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*.

I especially recommend this book to readers who are attempting to get a toehold into an appreciation of *The Silmarillion*. I will end by repeating that I find Sam McBride's *Tolkien's Cosmology: Divine Beings and Middle-earth* to be such a pleasant experience that I recommend it for pleasure reading to all Tolkien fans. I know I will be rereading it in the future.

PHILLIP FITZSIMMONS is the Steward for Society Archives for the Mythopoeic Society. His professional title is the University Archivist and Special Collections Librarian at Southwestern Oklahoma State University (SWOSU) in Weatherford, Oklahoma. At work he is responsible for the General Thomas P. Stafford Archives and is the administrator of the SWOSU Digital Commons. He manages Mythsoc's physical and digital collections through the SWOSU archive facilities. The Mythsoc digital repository is found at <https://dc.swosu.edu/mythsoc/>. His research interests include the works of J.R.R. Tolkien, Owen Barfield, the Inklings, and Joseph Campbell, and digital services for academic libraries with an emphasis on archive management, institutional repository administration, and library reference services.



DIARY OF AN OLD SOUL. George MacDonald. Annotated edition with introd. and notes by Timothy Larsen. Downers Grove: InterVarsity Press Academic, 2024. 296 p. 9781514007686. \$30.00.

FIRST PUBLISHED IN 1880, *A Book of Strife in the Form of the Diary of an Old Soul* by George MacDonald is a collection of 366 poems, one for each day of the year including one for the twenty-ninth day of February that occurs in leap years. In this republished edition with the shorter title *Diary of an Old Soul*, Timothy

Larsen provides an introduction with occasional annotations in the poems. Larsen writes about poems that are “designed to slow us down,” a characteristic shared with devotional literature (3), which he explores briefly in the context of the Victorians and MacDonald. Larsen also evaluates the meaning of MacDonald’s book title and how “strife” and “old soul” relate to the poems’ content (10–12), along with a key conclusion being that *Diary of an Old Soul* is “a collection of prayers” that “draw close to the heart of the deepest forms of spiritual devotion” (13). The poems express MacDonald’s faith in God, sometimes with allusions to passages from the Bible and often rich with imagery from nature, and how his faith intertwines with and illuminates his life experiences.

There have been other republications of *Diary of an Old Soul* since the 1880s, and this republished edition claims to follow the original text closely. As an annotated edition, the actual annotations seem sparse, though this is fine to avoid having a plethora of footnotes and reference numbers that can be distracting, even when they are minimal, on the same page as the poems. The notations vary; there may be one to three footnotes for a poem, or no footnotes for several pages. The content is of scholarly or general interest and helpful as definitions of words less well known for the general reader or providing biographical information behind the poem or the time it was written.

While this is an academic edition, the introduction’s scholarly information is intermingled with personal commentary, and Larsen refers readers to “scholarly treatments” of MacDonald’s book in a footnote (2n1). It could have been interesting to share more background on MacDonald during the time of writing and publishing his poems, so to better complete the picture, I looked through MacDonald’s published letters. For instance, in a letter to his sister Georgina (Mrs. William Cowper-Temple), dated January 26, 1880, MacDonald writes her, “I send you at last a copy for yourself of my little book,” his privately published *Diary of an Old Soul*. He writes further: “Where shall we send the twenty copies you were so kind to order? Looking over it with more interest that I have yet felt for a book of my own, I think it is not a failure, but a great deal will depend, not only on the degree and kind of spiritual training but on the mood of the reader. That you will be with me in it I have every hope” (301). Notably here, MacDonald implies that the book’s success will also depend on how readers approach the poems and possibly to what depth of spiritual insight and understanding they have in appreciating what the poems communicate. This corresponds with what Larsen writes in his introduction about the devotional nature of the poems.

Following Larsen’s introduction, MacDonald’s poems are divided like chapters into the twelve months of the year from January to December, with each poem numbered for its respective day in the month. The book’s format

easily serves as a regular companion throughout the year as a daily reading with a blank page next to each page of poems—like MacDonald’s first edition and intention—where readers can write or reflect on paper extending the “devotional conversation” (20). There is often a continuity between the ideas and themes (such as life, death, and love) running through the days that add to the interest in following how they may unfold or weave other thoughts and prayers together. For example, November’s poems begin the first day with the concept that “Thou [Christ] know’st it all” and introduces the word “dark” briefly. In the poem for the second day of November, MacDonald expands on what Christ knows, including human experiences and the difficulty of being, and again mentions the dark. This motif becomes more prominent through the next three poems and connects with the night, culminating on the fifth day of November’s poem with the poet looking for Christ in the dark (243–44).

MacDonald’s spiritual impetus might not resonate with all readers, but the depth and insights he writes about can speak to those willing to read and reflect on one or many of the poems. The beauty of this book is MacDonald’s poetic words and imagery portraying his deep belief and trust in God no matter how difficult or painful life can be, and readers may also find encouragement and hope in the pages. This particular published version is red cloth with gold embossing, under the dust jacket, and can be an attractive gift or addition to a personal library. Its appearance both inside and out would probably please MacDonald himself who “loved books as physical objects” (19), and more importantly, anyone who values poems will likely find enjoyment or something meaningful to contemplate within them.

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TIFFANY BROOKE MARTIN has a PhD in English and the Teaching of English from Idaho State University. Her dissertation was on Owen Barfield’s writings with a focus on fantasy and fiction, and she has been an adviser and editor for the Owen Barfield Literary Estate. Tiffany currently works as global editorial content manager for Roquette, an international company that produces ingredients for food, health, and nutrition markets.



MIMETIC THEORY & MIDDLE-EARTH: UNTANGLING DESIRE IN TOLKIEN'S LEGENDARIUM. Matthew J. Distefano. Chico, CA: Quoir, 2024. 202 p. ISBN 9781957007922. \$19.99.

MATTHEW DISTEFANO'S FRIENDLY VOLUME extends considerably the conversation about resonances between two twentieth-century literary giants begun by Hayden Head's 2007 *Mythlore* article, "Imitative Desire in Tolkien's Mythology: A Girardian Perspective." René Girard (1923–2015) rose to prominence as a literary scholar with the publication of his first book, *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque*, in 1961 (translated in 1965 as *Deceit, Desire and the Novel*), around the time Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* came into vogue, but there is no evidence that they knew each other's work. Yet, as Distefano ably shows, Tolkien's work manifests the insights Girard found in the novels of Cervantes, Stendhal, Flaubert, Dostoevsky, and Proust, which led him to form the theory of desire, violence, and cultural origins he went on to pursue across other classic literature, from Greek tragedy to Shakespeare, and into fields such as anthropology and biblical studies. Most important for Distefano, however, is that both authors, each of whom he has written about separately, distill valuable wisdom for living. Bringing them together not only clarifies essential aspects of Tolkien's work by reading it through the lens of Girard's mimetic theory but also highlights, extends, and one might even say enacts aspects of Girard's theory that are easily overlooked.

Distefano's short, digestible chapters are organized into five sections that move from an overview of mimetic theory, with Tolkienian examples, to a more extended focus on elements that most reward mimetic analysis: the One Ring and, especially, Hobbits.

The aptness of illustrations from Tolkien's works make this an excellent introduction to Girard's theory. Part of mimetic theory's beauty is the simplicity and power of its two central ideas. First, human desire is fundamentally imitative and unconsciously so—hence the term "mimetic." Beyond our responses to what meets immediate physiological needs and appetites, we copy the desires of others, which leads us into rivalry for the objects of these shared desires. Girard primarily studied the violent consequences of mimetic desire, and sometimes even used the term to refer just to rivalrous desire, but, as Distefano rightly emphasizes, he also made clear that mimetic desire can have either good or bad results and is simply a fact of our nature. Indeed, Girard saw it as essentially good because it makes us free to choose our models rather than be driven just by appetite and instinct. The steady drumbeat of Distefano's explication is how hobbits can serve as models of positive mimesis, desire that leads to friendship rather than strife.

Yet Distefano also pays strong attention to Girard's second thesis: that human groups have had a persistent pattern, since prehistory, of temporarily resolving the escalating violence of mimetic rivalry that always threatens to engulf them by directing their violence at a single, essentially arbitrary victim — what we have come to call in English, using a word from Tyndale's translation of Leviticus, a scapegoat. Spontaneous scapegoating gives rise to the universal components of primitive religion: repetition of the scapegoat mechanism in the form of sacrificial ritual, prohibitions of the most virulent causes of rivalry, and myths that misremember the original victims of scapegoating as gods and sacralize violence. From this, according to Girard, develop the major institutions of human culture. Here Distefano reaches deepest into Tolkien's legendarium for illustrations: Melkor's mimetic envy as the source of proliferating violence, the ban of the Valar against sailing to the undying lands, the sacrifices initiated by Sauron in Númenor. Readers of the *Silmarillion* will be able to add more.

Again, however, where Girard's analysis of culture focuses on the workings of sacred violence, Distefano emphasizes Tolkien's alternatives. The culture of the Shire, for instance, balances a minimum of prohibitions with the freedom of imitating non-conflictual models of desire and celebrating non-sacrificial rituals of friendship. While myth in Girard's negative sense is present as the discord introduced by Melkor into the music of the Ainur (and variously darkening the minds of the peoples of Middle-earth), the stories told by Tolkien are what Distefano calls "subversive mythology." Thus Beren is an "attempted scapegoat" of Thingol who becomes instead a model of heroic self-sacrifice, and Thingol a model of conversion from resentment to pity. The whole story of Smeagol/Gollum, Frodo, and Sam is a similarly subversive myth that Distefano deals with a much greater length. Gandalf's story of how Gollum's original community scapegoated him allows him to be seen with pity. Frodo's self-sacrifice becomes a reversal of scapegoating when he chooses his final exile from the Shire.

Distefano points out one instance of Tolkien mythologizing in a negative sense: the depiction of Goblins in *The Hobbit* as the embodiment of evil, a myth that justifies their destruction at the Battle of the Five Armies, where they function as a scapegoat that makes temporary peace between Dwarves, Elves, and Men. Though Distefano does not consider the more complex depiction of Orcs in *The Lord of the Rings*, he briefly raises the issue through a quotation from George R. R. Martin complaining that Tolkien fails to answer questions about Aragorn's policy toward them as king. Distefano suggests that Tolkien gives us enough to imagine that Aragorn would show the kind of pity that Frodo shows Gollum. I would add that Tolkien strongly implies as much, and answers Martin's concern, when he writes, in the chapter "The Steward and the King," that "the slaves of Mordor he released and gave to them all the lands about Lake

Núrnmen to be their own." While calling the Goblins "Manichean 'bad guys'" (97, 136) may fit the polarization of good and evil in *The Hobbit*, the depiction of Orcs, along with the other antagonists in the larger legendarium, ultimately conforms to Tolkien's (and Girard's) Augustinian vision of evil as a privation, and perversion, of good.

The two chapters devoted to the One Ring well demonstrate how it rewards a mimetic analysis, with emphasis again on the culture and models of positive mimesis that help Hobbits resist the contagion of desire for power that it represents. Readers will be able to extend this analysis to the Silmarils and the Arkenstone as both objects and symbols of rivalrous desire (the latter discussed by Joshua Hren; see below) as well as Tolkien's depiction of dragon-sickness in *The Hobbit* and his poem "The Hoard."

In the final chapters, Distefano's interest in Tolkien's models of positive mimesis takes center stage, primarily with reference to the Shire but also with mention of non-Hobbit members of the fellowship of the Ring—which could, again, be extended to Éomer, Éowyn, Faramir, and others. Brief discussion of "Boromir's folly" could likewise point to the fuller representation of mimetic rivalry in his father, Denethor. But the mutual illumination of Girard and Tolkien on the positive potential of mimesis is the strength of this book, which comes through also in the "lessons from Middle-earth" at the end of each chapter, Distefano's reflections on his own efforts to live these out, his friendly tone and informal style, and his hope that conscious desire really can save us all.

To explain why Tolkien and Girard would be so deeply compatible, Distefano adverts to their shared Catholic faith and to the importance Girard places on Judeo-Christian revelation for showing how to interpret myth. Indeed, Girard finds the Bible supreme for its insight into mimetic desire and scapegoating, and thus for conceiving peaceful modes of communion. The greatness of many works of literature, for Girard, comes from how they anticipate or reflect these insights. The fact that Girard found his way to these insights by way of his reading of classic literature invites the question of whether something similar might be true for Tolkien, whose creative works were nurtured by his responses to the literature he studied and loved. Distefano's case for adding Tolkien to the Girardian canon invites consideration of the two side-by-side as interpreters of Western literary tradition.

One key here, with further support for Distefano's mimetic reading, is Tolkien's major work of literary theory, "On Fairy-stories." The functions of recovery, escape, and consolation that Tolkien identifies in fairy-stories, achieved above all by "eucatastrophe," map well onto what Distefano calls "subversive mythology." Likewise, the distinction Tolkien makes in this essay between magic motivated by possessive desire to dominate and enchantment that seeks shared enjoyment (evoked by Galadriel's comments to Frodo and Sam

before they look into her mirror) corresponds to, and is illuminated by, the distinction between negative and positive mimesis. Tolkien calls such enchantment an “elvish craft,” which implies that Elves might be seen alongside Hobbits as equally, though differently, positive models of desire.

Distefano has made good music from the resonances between Tolkien and Girard. There are more songs to be sung, and I’m sure Distefano would welcome the singers around his fire with a cup of their favorite equivalent of Old Winyards.

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CURTIS GRUENLER is a professor of English at Hope College and editor of the *Bulletin* of the Colloquium on Violence & Religion, the international academic group for those interested in mimetic theory. He is the author of *Piers Plowman and the Poetics of Enigma: Riddles, Rhetoric, and Theology* (University of Notre Dame Press, 2017) and, most recently, “On Fairy-stories as a Theory of Literature: Tolkien Meets Ricœur and Girard on the Field of Myth” (*Religion & Literature* 55.2).



POTTERVERSITY: ESSAYS EXPLORING THE WORLD OF HARRY POTTER. Edited by Kathryn N. McDaniel and Emily Strand. Jefferson, NC: McFarland, 2024. 276 p. ISBN 978-1-4766-9053-7. \$29.95.

THE IVORY TOWER, HARRY POTTER, AND BEYOND: MORE ESSAYS ON THE WORKS OF J.K. ROWLING. Edited by Lana Whited. Columbia, MO: University of Missouri Press, 2023. 424 p. ISBN 9780826223005. \$66.00.

TO MY MIND, THE MOST COMPELLING scholarship makes precise, well-researched arguments and raises serious questions about both the specific object of inquiry and the larger assumptions and goals of the field. With these criteria in mind, this review considers two excellent recent anthologies: Lana Whited’s *The Ivory Tower, Harry Potter, and Beyond: More Essays on the Works of J.K. Rowling* and *Potterversity: Essays Exploring the World of Harry Potter*, edited

by Kathryn McDaniel and Emily Strand. The various chapters of these books run the gamut of theoretical and applied approaches to J.K. Rowling's texts, and are incisive, inclusive, intellectually stimulating, and innovative. Given their shared focus, I will be reviewing both together here.

That said, what precisely is their focus? Before even opening the texts, their titles raise an interesting question as to how this field self-identifies. *Potterversity* is much more focused on happenings internal to the world of Harry, Hermione, Ron, et al, whereas *The Ivory Tower* emphasizes the *Beyond* of its title as it explicitly considers Rowling's other writings. To be clear, Rowling's output extends far beyond her *Harry Potter* fame, now including "three companion books; a novel of social realism for adults, *The Casual Vacancy*; seven Cormoran Strike detective novels; the story basis for a London and Broadway play, *The Cursed Child*; a book-length fairy tale, *The Ickabog*; a holiday fable, *The Christmas Pig*, and three screenplays in the *Fantastic Beasts* film series," as well as numerous other essays (Whited 3). With such a broad range of texts and styles by the same author, the overlap—and distinctions—between *Potterversity* and *The Ivory Tower* serve as a sort of microcosm of a very present question in this domain of scholarship: how precisely to divide up the field. As these works of Potter studies, Rowling studies, or something else?

We often speak of Tolkien studies or mythopoeic studies, young adult literature or the fantasy genre; even as much as these differentiations are artificial, they still serve a purpose to scholars and the wider community. Titles, and the associations they implicitly raise, serve to divide the huge complexity and breadth of knowledge into digestible portions that can rapidly convey information. *Harry Potter*, though a massive cultural phenomenon, is a relatively recent entrant onto the scene of culturally significant texts, and the field is in some ways still working to define itself, in terms of its aims and scope and also in relation to the larger literary canon (Ide 127). The titles of these two texts offer two different views on how to partition this realm of scholarship. McDaniel and Strand write in their introduction that their work is in the realm of Potter studies; Whited, while nodding towards the prominence of the core *Harry Potter* novels, emphasizes that there is much to be learned from Rowling's other works (McDaniel and Strand 1, Whited 13).

The Ivory Tower, Harry Potter, and Beyond functions as a follow-up to Whited's previous volume, *The Ivory Tower and Harry Potter*, published in 2002. Twenty-odd years later, much has changed for the scholars and fans as Rowling's oeuvre has grown; these and the author's other projects are now requisitely in dialogue with many of the socio-intellectual movements that have pushed the boundaries of the humanities more broadly—intersectionality, critical race theory, post-colonial theory, etc. *Potterversity*, born out of the popular Potterversity podcast, similarly looks forward: born out of a medium

that has seen a massive amount of growth in recent years, Potteriversity brings scholarship to interested fans who may not be academics themselves (Rime et al 1261; McDaniel and Strand, "Potteriversity"). As McDaniel and Strand write, "[We are] bringing to the conversation a wide range of voices and making sure that our ideas are accessible—to magical folk and Muggles alike" (McDaniel and Strand 1). The podcast features discussions by researchers, and this dialogic approach is continued in the anthology: each thematic section includes transcribed discussions between the essay contributors and the editors that provide levity, accessibility, and further perspective to the complex issues faced in the text. And there certainly are complex issues at hand: Rowling's stated political positions, breaking into the mainstream of her fandom in 2020, have caused seismic ruptures in how scholars, fans, and some laypeople view and interact with the texts. Both anthologies do admirable jobs of including discussion of these notably complex and fraught issues. As McDaniel and Strand write:

A recent challenge in the world of Potter Studies is how (and whether) to respond to Rowling's controversial statements about trans people, which began in June 2020 and have continued. Like the *Potter* fandom in general, the scholars participating in our podcast and this book express a range of responses to the controversy. [...] You will, however, find in the essays below that some scholars have adjusted their analytical perspectives to consider Rowling's world in the light of her statements. (McDaniel and Strand 2)

This intentionality is both brave and needed; in few other major realms of literary inquiry is the author of the text actively commenting on their creation, its meaning, or its relationship to society and their fan base. Tolkien is no longer alive to explore his legendarium, but Rowling has become an active presence in the discourses she has generated.

In *The Gay Science*, Nietzsche's Madman famously declares that "God is dead. God remains dead. And we have killed him." But this is immediately followed with a question of meaning: "How shall we comfort ourselves, the murderers of all murderers?" (181). Reading over these anthologies, I kept returning to this the Madman and his questions, because they cut to the core of one of the key debates in literary studies—that of the importance of the author in interpretation. All of the various essays included in the two texts are forced to navigate a question that has always been central to literary studies, even as it has been answered many different ways over time: how do the author, the text, the reader, and larger society interact? In recent Potter studies, this issue has become far more acute than abstract academic debates as certain portions of the fandom have rebelled against J.K. Rowling and her political positions,

particularly on trans rights. In the introduction to *The Ivory Tower, Harry Potter, and Beyond*, Whited recognizes that this has become a “death of the author” moment in Potter/Rowling studies, noting that Potter fans “have had to reconsider or end their own relationships with the texts” (Barthes 142; Whited 10). Some authors within the anthologies still talk of Rowling’s intentions within their exegeses; however, others like Brent Slatterly, in his chapter of *Potteriversity*, declare Rowling “anathema,” recasting her as “She-Who-Must-Not-Be-Named” (McDaniel and Strand 239–240). Rowling is dead, and we have killed her—or, at least, some of us. This tension—between engagement and erasure of the author—is not clearly resolved within the chapters of these books.

I suspect that this juxtaposition speaks to a likely trend in upcoming scholarship: a distinction between Potter studies narrowly and Rowling studies more broadly. In this way, Potter fans who refuse to support Rowling’s further business ventures (for her works, certainly, have material value) may continue to engage with the world of *Harry Potter* that they have come to love, and those who are disinclined to dispose of her other projects can retain their ability to engage with them (Whited 372). That said, *The Ivory Tower* and *Potteriversity* misses its opportunity to explicitly suggest this kind of reordering of the field. Both editorial teams refer to themselves as operating within Potter studies, and little work is done to establish Rowling studies as a related but distinct field. Perhaps this will change over time if Rowling’s other texts become more popular and scholars focus more on them, but for now each reader and critic must find their own way through this political and intellectual morass.

Implicit in this critique is an assumption that anthologies like these function to both indicate the state of the field and to delineate the expectations for other scholars working in their domain; they are both descriptive and normative. There seems to be a tacit understanding across the editors and various authors of these manuscripts that Rowling’s political statements are problematic, and that arguments considering marginalization, tokenism, race relations and identity more broadly are academically and socially acceptable and necessary. Both books deftly note that the political leanings of many academics and *Harry Potter* fans have come into conflict with Rowling and other more conservative perspectives, though this phenomenon is replicated in the broader children’s literature space and across many academic divisions (Duggan 148). Politics may be omnipresent in humanistic inquiry, but it can also be corrosive if ideological adherence becomes a requirement for academic acceptance. Political scientists often speak of big-tent parties; is the *Harry Potter* studies world a big-tent interpretive community? Does it want to be?

I suspect that the editors and contributors of these volumes would respond to this question emphatically in the affirmative—that “the characters, stories, and situations of the magical world promote thinking that helps us

navigate our more mundane but no less dangerous world” (McDaniel and Strand 1). For example, Alyssa Lowery’s chapter in *The Ivory Tower* explicitly argues against overly racialized readings of Hermione’s S.P.E.W. and the house-elves, and Emily Strand’s piece in *Potterversity* explicitly utilizes Christian theology in her exploration of Christmas scenes in *Harry Potter*. The books suggest that regardless of one’s political affiliation, one can find an interpretive community within the acafandom.

Stepping away from this heavy discussion of politics, I wish to call out one particularly exciting inclusion in *Potterversity*: its use of “Conversation” chapters—transcribed dialogues between the editors and chapter authors of each thematic section. Not only did this give these various stakeholders additional opportunities to expound upon their views, they were able to engage in a level of critical discourse that is uncommon in these kinds of texts. For example, the “Playing Potter” conversation between Laurie Beckoff, Tyson Pugh, and Kathryn McDaniel and Emily Strand ties together the games of medieval fiction, pedagogical approaches to teaching literature, and the games internal to the *Harry Potter* world in an exchange that is interdisciplinary and evocative (McDaniel and Strand 210–212). Plus, the conversations are more informal, allowing for the text’s orientation as a work of acafandom to stand out as a piece of scholarship that is centered at the junction between the work and its cultural situation (McDaniel and Strand 1).

And this injection of levity and joy is important in such a fraught cultural discourse. To many, especially the more casual readers, Rowling’s texts are simply an escape from the mundanity of life; they are a way to become more than a Muggle. A final question I was left with after reading these anthologies was whether all of this interpretive activity detracts from the magic of *Harry Potter*. To paraphrase Tolkien, fantasy works because of its access to the numinous and the magical world beyond our own mundane reality (Tolkien 150). To my mind, these anthologies succeed precisely because they allow for interpretation while retaining the magic and joy of the texts. Each chapter and conversation is a celebration of the excitement and amazement of the secondary world hidden just beyond Platform 9 $\frac{3}{4}$ (in the case of *Harry Potter*). I had the opportunity to meet the editors—and many of the authors—of these volumes at the 2024 Harry Potter Academic Conference, and was delighted to find that all of these accomplished scholars kept the spirit of the magic of the stories central to their experience of scholarship and acafandom. I feel that these volumes succeed precisely because they allow for this synergy between creativity and analysis.

While there are many open questions of interpretation in the world of Potter/Rowling studies, these volumes go a long way toward answering a core question that vexes literature studies more broadly: what is the point of

analyzing these texts? The answer, according to *The Ivory Tower and Potterversity*, is to find new ways to feel the magic of the wizarding world each time one reads the books, watches the movies, or thinks about the stories. We can debate the politics of *Harry Potter* or J.K. Rowling, but we cannot and must not forget the joy of going to a world of wonder and of looking inside of ourselves to discover our own magic. If I abide by the criteria I set out at the beginning of this review—precision in scholarship and attention to larger assumptions and goals—then these two books certainly succeed, especially when taken together.

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LIAM BUTCHART, MD, MA, is currently a resident physician in psychiatry at the Icahn School of Medicine at Mount Sinai–Morningside/West program (New York, NY). He graduated from the Stony Brook University Renaissance School of Medicine and received his MA in Medical Humanities, Compassionate Care, and Bioethics from Stony Brook University, where he currently teaches on narrative medicine and virtue ethics. His research interests include psychoanalysis and literature, medical humanities, bioethics, and the intersection of the mental health illness experience with the arts.



HARRY POTTER AND RESISTANCE. Beth Sutton-Ramspeck. Routledge, 2023. 224 pp. \$40.00 pbk. 978-1032319872; also available in hbk. and eBook.

HARRY POTTER AND RESISTANCE IS A CHALLENGING BOOK TO READ, or at least this reader found it to be so. This is a partly a product of the extremely small font size that the book is printed in, but it is also a reflection of how densely populated with citations to other works the book is. Sutton-Ramspeck's scholarly approach to analyzing a book series that often is dismissed as "just children's books" is mostly welcome, though I sometimes found myself thinking "tell me what you think, not what everyone else thinks!" Still, all in all, Sutton-Ramspeck offers a compelling analysis of the Harry Potter series, emphasizing the centrality of rule-breaking and resistance in the narrative.

Sutton-Ramspeck argues that Harry's defiance transcends mere adolescent rebellion, serving as a fundamental element in combating systemic evils within the wizarding world. She explores how Harry and his allies challenge the Ministry of Magic's corruption and the entrenched racist ideologies that gave rise to Voldemort. The book draws parallels between the actions of Dumbledore's Army and the Order of the Phoenix with historical resistance movements, such as those during World War II and the U.S. Civil Rights era. And while the book was published in 2023, some might view the consideration of resistance to the second return to power of Voldemort to be particularly timely in 2025.

Sutton-Ramspeck's interdisciplinary approach mostly enriches the analysis, as she incorporates insights from political science, psychology, philosophy, history, race studies, and women's studies. This allows for a nuanced examination of themes like systemic oppression, the role of creativity in resistance, and the ethical complexities of rule-breaking. The book delves into the portrayal of house-elves, particularly Dobby, through a feminist lens, challenging interpretations that view the series as condoning slavery. Additionally, it investigates the language associated with dirt and purity, uncovering deep-seated prejudices in both magical and Muggle societies.

While the extensive use of critical theory may be dense for casual readers, it provides a thorough exploration for those interested in a deeper understanding of the series' social and political dimensions. By embracing the unresolved issues within the narrative, she underscores the series' capacity to inspire readers to contemplate and challenge societal injustices.

However, any current discussion of the Harry Potter franchise must grapple with the controversy surrounding J.K. Rowling's public comments on transgender rights. Sutton-Ramspeck does not shy away from this issue, providing a fairly thoughtful consideration of how Rowling's transphobic remarks have impacted the series' legacy. She acknowledges the harm caused

by Rowling's rhetoric, particularly its contradiction with the series' themes of inclusivity, empathy, and resistance to bigotry. Sutton-Ramspeck seeks to detach these tensions from the broader context of her analysis, emphasizing that the text and its creator should be critically separated. Nonetheless, she notes that while the series contains messages of acceptance and social justice, readers must also reckon with the ways in which Rowling's views complicate its reception and the cultural space it occupies.

Sutton-Ramspeck encourages readers to approach the series critically, embracing its potential to inspire resistance while remaining mindful of the real-world implications of Rowling's statements. In doing so, *Harry Potter and Resistance* contributes to an ongoing conversation about how fans and scholars can engage with works of art whose creators have been accused of perpetuating harm.¹

The book opens by framing rule-breaking not as mere adolescent rebellion but as a deliberate act of resistance. Sutton-Ramspeck explores Harry, Hermione, and Ron's defiance of both school rules and societal norms, arguing that these acts undermine corrupt systems, such as the Ministry of Magic's authoritarian policies. The chapter draws parallels to historical resistance movements, emphasizing how even small acts of disobedience can catalyze significant change.

The second chapter examines Dumbledore's Army (DA) as a case study in grassroots activism. Sutton-Ramspeck details how the DA mirrors real-world resistance groups, such as World War II resistance fighters and civil rights organizations. She discusses the importance of leadership, solidarity, and shared purpose in mobilizing against oppressive regimes, highlighting the DA's defiance of Dolores Umbridge and the Ministry's overreach.

Next, Sutton-Ramspeck delves into the wizarding world's deeply entrenched notions of blood purity and its parallels to real-world racism. She analyzes characters like Hermione, Hagrid, and Lupin, who resist systemic prejudices through their actions and advocacy. This chapter critiques the limitations of the series in fully addressing these issues, encouraging readers to engage critically with the text.

The fourth chapter focuses on female resistance, from Hermione's intellectual defiance to Ginny's active participation in battles against Voldemort's forces. Sutton-Ramspeck examines the gender dynamics within the series, addressing both empowering moments and the occasional reinforcement of traditional gender roles. The chapter also critiques Rowling's inconsistencies, particularly regarding intersectionality in her portrayal of resistance.

¹ This conversation is all the more timely given the recent revelations of allegations of truly despicable conduct by otherwise beloved fantasy author Neil Gaiman.

Sutton-Ramspeck then highlights how creativity becomes a tool for defiance, analyzing Fred and George Weasley's pranks, Luna Lovegood's eccentricity, and the satirical resistance of *The Quibbler*. These moments of levity and subversion are framed as vital counterpoints to the oppressive atmosphere of Voldemort's reign, showing how humor and individuality can undermine fear and conformity.

Chapter 6 is the final chapter directly addressing the text of the books. This chapter explores the ethical complexities of resistance. Sutton-Ramspeck addresses moments when Harry and his allies cross moral lines, such as using Unforgivable Curses or endangering others. She argues that these ambiguities mirror real-world ethical dilemmas faced by resistance movements, adding depth to the series' portrayal of rebellion.

In the seventh chapter, Sutton-Ramspeck again addresses Rowling's transphobic remarks and their impact on the Harry Potter fandom, which she had already touched upon in the preface to the book. As noted above, she critiques how these statements conflict with the series' themes of inclusion and justice, but advocates for separating the text from its author, proposing that fans and scholars can reinterpret the series in ways that resist the harm caused by Rowling's views.

The final chapter reflects on the Harry Potter fandom's activism, from charitable initiatives inspired by the series to grassroots movements challenging Rowling's statements. Sutton-Ramspeck celebrates the ways in which readers have turned the series' messages of resistance into real-world action, demonstrating how literature can inspire meaningful change.

While Sutton-Ramspeck critiques Rowling's views and some of the series' limitations, the book often leans heavily into celebrating the text as a beacon of resistance. This optimism risks overshadowing the deeper systemic issues within the narrative, such as its lack of diverse representation and the implicit reinforcement of certain hierarchies (e.g., the marginalization of house-elves and other magical creatures). Although the book addresses themes of race, gender, and class, the analysis occasionally feels compartmentalized rather than fully intersectional. For instance, the exploration of gender resistance could have been deepened by examining how these dynamics intersect with race and class in the wizarding world, particularly given the series' Eurocentric framing. Although the final chapter discusses the Harry Potter fandom's activism, it could have delved further into the complex dynamics within the fan community, particularly with regard to the schism between those who continue to support Rowling and those who reject her entirely.

While Sutton-Ramspeck engages somewhat with some critiques of the series, she fails to sufficiently engage with other criticisms of the Potter books, such as claims that the series upholds traditional power structures (e.g., the

privileged position of pureblood families like the Malfoys and the focus on the elite world of Hogwarts). She touches on these assessments but does not fully explore how these structural elements might undermine the series' broader themes of resistance. In addition, while the chapter-by-chapter structure is clear and well-organized, certain themes—such as rule-breaking and grassroots movements—are revisited multiple times, leading to some redundancy. A more concise integration of overlapping ideas could have streamlined the analysis.

All in all, despite its challenges, Sutton-Ramspeck's *Harry Potter and Resistance* is a valuable addition to the body of scholarship on the Harry Potter series. Its strengths lie in its interdisciplinary lens, candid engagement with Rowling's controversies, and thoughtful exploration of resistance as a multifaceted theme. However, the book's optimism sometimes overshadows deeper critiques of the series' structural issues. Nonetheless, for fans and scholars alike, this book is a thought-provoking resource that invites readers to reflect on the complexities of resistance in both fiction and reality. It is most impactful when viewed as a starting point for deeper conversations about activism, morality, and the role of literature in shaping societal values.

DOUGLAS C. KANE is an attorney specializing in employment discrimination and harassment cases and other civil rights matters. He is also a Middle-earth enthusiast who has loved the works of J.R.R. Tolkien for more than forty years. He co-founded and runs the Tolkien Internet discussion site thehallofire.net. His first book, *Arda Reconstructed: The Creation of the Published Silmarillion*, was published by Lehigh University Press in 2009, with a paperback edition released in 2011. He has also had numerous papers and reviews published in *Tolkien Studies*, *Mythlore*, and *The Journal of Tolkien Research*. Doug lives in Santa Cruz, California with his partner, Beth Dyer, and their cat, Legolas Lateef.



MAPPING A SENSE OF HUMOR: NARRATIVE AND SPACE IN TERRY PRATCHETT'S DISCWORLD NOVELS. Daniel Lüthi. Altadena, CA: Mythopoeic Press. 2023. 291 p. ISBN 9781887726238. \$19.95.

When Terry Pratchett wrote his first Discworld novels in the early 1980s, they were primarily parodies of fantasy novels in general and of the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy specifically. The further development of the Discworld series beyond this into its own secondary world over a span of 32 years is explored by Daniel Lüthi. This work begins with an exploration of fantasy works and their place in literature, starting with an attempt to define what the term "fantasy" means. He then delves into the similarities fantasy has

with postmodern fiction and how both these genres reflect the real world. While investigating this topic, Lüthi compares Pratchett's works with other well-known fantasy novels, not just Tolkien's. In comparison with *The Hobbit* and the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy, the first Discworld novels are quest fantasies but the quest is for our nominal hero to show a tourist the sights of Discworld. The "hero" in the first two novels is a failed wizard and primarily a coward. As Pratchett continued to write about this world, he used those characters that are normally in the background of fantasy novels and made them the focus of the novels. So our heroes in other Discworld novels are a witch, a city guard, or a con man, all of whom fight against what role the typical fantasy narrative would have them do but also fight against becoming the focus of the story. "Pratchett imbues his protagonists with an awareness of the power of stories that challenge the manner in which their counterparts in other fantasy books accept their roles" (81–82). His characters fight the narrative imperative that would have them behave in expected ways for others in their roles in other stories.

All of this leads to a discussion of the mapping of Discworld in the seventh chapter. Pratchett did not map out Discworld for his first two novels and, according to Lüthi, this was a deliberate decision. He did, eventually, work with Stephen Briggs to create a map of Discworld. In some ways, this is understandable. Once a map is constructed, the boundaries of the map constrain the stories that can be told. However, particularly for the novels set in the city-state of Ankh-Morpork, having a consistent structure to refer to became increasingly important to prevent confusion to the author and the reader. Still, Lüthi explains that readers asked Pratchett if the mapping of Ankh-Morpork would stifle the stories. This, needless to say, did not happen.

The last section of the book covers the further development of the Discworld and Ankh-Morpork. Lüthi points out that Pratchett's works are not just parodies of fantasy novels but are satires of our real world as well. In the later novels, Ankh-Morpork begins to industrialize which, of course, brings changes to the entirety of Discworld. While magic still has a central role in the novels, the Discworld equivalents of steam engines, movies, and telecommunications enter into the world. Since most fantasy novels are content to stay in a quasi-medieval state, this is a marked difference between Pratchett's works and the genre he began parodying. This section also discusses the multimedia resources developed from the novels. There are video games, movies, and the possibility exists of further movies and television series.

This book is a revision of the author's dissertation, which at times comes through, especially with the copious footnotes. It is, however, an informative treatise on the works of Terry Pratchett. This reviewer would have liked more about the mapping of Discworld and found the title of the book

somewhat misleading. Still for fans of the Discworld novels, this will be an interesting read.

SUSAN M. MOORE is a catalog librarian and collection strategist at the University of Northern Iowa. Prior to working at the University of Northern Iowa, she was a catalog librarian at the University of Arizona. She received her MLS from the University of Iowa in 1984 and holds a M.A. in Geography from the University of Arizona and a B.A. in Political Science from the University of Northern Iowa.



ART AND ENCHANTMENT: HOW WONDER WORKS. Patrick Curry. London and New York: Routledge, 2023. 244 p. ISBN 978-1-032-40467-7. \$48.99.

TOLKIEN WROTE AN ESSAY TO ACCOMPANY *Smith of Wootton Major* and at the very end he stated that “‘Faery’ is as necessary for the health and complete functioning of the Human as is sunlight for physical life [...]” (*Smith* 144–5). Faerie was to Tolkien both an embodiment and a source of enchantment (*OFS* 32) and from this remarkable statement it is clear that he regarded enchantment as essential for human flourishing. We have Tolkien’s thoughts on enchantment in “On Fairy-stories,” in the essay that accompanies *Smith of Wootton Major*, and in a few of his letters (#131 in particular), but there is much more that could be said about both enchantment and disenchantment, which is its lack or opposite.

Patrick Curry has written extensively on Tolkien, art and enchantment, and *Art and Enchantment* is his most academic in nature on these subjects, and the most fully developed and detailed. He lays out an ambitious plan for the book at the very beginning:

This book celebrates and defends the experience of wonder in art, and of art as enchanting. It explores the characteristics, conditions, and dynamics of artistic creativity and appreciation. But it also concerns the absence of enchantment, and the reasons for that. I don’t altogether rule out the possibility of any art enchanting, but I do suggest that some kinds are more like to than others, and we shall see why. (2)

The book itself begins with an Introduction, and a lengthy chapter called “What is Enchantment?” Chapters follow on specific kinds of art with two chapters each on Painting, Music and Fiction, a short chapter on Poetry, a Conclusion, and an ample Index. The book is heavily notated and referenced, and if nothing else the reader will find many suggestions for further reading on enchantment,

art and the intersection of the two. In addition, a worthy chapter on jazz that was cut for space has been posted on the author's website at patrickcurry.co.uk.

Enchantment is difficult to define simply, as it is a rich, complex phenomenon. It includes wonder, but it is a particular kind of encounter with wonder. With enchantment Curry is speaking of a specific phenomenon, or class of phenomena:

The heart of enchantment is an experience of wonder. It varies in intensity from charm, through delight, to full-blown joy. The last distinguishes radical or deep enchantment, rare but life changing. (8)

We most often encounter enchantment in the context of falling in love or an encounter with nature, but there are other ways it can be found, such as religion, food and drink, learning, humor, art, even sports (29).

Curry emphasizes that enchantment is not something that can be planned on, or willed or forced to occur. It cannot be bidden, created, commanded or managed. It cannot be found where either domination and control over others are an objective. Curry explains that:

Enchantment is fundamentally relational. It is wonder *at*, or enchantment *by*, another. It's not power over them, nor being the object of power. [...] It also follows that because no one is in charge, enchantment is wild, unbiddable. That inconvenient truth means that although it can be invited, it cannot be created, commanded, or managed. (8)

Enchantment cannot even be counted upon to reoccur under identical conditions, as it is deeply connected to a unique time, place and situation. Curry presents an example:

It was *that* movement of the fourth Brandenburg Concerto, just as the English Consort, as it then was, played it, in *that* evening's slanting light, there in Holland Park, interspersed with *that* blackbird's song, which transported us. (19)

Curry distinguishes enchantment from a mystical or dionysiac ecstasy or union, as enchantment is an encounter over a "gap of difference" (9). When enchanted we experience the "other" in a heightened way. A gap or boundary will still be present, but ceases to matter temporarily. We are still ourselves, but the "other" becomes a source of pure joy, sometimes overwhelming, for a usually too brief time. The "other" here can be almost anything: an animal, plant or place, or even an experience of the senses. Most of us have some experience

of enchantment, perhaps an artwork that moved us, the first time we tasted a favorite food or the first time we met a loved one.

Curry develops his understanding of enchantment from at least two starting points. One of them is Weber's well-known argument that the world is becoming increasingly disenchanted as it (supposedly) moves towards a view that "we can in principle *control everything by means of calculation*" (Weber 12–13). Religion, myth, magic are no longer necessary as "we need no longer have recourse to magic in order to control the spirits or pray to them. Instead, technology and calculation achieve our ends" (13). Curry appears to accept Weber's understanding of some of the causes of disenchantment: "rationalisation and intellectualisation" (Curry 198) and the drive towards "rational cognition and mastery of nature" (15). These are hostile to enchantment, as they are focused on control and possession, whereas enchantment is almost always a surprise, and requires an openness, what the travel writer Freya Stark calls "fearless receptivity" (qtd. in Curry 30). Curry points out that possessiveness is antithetical to enchantment, saying that "false enchantment" is "a desire either to possess the other or be possessed by them" (9, quoting W.H. Auden). Enchantment presumes a desire for the other to flourish (9). As Tolkien says about Faerie (a source of enchantment), it "represents love: that is, a love and respect for all things, 'inanimate' and 'animate', an unpossessive love of them as 'other'" (Smith 144).

Whereas Weber is focused on identifying disenchantment, the loss of enchantment, Tolkien is positively interested in identifying and re-awakening it. In Tolkien's usage of the term enchantment is an "elvish craft" or "living, realised sub-creative art" that "does not seek delusion, nor bewitchment and domination; it seeks shared enrichment, partners in making and delight, not slaves" (OFS 64). Enchantment is concerned with evoking wonder and creating beauty. In a letter to Milton Waldman, Tolkien describes the elvish craft of enchantment as a particular kind of 'magic':

Their [elves] 'magic' is Art, delivered from many of its human limitations: more effortless, more quick, more complete (product, and vision in unflawed correspondence). And its object is Art not Power, sub-creation not domination and tyrannous re-forming of Creation. (*Letters* 205, #131)

In Tolkien's understanding (which is largely Curry's as well) enchantment seeks partners, not possessors or possessions. It seeks to create and delight, rather than dominate.

While enchantment cannot be made or forced to occur, conditions can be created which make it more likely to occur, and much of the focus of *Art and Enchantment* is on art, artists and artistic movements and Curry's thoughts on

whether they might be more, or less, conducive to enchantment. Curry's point-of-view is definitely an opinion. Readers will not find much in the way of scientific studies or data in the book. But it is a point-of-view that has been carefully and extensively developed, and at the end it may be seen to have a great internal consistency, and perhaps usefulness for understanding an important phenomenon. This consistency and analysis begins from a particular understanding of enchantment and prevents the book from merely being an enumeration of what Curry does and doesn't like in art.

Curry also claims the book is not meant to be a discussion of what is and isn't art (2). Not all artists are trying to enchant and Curry gives examples of works such as *Guernica* by Pablo Picasso and *The Handmaid's Tale* by Margaret Atwood that are moving and powerful, but few would call enchanting (2). Curry is also willing to acknowledge that there are subjects like opera and hip-hop that are a "closed book" (3) to him, where he feels unqualified to speak for various reasons.

A few examples of art that Curry believes is likely to elicit enchantment are in order. As an example of a painter Curry proposes Claude Monet (49). This is not a particularly controversial position as Monet (and many of the other Impressionists) have been and continue to be well-regarded for the beauty of their works. Curry suggests that popularity may actually be a hindrance to enchantment because of over-familiarity, but encourages getting to know Monet's works better anyways (49–50). In particular he recommends the lesser-known *Nymphéas* (Water Lilies) cycle of paintings from later in Monet's life, which he compares to Beethoven's final string quartets as high points in Western art (50).

In contrast, Damien Hirst (perhaps better known in the UK than North America) is an example of an artist that Curry thinks is disenchanting, part of an art world that is actively hostile to enchantment (103–104). Hirst is infamous for artworks consisting of animal carcasses in formaldehyde. Another work features 9000 dead butterflies. It is easy to see how far this is from enchanting; its purpose instead is to shock or horrify. Curry's scorn for Hirst is obvious, describing him as "a foul-mouthed brutalist whose grotesque self-pity has survived extravagant wealth (c. \$384 million)—the reward of an art world run by business" (104).

Curry sees Damien Hirst as an example of the modernism that is a particular enemy to enchantment in his view (104). Curry draws a distinction between the modern sensibility that we are all affected by, and the modernism that developed later as an ideology (31). He notes that in the 19th century some people in the West and Japan began to see themselves as modern, which led to, among other things, a relaxed attitude towards tradition. This sensibility led them to ignore tradition at times and experiment and innovate. However,

towards the end of the 19th century modernism as an ideology got its start. It was a sometimes virulent reaction to tradition, which was associated by modernists with superstition, oppression and ignorance, and which therefore needed to be destroyed (31). Modernism was intended to be progressive, but it “needs icons to smash and enemies, both past and present, to smite” (31) and has seemed to delight in only systematic destruction and deconstruction. With the overturn of tradition, scientific naturalism and materialism (31) take its place, and Weber has pointed out that these are about control and possession, and therefore hostile to enchantment. Curry argues that the movement is still ongoing, and continues to be programmatically opposed to enchantment:

Now there’s no doubt that modernism was originally experienced by some as tremendously liberating and exciting, nor that it has resulted in some good and occasionally great art, along with a lot of rubbish. But wonder, delight, and joy in art are things that modernists largely reject. (32)

Concerning music, it has been said (perhaps by Debussy) that “space is the music between the notes,” and Curry notes that enchantment takes place across gaps and spaces (9). He writes that “Enchantment lives even in the cracks, in the sense of imperfections, within the notes—one reason why I think acoustic instruments, improvised music, and live performances have the greatest potential for enchantment” (123). Among composers he recommends Debussy and Ravel as particularly conducive to enchantment, as well as some lesser-known 19th and 20th century composers such as Satie, Fauré, Messiaen, and Takemitsu.

Curry is not afraid to include “children’s literature” in his discussion of enchantment in literature. He mentions *The Wind in the Willows* (Kenneth Grahame), which many would agree with. The chapter “Piper at the Gates of Dawn” contains some of the most enchanting moments in literature. It may surprise everyone except those who have read them, but he commends the “Mary Poppins” novels by P.L. Travers for their portrayal of the titular character as “at once a force of nature and a spiritual being of indeterminate sort [...] she is completely unbiddable, a barely-self-controlled cyclone of wild enchantment” (183). Curry is less fond of *His Dark Materials* for its didacticism and *Winnie-the-Pooh* for its preciousness, though he recognizes that some will see wonder in these (180, 179).

Readers of this journal who are interested in enchantment or Tolkien’s understanding of enchantment may find much to think about in *Art and Enchantment*. Curry’s knowledge of art is vast and the discussion is fast and wide-ranging. A familiarity, or willingness to get familiar, with the artists and movements he discusses will be helpful towards gaining from the book. Curry

keeps primarily to the 19th through 21st centuries, but there is still a lot to take in.

With all the discussion on art and artists in the book it is easy to lose sight of perhaps the most important argument that Curry makes, that enchantment is worth pursuing. He says that “it is not a luxury but something which can make life worth living, and even be life-changing” (31). Tolkien would likely agree, saying that enchantment is “essential to [...] full and proper human development” (*Smith* 131). Glamour, what Curry calls “false enchantment, the desire for possession” (30), and disenchantment are prevalent. It takes an effort to maintain an openness towards enchantment, but Curry and Tolkien would likely say the results are worth it.

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N. TREVOR BRIERLY has a background in the humanities with an MLIS from the University of Texas at Austin, a MA from Signum University and a BA in English from George Mason University. His research interests include worldbuilding in speculative fiction, Tolkien, Frank Herbert, Le Guin, Shakespeare, and the Renaissance. He has published an essay “Worldbuilding Design Patterns in the Works of J.R.R. Tolkien” in “Sub-creating Arda” (Walking Tree Publishers, 2019) and is co-editor of “Discovering Dune” from McFarland Books (2022). He lives in Northern Virginia and is sometimes enchanted by jazz, tea and cats.



BRIEFLY NOTED

HARRY POTTER AND THE MYTH OF MILLENNIALS: IDENTITY, RECEPTION, AND POLITICS. Priscilla Hobbs. Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 2022. 204 pp. **Hardcover:** 978-1-7936-2027-9. \$95.00; **ebook:** 978-1-7936-2028-6, \$45.00.

PRISCILLA HOBBS'S *HARRY POTTER AND THE MYTH OF MILLENNIALS* adds to an important and growing literature about the intersection between popular culture and politics. As she notes, the *Harry Potter* series was formative for a generation of young readers and almost certainly influenced their views of social justice, government power, and war. Hobbs combines an academic analysis of the series' political themes with her personal reflections about the franchise and American political trends during the early 2000s. The book is probably best suited to readers seeking a short overview of why J.K. Rowling's stories resonated with the millennial generation, and what lessons they might have drawn from it.

The first half of the book examines how the *Harry Potter* series became a cultural phenomenon. Hobbs initially frames Harry Potter's success as another example of the power of the hero's journey archetype. Rowling's story, however, departs from the hero's journey by emphasizing how Harry, Ron, Hermione, and the other protagonists created a "found family" that often challenged the social norms of their community. Hobbs argues that the series in effect gave young readers permission "to embrace their unique selves [...] even if it deviated from illusory social norms" (64), helping to explain millennials' passion for expressing and defending one's identity.

The second half explores lessons that fans have drawn from the *Harry Potter* series on a variety of issues, including worker's rights, media, and education, and how the fandom mobilized to support activism. Drawing heavily on Gierzynski and Eddy's survey of *Harry Potter* readers, Hobbs argues that millennials who read *Harry Potter* were more likely to accept religious and gender diversity, oppose authoritarian leaders, and condemn torture. The last chapter touches on fan criticism of Rowling's comments about trans rights. However, Hobbs's limited coverage of the backlash, which started years before the book's publication, prematurely dates *Harry Potter and the Myth of Millennials*, and indeed raises underexplored questions of how much *Harry Potter* will shape millennials' political discourse in the future.

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DOMINIC J. NARDI received his Ph.D. in Political Science from the University of Michigan and currently teaches at George Washington University. He has edited books about *Star Wars* TV shows (2020) and *Dune* (2022), and is working on a book about Studio Ghibli films as adaptations (2025). He has also written about politics and identity in *Blade Runner*, *The Lord of the Rings*, and *Star Trek*.



MAGIC, MAGICIANS AND DETECTIVE FICTION: ESSAYS ON INTERSECTING MODES OF MYSTERY. Edited by Rebecca Josephy. Jefferson; McFarland & Co., Inc, 2025. 240 pp. ISBN: 978-1-4766-8820-6. \$65.00 (paperback).

THIS ESSAY COLLECTION OFFERS NINE CHAPTERS exploring how magic (primarily the performance variety) intersects with detective fiction. Three chapters apply the typology of magic to detective fiction, three consider overlapping spaces between detective fiction and magic (magicians who solve crimes, etc.), and three showcase international (Japanese, Russian, Mexican) authors using magic in detective stories.

The second section offers the most useful material for scholars interested in Inklings-adjacent Dorothy L. Sayers and other Golden Age detective writers. Beatrice Ashton-Lelliott discusses Victorian-era magicians who were seen simultaneously as rogues and detectives (93–111), Christopher Pittard explores the magician antagonist Colonel Clay in Grant Allen’s novel *The African Millionaire* (112–130), and Rebecca Josephy considers how Maurice Leblanc applies magical descriptors to Arsène Lupin (131–154). Josephy’s essay offers an interesting counterpoint to claims that the detective story is inherently religious when she argues that magic shows and detective stories follow similar structures. “The genre, like the magic show, becomes a pseudo-religious narrative iterative experience: a new, modern, and scientifically advanced opiate for the post-enlightened masses” (149). Whether religious authors like Sayers, Ronald Knox, and G.K. Chesterton turned the would-be opiate into a channel to re-enchant the masses is of course up for discussion.

Other fruitful insights for Golden Age fans appear in Zi-Ling Yan’s chapter in the typology section (13–39). Yan applies Robert Neale’s five-tier typology of magic to detective fiction: the tiers range “from primary magic (the self-unaware predisposition to magical thinking) to reflexive magic (a fully self-aware experience or meta-magic)” (21). If applied to fiction, Neale’s tiers show how detective stories offer a spectrum of magical content (proven or disproven

supernatural causes?) and a spectrum of attitudes toward magic (is the final plot reveal not unlike a magic show?). For example, Yan places Sayers's Lord Peter Wimsey despairing of justice prevailing in *Murder Must Advertise* and *Unnatural Death* in the final tier, "works that interrogate the magical effect in a serious mode," questioning whether the detective can perform the desired magic trick to conquer evil (31).

While Yan does not mention Charles Williams when discussing the second tier, which features ritual magic (22–25), his discussion of characters like Sax Rohmer's Moris Klaw shows why Williams is under-discussed in crime fiction studies. *War in Heaven* may be a detective story (see Higgins, "A Christian Detective Story?"), and Williams admitted that Rohmer inspired him to write his first novel (Lobdell 104), but his approach fits outside Rohmer's occult detective formula. The occult detective tale explores "cause-and-effect relations" involving paranormal forces that are "strictly retributive" if crossed. Neutralizing these forces requires "identifying sources of contamination and conducting purification rites"; since the contamination is usually something exotically foreign "best purged [...] from the national body," occult detective stories ultimately if "surreptitiously defend political, racial, class and gendered interests" (24). Williams rarely connects paranormal activity to "bad karma" and would rather complicate than affirm national visions of foreignness (see the ambiguous Nigel Considine in *Shadows of Ecstasy*) or gender (see Nyman on Williams's complex female figures). Williams writes detective stories about magic but evades easy clichés, which also means he evades easily labeled genre categories.

These essays offer useful ideas for scholars thinking about Sayers, Williams, and their associates as detective writers interested in magic, but little direct discussion. The focus is very much on performance magic over ritual magic (no references to Williams, almost no references to Aleister Crowley's crime stories). The focus is also very much on American authors over British ones (Chesterton only gets mentioned in one of Yan's footnotes [37], and in passing when Tobin discusses Chesterton scholar Martin Gardner [47]).

That said, the book offers fresh content on two under-discussed figures adjacent to Sayers and the Inklings. Neil Tobin contributes two essays, one on detective fiction authors who explored performance magic (40–63) and the other on performance magicians who solve crimes in detective stories (64–90). Both essays extensively discuss John Dickson Carr, much influenced by Chesterton and much supported by Sayers. Carr was also friends with William Lindsay Gresham, Joy Davidman's ex-husband and author of the crime novel *Nightmare Alley*. While often mentioned in Davidman scholarship or discussions of *Nightmare Alley* adaptations, few crime fiction studies analyze Gresham. Tobin's two pages discussing Gresham's crime fiction and friendships with Carr,

Clayton Rawson, and Bruce Elliot (49–50) might be the first time an academic book has discussed Gresham as a crime writer since Charles Shapiro's 1968 essay. Carr is better-known but limited academic work has been published on him beyond Douglas G. Greene's 1995 biography.

Readers interested in the Detection Club will be disappointed by *Magic, Magicians and Detective Fiction*, but it does fill in some important gaps in the American detective fiction conversation. Read alongside existing scholarship, it may help scholars wanting to bridge Carr and Chesterton, Williams and Sayers, and other topics that intersect detective fiction with magic or myth.

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G. CONNOR SALTER has a Bachelor of Science in Professional Writing from Taylor University. He has spoken on Inklings topics on several occasions, including "William Lindsay Gresham: Writer, Magician, Seeker" (November 3, 2023) and "The Lion and the Vampire: The Inklings and English Horror Films in Conversation," (October 29, 2021), both for Inklings Folk Fellowship. He has contributed to many publications, including *CSL: The Bulletin of the New York C.S. Lewis Society*, *The Lamp-Post*, *Fellowship & Fairydust*, *The Oddest Inklings*, and *A Pilgrim in Narnia*. His recent work includes "William Lindsay Gresham and Norse Poetry: A Surprising Discovery," (*CSL*, vol. 55, no. 1) and "Tellers of Dark Fairy Tales: Common Themes in the Works of C.S. Lewis and Terence Fisher" (*Mythlore* vol. 41, no. 1).





Patrick Wynne

A note on the cover design:

The Mythopoeic Society has long used an inward-oriented triskelion design as its logo. In Mythlore #3 (July 1969), editor Glen GoodKnight reproduced a sketch by BG Callahan which labels the three arms to represent J.R.R. Tolkien, C.S. Lewis, and Charles Williams, and identifies them with the authors' key concepts of, respectively, Eucatastrophe, Sehnsucht, and Romantic Theology, all leading to Joy at the center. Starting with issue #142, Mythlore's cover features a plurality of outward-reaching triskelions, which represent an open and inclusive approach to mythopoeic fantasy, still centered on the Joy it brings us as readers and scholars, and still anchored by, but quite rightly reaching well beyond, our original core three authors. The open source triskelion design used on the cover and interior of the journal is <https://openclipart.org/detail/278014/triskel> by roshellin.

A note on the type:

The main body of the text of Mythlore is set in Palatino Linotype, a balanced and graceful lyrical modernist face created in 1948 by Hermann Zapf and based on humanist Renaissance designs. It was initially cut by hand and cast as a foundry type, even though phototype machines and early computers were in use at the time. This combination of modernism and deliberate anachronism, as well as the date of the type's design, makes Palatino especially suitable for studies of the works of Tolkien, Lewis, Williams, and other modern fantasists. Mythlore first started using Palatino in 1988, when it switched to computer typesetting. Starting in 1989 a face called Tolkien, adapted from Kelt, was used for titling for a number of years but later phased out. We have returned to Tolkien for titles and other accents in 2007.

MythLORE Submission Guidelines

Mythlore is a refereed scholarly journal, available in print, electronic, and online open access formats. *Mythlore* welcomes submissions focusing on the works and scholarship of J.R.R. Tolkien, C.S. Lewis, and Charles Williams, as well as articles on other authors and creators of mythic and mythopoeic literature and media. We invite articles from all critical perspectives. All published articles have been recommended by at least one referee; in the case of authors connected with the journal or on the Society's board, a minimum of two recommendations is required. Notes and reviews are not refereed. A more detailed statement of editorial purpose is available at <http://dc.swosu.edu/mythlore/aimsandscope.html>

All submissions for publication should conform to *The MLA Handbook* 9th ed. (New York: Modern Language Association, 2021), include a list of works cited, and normally should be 5,000-10,000 words. A detailed style guide can be found at https://dc.swosu.edu/mythlore/style_sheet.pdf. Reviews of books should be 1,000-5,000 words. Please inquire with the editor before submitting book reviews or shorter Notes. Letters are also welcome. Submissions should be formatted as Microsoft Word or plain ASCII text files and submitted by setting up an author account at <http://dc.swosu.edu/mythlore/>. Authors may expect a decision regarding publication within six to nine months.

Janet Brennan Croft

Editor, *Mythlore*

University of Northern Iowa

Rod Library 213A

Cedar Falls, IA 50614

mythlore@mythsoc.org

janet.croft@uni.edu